

FAIR GAME

FIRST LINE PR



THE RULES OF THE RINK

RUTH STILLING

fair game

The Rules of the Rink

Book One

ruth stilling



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FAIR GAME

THE RULES OF THE RINK
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*To the readers who changed my life with their overwhelming love for this
guy called JJ.
Here's another Jones.*

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trigger/content warnings

Dear Reader,

Thank you so much for choosing to read *Fair Game*, the first book in The Rules of the Rink series.

While this book is a fictional contemporary romance and, of course, has a happily ever after, I want to bring to your attention to certain themes featured within this story so you can make an informed decision about whether or not to continue reading. Please be aware that the following information does contain spoilers; however, I want to offer all my readers the opportunity to be fully versed in all potentially triggering scenarios prior to reading.

Fair Game contains sexually explicit content and strong language throughout the entire story. You will also find mention of divorce and a troubled marriage, cheating (not between the main characters), an abusive childhood (not involving the main characters) and details of a controlling boyfriend (not involving the main characters).

This book contains the reformed playboy trope, and at the beginning of the story, Will is very much still living that lifestyle. With this in mind, I want to point out a scene toward the beginning of the book, where Will sleeps with a woman (off-page) who does not turn out to be the love interest. At this stage in the story, Will is single, and there are no romantic feelings between the main characters. My intention in this story is to show you, the reader, the full journey of Will falling in love.

Trust me when I say that when Will falls, he falls first and *hard*, and I am so unbelievably excited to share another incredible Jones man with you.

Prepare to swoon, clench those thighs, and be screaming all the way until the end.

I had the BEST time writing this story, and I truly hope you do while reading it.

Lots of love, always,
Ruth

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playlist

“Ruin My Life” by Zara Larsson
“Espresso” by Sabrina Carpenter
“Back to Friends” by Sombr
“At Last” by Etta James
“All of Me” by John Legend
“Red Light” by Billy Ocean
“505” by Arctic Monkeys
“I Knew You Were Trouble” by Taylor Swift
“Greedy” by Tate McRae

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prologue

. . .

Will

June

Brooklyn

Public service announcement: I don't want to be a pro hockey player anymore.

Scrubbing one sweaty palm across my jaw, I brace an elbow on my knee and try to act like this hasn't turned into the complete shit show Dad feared it would.

The Seattle Rogues.

The NHL's most recent expansion team, who finished at the bottom of the league last season, just selected me in the draft.

I mean, there was never any doubt that my name was going to be announced as the first-round pick, but why, after years of the worst team in the league missing out on their first choice, did the lottery that was the draft have to screw me over?

The Seattle fucking Rogues.

I'd rather cut off my balls, toss them in a deep fryer, and offer them as entrées to the people sitting in this room.

And that's the worst of it. Some of those present might as well eat my hairy ball sack. They pretty much own the rest of me.

"I fucking knew it." Emmett Richards, assistant coach for the Rogues, stands from where he was sitting on the couch opposite me and walks the few paces in my direction, hand outstretched for me to take. Behind his

black-framed glasses, his eyes crinkle with the kind of grin I struggle to return.

“On your feet, son,” my dad—Jensen Jones, former Seattle Scorpions goalie—turns to me and whisper-hisses through his teeth.

I rise to my feet and take Emmett’s hand, and a round of applause echoes around my parents’ large living room as the TV glows above the fireplace.

The former New York Blades defenseman rests his other palm on my right shoulder, squeezing his fingers gently. “Fate had a hand in tonight, I’m telling you. The Rogues need a generational talent like you, Will. And by the time you join us after a few years in college, I know you’ll be proud to wear the green-and-gold jersey.”

He clears his throat, and my dad stands, too, offering his hand for Emmett to take. Emmett continues speaking as he releases my hand and shakes Dad’s.

“Over the past ten years, Seattle has grown into a hockey epicenter, and I know when you finally sign with us, the Rogues will be an absolute force. Maybe even bigger than the Seattle Scorpions.” He sounds like he’s convincing himself at this point.

Of all the expansion proposals put to the league, a second team in Seattle was not one hockey fans were predicting.

I guess that’s what happens when huge corporations with more money than sense—over three billion dollars in the bank, to be precise—swoop in and make an offer that’s too hard to refuse. Sure, hockey in Seattle is big these days, but the same could be argued with places like Toronto.

Who didn’t get the goddamn first-round pick.

Dad quirks an unsure brow, dropping his hand from Emmett’s and sliding both into the pockets of his black dress pants. “You’re going to have to forgive me here, Emmett, but I don’t see it. This next season will be the Rogues’ third, and we both know it takes years for a team to gain any kind of traction in the league. Even with a fancy arena and the fan base to fill it.”

Tension-filled silence falls between the two guys who once played against each other on the ice, although it feels more like a rivalry has formed tonight.

My family is hockey crazy. My mom, Kate, and my twin sister, June, are both Seattle Scorpions fans through and through. My dad is an NHL Hall of Famer, having helped lead the Scorpions to three Cup victories, and

is the goalie coach for the New York Blades. He had me and June skating before we could walk.

I had dreams of playing pro for one of the prestigious teams.

But in four years, I'll sign a contract and join the team no true hockey fan wants to acknowledge. Twenty-three players who celebrate a regular season win like they just won the Cup. It's fucking embarrassing.

"Well, this is ... awkward," Mom declares as she walks into the living room and kisses me on the left cheek. "Congratulations, honey." Her eyes flick to Emmett's and then Dad's. "I know the Rogues weren't your first choice, but—"

"Last fucking choice," Dad interjects, earning a stern glare from Mom.

She smiles at Emmett while he scratches at the back of his neck.

Poor guy. He's a damn good coach, but even a miracle wouldn't be enough to steer the Rogues on course.

"Four years of the NCAA league in college, and you'll be a pro hockey player. It's what you've been working all these years to achieve." She finishes her sentence and raises a glass of wine to me, Dad, and Emmett.

Without drinks to *celebrate*, all three of us nod our heads.

Mom casts her eyes around the light-blue living room like she doesn't live here, looking about as uncomfortable as we all feel. "What time are Jessie and Mia arriving?"

Emmett pushes back the sleeve on his white dress shirt to check his watch. "Anytime now. Jessie needed to finish up on a call with the general manager, and then he was going to pick up Mia and the girls."

Mom's eyes grow wide. "Drew and Marley are coming too?" She downs the rest of her wine in one hit. For saying this woman co-owns one of the biggest legal practices in the country, she sure as shit can't hold it together when we're hosting a draft party and there's a chance we'll run out of breadsticks.

But given that Jessie Callaghan—former Seattle Scorpions forward and Rogues head coach—will call the shots on my future pro career, Mom will go to any lengths to keep that man happy.

Even if they've all been family friends since before June and I were born.

When Mom turns on her heel and makes for the kitchen, Dad looks like he wants to say something, but is cut short by the doorbell.

"June, will you get that, honey? It's probably the Callaghan family!"

“When have we ever referred to them as the *Callaghan family* rather than their first names?” June mocks beneath her breath as she slides her phone into her jeans pocket and walks toward the entryway, long, dark hair swishing down her back as she moves.

She’s barely said two words since the draft program started, and with the way she has her head buried in her phone ninety-nine percent of the time, I forgot that she was within earshot.

Not that it matters. June already knows how I feel about tonight’s outcome. As twins, we’ve always been able to read each other’s mind, although it’s not hard to sense my devastation—it’s written all over my face.

More silence descends on the room before Emmett thumbs behind him. “I’m going to go help out in the kitchen.”

“You need to do a better job of looking happy about this,” Dad says after a few seconds. With only us left in the room, he doesn’t bother whispering.

I shrug and exhale a deep breath. “Are you happy about it?”

Dark brown eyes similar to my own fix on me. “Of course I’m not. Your ability is unmatched, and you have the makings to become one of the greatest forwards of all time.” He scoffs and runs a frustrated hand through his dark hair. “And if Jessie waltzes in here and pretends like he would’ve been happy with a team like the Rogues when he was a first-round draft pick, then I’ll likely lose my—”

“Lose your what, JJ?” A deep voice cuts my dad off. Only Mom ever refers to Dad using that nickname, although nothing about the way Jessie says it is endearing.

Dad and Jessie’s close friendship has been built around hockey. As former teammates and now coaches for different teams, they’ve always had a ton of respect between them. Respect that I can tell is being tested right here in this room tonight.

Jessie narrows his bright blue eyes at Dad. “You knew before tonight that there was a real chance that Will would be a Rogue, and it’s high time you got used to it. We’ve got the best facilities and coaching staff in the sport, and Will ...” Jessie sets his eyes on me, and I really do try to smile. “Will is going to have a fucking great career with me guiding him every step of the way.”

When it comes to the latter, I have zero doubts. Jessie—or soon-to-be Coach Callaghan—has consistently had my back, and we’ve always had a special bond. Hell, I’m even named after his late brother, who died when he was a few days old.

“Gah! Will! First stop, the University of Minnesota, and then Seattle!” Marley—Jessie and Mia’s fifteen-year-old daughter—strides into the room and wraps her arms around my shoulders, planting a kiss against my chest.

She’s only three years younger than me, but I tower over her petite frame.

If anyone can draw a grin from me, it’s Marley and her sunshiny personality. Once again, I try to look happy. She frowns when I fail, tipping her head to one side and studying me.

“I thought the NHL was your dream. You’ve been going on about it since I could understand words.”

“Playing for Toronto was his dream. The Seattle Rogues are beneath someone like William Jones.”

I roll my eyes as Drew Callaghan—eldest daughter of Jessie and Mia—perches her head on her sister’s shoulder.

“I don’t think I’m superior, Drew,” I drawl.

She quirks a brow, and I actually smile.

“I *know* I’m superior.”

Drew deadpans as she joins the circle our group has formed in the center of the room. With Jessie and Dad engaged in a debate over expansion teams and their importance in the league, I focus my attention on Drew and Marley.

“Here’s a little tip for you, Jones.” Drew squeezes her thumb and forefinger together until there’s a tiny space between them. “When you arrive in Minnesota in August, try and work on that cocky attitude. A twenty percent reduction should render you tolerable.”

I burst out laughing. If there’s one thing I’ll miss when I head off to college, it’s the banter I’ve always had with Jessie and Mia’s oldest daughter. Maybe it’s because I’m only eighteen months older than her, but that still doesn’t explain why she’s pretty much the only female friend I have—or would at least keep if we hadn’t been thrown together through circumstances surrounding our parents.

Drew’s the total opposite of me. We share dark-colored hair, and that’s the extent of our similarities. But if I were the jelly, she’d be the peanut

butter. Together, we just ... get along. Although I'm not all that sure she'd agree with me. Not based on the condescending way she's looking at me right now.

I smirk because it's fun to rile up someone who has their shit together twenty-four/seven. Anyone who graduates high school a year early is well ahead of the game, and Drew is exactly that person. At almost seventeen, she'll be staying in Seattle to study public relations while I geek out over math for four years.

What can I say? I'm smart, good-looking, and amazing at hockey.

With Jessie and Mia living mainly in Seattle, we only really get together when they stay in their New York apartment during the holidays and sometimes for the summer break, although I wasn't expecting to see her this time around.

"I thought you were staying behind in Seattle with your boyfriend," I say to Drew, taking a diet soda from Mom as she hurries around with drinks and snacks before Jessie and Dad break off to help her.

Drew drops her blue eyes to the floor, and Marley leans into her.

Fuck.

"I ended things with Boyd." Drew shrugs, and I feel like shit for the sad look on her face right now.

Unlike her sister, Drew always carries a stoic expression. She's self-assured, and she keeps her thoughts and emotions well hidden.

"He's heading to Texas for college, and I didn't think a long-term thing would work. Plus, we'll both be too busy with school."

I take a sip of soda, wishing Drew were still ripping the shit out of me. At least she sounded happy then, even if it was at my expense.

"Whatever the reason, breaking up sucks."

Drew chuckles low, throwing her wavy chocolate hair over one shoulder. "How would you know? Eighteen and never had a girlfriend."

"Ew, Drew," Marley announces, "I don't want to think about Will kissing anyone."

I waggle my brows at them both, and Marley looks disgusted.

"There's only one thing I'm better at than hockey." I laugh.

Arms folded across her chest, Drew tries to suppress a smirk and fails. I'm way too funny for her to succeed, and I love that.

"Let me guess ... making out."

Marley spins on her heel and is out of the room in seconds, leaving me and Drew alone with the voices of everyone else filtering from the kitchen.

“So, you’re telling me that girls actually stick around you long enough for you to kiss them?”

My eyes fall to her full lips and—*fuck, what the hell is wrong with me?* This is Drew Callaghan. Our parents have photo albums of us playing together in the backyard when we were babies, wearing nothing but diapers.

That said, it’s been way too long since I actually did kiss a girl, never mind got laid.

Two weeks too long.

Drew waves a dismissive hand in front of her. “Scratch that. I already knew you were the playboy around high school.” She groans. “That’s another thing you need to cut down on when you go to college and especially now that you’ve been drafted.” She pins me with a serious expression. “Stop putting your whole life on social media.”

I go to reply, but she starts counting on her fingers, like a teacher reaming me out for turning in shoddy homework.

“What you’re wearing, where you’re going out that night, who you’re going out with, who you kissed, what you ate for dinner that day, who you consider to be a first-rate asshole, and who you’d like to punch on the ice ...” She draws in a deep breath. “You have to start acting like a professional.”

I balk at her. “I am a professional. Always.”

Drew throws her head toward the ceiling and laughs so hard that I’m almost sure she’ll topple backward. Like her sister, she’s petite in build.

“You”—Drew points a manicured fingernail at me, one arm wrapped around her middle—“are anything but professional. I’m surprised the Rogues haven’t told you to remove ninety percent of your social media content.”

I frown. “What’s wrong with being honest and relatable? I thought that’s what fans wanted in celebrities these days.”

Drew shakes her head at me, another condescending expression overtaking her features. “And this is why I’m doing a degree in public relations—to help people like you from ruining your careers before you’ve even gotten started.”

The lines in my forehead no doubt grow deeper. “So, now that I’m officially drafted, I have to become boring?”

Hurt flashes through her eyes, and I hold up a hand.

“Not that I’m calling you boring. I—”

“You are calling me boring, Will,” Drew interrupts me. “And that’s okay because slow and steady always wins the race.”

I stare down into my soda glass, watching the bubbles pop for a second. People like Drew might think I’m a loose cannon, who doesn’t give a shit, but they couldn’t be more wrong.

It’s hard, having the weight of four years in college on your shoulders, along with the expectations of an entire hockey team that’s waiting for when you graduate.

“Work hard, play harder,” I eventually respond to her idiom with one of my own.

Her eyes sparkle right before she holds out a hand, and I slide my palm into hers. Warmth and soft skin steal my thoughts for a second before she speaks again.

“Well, anyway, congrats on the draft, Will. I’m sure you’re going to be amazing.”

1

. . .

Drew

Four Years Later—Late August

Seattle

Fixing my black suit jacket, I clear my throat and push through the heavy wooden door into the briefing room.

If I had my own PR company, this isn't how I would furnish it. These offices are too clinical, cold, and almost soulless. Only a floor plant, positioned in the far-right corner of the room, adds any kind of life or color to an otherwise bland box.

Still, the office decor wasn't the reason why I joined First Line PR straight out of college just over a year ago. Colton Davis, the CEO, is renowned for signing some of the biggest names in sports and has a reputation for being forward-thinking when it comes to building and maintaining their brand.

When I completed an internship here in my junior year of college, I knew he was the guy I wanted to build my experience with, in the hopes that, one day, I'd be ready to open my own firm and replicate some of the best practices I learned while working here.

"Drew!" Hands in the pockets of his gray suit pants, Colton spins on his heel and invites me to take a seat on one of the white leather chairs surrounding an oval-shaped table.

Setting my laptop down in front of me, I opt for the usual seat, which gives me the best view of the projector, set at the front of the room.

I wouldn't say that Colton intimidates me, even though he's fifteen years older than me and also my boss. However, when he calls me into an early morning meeting with zero indication of what it will be about, I do grow a touch anxious.

This can't be to do with my performance. At my review last month, he was happy with the portfolio of clients I had been building. Most of the names are smaller, such as a couple of major league rugby stars, but I did recently receive great feedback from upcoming tennis sensation Malcolm Leroy, who made a wild card entry to the Wimbledon Championships this year.

"Don't look so damn worried, Drew," Colton breathes out, sliding back the chair opposite me and taking a seat. He balances one leg over the other knee and casually leans back, chewing on his bottom lip.

I open the lid on my laptop and navigate to the Notes app. "Sorry, I was focused on getting here on time after I got your meeting invite late last night."

Colton smirks and checks his watch. "We're a half hour early getting started. I can't imagine you being late to anything in your life." He taps his chin, brown scruff lining a strong jaw and deep brown eyes narrowing in thought. "Come to think of it, I don't think you've ever been late to work."

I flush because he's right.

As I type out the date and time, ready to begin taking notes, Colton rests his elbows on the table and clicks his tongue.

"We secured the Rogues contract."

My head whips up, my eyes bulging out of their sockets. "But I thought you weren't expecting to hear if we'd been hired for another couple of weeks."

Colton looks delighted. "I actually have you to thank for that."

Interest piqued, I sit up straighter in my chair. "How so?"

"Will Jones."

I stop typing and eye my boss over the rim of my screen. Will signing with the Seattle Rogues this season isn't exactly fresh news, although I remain clueless as to why that has anything to do with me.

For the past four years, Will and I have kept in light touch, only seeing each other at family events and the holidays. That said, I haven't been totally oblivious to his time spent in college or while playing in the NCAA.

It's hard to miss anything that boy does with his daily movements constantly shared on social media.

I internally roll my eyes at the memory of his posts from last week, when he arrived in Seattle and immediately bought a McLaren Artura Coupe in racing green with gold detailing, captioning the post: *Touchdown in Seattle. Time to go Rogue.*

From the first memories I have of Will to when I last saw him at Christmas, he's always been the same—incredibly self-assured, to the point where he's arrogant and impulsive, especially with money; committed to hockey, but not much else, especially women. He's the ultimate alpha playboy with a bank balance and athletic skill set to match.

Really not my type of man.

Yet, beneath all that bravado, there's a person the world has yet to see. A kind heart that occasionally reveals itself in the gold flecks of the deepest brown eyes I've ever seen.

"What about him?" I ask, playing a little dumb.

Colton knows about my association with the star rookie forward and especially the history between our parents.

He hesitates for a beat when we lock eyes. "The Seattle Rogues have expressed some ... concerns over his online conduct and public image."

He scratches at the back of his neck. My boss is a huge Rogues fan, so I know he's all too aware of the reputation Will carries.

"Ordinarily, the Rogues keep their PR in-house, especially for rookies, but when we pitched to them a couple of weeks ago and they started talking about Will being a potential client"—he winces a little—"I kind of dropped your name, and with your dad being the head coach, I explained that we would be well suited to offer Will the support he needed as he made the transition from collegiate hockey to the pros. Since he won't be spending a year playing in the AHL, he'll need all the help he can get to successfully navigate the huge jump."

Other than the date, time, and a couple of lines, I've barely made any notes since I sat down a few minutes ago.

My fingers pause over the keyboard. "You want me to assist you with representing Will Jones?"

When Colton shakes his head, I feel a stab of disappointment. Sure, even in the infancy of his pro career, Will is already a bigger name than any of my existing clients, but I have a head start over anyone else working at

First Line. Even my boss. The new Rogues forward is a complex character, and I have him all figured out.

Colton points at me, eyes sparkling with something like excitement. “I want you to take the lead with Will and represent him. The Rogues think it’s a great idea, and I agree with them.”

Although I aim to sound more casual when I ask, “Are you serious?!” I actually come off as an overenthusiastic puppy who’s just been shown a bowl of their favorite food.

My boss chuckles low, nodding his head a few times. “Yes, for real. Naturally, we’ll have weekly check-ins so you can ask any questions and we can talk about the progression of Will’s public profile, but I think you’re ready to expand your client list and take on something—or someone—a little more challenging.”

I shut my laptop, brain spinning out and rendering me incapable of making notes.

“Does Will know anything about this?”

Colton’s eyes flick up to the clock positioned on the wall above my head. “He will in around an hour. The general manager will call him in for a conversation ahead of the preseason getting under way.”

“And my dad?”

Despite moving out of my parents’ home in Kirkland six months ago, I still speak to them almost daily, and Dad hasn’t breathed a word about Will or the contract being awarded to First Line.

He shrugs his shoulders. “I’m not sure how much Coach Callaghan knew about First Line’s interest in representing his players.”

I scrunch up my nose. “He’s only concerned with what happens inside the rink. As long as nothing from the outside affects his team’s performance, then he doesn’t care much beyond that.”

Colton hums his agreement. “I’d be the same if I were him—another bottom-of-the-league finish last season has got to be weighing heavy on his shoulders by now.”

I smile at my boss, though it’s only to mask the truth in his statement. Sometimes, I wonder if Dad regrets taking on the role and relinquishing the college hockey job he had before the Rogues were formed. With the Scorpions flying high each season, it feels like the city is divided, and while Emmett Richards’s appointment a few seasons back has definitely helped, I

know Dad is holding out for Will's arrival to make an impact on the team and start turning losses into the wins they desperately need.

And regardless of his cocky nature, Will absolutely possesses the type of generational talent it takes to alter the fortunes of a team and inspire its fan base.

Quickly, excitement over the prospect of working with Will—along with the exposure this could bring for my own career—fizzles out, leaving behind the reality of what I'll be taking on.

Will hasn't hit one puck in the NHL yet, and he's already got millions of eyes on him across North America.

I swallow hard, and Colton notices the shift in my demeanor.

"Is this something you want to take on, Drew?"

I pause on answering for the briefest second.

"Because I personally think you are ready." He continues talking. "Sure, Will is a handful—we all know that—but I really think this is a great chance for you to get your name—"

"I want the job." I don't even let Colton finish his sentence.

He smiles and clasps his hands on the wooden table in front of him. "And you know I'll be here to support you, right?"

I nod once, pushing all self-doubt to the back of my mind.

It's Will, for Christ's sake. If he gives me shit, I'll just tell him to get a goddamn grip and start acting like a professional. We've known each other for years, and he isn't about to screw this up for either of us. He wouldn't do that to me.

"Good. That's settled then," Colton confirms, dropping his leg and standing. "I think your priority is to first study his existing social media—along with any other public platforms he may have—and work out what needs to be archived."

Just the entire past decade then.

Reopening my laptop, I hastily begin taking notes.

"I also think it would be wise to draft up a tailored crisis management plan and have Will approve it within the first week of you two working together."

My fingers still. Crisis management is a part of what we do as publicists, but it's interesting Colton wants me to pull one together so quickly and one customized for Will.

“What about brand partnerships?” I question. “Do we need to steer Will’s image in a certain direction and align with particular companies?”

Colton nods. “I understand that Will’s team has several potential deals in the works, although nothing has dropped as of yet.” Lines form across his forehead. “Apparently, a deal with a huge, and very influential, new sneaker brand went south a couple of weeks ago, and that’s contributed to the Rogues seeking external PR expertise.”

My jaw pops open. “Are you talking about Repeet? They’re making waves in the leisure industry right now.”

Colton nods and grimaces at the same time.

I rack my brain, trying to think over what Will could’ve posted or said that would put a brand deal like that in jeopardy.

When Colton gets a call on his cell, I take advantage of the pause and pull up Will’s socials.

Nothing on TikTok.

Or Threads.

Nothing on Instagram.

Fuck.

Will got into an online argument with a New York Blades fan two weeks ago over ...

Potato chips?

He doesn’t even eat junk food.

“My body is a temple and should be treated as such.”

Once again, I internally roll my eyes, recalling a line Will has regurgitated so many times around the dinner table. I’d happily shove a brownie down his throat just so I didn’t have to hear it again.

“So, yeah”—Colton ends the call and picks up his previous thread —“right now, the priority is curating his image into something approachable and humble.”

How I don’t snicker I’ve no idea.

“Sure,” I say with a sweet smile, tucking my laptop under one arm before I stand.

“I’m certain you’re already aware of this, Drew. But I want you to make Will your top client. And if that means relinquishing some of your smaller clients for the benefit of this relationship, then I don’t want you to hesitate in coming to me.”

I nod once and make for the door, ready to start work the second I reach my desk.

With my hand on the door handle, I turn around to face my boss. While I might be the obvious choice to represent Will, considering our history, the risk Colton's taking isn't lost on me—I'm good at my job, but I've also been a full-time publicist for just over a year, and compared to a lot of my colleagues, I'm very inexperienced.

"I really appreciate this chance," I tell the man who has believed in me from the second I walked through his doors. "And I won't let you down."

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Will

“Will, you got a second?”

Dressed in gray sweats and a black Dri-FIT, Jessie Callaghan—and now my coach—stops me before entering the gym.

After the meeting I just had with him, my agent, the team owners, general manager, and the in-house PR team, I need to blow off some steam. I’ll be honest, when I’m this pissed at something, it’s hard for me to remain professional. I’m hotheaded, like the rest of my family. Call it a classic Jones trait.

Add in the fact that I see Jessie as more of an uncle than a coach, and I’m fighting even harder to keep my cool.

My silence when we lock eyes causes him to wince as he thumbs behind him to a door.

The Rogues’ arena in Belltown is state-of-the-art, with an underground players’ gym and multiple briefing rooms. When the US-based consortium had this place designed, they wanted to keep everything under one roof—from where we played and practiced to individual conditioning programs the players would undertake in the preseason.

Great idea in principle, but when I’m in this kind of mood, I’d do anything for a bit of goddamn privacy.

They want to introduce special fucking PR measures because I cannot be trusted to run my own social media.

And to add insult to injury, Drew Callaghan has been assigned to represent me now that she works for some hotshot PR company called First Line, or whatever the hell it is.

Taking orders is hard enough for me at the best of times, and now I'm receiving them from two people with the same last name.

"I need some time to think about what happened in there." I point down the hallway toward the room where I was summoned an hour ago. "Because me being put under surveillance came straight out of left field."

Coach's brows pull together, and he turns on his heel, depressing the handle and opening the door. "Maybe we should have this conversation away from any potential eavesdroppers."

I scoff and nod my head, walking into the meeting room and dumping myself down on a black leather desk chair.

This place is a corporate dream, every single room adorning the green-white-and-gold Rogues' logo.

It makes me want to throw up. Where are the trophies and pictures from former players lifting the Cup?

Oh, right. Yeah, they don't exist.

Waiting for Coach to take a seat on the opposite side of the table, I know he doesn't deserve my bratty attitude. There's no way he had a hand in my fate, even if I'll be his daughter's new client.

Coach pulls on the bill of his green cap and exhales a long breath. "I don't think assigning you an external publicist is totally left field. All the guys on the team have representation of some kind."

I slump down in my seat and fold my arms across my chest. "How many rookies have been hauled into a meeting room before they've played one game for the team and told that they need to be monitored to avoid ending up at the center of a PR crisis?"

Coach clears his throat.

"I mean, take your career, for example." I hold my hand out. "You went through your fair share of shit, but did you ever have that happen?"

He just smiles, although it's too dark to be friendly. "No. I got kicked off the team and traded to the other side of the country instead."

I fall quiet because that's exactly what happened. Coach's early career wasn't unlike my own—while I haven't fallen for his daughter like he did his GM's, I am a rookie with the weight of fans' expectations on my shoulders.

"I'm not a liability, Coach," I tell him.

He quirks a brow and reaches into his jacket pocket, pulling out his cell and scrolling. "So, your Instagram was hacked when your handle responded

to a comment underneath a post about your new fancy car, saying, *Since I'm stuck playing for the worst team in the league, I used my fat signing bonus to lessen the pain.*"

I roll my lips together, trying to suppress an inappropriate smirk. I forgot about that reply.

Coach taps his phone screen a couple of times. "Or how about the blonde you're pictured with here?"

He turns the phone around so I can see the supermodel hanging off my arm in a nightclub last week. It was posted to my stories, so he must've taken a screenshot and kept it as evidence.

"At least I'll be scoring somewhere in Seattle. The girls in this city are fiiiine," Coach reads the caption I posted to go with the image of the girl whose name I can't remember. Although we did bang that night in her hotel. She was on a bachelorette weekend, and I don't have a list of girls to hit up in Seattle. Yet.

He shakes his head and repockets his phone.

"It's not like you have alcohol to blame, Will. You hardly ever drink, and I'm proud of you for that."

I puff out my chest a little. "Very rarely."

With the way he's looking at me right now, you'd never believe that we're practically family. Damn, this guy has professionalism down to a fine art. I see where his daughter gets it from.

After a few beats of nothing, Coach releases a sigh. "You have an amazing career ahead of you, and it's a true privilege to be coaching you." He pauses for a moment, bright blue eyes that remind me of Drew's fixing me in place. "But you have a lot of learning to do. Pro hockey is nothing like the NCAA. Here, you have a team paying you extortionate wages, and they expect nothing but your best."

I nod my head. "I'm committed to the game—you know I am."

He doesn't argue with my statement. "On the ice, you're one of the hardest-working rookies I've seen. Off the ice, you're ..." He swallows. "Well, you're a fucking nightmare."

My mouth hangs open.

So, Coach *did* have a hand in the meeting earlier today.

"Was First Line PR and Drew your idea?" I ask, voice laced with contempt. It's ill-advised for me to get mad with the guy who calls the shots over my fate, but I'm done playing around.

“Jessie,” I demand, knowing that I’m overstepping player-coach boundaries.

Lips pursed, he palms the desk separating us. “It’s Coach to you, Will. And since you asked, no, I didn’t have a clue that Drew was going to represent you. First Line PR got the contract, and all other decisions were made without my knowledge.” He leans back in his chair. “Believe it or not, my concerns center around what goes on *inside* the rink.”

Our gazes are trained on each other as neither of us speaks for several seconds.

“You wanted to see me, Coach?” A male voice I don’t recognize filters through the door.

Coach turns to face it, voice adopting a much softer edge as he says, “Yeah, sure, come in, Silas.”

Silas Stanton—light-brown hair, dark blue eyes, a defenseman and the Rogues one and only captain since they first formed—waltzes into the room.

With a tip of his chin, he acknowledges Coach and immediately holds out his hand for me to shake.

I reciprocate, but don’t return the warm smile he gives me. It’s obvious Coach invited him here for a purpose, and I’m willing to bet it has something to do with why I’m sitting here.

Other than his game, I know very little about this guy. His career has been checkered with injuries and dubious press reports speculating on his personal life. Only since Silas joined the Rogues has he straightened up his act outside of the rink. Bar fights, random women, and wild house parties made up the first few years of his pro-playing days. Now thirty-one, he’s arguably one of the veterans on a really young team.

The perfect role model for me.

“It’s good to finally meet the guy the state of Washington cannot stop talking about.” Silas squeezes my hand before releasing his grip and taking a seat next to me. He drums his fingers on the armrest of his chair. “How can I help, Coach?”

Scrubbing a hand across his jaw, Coach looks from my teammate to me. “I thought it would be good for you both to formally meet before the preseason kicks into overdrive on Monday.”

Neither me nor my new captain says anything.

“The plan is for you to share a hotel room where possible during an away series. I want Will rooming with either you, or another senior member of the team.”

I huff out a breath. Sure, it’s not unusual for rookies to room with their captain or an older player on the team, but to make it so official is really odd.

I turn over my shoulder and examine the room behind me.

“What’s the matter, Will?” Coach asks.

I focus back on Coach. “I was wondering where the day care center was in this building. You know, just in case you want me to register there too.”

Silas snorts a laugh, and it’s immediately snubbed by Coach’s glare.

“I’m just trying to make the transition from college to the pro hockey world as seamless as possible for you, Will. I don’t think you truly understand how many pairs of eyes are going to be watching your every move. You’ve been living in Seattle for two weeks, and you’re already attracting attention.”

I shrug. “Surely, that’s good for the team, no?”

From beside me, Silas shakes his head. “Not when the Rogues already carry a reputation for being reckless. We’ve managed to rack up more league fines in five seasons than the Scorpions have in double that time.”

I hold up a hand. “From misconducts that have nothing to do with me.”

Coach tips his head from side to side. “True, but we can’t afford to have you arguing with fans on the internet and acting like a complete jackass all over the city.” His voice turns softer. “I know you didn’t want to join the Rogues, but we have been desperately waiting for you. The fans have been highly anticipating your arrival.”

I think back to the final few games of last season and how Dad told me they had chanted my last name at one home game he attended.

I roll my shoulders back, attempting to alleviate the unwelcome pressure weighing them down. “I don’t like being told what to do; it makes me feel like a child when there are guys younger than me on the team. It also feels weird to have your daughter represent me and call the shots over my public image.”

My new captain’s eyes grow wider. “Drew?”

After a second, Coach nods his head. “Yeah, Drew is going to be working with Will.”

Silas puffs out a breath. “Well, you’re in good hands there.” He folds his arms across his chest. “And I’m not just saying that because she’s your daughter, Coach. I work with her colleague, Lydia West, and while I don’t want to come off as rude, Drew makes her look like an amateur.”

That doesn’t surprise me at all. I bet Lydia “loves” her already.

“You should give her a chance, Will,” Silas adds. “Twelve months, and you’ll be the league’s golden boy, shutting sponsorship deals.”

Exhaling a long, exhausted breath, I massage my left temple. “All right, I’ll work with Drew and try to stay in line.”

Sitting up straighter in his chair, Coach practically beams. “Good decision, Will. Now let’s crush the preseason.”

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Drew

WILL

Have you moved?

ME

No. Why?

WILL

I'm standing outside your apartment door, and no one is answering. When I asked one of your neighbors if you still lived here, she looked at me blankly.

ME

Ah, you likely spoke to Mary. She forgets everything. Plus, I've only met her twice. Why are you there anyway? Our meeting isn't until tomorrow, and it's at the First Line offices. I'm out right now.

WILL

Where are you?

ME

At the store, grocery shopping.

WILL

Don't get anything for dinner tonight.

With a loaded shopping cart, I stare down at Will's random text.

ME

Why not? I'm literally about to pay for a whole week's worth.

WILL

Because I'm taking you out tonight to celebrate.

ME

...

WILL

Duh. It's your birthday tomorrow, isn't it? Plus, you get to work with me, so that, in itself, needs to be commemorated.

Also, working on your 21st birthday is dull and should be illegal.

ME

I have a ton of work to do tonight.

WILL

So? Do it afterward. Didn't you ever pull an all-nighter in college? I did. And not just because the librarian was hot.

Wait, scratch that. Of course you didn't. You were the annoying one, asking the professor to bring the deadline forward.

I'll hang out with Mary while I wait for you to get home.

Forty minutes later, I'm hauling multiple grocery bags out of the elevator and trying to balance everything in my black work heels when Will appears in front of me, wearing a crooked grin.

Hands in the pockets of his black dress pants, he drops his eyes to my bags. "Need a little help with all that?"

Here's the thing: Will Jones is a god on the ice. I guess, considering his dad's talent, the chances of him making it pro were always high. But this guy makes even the greatest players look straight average. I'd also be a liar—or totally blind—to deny how good-looking he is. Loose, dark waves—which any woman would kill for—complement olive skin while a smattering of freckles across high cheekbones finishes off a model-worthy face.

And don't get me started on that prominent jawline or the way his sophisticated taste in clothes screams of a man several years older than Will and in his late twenties. Combine that with Will's boyish charm and features, and it's dynamite to the opposite sex.

Trouble is, Will already knows all of the above, and that is a huge turnoff for me. Not that I've ever really thought about Will that way or

entertained the prospect of anything more than we already are—friends who can't help but clash due to our differences.

I've had a few boyfriends over the years, and each of them has shared similar qualities: humble and understated in their appearance and personality.

My parents always taught me that pride comes before a fall and never to believe your own hype. Will Jones embodies all those characteristics.

"I'm good," I tell him, stepping into the hallway and making for my front door.

It feels like my fingers might fall off when Will dips his hand into my jacket pocket and pulls out my apartment key, unlocking my door and opening it.

My place is nice, and that has nothing to do with the modest salary I earn. Thanks to my dad's long and illustrious pro hockey career, our family wants for nothing. That said, we're nowhere near as wealthy as the Joneses, who have multiple houses across the country and one of the biggest legal practices in the US. Will's mom, Kate, is a phenomenal lawyer and, alongside a couple of friends, has built a legal empire over the last decade.

Will and his sister, June, have lived in luxury their entire lives, although I definitely wouldn't describe them as spoiled when it comes to getting their own way. Kate would never allow that and insisted that her son complete four years in college to get a full education before he set foot in the NHL. Will wanted to turn pro straight out of the draft, but no one argues with Kate Jones.

Literally no one.

"I won't ask how you knew where I kept my door key," I say, leading him into a white marble kitchen and setting the bags down on the island.

He closes my front door and hooks the keys onto the holder, which sits above a white console table in my entryway.

When he reaches my kitchen, he does a three-sixty spin and inspects the space, hands back in his pockets and a gray sweater rolled up to the elbows. It's open at the collar, revealing a thin yellow gold chain I don't recognize. There's a small medallion hanging from it, and I'd move a little closer to inspect it if that wouldn't look weird and somewhat invasive. I wonder if it was a gift for his twenty-second birthday last February since he wasn't wearing it at Christmas.

“What can I say, Drew?” Will’s dark eyes land on mine, and he walks toward me, dipping one hand into a grocery bag and pulling out a tub of brownie ice cream. “You’re that predictable.”

I frown at him and snatch the ice cream from his grasp, marching it across to my freezer, where I pull open a drawer and add it to my already-well-stocked stash.

“Ooh, strawberry cheesecake.”

I’m back across the kitchen and taking the dessert from his hands. “Just because you only eat chicken and brown rice doesn’t mean others don’t live like normal people.”

Will chuckles and peers into another bag, which I grab and pull out of his sight.

“I’m not here to judge your eating habits, even if you do have enough ice cream to feed all of Seattle.”

I deadpan and prop my hands on my hips, foot tapping impatiently against the glossy gray floor tiles. “I’d say you’re absolutely judging me, and I don’t appreciate it. Especially now that we’ll be working together in a professional capacity.”

Maybe it’s my imagination, but when Will’s eyes drop down the length of my body, I swear he bites on the corner of his lip.

I’d also have to be blind to miss the way this man tears through women like the female population is due to turn extinct at any moment. Still, my cheeks heat at the way he takes in my black suit dress and jacket, even if I know he can’t help but flirt with every woman he sets eyes on.

“Speaking of which”—Will checks the gold Rolex on his left wrist—“I’m really fucking hungry, and it’s going to take us at least a half hour to get across town at this time of day.”

I frown. “Why travel that far? There’s a nice Italian restaurant a couple of blocks away.”

Rounding the island, Will moves toward me. He walks like he skates—effortlessly and with a swagger I can’t easily describe, causing my sentence to die before I’ve finished it.

“Because I don’t eat just anywhere, Drew. You know I only eat organic, and half of all restaurants try to get away with foods packed full of additives.”

I’d point out that this Italian restaurant only serves homemade food if I cared enough to argue. But just like with his mom it’s pointless trying to

change Will's mind once it's made up.

"All right," I drawl and point to the bags and then my clothes. "But give me at least ten minutes to put away my unhealthy shopping and change into something more casual. Then I'll call us a taxi."

Will clears his throat and grimaces. "You might be a little underdressed in casual clothes. And I have my car, so no taxi needed."

Sliding a packet of spaghetti into one of the top cupboards, I mentally cycle through the clothes in my wardrobe. "How fancy are we talking?"

Will sidles up alongside me with a packet of white rice. From this proximity, I can smell his expensive, spicy cologne, which could easily be overpowering if he didn't apply just the right amount.

"Like two hundred dollars for an entrée."

I almost choke on my own tongue. While we were both raised around money, my parents lived—and still do live—a very modest lifestyle. Dad came from a background where he had nothing, and when Mom witnessed his awful childhood, I think it put a lot into perspective for her too. Most of their money is piled into their beloved charity for domestic abuse victims, Never Silent, where my sister and I volunteered during summer breaks from school.

"Will, that's ..." My sentence trails off when I swivel to face him and realize just how close he actually is.

Full lips tip into a panty-melting smile that I'm sure he's perfected in the bathroom mirror.

"What other plans do you have for your twenty-first birthday?"

I think about it for a second. "Dinner at my parents' tomorrow night. Dad's cooking my favorite pot roast."

The way he wants to roll his eyes is obvious, although he doesn't. "I'm not letting your big day pass without at least a filet mignon and a glass of Dom Pérignon."

I roll my eyes instead, cheeks burning again because I'm shit at accepting compliments or being spoiled in any capacity at all. And frustratingly, Will already knows that.

"I'm paying half the bill."

He shakes his head and moves back to the island, pulling out a bunch of bananas.

"See, I do eat healthy," I declare, pointing at the fruit in his hand.

His free hand disappears inside another bag—the one where the ice cream and cheesecake appeared from earlier.

“Whipped cream.” He sets the can on the island, going back for something else. “Cherries.” He lowers his hand and pulls out the last item. “And sprinkles.”

I shrug and close the top cupboard above my head.

“Call me a genius, Baby. But these look like the ingredients for an ice cream sundae or a fancy hot chocolate.”

I skip over his accurate observation and zero in on the real reason behind my annoyance. “Did you just call me Baby?”

Will’s lips curl into a devilish smile. “I sure did. Now that we’re partners, I figure I should call you a nickname that fits my uber-unprofessional reputation.”

I scoff and snatch the whipped cream from the side, opening the refrigerator.

“Address me as Baby again, and I’ll be storing this”—I wave the can of whipped cream at him—“where the sun doesn’t shine.”

4

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Will

“**W**hat’s the matter?” I ask Drew, pulling into the restaurant’s valet parking and killing the McLaren’s engine.

She scoffs and shakes her head, still staring out the windshield. “You do realize that this place won’t have any tables for another three months?” Drew points a pink manicured finger at the restaurant entrance. “You can’t just walk in there and expect to be served.”

I look confused because I am. “I have the last three times I ate here.”

Her head whips to me. “Three times?! You’ve only been living in Seattle for two weeks.”

I shrug, and the valet opens the driver’s door.

Stepping out, I hand him the keys, and Drew climbs out when one of his colleagues opens her door.

“What’s the big deal? They sell delicious food, and the owners are nice.”

Standing under the bright entryway lights, the girl I splashed around in baby pools with looks every bit my date for tonight, and I’d be a liar to claim otherwise. The black bodycon dress she’s wearing hits mid-thigh while hot-pink sandals match her nail polish perfectly. She’s kept her hair in the tight, low bun she was wearing when I showed up at her place, which surprises me since I’ve only ever seen it around her shoulders.

It’s clear that work Drew is very different from the girl I’ve only encountered in social circles. I could sense it from the email she’d sent me to arrange a meeting, which I absolutely wasn’t going to have in an office on her twenty-first birthday.

Who the fuck doesn’t go out and celebrate a huge milestone like that?

Drew Callaghan is who.

Maybe I shouldn't have called her Baby earlier, although I couldn't help it. She's always thought I was unprofessional, so I might as well go the whole way with a cutesy nickname.

"Mr. Jones," the server who waited on my table last week immediately greets me before guiding us to a table set at the back of the plush restaurant.

I like the vibe in The Loft. Dark blue tablecloths, low-level lighting, and candles on the tables give it an exclusive feel, which goes with their insanely expensive menu.

The server's eyes track to Drew as he pulls out a cream chair for her, and she takes a seat opposite me.

"Are we celebrating tonight?" he asks, adjusting the white towel over his arm.

I'm half tempted to call Drew Baby again and explain that we're on a date, but I think better of it at the final second. I don't doubt that she'd follow through with her threat and shove a can of whipped cream up my ass.

I tip my chin at Drew right as, "No," leaves her lips, and I say, "Tomorrow is Drew's birthday, so we'll take a bottle of your best champagne."

With a tight nod and a, "Happy birthday," the server makes for the bar, leaving two unimpressed eyes boring into my skull as I examine the menu.

"The steaks here are really good and all grass-fed."

"Are you for real?" Drew's tone of voice tears my eyes away from the menu.

"Huh?"

"I said, are you for real?" she repeats. "You know I'm not twenty-one until tomorrow, so technically, I can't drink alcohol until then."

Closing the menu because I already know I'm having the mignon, I clasp my hands together and study her right as the server returns with a champagne bucket. He takes the bottle and pops the cork. Another server sets a bottle of water in the center of the table, along with two champagne flutes and two water glasses.

After he's filled our water glasses, the server goes to fill my champagne glass, and I set a hand over the top.

"Only for the birthday girl tonight," I tell him, earning me a glare from across the table.

I probably shouldn't be smirking at Drew as the server pours the champagne and asks her to taste it.

"Yeah, it's really nice. Thank you."

He fills her glass to the top, sets the bottle in the ice bucket, and leaves, confirming he'll be back to take our food order in a moment.

Silence descends on our table as I pick up my water glass and hold it out in front of me.

"Happy twenty-first birthday, Baby."

Full, peach-stained lips roll together. "You just couldn't help it, could you?"

I grin around the rim of my water glass. "Loosen up a bit, Drew. No one here knows you're only twenty, and they think you're my date, so I doubt any questions will be asked."

She leans forward and whisper-hisses, "And that's precisely the problem—I'm not your date. In fact, as of yesterday, you're officially my client, and within the space of twenty-four hours"—she casts a hand over the table—"I'm sitting opposite you in a tight black dress with a whole-ass bottle of champagne while everyone around us thinks we're banging!"

I just grin again because this is way too much fucking fun. "I don't personally see a problem. Let people think what they want. The staff here doesn't gossip."

Drew's head lolls forward, an exasperated noise leaving her lips. "Since we're here, I might as well lay some ground rules."

When she lifts her gaze back to mine, the stern look in her eyes is unmistakable.

She goes to speak and then stops, picking up her black purse and unzipping it.

Drew pulls out a black pen and then a small notepad, and I burst into hysterics.

"Why did you bring stationery to your birthday meal?"

I don't get a response, only a click of her pen and a quirked brow.

"*Rule one*"—she begins scrawling—"Never address the publicist as Baby."

Thoroughly entertained with the way she's lecturing me like I'm not the next biggest talent in hockey, I revel in the way it oddly puts me at ease.

"*Rule two: From now on, all official meetings between the client and publicist must take place in the First Line PR offices.*"

I wait for her to finish writing before clarifying, “This isn’t an official meeting. We’re here to celebrate your birthday as friends.”

I’m ignored once more.

“Rule three: The client should never show up at his publicist’s apartment without her prior knowledge or approval.”

I nod my agreement since I hate unannounced visitors too.

When Drew bites the end of her pen in thought, my throat runs dry, and I pick up my water glass to take a sip.

“Rule four”—her eyes lift to mine, mirth sparkling in her blue irises —“There is to be no judgment about what the publicist eats or drinks. That includes any working lunches the client and publicist might share or events they might attend together.”

“Wait.” I hold up a hand. “Why would you come to events with me?”

Drew blows out a breath, although I see the subtle pink flush as it stains her cheeks. “Why wouldn’t I? I’ll be responsible for writing speeches you give and curating your overall image. The best way to gauge how you’re received in the public eye is to witness it firsthand. Obviously, I’ll be keeping a low profile. In fact, you’ll barely know I’m there.”

If you’re wearing dresses like the one tonight, I’ll definitely fucking notice.

I smile and nod my agreement. “Makes sense, I guess.”

“Rule five: The publicist will require the client’s credentials and around-the-clock access to all of his social media accounts.”

I balk. “Why the hell do you need that?”

She throws me a confused look and holds out a hand. “Does that really need an explanation? To be honest, you might as well give me your usernames and passwords now so I can log straight in and start posting on your behalf. Our content creator already has a brief from me. First, we’ll start with a post that confirms how happy you are to be joining the Rogues since there isn’t any sign of that from you.”

“Nope.” I shake my head. “No way. I run my social media. If I hand it over to someone, then people will notice a change.”

Drew’s chuckle is dark. “That’s precisely what we’re aiming for. We’re looking to create a more personable profile with less of the jackass attitude your followers have come to expect.”

I’m sure I look offended, and that only makes her laugh more.

The server returns to our table, and Drew orders ... a fucking Caesar salad?!

“Have you turned vegetarian?” I quickly ask before the server leaves.

Drew’s eyes dart from the server to me. “Um, no. I just didn’t want—”

“We’ll go with two filet mignons, please. Both medium rare,” I confirm.

The server nods his head and makes a note. “Any side dishes to go with your filets? I can recommend the garlic greens.”

I can feel Drew’s eyes as I say, “One of each dish, please. My girlfriend has eclectic taste buds.”

“Wait.” Drew stops the server before he leaves, a menacing grin overtaking her expression. She picks up the menu again and flips to the dessert section at the back.

Don’t you fucking dare.

“And my boyfriend has a sweet tooth, so I’ll just go ahead and order our desserts right now.”

The server looks bemused but complies.

When her eyes stop scanning, I know my low sugar diet is fucked.

“A slice of your strawberry cheesecake, please.” She snaps the menu shut and hands it to the server. “With extra cream.”

Silence falls between us before she simply smiles and picks her pen back up.

“Rule six: To add further to rule four, the client shall never order food on his publicist’s behalf. Not unless he wants to be diagnosed with early-onset diabetes, courtesy of desserts being forced down his throat.”

I grind my molars at the prospect of eating the first dessert I’ve had in years. Hell, I don’t even have an Advent calendar at Christmas.

“You can eat the cheesecake,” I tell her.

“Well, I guess you’re enjoying two filet mignons and a ridiculous number of sides then, aren’t you?” she volleys back.

More silence to go with our stalemate.

“My username is the email you sent the meeting invite to.” I begin speaking after a few beats. “And my password is”—I lean forward—*“Will has a really nice ass that I want to Kiss twenty-five. Capitalized W and K with the number expressed in numerals.”*

Drew doesn’t even respond as she writes down my login details and pulls her phone from her bag, opening the Instagram app first. “Is that the password for all of your accounts?”

I nod once. “Yep. Apart from Facebook because I fucking hate that site and don’t use it.”

When she finishes entering the password, I hit Accept on a verification email, which grants her immediate access.

“Holy fucking shit,” she whispers, lips parting to form an O. “Will, you have over ten thousand notifications here. When was the last time you checked them?”

I shrug. “While you were getting changed. But I also have over a million followers, and I posted while I was waiting for you to get back home, so ...”

She navigates to my profile grid and opens the post I made over an hour ago.

The first image is a picture of her white front door and nothing else.

“When you’re stood up for a date,” she reads the first line of the caption and swipes to the next image, which is a selfie I took of myself, smiling, *“and you showed up, looking like this.”*

To be fair, I look fucking hot, and that post one hundred percent warrants all the engagement it’s getting.

Slowly, Drew closes her eyes. “For the love of God, William, what if someone recognizes my door?” She tips her head across the room at our server. “Or a certain someone starts talking about you showing up with me tonight as your girlfriend.” She pokes her pointer finger at her chest. “We both have famous names in hockey.”

“No one is going to talk, and if people can decipher your white front door from millions of others in the world, then they deserve their five minutes of going viral for being a smart-ass.”

She grumbles something inaudible just before a private message notification drops down. I can’t see the whole thing, but it’s obviously from a girl, and it’s for sure a booty call. The kissing-face emojis and wet symbols give it away.

Drew drops the phone to the table with a clatter. Almost disgusted. “Are you hooking up via Instagram?!”

I shrug and act like I’m not a little embarrassed.

“It’s safer than me giving girls my number. If we hook up one night, then this is a better way to keep in touch for round two.”

All the blood drains from her face.

“Rule seven: Moving forward, the client will never ever share private messages with random members of the public, especially for hooking-up purposes.”

“Then how will I ... you know,” I ask, waggling my brows, which I know she hates, “arrange to meet up after a game or something?”

Drew throws up a hand. “I don’t much care. So long as it can’t be screen-grabbed, it’s not really my concern.”

“Are we done with the rules?”

“Yes,” she confirms, looking more than pleased with herself. “For now.”

Picking up her phone, she takes a picture for her own records and hands me the piece of paper. “This is for you. Sign it and keep it as a point of reference.”

I take the black pen she was using, sign at the bottom, and fold it in half. “Is this the usual contract you make with your clients?”

Drew makes a face akin to pride. “No. And I’m sure you’ll be stoked to know that you’re one of my more unique—and high-maintenance—clients.”

Drew’s List of Rules for William “Hotshot” Jones

Rule one: Never address the publicist as Baby.

Rule two: From now on, all official meetings between the client and publicist must take place in the First Line PR offices.

Rule three: The client should never show up at his publicist’s apartment without her prior knowledge or approval.

Rule four: There is to be no judgment about what the publicist eats or drinks. That includes any working lunches the client and publicist might share or events they might attend together.

Rule five: The publicist will require the client's credentials and around-the-clock access to all of his social media accounts.

Rule six: To add further to rule four, the client shall never order food on his publicist's behalf. Not unless he wants to be diagnosed with early-onset diabetes, courtesy of desserts being forced down his throat.

Rule seven: Moving forward, the client will never ever share private messages with random members of the public, especially for hooking-up purposes.

I, the client, hereby agree to comply with all of the above.

W. Jones #25

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Will

Four days after my “business” meeting with Drew, I’ve got an inbox full of unanswered emails from her and a to-do list into next week.

Why would anyone need to know my entire events schedule for the next twelve months? Hell, aside from conditioning and practice, I don’t know what I’m doing this weekend.

It’s tempting to ignore her completely and claim all her emails fell into my Spam folder—and I’d do it if I thought she’d let me get away with it. Professional Drew is intense and committed and, to be honest, kind of fucking intimidating.

“Will, hi. It’s nice to meet you at last.” Standing by a massage bed in the center of a therapy room, a blonde-haired woman smiles warmly at me.

Remembering the introduction email she sent a couple of days back, her name is Candice, and she is my appointed physical therapist, or PT, for the season.

Fuck.

She’s hot and absolutely the type of girl I would take home with me if I got the chance.

Is there not a male PT who can touch my groin? Getting a hard-on during a massage is not the kind of first impression I want to set.

Professional. Act professional, William.

Rolling my shoulders back, I stride toward Candice and hold out a hand for her to take.

But when I see pink creeping beyond the open collar of her white polo shirt, I’m tempted to think that my attraction is reciprocated.

We hold our handshake for a little longer than normal before Candice pulls away and clears her throat.

“So, I figure we can use today’s session to get to know each other, and then we can create a pre- and postgame routine based on what feels good for you.”

You wrapped around me all night would feel pretty damn good.

I zone out for a beat and come to, realizing that she’s asking me to look through and sign off on some paperwork.

I hop onto the bed and take the clipboard from her, scanning the words on the page, although not really digesting them.

A fingernail points to the dotted line at the bottom.

“From studying your initial medical assessment, I built in some additional targeted soft-tissue stretches and trigger-point therapies to help relieve the tightness you’ve been experiencing in your groin region.”

I swallow hard and close my eyes.

Pro-fucking-fessionalism.

“Yeah,” I say, signing where indicated and handing her the clipboard. “Toward the end of last season, the college trainers had to work overtime with me to reduce inflammation.”

Her eyes drop to my dick, and I’m considering my fastest route out of here.

“It’s not unusual for players who pick up a lot of ice time throughout the whole season to identify areas of physical weakness. I’m guessing yours is right here?”

Without much warning, she presses two fingers into my left groin, and I clench my jaw.

“Yep. That’s definitely my weakness.”

Candice relaxes her fingers. “How much stretching do you do at home?” she questions, hands propped on her hips. “Because you’re knotted up pretty bad, and I’m concerned you’re at an increased risk of injury. Plus, without regular massages, your recovery will be slower since the blood flow will be hindered.”

It’s not fucking hindered right now—I can promise you that.

I lift a shoulder and try to get a goddamn grip on myself.

Banging the PT is a direct breach of my contract and punishable for us both.

If people find out.

“I work on stretching and core stability at least six days a week, either in a team facility or my home gym.”

Candice nods a couple of times, picking up the clipboard and flipping the page to make some notes. “I think the best course of action is to schedule an intense treatment plan over the next few weeks, from now until the regular season starts in October. I’ll also send you home with an updated stretching routine, which you should incorporate at least every other day and definitely after each practice and game.”

She taps her pen against the clipboard, eyes falling to my gray sweatpants.

“Would you mind if I got a better feel?”

I practically swallow my tongue. I’d pin this girl as in her mid-twenties, and she definitely isn’t wearing a ring on her left finger.

Swiveling to lie down flat on the bed, I hook my thumbs beneath the waistband of my pants and push them down to my knees, kicking off my white Nike sneakers.

Candice stares at me, open-mouthed.

Shit.

“You want to feel my groin, right?” I clarify.

A slow smile creeps across her face. Jesus, she thinks I’m cute and not at all sexy.

“Yeah, I do. But I usually step out of the room so my patient can undress in private.”

Like I ran for a bus but missed it and now I’m trying to play it off as a random light jog, I continue pushing my sweatpants down until they’re pooled at the end of the bed.

“I’m not shy when it comes to shit like that.”

I smirk up at her, and to my surprise, she fucking winks at me.

Hell yes.

Placing a fluffy white towel over my legs, she rests it at the top of my thighs and carefully presses her fingertips into the offending area.

“From what I understand, you aren’t shy about much, Will.”

I dig my fingernails into my palm when Candice’s fingers find a particularly tender area, and she begins massaging the knot that’s formed there.

“I’m sorry you got stood up for a date the other night.” She moves toward my dick. “Some people don’t know a good thing when they see it.”

Despite a hot girl's hands all over me and the flirtatious turn our conversation has taken, all I can think about is a dark-haired Drew berating me over dinner as she scrolled through my social media.

While I haven't deleted the post I made, I haven't posted anything more since that time.

I know at least one of Drew's emails contains content for me to approve before it goes live, and I should really reply. Still, I'm struggling to accept handing over control, even if it is the right thing to do for my public image.

"Oh"—I wave a hand and wince when Candice moves to a different spot—"that was me messing around. I didn't actually get stood up. A friend kept me waiting outside their apartment, and I was bored."

Her brows pinch together, and who can blame her? I sound like a fucking weirdo right now.

Penance for posting bullshit on the internet, I guess.

"So ... you're not seeing anyone then?"

I pause on replying for a second and think over my options.

It's been well over a week since I last got laid, and in William Jones's world, that's a fucking long time.

I decide to play with Candice a little bit.

"Do you frequently ask about your patient's relationship status? You know, while also offering them privacy to take their clothes off?"

She flushes at that, and suddenly, I'm not Will Jones, the cute rookie, any longer. I'm the hot new Rogues forward, irresistible to the female training staff.

As it fucking should be.

"Not ordinarily," she replies, voice a little higher than before. "But then, not everyone strips in front of me either."

Eyes fixed, we're locked in a game of who will speak next.

We both know this is way over the line already, and I get a hunch that Candice is not the type to flirt with players.

I should probably take the compliment and respect the boundaries set by the team. Player-staff fraternization *never* ends well and would undoubtedly sit at the top of Drew's rulebook.

"I guess it's only polite for me to ask." I throw her a wink of my own. "What's your current dating status?"

Drew might like to formulate a long list of rules to keep me in line, but contrary to popular opinion, I actually have some of my own.

Starting with taken women.

Before anything goes down with them, I want to know if they're seeing someone, and if they are, I never go there.

My parents taught me a lot of things, and integrity sits at the heart of the way I was raised. I've never had a girlfriend —aside from when I was in middle school and too young to understand what relationships actually were—and that's deliberate on my part. I like women too much, and I plan to play as hard as I work this season. Just like I did in college.

Candice shakes her head. "I actually broke up with my boyfriend a couple of months back. We were in a long-term relationship, but it just ... fizzled out. These days, I'm only interested in a good time and nothing serious."

Sitting up on my elbows, I smirk in a way that is the opposite of professional.

"Are you as good at keeping secrets as you are at working out the tension in my groin?"

Candice giggles. "I can be a vault when I need to be."

Bracing my palms behind me on the bed, I rise up until my lips brush the shell of her ear. "Then how about you be a vault this Saturday night and do as you please with me for a few hours?"

6

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Drew

From: Drew Callaghan
To: Will Jones
Subject: Read receipts are a wonderful thing.

Will,
You're aware that when you hit Read on an email, the sender knows that you've seen it, right? Where are you? I'm sitting in Riley's Bar, where you asked me to meet you—which is a direct breach of rule two, by the way—and you are now a half hour late. Today is officially my day off, and I have a gym class in an hour. We need to go over content for Instagram and plan out your social calendar.

Regards (note the absence of “kind”),
Drew

“Someone looks like they could use a drink.”

I set my cell on the bar top when a Manhattan is slid toward me by a slender hand belonging to someone I've met on more than one occasion.

Nights out are not really my thing. I prefer to stay home and watch a movie or read. However, when First Line has monthly team evenings out, they generally hit up Riley's Bar, and because I don't want to be seen as boring or unsociable, I always make an appearance.

My gaze moves from dark red nail polish to a tight red tank top before contrasting black hair and blue eyes capture my attention.

The female bartender here is strikingly beautiful, and a little like how she remembers my favorite cocktail, I could never forget a face like hers.

She's tiny—I'd guess not much more than five feet—but she commands the bar area like the head female in a pride of lions.

Impossibly fair skin shines beneath the twinkling lights set above the bar, and when she smiles, I'm pretty sure every person in this place holds their breath.

I know I do.

Given we've never interacted beyond me ordering a drink and she isn't wearing a badge, I have no clue what her name is.

I offer her a warm smile and take a sip of the cocktail.

The whiskey burns my throat, but I welcome the feeling as it slides down and warms my frosty mood, thanks to a delinquent client.

"Did you add an extra shot?"

Grinning, she picks up a fluffy black towel from behind her and begins wiping the bar top. It's pretty early on a Saturday night, so the place isn't busy, and the music is quiet enough to hold a conversation.

"With a Manhattan, I always think the stronger, the better. Rye whiskey is too delicious not to be appreciated."

She sweeps her long hair over one shoulder, and I reach into my tote bag, set on the empty chair next to me.

The towel lands over my hands, and I pause on unzipping my bag.

"I hope you aren't reaching for your wallet because this one is on the house."

Just like with compliments, I struggle to accept people's generosity too.

"Won't you get in trouble for giving away free drinks?"

I'm met with an arched brow as I hand her the towel back.

"Not if you're the newly appointed bar manager."

I raise my glass to that. "Congrats. I'm happy to hear someone's job is going to plan."

Taking a twenty-dollar bill from another customer, she rings up their order and hands them the change, bracing her forearms on the bar as she leans forward.

"I actually thought you were waiting on a guy who hadn't shown up. You know, since it's Saturday night and you look a little lost."

Puffing out a despondent breath, I tap my phone screen once to see no reply from Will. Not even a Read receipt this time.

“Well, you’re right about being left hanging by a man, although tonight was definitely not a date, more like the most disorganized client you’ve ever met.”

The girl, who I’d pin as being in her mid-twenties, narrows her bright blue eyes at me. Maybe it’s the striking red lipstick she always wears that sticks in my mind. I’ve never seen such full, plush lips before.

“He sounds like a dick who’s too distracted by his own self-importance.”

I chuckle because that statement could not be more accurate yet wrong, all at the same time. Sometimes, I wonder why I like Will because I’m for sure not susceptible to his charm.

“You work for First Line PR, don’t you?”

My head snaps up from where I was studying the cocktail.

“Relax.” She smirks. “I’m not going to tell anyone that Colton Davis’s staff spends their weekends berating clients for being assholes.”

“H-how do you know my boss’s name?”

“Honey”—she wipes the bar top again—“Colton is always in here, and you guys book regular booths. It doesn’t take a genius to put the pieces together.”

I lift a shoulder and let it drop. “I guess not.”

After a few minutes of her serving other customers, another Manhattan appears beneath my nose.

“If I drink that, then I’ll be wasted and definitely no good for the gym.”

She balks like I just insulted her. “Exercise on a Saturday night? Oh, please. Stay here and get wasted with me.” Her eyes scan the bar area. “I have a feeling tonight is going to be slow. Neither the Scorpions nor Rogues have a preseason game.”

I know. One of the players is supposed to be sitting next to me right now.

“You follow hockey?” I ask, wondering if she’s astute enough to know I’m Jessie Callaghan’s daughter.

While my dad retired from the game years ago, being a Hall of Famer and now the Rogues head coach means his face is very well known.

The girl’s eyes leave my face, and she twists her lips. “I wouldn’t say that I follow it exactly. But I do know one of the Rogues players.”

That piques my interest, and I wonder if he’s a First Line client. “Oh, yeah? Who?”

She side-eyes me. “Before I divulge information like that, I need to know your name.”

“What? So you can hunt me down if I somehow find a way to use it against you?” I snort a laugh and finish up the first cocktail, pulling the second toward me immediately afterward.

Her face is expressionless, and suddenly, I realize she isn’t messing around.

“Drew,” I confirm, opting not to add my last name. “I’m the only Drew working at First Line.”

She lifts her chin and taps a fingernail on the bar in thought. “Vesper. And there’s likely only one of me in the whole of Seattle.”

I have an actual girl crush on the woman with the coolest first name ever.

“Nice to meet you, Vesper. Officially meet you anyway.”

Shiny red lips press together, and I’m mesmerized. I wonder if she’s dating a player because I’d one hundred percent be into her if I were a hot-blooded male.

“Silas Stanton. Captain and defenseman for the Rogues. He’s my boyfriend’s older brother.”

I take another sip of my cocktail. “Silas is represented by my colleague, Lydia West.”

“You can’t pull a face like that and then remain silent,” Vesper demands.

Swallowing, I’m already feeling the whiskey’s effects, and typically, when I drink, the first thing to desert me is my inhibitions.

This could end badly.

I take another sip of my drink.

“Lydia is kind of a rival colleague, and Silas doesn’t like her all that much.”

Vesper bursts out laughing, a lyrical melody to her voice when she speaks again. “Oh, well, Silas doesn’t like many people, and I think the feeling is mutual for most who have met him. Including his brother.”

My eyes grow wide.

Screw you, Will. This conversation is far more intriguing than listening to you jabber on about how many goals you’ll score this season or how many Likes you typically get on each social media post.

Or how I’ve already consumed more alcohol than you have in a lifetime. We get it, Hotshot.

“Do you like him?” I ask.

Vesper considers my question for a second. “Silas Stanton is a complex character, and I highly recommend you leave him to your friend Lydia. Personally speaking, he’s actually pretty likeable when you peel back the layers. Professionally, I imagine that he’s a handful.”

I roll my eyes. “I guess that makes two First Line clients then.”

Vesper leans in a little closer, and I close my eyes, rueing the moment I said yes to a cocktail. I should be back at my place, getting ready for a spin class, not airing my dirty laundry to someone I barely know.

“William Jones, by chance?”

I’m part relieved, part alarmed by how easily she guessed correctly. At least I don’t have to say his name, but the very fact that Vesper knows speaks volumes about him.

“That boy is trouble,” she confirms. “Very hot, but trouble nonetheless.”

Heat prickles my cheeks. “I’m not making any comment.”

Vesper just smiles, and I appreciate that she doesn’t push me to say anything more. It’s comforting to know she respects the boundaries I’m trying to establish.

“It doesn’t matter how rich or famous these boys are; I wouldn’t accept being ignored like that.” She stands up straight and tuts. “At the end of the day, you have a job to do, too, and they should acknowledge that by at least showing up to business meetings. Even ones in a bar on a Saturday night.”

When she winks suggestively, I descend into a full-blown panic.

“There’s nothing going on between us!” I declare way louder than I should have. Wincing, I cast my eyes around the bar, which is mercifully still quiet. “We know each other from the past, but that’s as far as it goes.”

“So, you’re friends?” Vesper clarifies.

Are Will and I friends? I think about the meal he treated me to for my twenty-first birthday and how it feels like there are two sides to his personality—one that cares and wants to help celebrate special days in my life and another that can’t even be bothered to reply to a simple email or show up tonight.

“We’re friends, but not close, and we *definitely* are not romantically involved.”

She studies me for a second and then spins on her heel, heading toward a couple of customers who just approached the bar.

I take the chance to check my phone and find zero notifications.

You know what? Fuck this.

Opening Instagram, I click into Will's account and load up the draft of the post I was going to have Will check over tonight before I sent it live.

It's an action shot of him wearing a Rogues jersey. When a player joins a team, it's standard practice for them to have professional images taken for promotional purposes. Often, they look stilted and premeditated. However, the file the Rogues' media team sent me the other day was far from it. Will's smile is bright, and the stick wind-back the photographer captured looks like he's genuinely taking a shot on goal in a big game.

Will has always been a natural in front of the camera and, in theory, is perfect for marketing teams—the complete package, capable of selling out merchandise several times over.

If only he could get his head out of his ass and grow the fuck up.

Scrolling down, I look over the caption I wrote for any typos and double-check that it sounds like Will wrote it.

September has rolled around, and that can only mean two things: the regular season is only weeks away, and our first preseason game is coming up this Tuesday. Turning pro has been a dream of mine since before I set foot on the ice, and I could not imagine a better opportunity than to debut in the NHL wearing green and gold. The team and coaching staff here at the Rogues have made me feel incredibly welcome, and I want to thank you, the fans, for embracing my arrival with open arms.

To my parents and sister, who have helped guide me to where I am today, I want to say thank you. I wouldn't be doing this without you all by my side, every step of the way.

Rogue for life.

Will #25

This reads nothing like one of Will's captions.

Excellent.

I hit Post, and immediately, the guy Vesper just finished serving starts checking his phone, showing the screen to his friend as they begin talking about my client.

Jesus. Will really has the entire city eating out of his palm.

“I’ve been thinking.” Vesper’s voice pulls me back to reality.

Locking my cell, I drop it into my bag. “Shoot.”

Her face turns devilish. “I think you should lay down the ground rules with your client right away.”

“Oh, I did,” I explain. “We have a set of rules, which he’s already ignoring.”

Vesper shakes her head. “No, no. I’m talking about you becoming Muhammad.”

I look confused—I know I do.

“If the mountain won’t come to you, then maybe you should go to it,” she clarifies.

Taking the advice of a stranger is probably not the best idea, but I like this girl, and I’m pretty tipsy at this point. So, what the hell?

“I do know where he lives,” I muse.

My partner in crime waves a hand out in front of her. “Then what are you waiting for? Take control of the situation and the arrogant rookie who thinks he can skate circles around his publicist.”

As I down the rest of my cocktail, a small voice in the back of my mind is screaming that this is a mistake.

I grab my bag anyway and head for the exit.

7

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Will

“**W**hat the fuck is wrong with you?” I whisper the words softly enough so Candice—who’s currently lying naked in my bed—can’t hear as I yank open the refrigerator door and hang my head inside.

There are only green smoothies and meal preps for the next week in here and definitely not the answers I’m searching for. Still, the cool air is a welcome distraction from the fact that we shouldn’t have done what we just did.

At twenty-two, I’ve been with a lot of females—around fifty percent more than I’ve admitted to my mom—and not once have I regretted hooking up with any one of them.

I love sex. I love women. I ...

Fuck.

“Is everything okay?”

Dressed in only her top and panties, Candice stands in the entryway that separates my living space from the hallway.

When I invited her over to my place, I had every intention of going several rounds with her. In the end, I didn’t even come once, and that was by design. Conversely, she did—because there’s no fucking way a girl is leaving my bed unsatisfied. The second she finished, I was pulling on a pair of athletic shorts and making my excuses to leave the bedroom.

My forced smile falls flat, and I move toward her, setting my hands on her shoulders. The last thing I want is for any woman to think they aren’t sexy or did something wrong.

Equally, the worst thing I can say is, *It's not you; it's me*. Because no one ever believes a person when they say that, even if it's true in this particular scenario.

I breathe out slowly and scramble for something to say right as my intercom buzzes.

"I'd better get that. The front desk doesn't call unless it's someone who doesn't have the code to access my apartment."

With a tight nod, Candice steps away from my grasp, quizzical eyes moving between mine. "Is it okay if I grab a shower?"

I walk a few paces up the hallway and open my linen closet, handing Candice two fluffy white towels. "Are these enough? If you want a bath, just help yourself. It's huge, and it has a whirlpool feature."

She wets her lips and moves closer, full tits pressing against my sternum. "It would be better if I had some company."

I thumb behind me, and the buzzer rings again.

Candice drops her shoulders in frustration, and I'm wondering why the hell I feel relief more than anything else. Jumping into a whirlpool bath with a hot girl is always at the top of my agenda.

Saying nothing, I move down the hallway and toward my intercom, the soft sound of the bathroom door clicking shut in the distance.

"Yeah, sorry," I say as soon as I press the button by my front door. "I just had to throw on some clothes."

"Um ... okay."

"Drew?"

There's a long pause, filled with nothing but cringe.

"I have clothes on now, just to confirm."

"That's ... really great to know, William." Drew sounds about as pained as I feel. "In case you haven't already figured it out, I'm downstairs in the lobby. The front desk wanted to make sure it was okay with you for me to come up."

Fuck.

Only I could bang the PT and have my publicist show up straight afterward.

Body temperature rising, I think through how to get out of this. Turning Drew away will look really rude, but she cannot find out about Candice.

The only person who might be proud is Dad, and that's only because he was a fuckboy, too, when he was my age.

Until he met my mom and became a boy obsessed.

"You left me hanging in Riley's Bar. We were supposed to meet for an hour before I went to the gym."

Shit. We were.

"I'm really fucking sorry."

Drew murmurs something inaudible, and I figure if I can turn her around before Candice emerges from the bathroom, there's an outside chance I'll get away with the shit show I've created for myself.

"The code for the private elevator is 8825. It'll bring you right into my apartment."

A couple of minutes later, I've thrown on a white T-shirt, and Drew's standing in front of my fireplace, looking suspicious.

"I'm curious," she says, gaze roving the room, which I had decorated in a monochrome finish. It looks fucking brilliant. "But is your private elevator code a combination of your dad's and your jersey numbers?"

Taking a seat on the gray leather couch behind me, I nod once. "Yeah, same as the passcode on my phone."

She dips one hand into a fucking huge black tote bag she has slung over her shoulder, and I probably shouldn't laugh when she fetches out a notepad and pen, but I can't help it.

"Rule eight: The client won't make ridiculously easy-to-guess codes in order to access his apartment and phone. Switch them up, William. Before you find a random girl lying naked in your bed or snooping through your phone."

Too late for that.

As Drew finishes up writing and drops the pen and pad back into her bag, I take in her outfit. "Do you frequently wear knee-high black boots and a gray sweater dress to the gym?"

Drew's eyes ascend my body, and I get a flush of heat similar to when I answered the intercom.

"Just out of curiosity," she says, completely ignoring me, "how quickly do you need me to leave your apartment?"

With a sense of dread rising up my throat, I follow her line of vision across the room, and my eyes fix on a black bra slung over one of the floor lamps.

"I'm assuming you already have a random girl in your apartment, and right now, she's in the shower. Or possibly hiding."

For the first time in my life, I'm rendered speechless, and I've no idea what to do with that or the hot mess I've managed to land myself in.

Still, at least Drew doesn't know the *random girl* is actually Candice.

"The bath water is still hot if you want to come join me ..."

Eyes ablaze, Drew aggressively points to my PT, who is now standing a few feet away from us, wearing only a black thong, with one arm covering her tits.

"Are you for real right now?!" Drew exclaims. "That's the team PT, Candice Hale." She huffs out a despondent breath. "And before you get all nosy and ask me how I know, Dad had a Christmas party for his staff, and I swear to God ..." Voice climbing higher, Drew pauses to catch her breath.

"Hi," is all Candice says, her free hand raised in a small, awkward wave that summarizes the situation perfectly. "I'm going to get going," Candice adds after a few more seconds.

Then she scurries back down the hallway, and the bedroom door slams shut.

Drew can't even look at me, and I don't fucking blame her because now I know why sleeping with Candice was nothing like all the other sexual encounters I've experienced before.

It was a selfish, high-stakes move that wasn't just dangerous for our careers, but for my publicist's too. And that makes me feel like the shittiest person ever.

"Do you know what will happen if this gets out?" Drew's tone is low and accusing.

I force my eyes to look at her because it's the respect she deserves, and when I do, I see the disappointment in her gaze.

Something I put there.

While Drew was waiting for me to show up in town, I was busy doing what I do best.

Being a fucking prick.

"I'll have fines coming out of my ass," I bite out. All the anger I'm feeling is directed internally.

Drew steps toward me, and I'm surrounded by a scent of lemon and bergamot. "Fines are the least of your worries, Hotshot." She says the name with a mocking undertone and points back toward where Candice just disappeared. "That girl will likely lose her job, and guess what will happen next."

Before I can answer, Candice reenters the living room. Now fully dressed.

I stand so I can show her to the front door. There's no way she can stay, given the charged atmosphere, and I need some time to calm Drew down.

Candice holds up a hand, tears pooling in her eyes. "I promise I won't say anything about what happened. I've had a really shitty time lately, and this was a complete misjudgment on my part."

On a sob, she heads toward my front door, and Drew races after her.

I hear muffled voices for approximately thirty seconds before my front door closes, and Drew comes to sit beside me on the couch.

We both sit facing the floor-to-ceiling windows and stare out at the darkened cityscape until, finally, Drew breaks the tension with a line that has me chuckling despite everything that's just gone down.

"Rule nine: The client agrees to stop doing things that make his publicist want to commit a felony."

Still amused, I turn to look at her properly, and that's when I see her disappointment has been replaced with despondency over my careless actions.

My laughter fades, and if I hadn't been the total opposite of professional already, I'd wrap my arms around her slender shoulders.

"You look really nice, by the way." I don't know why I say it, but the words tumble from my subconscious. "No one, not even your client, has the right not to show up when you're looking like you do right now."

Drew playfully nudges her shoulder into my upper arm. "That kind of sweet talk doesn't work on me, Jones. Save that for the girls you can bang without breaching any contracts."

I stare at Drew for a beat, examining her unreadable expression.

"You know what's weird?" I point out.

She shakes her head once, and I know we're now talking as two people who have known each other for years and no longer in a professional capacity.

"Hooking up as a pro player doesn't hit the same as it did when I was in college."

Drew offers me a tight smile. "Frat parties have no place in a pro hockey player's lifestyle. It's all drinking and beer pong and waking up, not knowing where you are ... or who you're with."

I pull back, jaw popped open. “Are you talking from experience, Miss Callaghan?”

Drew and one-night stands do not belong together in the same sentence. She’s too much of a good girl for that.

Or maybe that’s just the way I’ve always seen her.

She blushes, and I’d be blind to deny how cute it is.

“Maybe you haven’t got me all figured out after all, Hotshot.”

She stands, and all I want is for her to stay and tell me exactly what she meant by that statement.

“Candice won’t breathe a word.”

Back in professional mode, Drew walks across to the floor lamp, tossing my PT’s bra at me. I catch it against my chest.

“You need to return this to her at your next session. If that’s who it belongs to.”

Drew’s halfway out of the living room when I drop the bra and move to catch her by the forearm.

She spins around, and her perfume hits me again as her blue eyes stare up at me.

“I’m really fucking sorry for letting you down today. I promise it won’t happen again.”

I’m not sure if she believes me, but the softness in her expression reveals that she’s at least accepted the apology.

“It’s okay. I just need you to cooperate and stop doing stuff that could endanger your future.”

Drew glances at my front door, and I consider telling her to take the elevator. That way, I can talk with her a few seconds longer.

“You have an awesome career ahead of you, and it’s my job to get the best out of every opportunity that comes your way.”

Her voice is warm and caring, and it wraps around me like the feeling of a hot summer’s day on the beach.

“I also posted on your behalf because you weren’t getting back to me and we needed to acknowledge your arrival with the Rogues before it was too late.”

Heart racing, I slide a hand into my pocket and pull out my phone.

I fucking hate the picture she used, and the caption is absolutely not in my own words.

“Repeet liked my post,” I say.

Drew rises to her tiptoes so she can see the screen. “They’re the ones who pulled out of a collab with you, right?”

I nod once, remembering how pissed I was at the time. “I thought they’d turned their back on me and forgotten about my existence.”

A palm lands on my forearm, and we lock eyes again.

“And that’s exactly what I’ve been trying to tell you, Will. No brand—unless they’re totally idiotic—would burn bridges with you. Repeat is just waiting in the wings to see how you present yourself now that you’ve turned pro. They want to see you demonstrate the kind of brand that will align with theirs. If you can hold yourself together and follow my lead, then the deals will start rolling in soon. I promise.”

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Drew

Thanks to an unruly client who is incapable of following basic instructions, I already know my weekly check-in with Colton will be difficult.

One social media post in two weeks. That's all I've managed to achieve with Will, who prioritized his sexual conquest above the meeting he was supposed to have with me.

I thought controlling his erratic behavior would be straightforward and I'd be the last person he would screw around. Evidently, I was mistaken.

Will is a law unto himself, and everyone else is merely a spectator.

Yet, despite all of the above, I'm struggling to be mad at him, and that, in itself, makes me more infuriated. Perhaps I'm giving him more leeway based on our past, or maybe I'm not cut out for this job at all. A client has never tested me—or my patience—to this degree.

I thought Will had more respect for me and my career.

"So ..." Colton opens the conversation with an ominous tone. He clearly has about as much faith in me taming the Rogues rookie as I do. "How're things going with Will? I saw his post about joining the Rogues." Colton bites down on his bottom lip. "Or should I say, your post on his behalf?"

Heat invades my entire body. I knew the caption wasn't reflective of Will's voice, but he left me with no choice. The regular season is only weeks from starting, and he had to make a statement to the fans.

"Everything is shaping up fine," I lie, hoping that Colton will buy it.

He doesn't, quirkling a questionable brow.

“How about his events calendar? I’d like to see him attend at least two galas this season.”

I shift in my seat. “We haven’t gotten that far yet.”

“Hmm ...” Colton swipes a palm across his mouth. “Can you handle him?”

I sit up straighter, shoulders back and voice more assured when I respond, “Who, Will?” Waving away my boss’s uncertainty with a hand, I tag on a small chuckle. “Sure. He’s been preoccupied with the preseason, but we’re strategizing, and I have a meeting at his place tonight.”

I absolutely do not have a meeting with him tonight.

Colton looks and sounds more positive when he says, “Great. Let’s step up social media posts to every other day during the rest of September and go from there. Right now, general public consensus is, he’s not showing his excitement over joining the Rogues, and that needs to change. Stat.”

I nod in agreement and pull out my phone when Lydia knocks on the door and strides into the meeting room like we weren’t just having a private discussion.

She’s wearing a white blouse and black dress pants, hair styled into a short, dark bob.

We exchange a glance before I drop my eyes and zone out of whatever crap she’s spinning for Colton’s benefit.

Lydia has kissed our boss’s ass since the day I joined First Line, talking a great game when, really, she wouldn’t know how to build a client’s profile if an instruction manual hit her in the face.

ME

I need to meet you tonight.

Will’s response is almost immediate, and it fills me with hope that the ass-kicking I gave him on Saturday night actually resonated.

WILL

You scare me when you send messages like that.

ME

Why?

WILL

I’ve never had someone boss me around before.

ME

Um ... your mom is Kate Jones. She bosses people around for a living.

WILL

Okay, I'll rephrase. I've never had someone boss me around and I paid attention to what they said.

That pulls a smile from me.

ME

Well, get used to it, Jones, because I need to sit down with you tonight and finalize your schedule for at least the next six months.

WILL

Shall I cook you dinner?

I have no idea how to respond. I haven't even thought about eating beyond the lunch sitting in the refrigerator, which I'll likely ignore in favor of working through my break.

ME

Wait. Can you actually cook? I figured you had a private chef.

WILL

Why would you assume that?

ME

Because I can't imagine you carrying out domestic duties.

WILL

Maybe you don't know me all that well then.

ME

What time should I stop by?

WILL

I'll be finished in the gym by 6 p.m., so let's say 7?

ME

I'll send a calendar invite.

WILL

Drew, it's literally six hours from now. We don't need an email to confirm.

ME

Actually, we do. This isn't a social visit, even if you are cooking dinner. And once again, the location of our meeting is in direct breach of rule two.

And I'm already mentally cycling through my wardrobe for an outfit.

WILL

Shall I wear a suit?

When an involuntary bubble of laughter escapes my throat, Colton and Lydia pause their conversation and look at me.

"Sorry," I say on a wince. "I was just checking the football scores. Detroit rolled over Pittsburg."

Lydia's brows pull together before she shakes her head. "Some people find the strangest things amusing."

Fuck off, Lydia.

ME

Regular clothes will do just fine.

WILL

There's a first time for everything, I guess.

ME

Huh?

WILL

What you just said—no woman has ever specifically requested for me to wear regular clothes when coming over to my place for the night.

I blush even though I shouldn't because this is classic Will Jones behavior.

ME

I don't want to know the details of what kinky outfits your conquests make you wear. Should I add that to our list of rules?

WILL

No need. Generally speaking, they prefer me naked.

I'm not sure how to describe the sound that leaves me next, but it's entirely not appropriate for the workplace.

"Are you sure you're all right, Drew?" Colton asks.

Lydia's eyes are now rolling into the back of her head at my display.

"Huh?" I look up from my phone, and his eyes drop to the screen.

Shit. He'd better not be good at reading upside down.

I point to my phone, angling the screen away from them both. "Will can meet me tonight."

"Shouldn't you be setting up a meeting via email rather than over text?"

I hate Lydia and her constant need to make me look like an idiot.

Locking my cell, I set it face down on the table and look her straight in the eyes. "I guess that depends on the relationship you have with your client. I personally believe that sacrificing a few formalities opens up an otherwise stilted exchange and puts the client at ease around you."

She scowls, and I grin back at her.

"So long as you're both clear on boundaries," she bites back.

Colton must sense the rising tension, as he cuts into our exchange. "I think you both make valid points, although I have no doubt about Drew's professionalism. It's important that she leans into her friendship with Will."

Lydia gives Colton a muted smile and spins on her heel, making for the exit as I get back to my text conversation with Will.

ME

You know what? Cancel dinner. I've lost my appetite at thoughts of you naked.

WILL

The lady doth protest too much. I'll make you something really special.

ME

Ugh, okay. Anything to massage your huge ego. So long as we get done what we need to.

WILL

Massaging my huge ego ... the number of ways I could respond to that.

ME

Shut it.

Ten minutes later, I'm back at my desk when my phone pings again.

WILL

I'm at the grocery store. What wine do you like?

ME

How many business meetings have you been to where they drink wine?

WILL

None. But that's only because they weren't hosted by yours truly.

ME

I'll take a club soda.

WILL

Boring. I'll get a bottle of Chardonnay.

ME

Do you ever listen to what anyone says?

WILL

Only if they aren't talking shit.

ME

I don't want any wine, but I could go for a slice of Key lime pie with vanilla ice cream.

WILL

Your sugar addiction is out of control.

ME

Treat yourself, William. You know you want to.

WILL

Six months of working with you, and I'll perfect my public persona, but be the size of a freaking apartment block. Do you know how many years it took me to carve this physique?

ME

That's a problem for your dietician. Not your publicist.

WILL

Let me send you a picture of my body so you can see how hard I've worked on it.

ME

Rule ten: The client is not, under any circumstances, to EVER send naked photos to his publicist.

WILL

What if I cover my dick with a hand?

ME

ANY CIRCUMSTANCES.

“You and Will sure do like texting a lot.”

I have zero idea how long Lydia has been standing behind me, but as she props her bitchy ass on the corner of my desk and I casually lock my phone and set it screen down next to me, I wish she would disappear underground and never return.

“We have a lot to talk about,” I reply. “And like I said, building a good rapport with your clients is the key to long-term success.”

She twists her lips in thought, and I just know some of her bright pink lipstick will be on her teeth. It always is.

“Colton really gave you your big break, assigning Will to your management. Add in the fact that you’re his coach’s daughter, and I guess the stakes are set really high for you to tame the wild rookie.”

I shake my head and shoot Will the calendar invite he was convinced we didn’t need.

“I’m not trying to tame anyone. I’m here to help Will maximize his potential.”

She scoffs, and my patience with this woman wears a little thinner.

“Girl, I hate to break it to you, but that guy is a lost cause. No one is capable of turning him into a responsible public figure.”

If jealousy had a face, I’d be looking at it right now.

“Did you want Will as a client and missed out?”

Her jaw pops open as she slides off the table and stands up straight. “Let’s be really real here, Drew.” Lydia plants a palm on my desk and leans in so only I can hear her next words. “Colton only gave you Will because of who your dad is and not because of your *extensive* experience in the PR field.”

Of all the responses Lydia could’ve given me, weaponizing my dad’s position in hockey and turning it against me was the worst possible outcome.

“Let me make a suggestion, Lydia.” I drop my voice and narrow my eyes at her. “How about you work on retaining the clients in your portfolio?” I lean in a little closer. “And I’ll focus on working with one of

the nicest guys in hockey with an even brighter future.” I clear my throat, hating that people view Will as a lost cause when he’s anything but that. “And I would appreciate it if you never spoke about my client like that ever again.”

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Will

“We’re all heading out for a meal tonight. How about you join us?”

Taking a large pull from my water bottle, I smile gratefully at Silas when he enters the conversation and interrupts my workout with the most annoying person I’ve ever met.

Tristan Vaughn.

Jackass doesn’t even cover it.

At twenty-six and having played pro for seven years, this guy has a rep for being a dick, and, jeez, does he live up to it. How the hell we’ll pull off playing on the same forward line without me throat-punching him in the first period I have no idea.

“I’m busy tonight,” I confirm, dropping the dumbbell in my left hand to the soft black mat beneath my feet. “I have a meeting with Drew.”

Silas bends down to pick up the dumbbell and sets it back on the rack behind me. “How are things going with her?”

Curling my bicep, I blow out a slow breath and repeat the rep with the dumbbell in my right hand.

The last time Drew and I were in the same room together, I was trying to hide the hookup I’d just had with my PT. The same PT who now can’t look me in the eyes when I’m lying on her treatment bed.

I should probably do us both a favor and request to be reassigned.

“Things are fine,” I reply, briefly glancing at my captain.

His blue eyes move to mine, and then I look away. The last thing I need is for him to see my discomfort over the memories of Candice’s bra hanging off my floor lamp.

The details of that Saturday night can never get out.

He scratches at the back of his neck. “I approached Drew to ask if she’d take me on as a client.”

My attention darts to him. I’m aware that representing my captain would be amazing for her career, but I don’t like the thought of Drew working with another hockey player. For starters, she wouldn’t have the time to manage us both.

“What did she say?”

He just smiles like he’s having a private joke with himself. “She sent me a very professional reply, but declined the opportunity, explaining that I was assigned to Lydia and her portfolio was currently full.”

The satisfaction I feel is definitely unjustified. Regardless, it slides through my veins.

Changing the subject, Silas thumbs over his shoulder to where Tristan and another one of my teammates, Mason James, are talking by the spin bikes. “I see you and my winger were just hitting it off,” he sarcastically points out.

Given Mason is a defenseman, I know he can only be referring to Tristan, and it would be pointless for me to deny the disdain I feel toward him. I barely know the guy, and I already hate him.

“He’s a prick.”

Silas chokes out his next words. “Don’t hold back, rook. Go ahead and tell us all how you feel.”

My attention zeroes in on a mass of loose black curls as Tristan throws his head back and barks a laugh toward the gym ceiling in response to something Mason said.

“He likes to think he’s the popular guy around here and acts like everyone loves him when even his laugh annoys the shit out of me.”

Silas’s eyes grow wide, and I can tell that he likes the guy. Fuck knows why.

He shrugs a single shoulder, and I turn and set my dumbbell back on the rack.

“He’s confident and not afraid to say what he thinks.”

With my back to Silas, I scoff, recalling the brief conversation I just had with Tristan, where he told me that leading scorer in my rookie season could only happen in my dreams.

Clearly, the guy has never watched me play or refuses to acknowledge that now that I've signed with the Rogues, he's no longer the best forward on the team.

"If I were you, I wouldn't hate on him too much. You guys have way more in common than you think."

"We both wear a green-and-gold hockey jersey," I retort, picking up my white gym towel from the floor and wrapping it around the back of my neck. "That's where our similarities start and end."

I reach out and tap a finger against my captain's temple. "And if you can't see how full of himself he is, then that isn't my issue."

He folds his arms across his chest. Down the length of his right forearm is a word scribed in black ink that I can't decipher. I want to ask him about it, but he speaks first.

"You need to get along with Tristan. He's a fan favorite because he scores a lot of goals, and it won't go down well if you come in and rock the boat."

Biting my lip, I nod at Mason James. He looks the total opposite of Tristan. With his mass of dirty-blond hair and bright green eyes, I can see why he's popular with the fans for a whole different reason from Tristan, even if his looks aren't the only thing that he brings to the ice. He's a damn good defenseman, although with the goals the team leaks, he's fighting a losing battle. Our current goalie, Denver Smith, has the worst shutout record in the entire league and, to be honest, belongs on the farm team.

Trouble is, the alternate goalie is even worse than Denver, and trying to convince a decent goalie to transfer to a team where shutouts are nearly impossible is like trying to stop the tide from rolling in.

"Tristan isn't a team player. He's not interested in assists, only in how many times he can light the lamp," I tell Silas, although it seems to fall on deaf ears.

"You're both cocky as hell, and I'll be really honest ..." He puffs out a despondent breath. "I was worried that you guys wouldn't get along even if I hoped that you'd show some maturity."

Right as Silas finishes up his sentence, Tristan turns and makes a beeline for us, sharp gray eyes full of mirth when they lock on me.

He's two inches shorter than me and around thirty pounds lighter. I know because I've memorized the stats for each of my teammates. Hardly difficult when you're gifted with numbers like I am.

“Why the scowl, Jones?” Tristan asks me on his approach.

Most of the guys here use each other’s first names because Coach prefers it between players, but Tristan makes an exception where I’m concerned. Probably because he knows it will wind the hell out of me, and getting beneath my skin is his only realistic play at getting the better of me this season.

He’s an average player at best, but he shines on a subpar roster.

“Because you piss me off,” I bluntly reply.

Mom and Dad never minced their words, and neither do I or my sister.

To my surprise, Tristan seems to appreciate the directness. Aside from his stats and dickhead nature, I actually know very little about this guy. Unlike me, he rarely uses social media, and when he does post, it’s always hockey-related and thanking the fans.

Kiss-ass.

Drew would be impressed, and for some reason, that makes me despise the guy even more.

“I’m sorry for any inconvenience I might have caused you, Jones. I merely pointed out that making lead goalscorer in your rookie season is madness, and I’m advising that you adjust your expectations.”

I step toward him, a silent reminder of our physical differences. “Did my record in the NCAA pass you by?”

I know it didn’t—I can tell by the sour look on his face. He probably thinks that collegiate hockey is a waste of time, given he went straight into the pros after a year on the farm team, but he’d be wrong. College hockey is the best prep for any future pro, and I’m glad I listened to my parents’ advice to hold out on the NHL.

“Can we save the face-offs for the opposition?” Coach enters the conversation from nowhere, coming to stand between me and Tristan.

I’m the one who breaks eye contact first, setting my attention on Coach.

“Just getting to know each other,” I reply.

Coach sounds less than convinced when he says, “Sure,” patting Tristan on the shoulder. “Vaughn, I need you in my office ASAP. I have your medical reports back from Candice, and I wanted to go over the good news with you.”

The elbow injury my teammate picked up on the back end of last season is not the reason why I blush, and Tristan’s smirk makes me regret my hookup with Candice even more.

When Coach heads toward the doors and Silas makes for the treadmills, I'm already thinking up excuses to cut my gym session short.

Something I never do.

"Can I offer you some more advice, Jones?" Tristan whispers.

Swallowing down the temptation to tell him to fuck off, I somehow manage a friendly smile. "I have a feeling I'm going to get it anyway, so go ahead and say whatever helps boost your ego."

He swipes a hand across his jaw. "Banging the team PT doesn't count toward your goal tally. In fact, I wouldn't classify it as scoring at all."

If I punch him, then I'll effectively confirm his suspicions because that's all he has right now. There's no way Candice would breathe a word to anyone, let alone to the team's biggest asshole.

My breathing is steady, expression stoic, as I quietly reply, "And spreading shitty rumors about your new teammate isn't going to help you out either. You need my assists as much as this team needs my goals. And whether you want to admit that or not makes no difference to me. I'll be the crowd favorite by the end of the season."

The tendons in Tristan's jaw flex. Being the golden boy means everything to this guy. Only the weak require validation from others.

Still, I'm curious as to how he guessed about Candice. Surely, a brief flush of my cheeks wasn't enough to spike his suspicions. The guy isn't smart enough for that.

"Word is, you struggle to keep it in your pants, Jones." Tristan's voice adopts a darker edge. "Next, you'll be fucking Drew because you just can't help yourself. What a conquest that would be."

I square up to him, not giving a shit who witnesses it. "Say what you want about me, Tristan, but never *ever* speak about Drew in that way again." My warning is more of a hiss.

He lifts a single shoulder and looks off to the side before focusing his attention back on me again. "It's funny how you have such a visceral reaction to the women you've either fucked or would like to fuck in the future."

I shake my head at him, perplexed over his behavior. Sure, we don't get along, but this feels like he's trying to sabotage my pro career before it's even gotten started.

"What the fuck is wrong with you?"

Tristan rolls his lips together, jaw still ticcing. “Hallie Vaughn. I don’t suppose that name means anything to you, does it?”

At first, the memory of that name is hazy, and then my brain catches up as I recall the hot blonde from my sophomore year in college, who has the same last name as ... Tristan.

Fuck. She never once told me that her brother was a pro hockey player.

“You banged my sister and then broke her heart after you stood her up at the movie theater and then ...” His fingers twitch at his sides. “And then you took her best friend out and fucked her too.”

I did exactly that, and I know Hallie was really fucking mad at me for ghosting her. The last text she sent me before she blocked my number and avoided me around campus contained more expletives than it did regular words.

“So, yeah,” Tristan continues when I say nothing, “I guess you could say that there’s everything wrong with me when it comes to dickheads like you, Jones. You fucked my baby sister, and I’ll never get past that.”

“We were never officially dating.” I point out the truth. “She wanted more, and I didn’t. I made that really clear when we hooked up for the first time.”

Tristan’s gray eyes turn almost black. “The *first* time?”

Shut up, William.

Tristan prods his finger into the center of my chest, and I don’t move away. He needs to have his moment of anger because I’d be the same if anyone hurt June.

No, I’d be worse than Tristan. I’d fucking murder them.

“If you want to keep that pretty face of yours symmetrical, then stay out of my way.”

I scoff at his pathetic threat and step into his finger. “How do you think the fans would react if you beat up the player they’ve been waiting to arrive for over four years?”

He considers that for a moment, burning rage softening in his eyes.

“Like I said”—I double down on the upper hand I have—“I never want to hear you speak of Drew like that again. She’s the ultimate professional. And for what it’s worth ...” I let him hear the apology in my voice. “I don’t make a habit of hurting women. If I’d known that Hallie was into me like that, I wouldn’t have slept with her for a second time.”

All I get is Tristan's stony expression. "At least you live up to your last name—your dad is an entitled prick, and from what I read about your mom, she looks down on everyone around her too. I'm willing to bet your sister is the same."

I squeeze my forehead against his, looking down at the piece of shit below me.

"Say that again," I spit right before Silas breaks us up.

"Say that again!" I repeat, but I only get Tristan's satisfied smirk.

"Will, your session is over." With a palm in the center of my and Tristan's chests, Silas tips his chin at the locker room door. "And, Tristan, I think you were supposed to be in Coach's office ten minutes ago."

Tristan grunts, and I snarl as I spin and pound the heel of my hand into the locker room door before ripping the towel from around my neck and tossing it at the wall.

"I fucking hate it here!"

10

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Drew

Something is wrong with Will.

He's subdued, grumpy, and he generally looks unhappy.

As he moves about the kitchen, finishing off the lobster dish he's been prepping since he got home from the gym, his shoulders are slumped, even if he's trying to hide whatever is weighing them down.

"I think the fans would appreciate some insight into your pregame routine, if you'd be willing to make a video, talking them through it at some point?" I suggest from where I've been sitting at his kitchen island for the past half hour, head buried in my laptop.

With his back to me, I can't be sure what Will thinks about the idea, although I know he isn't camera shy.

He stirs the large pot on his burner, which smells freaking insane. Will comes from a family who can really cook, and therefore, I assumed that he'd had every meal handed to him throughout his life. I was wrong. There's no doubting his passion for—and ability with—food.

I mean, who makes a lobster tail for an evening work meeting?

"So, I'd be guiding them through what time I wake up and how I prepare my body? From the light exercise I do to what I eat before a game?" He tips his head over his shoulder and smiles at me, but again, it falls a little flat from the usual grin I'm used to. "I guess I could, although I'd have to set up a tripod, and it would take a lot of editing."

I schedule the post on the content calendar for a month from now. The regular season will be well underway by then.

"I can help shoot the video. We have access to camera equipment, and then I'll edit it and show you the final take before we post it to your social

media.”

Will’s halfway to his refrigerator when he pauses and turns toward me. “Is there anything you can’t do, Drew?”

Another compliment, another flush of my cheeks.

I clear my throat and open the Notes app on my laptop, checking off another item on the list of things we need to cover while Will begins to plate up the food.

“There’s plenty I’m useless at,” I tell him, pointing at the expert way he arranges the lobster, scalloped potatoes, and salad. “As you know, contrary to my dad’s talents, I’m terrible at ice hockey and skating. And I cannot cook to save my life.”

I’m also terrible at keeping my eyes to myself when faced with bulging biceps as Will carries my plate over to the island and sets it down in front of me.

But I’ll blame that on the unnecessarily tight black T-shirt he’s wearing.

Meanwhile, I feel overdressed, having decided to play it safe with a fitted black pencil skirt and a white button-down blouse. I wish I’d just opted for jeans and a sweatshirt, like most normal people would’ve done.

On a cheeky grin, which is way more typical of Will, he rests a palm on my laptop lid and slowly closes it until I retract my fingers so they don’t get trapped.

“It’s time to stop working now, Drew.”

There’s something about the gravelly tone to his voice that makes the hairs on my arms stand on end, and I’m not ashamed to admit that I get why women find him so attractive. Even if I’d never ever confess that to anyone.

Picking up my laptop, he sets it on the vacant stool next to me, and I pull the food toward me, mouth watering at how delicious it smells and how hungry I am.

When Will slides onto the stool directly opposite where I am, he has his dinner in one hand and a bottle of white wine in the other.

Like he did in the restaurant that day, I set a hand over my empty glass. “I have an early meeting tomorrow, and I don’t need a headache.”

His shoulders drop as he sets the full bottle down and picks up still water instead, filling my glass and then his own.

“What do you think of the lobster?” Will asks after I’ve taken a couple of bites.

I point my fork toward my plate, trying to find the right words to describe the burst of flavors. It's seasoned perfectly.

"Did your dad teach you to cook like this?"

Will takes a bite of lobster tail and nods once. "Yeah. He taught June and me, but I'm the better cook."

I roll my eyes, and he chuckles.

"Sibling rivalries are intensified when you're twins."

For a second, I think about my relationship with Marley. Now nineteen, she lives in Vancouver, where she moved to be with her boyfriend, Greg, who is a couple of years older than her. She's always been fiercely independent, and she's working and studying to become a qualified social worker.

"The only things Marley and I fought over were clothes, shoes, and makeup."

When I set my eyes back on Will, his plate is almost clean.

"And why are all hockey players the same?" I tip my chin at what's left of his dinner. "I swear to God, I have no idea how you guys don't give yourselves indigestion with the way you eat so fast."

Folding his arms across his chest, Will sits back in his stool and watches me eat. His actions should freak me out, but weirdly, they don't.

"And I have yet to meet a girl who can finish inside ten minutes."

The second he stops speaking, Will's eyes grow wide, and I have to slam a palm over my mouth to prevent him from seeing what's currently in there.

"I mean ... finish eating inside ten minutes, not ..." Will gives up on his explanation, only digging himself deeper as we both laugh so hard that I have to grab a napkin from the center of the island and spit my mouthful into it.

"Holy shit!" he declares. "If a girl was struggling to come after five minutes of my tongue, I'd be fucking devastated."

I drop my fork to the plate with a clatter.

"What?" he asks, no doubt picking up on the devastation written right across my face.

I scoff. "Does the word *boundaries* mean anything to you at all?"

I don't miss the tinge of pink as it creeps across his cheekbones.

"TMI, William. Way too much information."

He clicks his tongue and shifts his plate out of the way, gazing at me intently.

It's obvious that he's doubling down, and I'm so tempted to remind him that this is, in fact, a professional meeting and not a social one.

Still, I can't help my curiosity to find out what he'll say next.

"That actually kind of surprises me, Drew."

I balk. "Why?"

He shrugs. "The other day, when you were talking about frat parties and waking up in random beds, it sounded like you were speaking from experience."

If I wasn't red before, then I definitely am now.

How is it that every work meeting with this guy descends into chaos?

Oh yeah, because it's Will.

Picking up my fork, I take a bite of potato and buy myself a few seconds of thinking time. I figured my overshare the other day had gone unnoticed, but clearly, Will was listening to more than I thought.

"Contrary to popular belief," I confirm on a swallow, "I am capable of having fun when I feel like it."

Will's lips tip into a devilish grin. "Drew Callaghan ... were you a player in college?"

I chew around a piece of lobster tail, memories of my senior year still very clear. "There were a couple of guys. One was a football player, who I hope will never require a publicist."

Will picks up his water glass. This is the most invested I've seen him all night, but he also looks lighter and back to his normal self, and I'll take that bright smile any day.

"You can't drop bombs on me like that and then not tell me who they were."

I shake my head and set my fork back down on the plate. "He's playing pro now, and I think he just got engaged, so I probably shouldn't say."

Will drums his fingers on the countertop impatiently. "But we have a two-way NDA in place, no?"

I nod. "We do. Although it doesn't extend to personal matters."

He huffs out a breath. "Jamie Rose."

I shake my head. "No, and he's really not my type. He also didn't go to my college."

Will looks off to the side, brows pinched together in thought.

Christ. He really is desperate to know who I got into it with.

“Marshall Booth.”

If I had food in my mouth, then I’d spit it out. “No! We went to the same college, but he was a playboy.”

I pull a face and immediately regret it when I see the lines crease into Will’s forehead. He must think that I’m judging him.

I hold up a hand, part in surrender and part in apology. “Listen, I’m not saying that being a playboy is a bad thing or anything. I—”

“I get it.” Will blows out a defeated breath, a flat tone returning to his voice. “Guys who sleep around are a fucking nightmare, and I could never imagine that you would be into that.”

Dark brown eyes pin me in place. “This season, I need to make a few changes in my life, starting with the way I conduct myself off the ice.”

I shake my head. “You don’t need to change, Will, and no one is asking you to either. I’m simply here to make sure the public only sees what they’re entitled to and that you’re not doing yourself a disservice online.”

His expression softens a fraction before silence falls between us.

“It was Paul Tierney,” I say after a few seconds. “We had a thing for a few months, and it was fun.” I pause and have no idea why the next words leave my mouth. “Although I didn’t appreciate being his dirty little secret for a time.”

Nothing. No response from Will.

I drop my head down and push away the plate, picking up my laptop and opening it.

“Drew.”

I clear my throat. “We need to talk about the Rogues charity gala in three weeks. I assume you have cleared your schedule for that.”

“Drew.”

I swallow and finally look at a stern-faced Will.

“Yep?” My voice is higher than usual, and my attempt to pass off what I just revealed about Paul totally fails.

Will leans forward on his elbows, more out of concern rather than mischief. “What do you mean, dirty little secret?”

It’s pointless, expecting Will to drop the subject. Like I said before, he gets his stubbornness from his mom.

“Did he treat you badly?” His voice is sharper now, demonstrating a side to this man I haven’t really seen before. I imagine he’d be like this if

someone hurt June, but never me.

“He didn’t hurt me per se. But I definitely thought he was more serious about me than he actually was.”

I clear my throat and push down any remnants of the upset and humiliation I felt when he was pictured with his ex—who he’s now engaged to—on social media. Paul hadn’t had the balls to tell me that he was back with his previous girlfriend, and while I don’t think he ever cheated on her with me, I do know that’s why he always stayed over at my place and we never really went on dates where people could see us.

“Have you ever felt used by someone, and in the end, you’re madder at yourself for allowing them to treat you like that or for not seeing it sooner?”

Will considers my question for a second. “Not in a romantic sense. But I can relate to that feeling in other ways.”

I tip my head to one side, intrigued. “How so?”

Flattening his palms on the counter, he drags them toward him as he sits back. “It’s kind of how I feel right now as the hot new rookie for the Rogues—I’m here to serve a purpose and to get them a few more wins. I don’t have any allegiance to the team or the fans. They weren’t my boyhood team or one that carries prestige. I got screwed in the draft, and my whole career feels transactional.” He waves a hand in front of him, motioning to my laptop. “Like how many sponsorship deals I can secure for them. It’s all about money with this team and ...” He pushes a hand through his hair, and I can sense his frustration. “And while people might think that I’m all about image, I just want to play hockey. No pressure. No corporate bullshit. Just me, the ice, and three twenty-minute periods.”

“I didn’t realize you were so unhappy,” I say in a small voice.

Will rolls his lips together, and now the reasoning behind his earlier mood is clear.

“What about your teammates?” I ask. “I mean, I know you love the coach.”

He deadpans at me. “Silas is decent enough. Tristan Vaughn is a fucking prick though.”

“Why?”

“Where should I start?” he bites out. “He’s a cocky prick who thinks a lot of himself.”

I quirk a brow, and Will immediately points at me. “And you can save it, Drew. I don’t need your smart-ass pointing out the obvious.”

Amused, I lift a shoulder and reset my focus back on the laptop.

“For what it’s worth, Paul Tierney wouldn’t know a good thing if it hit him between the eyes.”

I scrunch up my nose, forcing myself to accept the compliment. “Thanks, but it doesn’t matter. I’m over him now anyway.”

“Is there ... anyone else?”

Our eyes reconnect for a split second after Will’s question.

I scoff. “I spent my twenty-first birthday working and my Saturday evening getting stood up by this really irritating client I look after. Does my life scream sociable and loved up to you?”

Will stands from his stool and rounds the island, reaching into the center of the counter for my plate. His cologne fills my senses.

“No, Baby, it does not. So, how about you run through the rest of your list while I pour you a glass of wine? And then you can nail the strawberry cheesecake I made especially for you. I’d say that you deserve it.”

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Will

JUNE

Word is, you'll get a hat trick in your debut tomorrow against Colorado.

ME

I'm not even starting, so that's likely not happening.

DAD

Give it time, and you'll be the first name on the team sheet.

MOM

I'm sorry I can't make it tomorrow, honey. A case has gone south at the final minute, but your sister and dad will make up for my absence.

DAD

No one could make up for your absence, Princess.

ME

I just puked in my mouth. Gross.

JUNE

I'm with my brother on this. Totally gross.

DAD

Hopefully, one day, you will both fall in love with someone as deeply as I did with your mother. Then you will understand.

JUNE

I shall not be betrothed to anyone.

MOM

Good girl, JJ. Women do not need men.

ME

Only when you need jars opened or something from the very top shelf in the superstore.

I send another text with the eye-roll emoji.

DAD

Son, do not provoke your mother. It is unwise.

MOM

Will, listen to your father. June, what time is your interview on Monday?

ME

Wait. Interview? What interview?

JUNE

It isn't at any time. I decided not to go for the job and started a freelance blog.

MOM

We can discuss this later when I get home.

JUNE

You won't change my mind. So many are saying it's the best way to get into sports journalism these days—build a social platform.

DAD

I hate to say it, but your name will give you a head start.

ME

Did I pass out and miss a few chapters? What are you all talking about?

JUNE

I've decided I want to be a sports journalist.

ME

Covering which sports?

JUNE

All, but mainly hockey.

ME

You should ask Drew if she can set up an interview with yours truly. That should gain you a few thousand followers.

JUNE

I don't want my career to piggyback off my brother's. Anyway, Dad has managed to get me an interview with a couple of the Blades players. I'm going to start local with New York-based teams and then work from there.

ME

Proud of you, JJ. I knew a career in medicine wasn't what you wanted.

JUNE

It will mean living with Mom and Dad for a while longer while I build the business, but that's a small price to pay. LOL.

DAD

I've already said that you can move into our apartment in town.

JUNE

And I've already told you, when I move out, it will be because I earned the money to do it.

ME

Fuck that. Take them for all they're worth, JJ.

MOM

You can be really crass at times, William.

"You've been nursing that soda for well over an hour." Silas slides onto the barstool alongside me and points at my full glass as I pocket my phone.

It's fucking weird to me that a team would go out the night before the first game of the regular season, but at least there's a ban on alcohol.

"Big game tomorrow," I breathe out. "I don't usually drink soda the night before I play. Only water."

Silas clinks his soda glass against mine. "At least come and join the guys. The idea of tonight is to bond, and you can't do that, sitting way over here."

I tip my head over my shoulder and briefly lock eyes with Tristan, who glares at me. I return it tenfold. He's starting tomorrow, and I'll be on the third line. Not that I expected to start in my debut, although he sure as shit

likes to rub it in my face and has done so since Coach announced the lineup.

“Something tells me that I’m not welcome.”

No one knows why we got into it in the gym that day, and I intend to keep it that way. I haven’t even told Drew.

Silas downs the rest of his soda, sliding the glass along the bar toward a dark-haired woman who always seems to be working whenever I’m in Riley’s Bar.

From my position next to him, it’s impossible to miss the way his eyes linger on the girl for longer than necessary.

“Do you know her?” I ask.

He shakes his head, although I’m not convinced he’s being honest.

“You don’t have her on speed dial then?” I goad, which does the trick.

My captain’s head snaps to me. “I have her number, Will, but only because she’s my brother’s girlfriend.”

I decide to test the waters a little more, mainly because I’m bored, but a small part of me can’t push past the way Silas looked at her a second ago.

“Your brother’s a lucky guy. She’s hot as fuck.”

Picking up a coaster from the bar, Silas flips it over in his large palm. “Her name’s Vesper, and she’s way too good to be with someone like my brother.”

I’m fortunate that sibling feuds are not something I’ve ever had to deal with, and that leaves me short on what to say next. It’s clear that my captain’s background—and maybe even his childhood—was very different from my own, but here he is, sitting next to me as an NHL captain who commands a lot of respect in the league.

For the first time since I walked onto this team, I feel a tentative connection to the Rogues beyond the coach I’ve always known.

“Does your brother live in town then?” I ask because I’ve never seen Silas pictured with a family member and I assumed that he was an only child.

He gives me a tight nod. “Yeah. Kane works as a gas station attendant. He moved here when I was traded to the Rogues.” He cocks his head toward Vesper, who is busy serving customers. “He met his girl a couple of years later.”

Silas looks at me then, and I can tell he can sense my confusion.

“Kane and I are half-brothers with the same mom. Shit went down with my dad, and they split. After that, she met a new guy, and he was ...” He pauses, smiling darkly. “Let’s just say, he also wasn’t a good man, okay?”

The last thing I was expecting when Silas joined me at the bar was for him to open up to me like this, and out of appreciation for the trust he’s placed in me, I opt to be candid with him.

“I never met my mom’s parents, but I know they were really terrible people. I only have my uncle Easton from Mom’s side of the family. There are bad apples everywhere you look.”

Silas makes an agreeable noise.

“Around a year ago and shortly before my mom died from cancer, she made me promise to look out for Kane. She knew he was a waster, like his dad, and I can’t break my word to her. So, I stick around and make sure I’m here in case he needs me.”

“Can I get you two another drink?” Vesper approaches us, bright blue eyes locking on Silas. After a beat, she focuses on me, and a playful smirk pulls at her red-stained lips. It feels like she’s more familiar with me than I am with her.

Silas pulls out his wallet, and Vesper waves it away.

“This one’s on the house. What can I get you?”

My captain pauses for the longest time, side-eyeing me like I’ll judge him for his next words. “Could really use a beer.”

I say nothing as Vesper spins on her heel and grabs a pint glass.

“Go ahead,” Silas says next. “Say that I shouldn’t be drinking the night before a big game. Tell me again how my body is a temple and I should treat it as such.”

I puff out a laugh. “You really think I’m a cocky dick, don’t you?”

Dark blue eyes connect with mine. “I don’t think it, rook. I *know* you’re a cocky dick.”

When Vesper slides the beer into Silas’s hand, I figure I have two options right now—berate him for the booze and live up to my reputation or do something Drew would likely be proud of. Appear human. I genuinely can’t remember the last time I had a drink, but somehow, it feels like sharing a beer with my captain means way more than the act itself.

“I could go for a half pint,” I say, pushing my soda glass toward Vesper.

Silas scoffs his next words. “Jesus, put the flag out. Our boy here isn’t a fucking robot after all.”

Vesper picks up my glass, her smirk growing wider as she leans across the bar. “I’ll get you a beer, but you should know that I’m charging you. Think of it as penance for standing up your publicist the other week.”

Shit. So, that’s how she knows me. Drew was probably sitting on this very stool that night, unloading her frustrations onto Vesper, while I carried on like a selfish prick.

“Fair enough,” I finally reply, handing her a twenty-dollar bill. “Keep the change.”

Ten minutes later and with a half pint of beer running through my veins, Mason James joins me and Silas at the bar. His dark blond hair is slicked back tonight, green eyes looking tired as he also orders a beer from Vesper and takes the stool on the other side of me.

“How are you feeling about the game tomorrow?”

I shrug and decide that I’ve had enough alcohol. “It’s Colorado, so a win will be tough, even at home.”

After Mason takes the drink from Vesper, she gets back to working, and Silas’s eyes track her as she moves about the bar area.

“You need to find a way to build bridges with Tristan.”

“Agreed,” Silas adds.

I give them both a warning look. “Have you tried speaking to him about that?”

Mason nods. “I have, and he’s being as fucking stubborn as you. You’re going to need to be the bigger man and bury the hatchet for you both.”

Silas clears his throat and glances at Vesper again. “Being honest, I don’t get why you guys have such a problem with each other. Teammate rivalries are normal, but this feels personal.”

As much as I like both of these guys, there’s no way I’m trusting them with the fact that I boned Tristan’s sister and left her brokenhearted. I don’t know them well enough yet to gauge how they would react. From what I do know about Mason, he’s been married for years, and Silas is clearly a good guy, trying to look out for his asshole brother.

“I’ll speak to him,” I tell them both.

“Good man,” Silas confirms, setting a palm on my right shoulder and pulling out his phone.

He doesn’t hide the screen as he navigates to a group chat and adds my contact into it.

My cell buzzes in my pocket.

“What are you doing?” I question.

He just smirks at me and repockets his phone. “Making sure you follow through on what you just said. Now that you’re a member of the group chat, there’s no backing out.”

Mason knocks his shoulder into me, voice playful as he says, “We will make a Rogue of you yet, Jones.”

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Drew

“Tell me that you’re wearing the long navy gown. Your hourglass figure looks insane in that dress.”

“Of course I’m wearing that dress,” I say to my sister, fastening the buckle on my left stiletto—which is way too high to walk in comfortably—before moving to the right one. “It’s the only gown in my wardrobe that I actually like.”

Marley groans happily down the phone as I stand from the bed and move to my open closet, inspecting the collection of purses I’ve built up since I was sixteen.

“I wish I could make it tonight. I haven’t seen you or Mom and Dad in way too long.”

Still examining my accessory options, I share in Marley’s frustration. It has been too long since we last saw each other, especially for a closely knit family like us.

“You’ll be home for Thanksgiving though, right?”

Marley falls quiet, and my heart sinks.

“I think Christmas is more likely. Work and college are insane, and I promised Greg that I’d spend this Thanksgiving with his family. So, we’re traveling to Virginia.”

Suddenly, my choice of bag doesn’t feel all that important.

“You have to promise me that you’ll come home for Christmas. Otherwise, I’m jumping on a plane to Vancouver.”

She snorts a laugh, and it fills my chest. I’ve been nervous about tonight and especially since we found out that Repeat and a couple of other

important sponsors will be attending the gala this year, but the melody to my sister's giggle will always soothe me.

"I promise," she confirms. "Anyway, what accessories are you going for? And, ooh, will you be dancing with any hot hockey players?"

"I'm attending this year in a business capacity, not just the coach's family," I grumble down the phone. "We both know I plan to fade into the background and observe how Will interacts with potential sponsors."

"Borrrring," Marley declares, and I roll my eyes even though she can't see me.

"I was thinking about taking the silver purse to match the sandals I'm wearing. Keep it sophisticated and simple."

Marley clicks her tongue. While we used to fight over clothes and makeup when we were younger, I definitely miss having her around to help style an outfit for me. She for sure has the better eye for detail when it comes to fashion.

"I say go for something bold and alluring."

However, on this occasion, I think better of her advice and reach into the closet, plucking the matching silver bag with diamanté detail from the second shelf.

"Silver purse it is then."

I'm waiting on Marley's objection when the beep on an incoming call stops me in my tracks.

Will.

My heart sinks again. This had better not be him canceling at the last minute—or even worse, he's forgotten about tonight altogether. I've only sent him three reminder emails in the past week, and none of them have returned Read receipts. Not that I'm overly surprised. His first week as an official NHL player has been incredible—he scored four goals already and made two assists. My best guess is, he's been celebrating with a new woman in his bed each night.

"It's Will." I cut off Marley's ramble, which I wasn't listening to anyway. "I have to take the call. Call you back tomorrow?"

With a quick goodbye, I end the call with my sister and rush out a, "Hello?" to Will, although my greeting sounds more like a grumpy accusation.

"Well, good evening to you too," he sarcastically responds.

For the second time today, I roll my eyes to no one.

“Please tell me that you remembered about tonight,” I drawl, walking toward my bedroom door and pulling it open.

My place is a wreck today, as I opted to slump on the couch with back-to-back mugs of hot chocolate and a chick flick instead of cleaning.

Will sounds mortally wounded when he replies, “Of course I remembered.”

Pulling the phone away from my ear, I check the time. My Uber ride will be outside in five minutes.

“And you aren’t canceling either?” I ask, cringing at the thought of him doing just that and Colton’s reaction when my client is a no-show. I know these types of events aren’t Will’s thing. A bunch of speeches and a charity auction will probably bore the shit out of him.

“If standing outside your door, waiting to give you a ride to the venue, constitutes canceling, then, yeah, I’m totally bailing on you at the eleventh hour.”

Apparently, walking in these heels isn’t as hard as I remembered as I stride across my living area and into the entryway, swinging my front door open to reveal a cocky-faced Will on the other side.

He’s dressed in a sleek black tux, black bow tie, and black loafers with exactly the right amount of ankle on show, and he styled his hair back in a way that accentuates his handsome face.

And by the way he braces his free hand on my doorjamb and smirks at me with his phone still to one ear, I just know he’s aware of how devastatingly good-looking he is.

I close my mouth and fold my arms over my chest, tapping my left foot impatiently.

It’s all for show, of course, but there’s no way I’m revealing how his presence alone makes my body react in an entirely inappropriate way.

Will Jones is not your type. He might be easy on the eyes, but he’s the complete opposite of the men you like. As are you for him.

So, why can I feel his eyes all over me as I continue to stand frozen in my doorway?

“Are you going to let me in?” he asks after a few beats of nothing, his voice low and gravelly.

I stand to the side so he can enter my apartment.

Hands in the pockets of his dress pants, Will clears his throat and turns to look at me. Perhaps the way his gaze ascended my body earlier was my

imagination. He appears more than composed now.

“I thought that we were meeting at the event?” I say, going to check my left wrist for a watch that doesn’t exist.

He steps toward me, and I take a couple back, keen to maintain distance between us.

“I figured it was pointless, you paying for an Uber, when your place is on the way to the venue. Plus”—he chuckles and pulls a set of keys from his pocket—“I wanted to show you my new car.”

A Ferrari key chain flashes as he turns the keys around on his fingers.

I balk at him. “But didn’t you just buy a new car with your signing bonus?”

Lifting a single shoulder, he steps toward me again. I have nowhere to go this time, my back now flat against the door.

“I did. However, I also have three allotted spaces in the parking lot, and it seemed a shame to let two go to waste.” He takes my hand and opens my palm, dropping the keys into it.

I look up at him and shake my head. “You’re a flashy bastard, William.”

His smirk should irritate me. Instead, it pulls a bubble of laughter from my chest.

“Can you drive in those heels?” he asks, bottom lip pinned between his teeth.

I continue shaking my head. “Oh, no, absolutely not. No way.”

He nods at me. “Rule one: The publicist must drive her client to events whenever he asks her to.”

Emboldened by his cocksure attitude, I take a step toward him. “It’s me who makes the rules around here. And I’m not your chauffeur, so don’t start crossing those boundaries. My responsibility extends to your public image and no further.”

I swear I see his eyes dart down the length of my body, but again, I could be imagining things.

“There’s nothing wrong with bending the rules from time to time. Live a little, Drew.”

He’s switched his cologne up tonight. It’s something woodsier, but just as nice.

My eyes drop to the keys. “Does it have a stick shift?”

His chuckle is more of a rumble. “It does, but you can use the paddles attached to the steering wheel.”

“I’ll need to cancel my Uber, and I’ll probably be charged if the driver’s already sitting outside, waiting for me.”

Will shrugs, like wasting money is no big deal to him. I guess it isn’t. I’m willing to bet that there’s well over seven figures sitting in his checking account right now, and that’s after buying whatever four-wheeled monstrosity is waiting for me downstairs.

“Why are you like this?” I ask, our eyes meeting again.

“Like what?”

I look off to the side and release a slow, calming breath. “Impulsive, testing, annoying, reckless—”

“Fun.” He cuts me off with his own description.

“If that’s what you call it,” I choke out. “Tonight was supposed to be about you arriving in an understated way and maybe making a couple of donations to this year’s nominated charity before exchanging a few words with the sponsors and making your leave *quietly*. Not in a supercar, driven by the publicist whose job it is to enforce all of the above.”

I know my protest is falling on deaf ears. Being honest, I’m not sure how much I ever believed that Will would follow my guidelines for tonight.

“You don’t just bend the rules, Will. You play by none of them at all.”

What I just said was supposed to be a warning, but Will only takes it as a compliment. Sometimes, I envy the confidence he has in himself.

“You know what I’ve come to realize about you, Drew?”

I raise a challenging brow. “What’s that, Hotshot?”

Reaching around me, he depresses the handle on my front door, and we both step out into the hallway.

Looks like we’re really going to arrive together then.

“I always thought we were opposites, but I didn’t quite comprehend just how different we were until we started working together.”

Pulling my keys from my purse, I lock up and spin around to face him.

“You like to ask for permission rather than forgiveness, whereas I’ll go ahead and take what I want anyway. To hell with the consequences.”

As we both walk toward the elevator, I press the Call button when we reach the end of my hallway.

“Something tells me that Candice Hale would not appreciate your approach to life.”

He shifts from one foot to the other, scrubbing a hand across a clean-shaven jaw. “Yeah, well, that was a mistake that I won’t be repeating.

Hooking up with people you work with is a bad idea.”

The elevator doors open, and we both step inside, an unexplainable silence settling between us as we ride to the underground parking garage.

Will pulls out his phone and clicks a couple of buttons, and when the elevator doors open again, his scarlet-red Ferrari Roma roars to life in the space directly opposite the elevator.

The smug smile he’s wearing is so typically Will when he steps out of the elevator and walks backward so he can face me.

I want to frown at him—I really do.

“Come on, Baby.” He thumbs over his shoulder, and despite myself, I giggle. “Let’s take my new girl for a ride.”

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Will

Holy fucking shit.

I thought that asking Drew to drive us to the gala would be a fun way to spend more time with a girl who is increasingly on my mind, even when she isn't sending me multiple emails.

Turns out, her behind the wheel of a supercar is the equivalent of me in the rink.

She's a goddamn natural.

The long slit that leads up her right thigh, hitting higher than normal when she depresses the clutch, has me staring out of the windshield and recounting the former Seattle Scorpion's captain and NHL Hall of Famer, Jon Morgan's, best goalscoring seasons in chronological order.

Where the fuck has this Drew been hiding?

When we reach a stoplight and she shifts into neutral, I chance a quick glance her way.

Glossy pink lips are tipped into the cutest smile as she drums her fingernails on the steering wheel.

"How do you know—"

"How to drive a car like this?" She tips her head to one side as she turns to look at me.

The dress she's wearing should be illegal—the way it dips down at the front, revealing smooth skin but zero cleavage. The shoulder straps are so thin that it makes the bodice look like a corset, but somehow, their presence gives the dress an even sexier effect.

To me, there's something about a woman who gives nothing away—emotionally or physically—to a guy, allowing his imagination to interpret

what lies beneath.

Drew is exactly that type of woman, and I stand by what I said to her the other week—Paul Tierney wouldn't know a good thing if it hit him straight between the eyes.

My brain itches to tell her that again, but I hold myself back because I'm eager to know how she learned to drive like Michael Schumacher.

Drew shifts into gear, totally forgoing the flappy paddles on the steering wheel, and we take off down the road.

"You know my dad and his love for muscle cars." Drew shifts gears again and holds the steering wheel with one hand, the other waving about, like a prop to her story. Confidence oozes from her every pore right now and—

Holy fucking shit, this is your friend and publicist, Will.

Jon Morgan, second season: ninety-two goals, one hundred twenty assists.

"Don't you remember that after he retired from hockey, he started following NASCAR and Formula 1 more carefully? He got invited to a number of track days, and he dragged us all along." Drew moves down a gear and takes a left. "Turns out, I actually really enjoyed them and picked up the basics pretty fast."

No fucking kidding.

"This is a nice car," she adds as we pull into the venue's parking lot, but instead of heading to the valet, she finds a space at the back and kills the engine.

"Why are we parking here?" I ask, keeping my eyes on her face and not her right thigh. I swear that slit is gradually working higher.

She takes her purse from where I've been holding it in my lap and hands me the car keys.

"This is a charity gala, and you read my emails about the importance of arriving in a modest style, no?"

I shrug. "Just because I drive nice cars doesn't mean I'm not humble."

She deadpans in a way only that Drew can. "William, do you even know the meaning of humble?"

I feign hurt, but actually, her words do kind of sting. It sucks to be misunderstood, thanks to an online persona I've manufactured, but to hear that Drew thinks I'm full of myself bothers me way more than it probably should. Even if she is responsible for my public image.

“If you had your own way tonight, what would you have me do?” I ask her genuinely.

She drops her eyes and thinks on it for a second, examining the purse that matches her stiletto sandals. “I’d like you to engage with a few of the sponsors—notably Repeat—take a few photos with some of the families who have been invited here tonight by the charity, sign some autographs, and make a couple of donations during the auction. Tonight’s event is about supporting people who truly know the meaning of having nothing in life.”

While tonight’s nominated charity isn’t the one run by Coach and Mia, it is another domestic abuse foundation, which focuses on rehoming women and families who have been rendered homeless due to violence from a former partner.

A lump sticks in my throat when I think about what Coach endured when he was a kid and the horrors he witnessed at the hands of his dad, who has been behind bars for most of my lifetime.

And while those thoughts weigh heavily in my mind for a second, I’d be an idiot to miss the slump in Drew’s shoulders or the sudden shine to her eyes.

This might be unwise, but to hell with the consequences. No one can see us in the darkened parking lot anyway. I take Drew’s hand in mine and rest it in my lap, squeezing her fingers gently. Her skin feels as soft and smooth as it looks, but there’s a chill to her fingers that makes me want to wrap my other palm around her hand and bring it to my mouth, blowing on her skin to warm it up.

“I know this night means a lot to you, Drew. It does to me too. Mom and Dad have only told June and me a few details about Jessie’s past. And I can only imagine how hard it must be for you guys to process what happened to him.”

“To them both.” Drew sniffs quietly. “Mom got caught up in the violence one time too.”

I squeeze her fingers tighter. “Your parents mean a lot to me.” I swallow hard. “As do you.”

She doesn’t say anything in response, ocean-blue eyes searching mine. Ordinarily, nothing about Drew screams that she’s only twenty-one. She carries herself with grace, maturity, and sophistication. Right now though, she looks incredibly vulnerable, and that stirs a foreign feeling inside me—one I don’t totally recognize, but one I don’t mind being there.

“I wasn’t going to say anything until later, but I already made a donation before I arrived at your place.”

Her attention whips to me, eyes wide with delight. “You did?”

I nod once, so fucking happy that I took a second out of my day to open the email from the charity, asking for advance donations.

“I figured since I’d treated myself to a new car, I should pay it forward and donate the same amount to charity.”

Drew chokes on her own breath, sputtering out, “What?! This car has to be at least two hundred fifty thousand dollars!”

Sure, the donation can be written off on my taxes, but that’s not why I did it.

“Maybe it can set up a family for a year or so.”

Drew bursts out laughing, and I find myself smiling at her.

“Will!”

She slaps her thigh hard, and I’m looking at that slit again.

“You’re so funny! That kind of cash could set a family up for *life*—or at least the next decade.”

Her laughter fades, and when she leans across the center section and sets a chaste kiss on my left cheek, warmth inflates my chest. Making people happy has always made me happy, although there’s something truly great when a person smiles at me the way Drew is.

“What you’ve given is going to make such a difference. And in the most non-condescending way, I’m really freaking proud of you.”



“I HAVE TO SAY, WILL, WE’VE BEEN REALLY IMPRESSED BY YOUR START TO the season.” The sponsor tips his drink at me as we stand next to the free bar, put on by the Rogues.

“You’ve really made an impact,” a female, dressed in a long red gown that almost matches her hair, agrees with the other sponsor.

Both she and the dude have told me their names a handful of times, but they might as well be speaking in Mandarin since I haven’t absorbed a word. I don’t even know which companies they represent.

Because all I’m focused on right now is Tristan Vaughn’s left arm wrapped around Drew’s lower back.

Drew has never enjoyed the spotlight, and I know that includes dancing, although with the way she's smiling and laughing with him as he moves her around the dance floor to one of Ed Sheeran's ballads, I'd only be fooling myself to deny that she's enjoying it.

He's single—I know he is. And if he isn't entertaining our coach's daughter to score brownie points with her dad, he's definitely angling to take her back to his place tonight.

I grip my soda glass tighter and force a smile at the redhead. "Thanks. I was hoping to make an early impact for the team, and I'm really happy with how things are going."

The male sponsor gives the woman a side-eye, inching a little closer to me, like he's trying to muscle her out of the conversation.

She takes the hint and backs off a little, offering me her congratulations again before making her way to Coach's table on the far side of the event space. The auction wrapped up an hour ago, and now business talk is in full swing. I know Drew wants me to take advantage of tonight and start networking when, really, all I want is to climb back into my new car with her and tear up the streets of Seattle.

I shoot another quick glance at Tristan, who hasn't looked my way once—and come to think about it, neither has Drew. Why should they? To him, she's my publicist, although I can't help the niggling doubt that he's only with her tonight to goad me.

The man who is probably around the same age as my dad runs a hand through his salt-and-pepper hair.

"Actually, Will, I wanted to take the opportunity to apologize for the way we backed away from the sneaker deal in the offseason."

My attention snaps back to the guy. I take him in a little more, and immediately, his face grows familiar.

He's from Repeat.

I remain quiet because I have a habit of putting my foot in my mouth.

"Initially, we were concerned about some of your ... social media content."

He clears his throat, and I try not to cringe. Arguing with a random fan over the nutritional value of potato chips was fucking stupid, especially when I threatened to shove a bag up his ass.

My eyes momentarily track to Drew's.

She's smiling right at me from over Tristan's shoulder as she throws me a subtle thumbs-up.

What would she say to this guy in my situation?

"I assure you that I'm not a complete dick."

The guy drops his head between his shoulders and barks out a laugh.

For fuck's sake, Will.

He holds up a hand. "I can see that, truly," he assures me in a jovial voice. "And I can see that you've been doing a lot of good work both on the ice and on your public profile." The guy's tone turns serious, and I really wish that I'd paid more attention when he gave me his name earlier.

I'm sure he said it was Andrew. Although it could be Andre or Angus. It definitely began with an A.

"I understand you don't have representation here with you tonight, but I would welcome further discussion in the near future if a deal were still on the table from your perspective."

Fucking bingo.

I'm back in Repeet's good graces with the perfect excuse to extract Tristan's wandering palm from the top of Drew's ass.

"Actually"—I raise a hand in the air at Drew, like some kind of master summoning his servant, and I hate the way that it looks—"my publicist, Drew Callaghan, is here tonight."

I've no sooner finished my sentence than Drew is standing beside me, shaking the guy's hand.

Tristan glares at me from the dance floor, and I bring my soda glass to my lips, taking a sip to suppress the smug smile forming on them.

"It's really great to see you again, Kevin."

Not even fucking close with the name.

Kevin gives Drew an appreciative smile. "Likewise, Drew. Tell Colton that we're long overdue for that lunch we keep threatening to have."

Drew straightens her shoulders and adopts a professional edge to her voice. "Absolutely!" She reaches behind her and snags a cranberry juice from the bar. "I'll be sure to pass along the message to him. We have a meeting first thing tomorrow morning."

Kevin hums an acknowledgment before getting down to business. "I was just talking to Will about the potential of revisiting the deal that collapsed in the summer. We've seen a lot of good things from him lately, and I'm impressed."

I expect Drew's eyes to grow wide with excitement, but to my surprise, her face falls stoic, body language giving nothing away.

"That's really great to hear, Kevin. I have a good relationship with Will's agent, and between my client and his team, we can certainly discuss moving things forward, if that's what Will would like."

They both look at me then, and I down the rest of my soda.

"I mean, I'm definitely interested. I'm a huge fan of your brand and how you're shaping the industry, you're trending all over social media."

I get another big smile from Drew.

"All right"—Kevin reaches out, planting a friendly hand on my left shoulder—"let me relay that back to our team. And, Drew, we'll reach out in the next couple of days to get the ball rolling again."

As we finish up our conversation and Kevin moves away, Drew steps in front of me, beaming from ear to ear.

"This has been a great night for you, Will. I wasn't expecting Repeet to come back into the frame so quickly, and that really is a testament to the professionalism you've shown over the past few weeks."

I drop my eyes to her spare hand and consider—for the briefest second—taking it back in mine, just like we did in the car.

What the fuck is wrong with me?

"Thanks, Baby. That really means a lot."

Her shoulders drop an inch. "Do I need to remind you of rule number one?"

I set my empty glass on the bar and cup a hand around my ear, mocking her. "What was it again?"

Of course I remember. I just want to hear the way she grits *Baby* out through her teeth.

She sets her own glass down next to mine and crosses her arms over her chest. Challenging me.

"Too bad. You'll just have to refer to the slip of paper I gave you in the restaurant."

When Drew brings a hand to her mouth and suppresses a yawn, I tip my head at the exit. "How about I drive us home? I could use an early night, and I can drop you back at your place."

Drew pulls her bottom lip between her teeth and gazes behind her toward a group of my teammates. "Actually, I already agreed to a ride home."

Like he can hear our conversation, I spot gray eyes shining from across the room.

“Tristan offered to take me back home, and I didn’t want to appear rude. He’s a nice guy and—”

“He isn’t a nice guy,” I snap straight across her sentence.

She rears back a fraction, and I close my eyes, annoyance with myself and my asshole teammate rolling through me.

“Sorry. It’s just that I don’t want you to—”

“To what?” Drew interrupts me this time. “Get into a car with a random stranger?”

She subtly motions behind her, but I know Tristan notices it. The smug bastard is likely loving this. He didn’t ask to drive Drew home to be “a nice guy,” but just to crawl under my skin and make a point that he can have whoever he wants, just how I acted when I was in college.

“I’m the coach’s daughter, and he’s a player on my dad’s team,” Drew continues talking. “He isn’t about to abduct me.”

I shake my head because what more can I say? She’s right, and whatever leaves my mouth next will only aggravate her further.

She blows out a long breath and looks up at me. Even in her heels, our height difference is still noticeable.

“Well done again for tonight, Will. As soon as I hear from Kevin and the team, I’ll email you all the details, and we can go from there.”

I don’t want her to leave when things are awkward between us, and I only have myself to blame for that. Tristan approaches us from behind Drew, and my attention rests back on her face.

“Text me and let me know that you got home all right.” It’s more of a demand than a request, and it sounds like it too.

Saying nothing, she nods once and spins around to face Tristan.

He waves a hand at me, and when Drew opens her bag to look for something, he throws me a wink that makes my blood run cold.

If he lays one goddamn finger on her, I’ll amputate each of them in turn.

“Coach is busy talking with a couple of guests, and I didn’t want to interrupt him.” Tristan looks me dead in the eyes. “So, could you let him know that I drove Drew home when you get a chance?” His tone is light and sickly sweet.

Oh, I’ll let him know all right.

“No problem,” I confirm and then reach into my pocket and pull out my phone, opening up the X app right as Drew and Tristan head for the door.

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Drew

On a yawn, I sit up in bed and switch off the alarm, reminding me that I have to be in the office in less than an hour.

Next, I grab my cell from its charging pad on the nightstand and begin scrolling. Like so many people these days, I have a bad habit of checking my phone before I've tuned in to my immediate surroundings.

With nothing of note on Instagram, I close the app and check my emails, sitting up straighter when I find one marked as urgent from my boss and sent over an hour ago.

From: Colton Davis
To: Drew Callaghan
Subject: URGENT

Drew,
Have you spoken with Will? What the hell did he post on X last night?!

Colton

Opening Will's account, I'm hit with thousands of notifications, more rolling in every few seconds.

The first thing my tired brain can register is the comments replying to whatever he posted, and nearly all of them ask the same thing: *Spill the tea, Will. Which teammate is the dick?*

Shaky fingers navigate to Will's profile, and when I see the idiotic post he made around eight hours ago, the comments make sense.

I want to thank everyone who was involved in making tonight's gala so successful, apart from my dickhead teammate.

All the blood drains from my face. I know precisely which *teammate* he's referring to. The one who kindly gave me a ride home last night.

What the fuck is wrong with him?

The first thing I do is delete the post, even though I know it'll make no difference since hundreds—maybe even thousands—of screenshots have been taken by now. Still, I hold out a sliver of hope that Repeet hasn't seen it yet, along with Tristan.

Taking a deep breath, I hit Call on Will's contact, anger rolling through me with every ring that goes unanswered. Eventually, I'm connected to his voicemail, and I close my eyes and swallow when the beep sounds, knowing if I don't maintain a modicum of professionalism, then we're both totally fucked.

"So, I just woke up to an absolute shitstorm on social media and a panicked email from Colton. You should know that I have deleted the post you made last night, and now I'll be heading into the office to embark on what will likely be the worst day of my working life to date. Call me so we can go over our crisis management plan." I pull the phone from my ear and can't help adding the next sentence, which I'll likely regret in a few hours. "And for the record, the only dick I see around here is you."

A half hour later, with zero caffeine running through my veins and a headache pounding in my ears, I sit across from a stony-faced Colton.

Reading him has never been an issue for me since he always wears his heart on his sleeve, but today, he's giving nothing away.

"Have you spoken with Will yet?" he asks in a voice that matches his demeanor.

I shake my head and flip my cell over on the table.

Still no response to my call.

"I think he has morning skate, so he'll probably get back to me after that. He was likely already on the ice when I called."

Colton's lips twist in thought. "Did you have any idea that he planned to make that post last night?"

I almost feel insulted that he would think there was a world where I'd ever be okay with what Will said.

"No," I simply reply. "But when he listens to my voicemail, he'll be in zero doubt over my thoughts on it. Especially after Repeet reopened

discussions last night.”

He hangs his head and groans out a disbelieving sound. “How long was the post active before you deleted it?”

“Eight hours.”

I watch the top of his head as he nods once. “And do you have any idea which teammate he was referring to?”

I’m going to throttle William Jones when I next see him. Not only has he thrown us both into the metaphorical equivalent of a PR lion’s den, but I also now have to explain why—and likely how—I know the teammate in question is Tristan Vaughn.

“Drew?” Colton presses.

I cross my legs under the table and draw a deep breath into my lungs. Tristan isn’t a client of First Line PR, but I know Colton is keen to get him on board. The last thing I want is for my boss to think that I’m involved with the Rogues forward.

“The atmosphere between Will and Tristan appeared frosty last night.”

Colton looks perplexed. “Do you know why?”

The temptation to shrug and deny any knowledge is strong. However, lying has never been in my wheelhouse and especially not when it comes to the guy who granted me my first big career break.

I give Colton a tentative glance, still unable to get a read on his overall mood.

“After the auction, Tristan asked me to dance. And after that, I spoke with Kevin Rogers from Repeet, and Will offered to drop me home when the night was almost over.”

Colton’s body language turns uneasy.

“I’d already accepted a ride from Tristan, and for some reason, that didn’t sit well with Will. It felt like he didn’t trust him, and when I pointed out that Tristan seemed like a nice guy ...” I trail off, feeling like this whole thing is ridiculous.

“Keep going,” Colton drawls.

I sigh and add, “Will cut me off, insisting that Tristan wasn’t a decent person. I couldn’t understand why he was in a shitty mood, especially after the conversation we just had with Kevin, but I didn’t hang around to find out. I was tired, and that’s all Tristan’s offer was—a ride home and nothing more.”

My boss visibly deflates, and I feel my cheeks heat.

“Rule number one, Drew: Never leave a disgruntled client unattended, especially not a trigger-happy one like Will Jones.”

I nod my understanding, something tugging in my chest when I think about the list of rules I handed Will back when we weren’t in the middle of a shitstorm.

“I’m going to work on a statement—it will be simple and to the point—and you can post it on Will’s social media.”

“I can put something together myself,” I offer.

Colton shakes his head and points to my cell. “Your priority is getting ahold of your client and figuring out his motivations behind the original post.”

The headache I was nursing begins to throb harder. “I’m sorry if I’ve let you down.”

A warm chuckle vibrates in his chest, and hope blooms in mine. Maybe I haven’t totally screwed everything up.

“We all make mistakes, Drew, and I’m willing to bet that Will is regretting his own right about now. I know you have a good working relationship with him.” He pauses and thinks for a moment. “Did Will make any donations to the charity?”

The unexpected tingles I felt when Will took my hand in the car resurface. “Yes. A very large donation before the gala began.”

Colton smiles. “All right, that’s good news at least. Leave the statement with me, and let’s try and keep this whole thing as low profile as possible. The dust will settle quickly on this one, I’m sure. It’s important that Tristan’s name is never revealed as the teammate Will took issue with. The team’s general manager is leaving this one solely in our hands to sort out.”

I stand from my chair and close my laptop, picking up my phone and pocketing it into the black dress pants I threw on in a hurry this morning. “Other than the statement, I plan to halt all posts on Will’s socials for at least a few days.”

He nods, and I make my way to the door, not stopping to look back at Colton. The last thing I need is for him to see the tears forming in my eyes.

I’m more than capable of doing this job, and I’m going to prove it to him over the next twenty-four hours.

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Will

Showing up at Drew's office was all I could think about when I got in my car after the worst morning skate I'd ever had.

Tristan wouldn't even look in my direction, let alone speak to me. It was the same with all the guys, apart from Silas, who I could tell was disappointed in me, even if he didn't say it out loud.

Pushing through the entrance of First Line PR, I stop midway to the reception desk when I feel a vibration in my pocket and pull out my phone. The voice message Drew left for me earlier remains unanswered because I'm still working on building up the courage to listen to it.

I know it won't be pretty, and I deserve every ounce of her wrath.

SILAS

Riley's Bar at 7 tonight. I want you all there so we can sort this shit out. Once and for all.

MASON

Does Coach know about this?

SILAS

Coach was the one who asked me to get you guys together.

TRISTAN

I can't make it. I have something else going on.

SILAS

Attendance isn't optional.

ME

I can be there.

SILAS

Good. I'll assume the same from you, Tristan.

TRISTAN

It doesn't look like I have much choice.

MASON

Guys, I get the importance of this, but do I really need to be there? I genuinely have something I can't miss tonight.

SILAS

You're excused because you don't make a habit of pissing your teammates off or posting about them online.

ME

Is everything okay, Mason?

There's something about Mason's last message that doesn't sit right with me, especially after his flat mood this morning. At first, I chalked it up to my stupidity online, and now I'm thinking it was over something else.

MASON

In the interest of transparency, no, not really.

SILAS

Is there anything we can do to help?

MASON

Unless any of you is a secret expert in marriage counseling, then, nah, I think I'm on my own with this one.

And just like that, all my troubles feel insignificant.

ME

I'm not a marriage counselor, but you are never on your own. I'm always here if you need to talk through anything.

TRISTAN

Same, man.

SILAS

What's the latest with Eloise? Shit, Mas, I'm sorry. I thought you guys were doing well.

I had no idea that Mason's marriage was struggling. From the outside, their relationship looked solid. I guess it's true when they say that you never

know what's really going on in someone's life.

MASON

She keeps threatening to move back home to France. Her parents want her to, and right now, I'm doing all I can to convince her to stay. She hates it in Seattle, but refuses to leave the house and make friends. Marriage counseling feels like the last roll of the dice to try and make things work. During the summer, I thought we were making progress and the scars from the past were starting to heal. Then the regular season started back up, and ... yeah, everything's going to shit again.

"Can I help you?" A bright-faced blonde woman smiles at me from behind the large white reception desk.

I blink a couple of times and lock my phone, still thinking about Mason.

"Hi," I say, approaching the desk. "I'm—"

"I know who you are," she says with a chuckle. "Are you here to see Drew?"

Impressed at her attentiveness, I nod once. "I don't have an appointment with her, but I was wondering if you could call her and ask if she had a spare hour to talk." I thumb behind me toward the glass double doors I just walked through. "I'm in need of breakfast, and I'm pretty sure she could use some too."

The lady just grins and picks up the phone, keying in a few numbers but keeping her attention firmly on me.

"Hey, Drew," she says after a few seconds. "I have Will Jones downstairs in reception for you. He wants to know if you can join him for breakfast."

She listens for a moment and then puts the receiver to her chest. "She wants to know if you're paying."

I burst out laughing. This girl is all kinds of hilarious.

"Yeah," I say, pulling out my wallet and waving it at the receptionist. "Anything she wants—cheesecake, hot chocolate, an ice cream sundae—it's on me."

The woman looks confused, and I'm not surprised. None of those items are considered breakfast food.

Another couple of seconds pass before the receptionist ends the call and points to a row of cream seats lining the left wall. "Take a seat for me, Will, and she'll be right down."



“ARE YOU GOING TO LOOK AT ME?” I ASK DREW, SOUNDING MORE desperate than curious.

This Waffle House has nothing on the menu I can eat. Even the fruit salad is likely full of additives.

Conversely, the woman sitting opposite me is studying waffle toppings like she’s considering ordering all of them.

Or maybe she’s deliberately avoiding eye contact because of what I did last night.

I wouldn’t blame her if she was, but still, I need her to give me her eyes so she can see the sincerity in the apology that I’m about to give her.

“I’m just so freaking mad at you, Will,” Drew declares, fingers gripping the menu even tighter.

“All right, what can I start you guys with?” The server looks between us both, obviously not recognizing me.

I motion to Drew for her to go first.

“I’ll get a black coffee and your berry surprise waffle stack, please.”

“And for you, sir?”

The server’s attention rests on me, and I pull my ball cap lower.

“I’ll just get a freshly squeezed orange juice, please.”

The server waits for me to add to my order.

“That’s all I want, thanks,” I finish with a smile.

She turns away before looking over her shoulder at me, a flirtatious glint in her eyes, which, ordinarily, I’d appreciate.

Right now, all I want is to gain Drew’s trust and turn her frown into the smile I picture when I’m not in her presence.

“You have every female in this town wrapped around your little finger, don’t you?” Drew’s tone is almost accusing and definitely not friendly, but, hey, she’s at least looking at me now.

“All but one,” I breathe out, pulling off my cap and setting it on the table.

She looks really pretty today, and I wonder if she’s wearing any makeup. It’s the first time I’ve seen the faintest smattering of freckles across her nose and cheeks.

Drew’s hair is pulled into a loose ponytail. It’s a relaxed look and a complete contrast to her tense shoulders.

I know her stress levels have everything to do with me, and I feel fucking terrible for letting emotions override my better judgment last night. The truth is, watching her leave with Tristan bothered me, and even though I regret making the post, I'm still desperate to know what happened after they left.

Did he just give her a ride home?

Did she invite him into her apartment for a drink?

Did he wake up in her bed and drive straight to morning skate with the same smug smirk he was wearing the entire time he was on the ice?

"Thanks," Drew says, taking her coffee from the server, and I pull the glass of juice toward me, turning it around on the table. "Well, I'm pissed off at you for posting what you did." She adjusts the collar on her white blouse. "Did you ever consider what would happen if Repeat saw it?"

No. I was too busy thinking about where Tristan's hands were wandering.

I shake my head and rid myself of invasive thoughts.

"Did you go home with him?" The question leaves me before I can stop it.

Drew sits back in the booth and empties a sachet of sweetener into her coffee.

"If you're asking if he took me home and then immediately drove back to his place, then, yeah, that's exactly what happened."

Frustration bubbles inside me, along with the same emotion I felt last night, but won't acknowledge because it's crazy for me to have a problem with Drew hooking up with any guy she chooses. When I was in college, I never even thought about what—or who—she was doing.

"I don't understand why you have such an issue with Tristan. It doesn't look professional."

I hold up a hand because if I have to hear the word *professional* one more time, then I'll lose my shit. On the ice, I'm the ultimate pro, but off it, I'm not, and it's about time I accepted that I'll never be the NHL's golden boy.

"I have my reasons for not liking him, and part of me bringing you here was so I could explain my actions, even if they were wholly unjustified."

Drew takes a sip of coffee. "What was the other part?"

I swallow and push my juice away. "I wanted to apologize. Away from your colleagues and boss and the bright lights of the office. I'm really

fucking sorry. The last thing I ever want to do is hurt you or the career I know you've worked so hard on. Even in the weeks since we've been working together, I can see the positive influence you've had on me, and I should've held it together, even when Tristan was goading me."

Drew looks at me, blue eyes examining me carefully. I never realized how big they were until I started sitting opposite her more often, like in the restaurant that time she forced me to eat cheesecake.

"What happened between you two?"

I feel my shoulders slump. "If I tell you, then you'll judge me."

"Why don't you try me before you assume how I'll react?"

She makes a good point, although I know she'll think I'm a piece of shit for what I did to Hallie.

"Back when I was in college, I unknowingly slept with Tristan's younger sister and broke her heart. I thought she was looking for fun, like I was, only to realize that she was into me and wanted more than casual hookups."

Drew quirks a brow at me. "Did you make it clear that you weren't looking for anything more with her?"

I shrug. "I didn't think I had to. Everyone knew about my reputation as a fuckboy who never dated seriously." My eyes briefly connect with Drew's. "But I think it was when I banged her best friend that shit got really messy."

"Will," Drew drawls, taking the plate of waffles from the server.

Picking up the syrup, she squeezes half of the bottle over the top.

I lean forward on the table, a playful smirk tracing my lips. "Did you want waffles and berries to go with your plate of diabetes?"

"Fuck off," she playfully retorts, shoving the biggest forkful into her mouth.

After a couple of seconds, she swallows and looks thoughtful.

"Say whatever is on your mind, Baby."

Drew points her fork at me. "Cut it out, William."

I mouth, *Sorry*, and wait to see if she'll tell me what was running through her mind.

"At the risk of overstepping every client-publicist boundary, how many people have you slept with?"

I pull my juice toward me and take a sip to quench the dry mouth I've suddenly developed. I didn't expect her to ask me that question.

“Truthfully? I have no idea.”

She loses her grip on the fork, and it dangles from her fingertips as she gazes at me. There’s no judgment in her expression, but there is disbelief.

“You’re only twenty-two. How can you not know?”

I shrug. “It’s just sex, Drew. No big deal. How many men have you been with?”

She rears back, like the question is only appropriate when she’s asking it. “I’m not telling you that!”

“Oh, come on!” I counter. “Play fair.”

She takes another bite of her breakfast. “Five.”

My jaw hangs open. “That’s all?”

“I only just turned twenty-one, and my parents likely think that I’m still a virgin.”

I burst out laughing. “There’s no way they think you’re still a virgin. You’re just telling yourself that to reduce the secondhand embarrassment of them knowing secrets about their little princess.”

Silence immediately takes hold of the conversation, although neither of us looks away. Our eyes are locked in a standoff, until I do something crazy, even for me.

Standing from the booth, I pull out my wallet and throw a hundred dollars in cash down on the table.

“What are you doing?” Drew asks in a small voice.

I reach down and take her by the hand, and she doesn’t resist, collecting her jacket and bag before I lead her out of the restaurant and into the parking lot.

Not a word passes between us when I unlock the Ferrari and open the passenger door for her to climb inside.

And when I slide into the driver’s seat and fire up the engine, I know this is my last chance to hold back from saying any more.

“What are you doing?” Drew repeats.

“I haven’t been completely honest with you, and I wanted total privacy when I said this. I know it’s probably a really bad idea, but making dangerous decisions is my MO these days.” I puff out a shaky breath. “I can’t believe I’m about to admit this.”

She swivels in her seat. “Will, you’re worrying me right now.”

I shake my head and take her hand, just like the night of the gala. Only for very different reasons this time around.

“I know I’m going to fuck things up when I tell you this.”

Drew looks down at our joined hands. “Did I judge you when you told me about Tristan’s sister?”

“No,” I reply. “But this has the potential to really freak you out, and I’m praying it doesn’t.”

More silence.

I inhale another unsteady breath and acknowledge that whatever happens next between us is inevitable.

I’m into Drew Callaghan. The one woman I shouldn’t want for multiple reasons.

“I lashed out last night because my teammate’s a dick—that bit is true.”

Reaching across the center section, I cup her soft cheek in my left palm. It pinkens in response to my touch, but she doesn’t pull away. Maybe she already knows that I’m crushing on her. I couldn’t tear my eyes away from her at the gala, no matter how hard I tried.

What the fuck are you doing, Will?

“But that wasn’t the main reason why,” I add.

Her breath hitches, and, fuck, it feels like there’s no oxygen in here.

“I was jealous.” I sigh out the confession. “I didn’t like seeing you leave with another guy because I wanted to drive you home myself.”

Drew’s chest rises and falls more rapidly than before. “Did you just want to give me a ride home?”

Despite the building tension, I refuse to look away from her. A little like my apology earlier, I need her to see that I’m not kidding around.

“Are you seriously going to make me answer that question?”

She just chuckles, her attention falling to our hands once more. “I don’t know what to say, Will.”

I squeeze her hand. “We’re sitting in my car, away from any eavesdroppers. Tell me that you like me, too, or that you at least find me attractive, so I don’t feel like I’m going fucking crazy here.”

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. . .

Drew

I expected today would be all kinds of unpredictable. And it is because Will Jones is the living version of a loose cannon.

An impossibly handsome, incredibly dangerous loose cannon.

Up until this point, I've always liked men who took the easy road in life. The ones who played it safe with their heart—and consequently, mine too. The only exception to that rule was Paul Tierney. After our fling ended, I convinced myself that the next guy would be more like the men who had come before him.

Will is everything I vowed to avoid, and while he might convince himself that my silence is down to the shock of what he just admitted out loud, we both know the real truth.

There's been something simmering between us since the day he showed up at my place and started unpacking my grocery shopping.

"Which of your rules am I in breach of this time?" Will muses, the weight in his voice revealing how stressed he is.

Things between us just got really complicated, really fucking fast.

It feels like my heart might beat out of my chest when I finally whisper, "All of them, I think."

He moves his hand from my cheek to the nape of my neck, and for a moment, I think he's going to kiss me.

Holy shit. He might not recall how many women he's slept with, and I cannot blame a single one of them for falling under his spell. Because if he pulled my lips closer to his mouth, there's no way I wouldn't let him do what he wanted with me.

"We can never go there, Will," I whisper.

His fingers tighten a fraction, eliciting tingles all over my body. “Is this your way of telling me that you feel something between us?”

I turn my head and gaze out of the windshield. The sky is bright and sunny today, the total opposite of my cloudy brain.

“This is me telling you that it’s pointless, voicing how I feel about you, because nothing could ever happen.”

When my eyes focus back on Will’s handsome face, pieces of dark hair fall into his eyes. It would be so easy to just go ahead and lay it all out in his car and confess to my attraction.

“I’m your publicist, your coach’s daughter, and our families have been friends since before we entered this world. You’ve had some pretty catastrophic ideas in the past, but this one has to be at the top of that list.”

Brown eyes continue to hold me captive.

“Is this just about sex for you?” I ask, recalling the way he glanced at my right thigh as I drove us to the gala. I loved his eyes on me that night, and I’d be a liar to deny it. “If it is, then it would be safer to hit up Candice for another round.”

Will frowns. “That hurts to hear you say that. Not everything for me is about sex. I don’t know how to explain my attraction to you, but I know it isn’t just physical.”

So much of me wants to throw the passenger door open and run a million miles away from this situation, and I know he wouldn’t stop me from climbing out of the car and doing just that.

My butt stays fixed to the black leather bucket seat, and I drop my eyes down his body. He’s wearing an emerald Rogues hoodie with his initials stamped on the left sleeve. Black track pants hug his thick hockey thighs perfectly. Dressed in casuals or a tux, Will is hot as hell. But just like how he described with me, I’m drawn to him for more than his looks. At one time, I found his cocky smirk infuriating. Now, it makes me want to kiss him, just so he’ll grin even wider.

“The last thing I want to do is hurt you,” I finally say.

He sighs heavily and pulls his hand away from my neck.

Instantly, I feel the loss.

“I’ve fucked everything up, haven’t I?” he groans in an exasperated voice.

“They say it takes two to tango—and for good reason.”

My response sparks a flicker of excitement in his eyes, and he strokes his thumb over the top of my hand.

“You’ve caught me totally off guard, Drew.” Will pushes a spare hand through his tousled hair. “This is going to sound really conceited, but ... I’ve never wanted someone I couldn’t have, and I don’t know what the fuck to do with these emotions now that I have them. I didn’t choose to be attracted to you. Before we started working together, I always saw you as the good girl and daughter of my parents’ best friends.” His forehead finds the top of his steering wheel.

“After I slept with Candice, I immediately regretted it. To be honest, I’d wanted to pull back even before we climbed into bed together. I wasn’t sure why I had been reluctant to go through with the hookup, but now it’s much clearer.”

Slowly, he swivels his head to look at me, although it’s still resting on his steering wheel. “I wanted her to be you. You make me laugh, even when you’re pissed at me for being a dick. But most of all, you fascinate me, and seeing you all professional and serious ...” His eyes move across my body, and I feel them everywhere. “Fuck.”

The single word makes me giggle, and he pulls his hand from mine, gripping the steering wheel hard.

“I wasn’t laughing at you,” I reassure him. “I’m shit at accepting compliments.”

He smiles at me. “I know you are. I’ve learned a lot about you over the past few weeks.”

More silence fills the car before some clarity finally breaks through the haze of confusion.

“I think we need some time away from each other. It’ll offer us both perspective. You can focus on hockey and won’t be tempted to post stupid stuff online ...” I trail off and lift a brow at him. “Who am I kidding? You’re always tempted to do that.”

I can tell he wants to laugh, though he doesn’t. Instead, he throws his head back into the headrest and gazes at me with a burning need that should be criminal.

“I’ll be posting a statement on your X account later today. After that, things will go quiet on your socials for a while. I can use this time to work on some of my other clients, and if I need you, then I’ll reach out via email.”

Will swallows thickly. “This is you pulling back, isn’t it?”

“Yes, and no.”

Will groans, and I know it’s at himself.

“In three weeks, when you play the Blades, I still plan to travel and meet you in Brooklyn, and I’m hoping that Repeet will want to meet while we’re in town. I also wanted to gather some social media content and—”

“Drew.” Will stops me in a soft voice. “I really fucking like you.”

The way he says it makes my heart—and panties—melt.

“I know.”

“Do you like Tristan?”

I shake my head. “No. He gave me a ride home to be kind, and that was it.”

“Are you seeing anyone else?”

Will fires the questions at me, and I continue shaking my head. This boy is so freaking intense—and every bit his dad’s son. So many times, Kate has talked about how Jensen pursued her relentlessly until she gave in and dated him.

I wonder how many women Will has made swoon like this until he finally had them exactly where he wanted—between the sheets and screaming his name.

Heat pools in my core. I know he’d be good in bed—better than good. It’s been a long-ass time since I’ve been with anyone. In fact, the last person was Paul.

“You’re killing me here.”

I reach across the car and pat his shoulder lightly. “Get a grip on yourself, Hotshot. I’m not seeing anyone, and even if I were, there are plenty more fish in the ocean for you.”

His face contorts, and I hate myself for saying it too. But this is our reality—we’re not supposed to be together. Whether it’s for a single night or a few fun dates. The universe and our lives are both telling us no.

“Is it because you know I’d rock your world and spoil you for all other guys?”

I scoff and almost choke on my own breath. “Only you, Will. Only you could say something like that to your publicist and get away with it.”

Bratty attitude on full display, he leans across the center section, woody cologne hitting me from all angles. “Only because I’m your favorite client.”

With him this close, I struggle to process thoughts, let alone form words.

After a second, I find my voice, although it's labored as I say, "In your dreams, maybe."

He pinches my chin between his thumb and forefinger.

Abort. Immediately.

"I have dreamed about you, Drew. And each of those times, I was *definitely* your favorite."

I should swipe his hand away and set clear boundaries.

That's exactly what I should do.

"Can you imagine how my dad would react if he found out that we were ..." I trail off, struggling to find the right words to describe something I want to do so badly.

Will breathes out, and it tickles my face. Instinctively, my tongue swipes across my bottom lip. He tastes as good as he smells. I knew he would.

"But he thinks you're still a virgin, so why would he ever suspect you of sleeping with his forward?"

"Will," I warn.

"Drew," he volleys back.

"I stand by what I said earlier—we need some time apart. Things have been really intense lately, and while you're playing well, the start of your career with the Rogues has been rocky in other ways. You need some time to bond with your teammates, and I need ..."

What do I need?

"What do you need, Baby?"

I release his grip on my chin. "I need to focus on my own career, and you need to stop calling me that nickname."

I can't be sure if it's disappointment or frustration that flashes through Will's eyes. Either way, he knows that I'm making sense.

I refuse to risk everything I've worked for just to find out how well he would rock my world in bed.

My thighs clench, and I bite on the inside of my cheek.

"As of the day after tomorrow, I'll be away in Pittsburg for a week."

I nod once. "I know. I keep a close eye on your game schedule."

Will closes his eyes and puffs out another breath. "If respecting professional boundaries is what you want, then I'll comply with that."

I can't help it when I say in a shocked voice, "You, comply with the rules? All right, who are you, and what have you done with my client?"

So much of me wants him to laugh, if only to alleviate the unbearable sexual tension between us.

I set one hand on the door handle, ready to leave, like I should've done ten minutes ago.

"Where are you going?"

I tip my chin at the restaurant entrance. "I'm going back inside to order another plate of waffles and finish up on some emails I need to send. They have free Wi-Fi, and I'm still hungry."

Will dips a hand into his right pocket, and I stop him with a palm on his thigh.

He freezes in place as soon as I touch him.

"If you're reaching for your wallet, then I won't accept your money. Technically, our breakfast should've been put through business expenses."

I feel sure that he understands the true meaning behind my statement—everything we do from now on has to be purely by the book.

No more sociable work meetings at his place or in a bar.

No more banter back and forth by text.

No more showing up at my apartment so we can travel to events together.

"When will we see each other again?" Will asks when I push the passenger door open and swing one leg out of the car.

I turn back to him and grab my bag from the floorboard.

"When we next meet at the office for the routine catch-ups that we should be having every two weeks. I'll send you a calendar invite."

17

. . .

Will

“Goddamn, man. Goal fucking machine!”

Silas collides with my chest and wraps an arm around my neck as we both turn and face the away crowd.

It feels like our support on the road is slowly increasing, and even if Tristan doesn't want to acknowledge my existence or the fact that I'm now ahead of him on goals scored so far this season, I know it has everything to do with the instant impact I've had on the team.

Silas knocks his helmet against mine. “No, seriously, you're on fire, and the W is definitely in the bag.”

“Shh!” I hush him, bringing a finger to my lips, which kicks up noise from our fans. “Don't jinx us before the final buzzer.”

He deadpans at me as we skate toward center ice. “We're two goals up, and there's fifteen seconds left on the timer.”

Flying straight past us both, Tristan rejoins the ice on a changeover from Coach, and my captain watches him as he gets into position.

“I see the talk we had at Riley's had the desired effect,” he points out sarcastically.

I look over my shoulder toward the benches and see Pittsburgh's coach asking the ref a question, which buys us a few additional seconds before the restart.

“I apologized for the post. What more can I do?”

Silas chews on the corner of his mouth guard. “Nothing. It's down to him to push past whatever issue he has with you. So long as you're scoring goals and killing it on the ice, I'd say that you're doing your job.”

I glance at Tristan again as he starts stretching out his left adductor while we wait for the ref to finish up talking. He still hasn't told anyone about what happened with Hallie, and a part of me wonders if he's deliberately staying silent so he can threaten to drag me with our teammates should he need to gain the moral high ground later.

Another part of me thinks he simply likes getting under my skin, or more specifically, a chance at taking my publicist to bed.

Jealousy burns through me when Silas skates off, and I see Coach motion for me to switch out for the final time.

"Nice work out there," Mason croons, shifting along the bench when I step off the ice and bump fists with Coach.

I take a seat next to him and pull out my mouth guard. The game still hasn't restarted, and there's no chance I'm getting back on the ice tonight.

I'm good with that. I came here to do a job—score and help the team secure another shutout. Mission accomplished.

"Thanks," I tell him.

Since the day he broke the news about his marriage, I've not been sure of what to say. The guy is going through a tough time, and from what I know of him so far, he doesn't deserve any of it. Why does shitty stuff happen to good people?

"How's, um ... how are things with Eloise?" I finally ask.

I can tell he's hurting, even if he's doing his best to hide it in a packed arena.

"You don't have to answer," I quickly tag on. "This probably wasn't the best time to ask you something like that."

Mason leans forward, resting his upper weight on his stick. He sighs deeply, and Drew's face flashes in front of me. It's been a week since she climbed out of my car. If her grand plan of us giving each other space was to somehow curb my attraction to her, then it hasn't fucking worked.

The only time I'm not thinking about the dark-haired beauty who likes to boss me around is when the puck is on the end of my stick.

"She flew back to France when we left for Pittsburg." Mason's voice is low and heavy. "I think we're over for good because this time, I have no clue how to fix us. Plus ..." He swallows and gazes absent-mindedly over the ice as the game restarts. "It's not like I can fly halfway across the world so we can talk. The hockey season is too congested."

I nod without any personal experience to draw on. “You know if you ever need to shoot the shit with me, I’m here. I promise not to post any of our conversation on social media.”

Mason’s head snaps to me before he bursts out laughing, and the game ends.

We both stand, and Coach appreciatively taps our helmets before we make our way down the tunnel.

“I bet you were really fucking popular with your publicist over that one.” He pushes through the locker room door and heads for the benches, where we’re stationed next to each other. “You’re long-term friends, aren’t you?”

The rest of the team starts trickling into the room, distracted with their own conversations about the game.

And as I take a seat on the bench and immediately pull my phone from my bag, checking it for any kind of message from Drew beyond a fucking calendar invite, I consider sharing what went down in my car the other week.

It’s driving me fucking crazy, keeping it to myself. Ordinarily, I’d call my sister since we share everything with each other, but she’d probably just laugh at me and definitely think that I was fucking around. Not that I could fault her for that. Drew and I are the most unlikely pairing.

To everyone but me.

“When you’re silent, you make me nervous.”

I bite on my bottom lip as Mason takes a seat beside me and starts unlacing his skates.

“Why?” I ask.

He just chuckles. “Because you’re hardly ever quiet. Normally, that mouth of yours is constantly moving, so when you have nothing to say, I start to question what’s going on in that head.”

I’d argue back if he was wrong.

“Oh, I have plenty to say,” I eventually reply. “Just struggling to work out how to word it.”

Mason moves to work on his other skate, and I stand from the bench, pulling off my jersey and tossing it into the laundry bin in the center of the room.

“You have the hots for her.”

I stand motionless.

He flashes me a knowing grin. “See what I mean? Your silence makes me anxious because I know there’s something fucked up going on in there.” He reaches forward and taps my temple. “And just so you know, banging your publicist—whether or not you have history together—is not a wise move.”

He freezes at his own thoughts and comes to stand directly in front of me. “Wait, isn’t she also Coach Callaghan’s daughter?”

“Shh!” I hush a teammate for the second time tonight. “Why don’t you speak up and let the whole damn arena know about it?”

Mason side-eyes me and pulls off his jersey, tossing it into the laundry bin too.

“I might be a little bit attracted to her,” I admit, squeezing my thumb and forefinger together.

Another dubious look comes my way.

“All right, Will, whatever you say.”

Mason starts pulling off his pads, and I do the same.

“Has anything happened between you two?”

“No,” I say with a headshake. “And you’re the only one who knows anything, so keep it that way.” I pause and study my teammate. “How did you guess?”

He looks at me like it’s obvious. “The gala. Dude, you were throwing Tristan daggers while he danced with her. Every time she moved around the room, your eyes would follow.” He shrugs his shoulders. “What can I say? I was dateless and bored that night. I had plenty of time to people-watch.”

Fuck.

“Was I that transparent?” I wince.

“Completely fucking see-through.”

Finishing up on my gear, I pull a white towel from the hook set directly in front of me and wrap it around my waist. “I’m taking a shower.”

Mason tips his head at the locker room door. “You aren’t hitting the gym for a cooldown first?”

I’ve never missed a postgame cooldown before. However, since I don’t have any press responsibilities tonight and all I want to be is back at the hotel so I can dissect the last conversation I shared with Drew some more, I grab my wash bag from the bench and say, “Nah. I didn’t sleep well last night and could use the additional rest.”

Mason looks doubtful. “You aren’t heading out tonight to celebrate a successful away series? Pittsburgh has some great places to eat.”

A little like a cooldown, I never miss a night out either, so when, “Nah,” leaves my mouth again, Mason catches me by the arm before I walk away.

“You need to come out tonight. If you don’t, people will start asking questions, especially after the way you’ve dominated the ice this past week.”

I really don’t want to go out tonight, but my teammate is right. It would be weird, and Tristan would likely love that I’m not there.

Releasing a low groan, I give him a tight nod. “All right. I’ll show up. But only for an hour because I’m genuinely fucking exhausted.”

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Drew

Each time I open social media, a new photograph or video of Will appears. It's like the algorithm wants me to do my job while drowning in an ocean of uninvited—and equally unhelpful—thoughts.

How many different women can this boy be pictured with in one night?

Sure, he isn't actually making out with any of them, but if the two blondes in the photo I'm currently looking at could straddle his thick hockey thighs, I have zero doubt that they would.

"Living up to his reputation again," Lydia singsongs in a voice that is way too upbeat to be genuine.

She continues viewing my laptop from over my shoulder, and after a few more seconds of scrolling on Instagram, I close the lid and spin around in my chair to face her.

"Can I help you?"

Like always, she perches her ass on the corner of my L-shaped desk and smirks.

"How many women do you think he's slept with?"

Immediately, memories of berry waffles, black coffee, and brown eyes burning with desire come flooding back. After I climbed out of Will's car and returned to the Waffle House, I sent precisely two emails out of the dozen I needed to that morning.

Truthfully, this week, I've been so unproductive that I might as well have taken it off sick. Will's confession has been on repeat since the day the Rogues left for Pittsburg. The online images from this away series have only made things harder.

Was everything he said bullshit?

Was I that easy to forget after I told him that nothing could happen between us?

Maybe his *attraction* to me was all a joke that I somehow didn't get?

No. There's no way he would fuck around with me over something like that.

"Repeet will love that he's not only insulting his teammates, but back to his playboy ways," Lydia sarcastically adds.

"Actually ..." I cross my legs over at the knee and sound every bit as satisfied as I feel to share this next bit of news with my colleague. Lydia could only dream of receiving the kind of email I did this morning. "That's where you're wrong. You can call him a bad boy or playboy, but Repeet still wants to meet with him in Brooklyn."

Her mouth pops open, and she immediately clamps it shut. "I thought they pulled away from a deal back in the summer."

I lift a shoulder like their interest in my client is a mystery to me, too, when we all know exactly why Will is drawing in big-name brands—you cannot keep talent down, and his physical image makes the perfect poster boy.

I also think him meeting Kevin Rogers at the gala helped to strengthen his chances. There's nothing like looking into someone's eyes to gauge their level of sincerity.

Another wave of uninvited memories comes crashing to the front of my brain.

"I really fucking like you."

Tingles accompany the gravelly tone in Will's voice as I recall his declaration for the hundredth time.

Lydia's gaze drops down the length of my body, eyes narrowing suspiciously.

I uncross my legs and spin back to my laptop, panicked that my body language screams of what's happening in my head.

Don't be ridiculous, Drew. Lydia may be a manipulative troublemaker, but she isn't a mind reader.

"I'll assume that you're accompanying him to New York then?" There's an edge of something in Lydia's tone that I don't altogether like.

I choose to ignore it and open my laptop, navigating to Kevin's email so she can witness his invite for herself. After a few seconds, I open up a new message addressed to Will and begin typing a very professional email,

confirming the invite from Repeet, along with the day, time, and place of the proposed meeting.

Lydia is still hovering behind me when I hit Send.

“Why wouldn’t I attend the meeting?”

She stands from the corner of my desk and moves in front of me.

Honestly, I don’t know what’s eating at this woman and why she’s never liked me. It feels conceited to think that it’s jealousy, but I’ve never given her any reason to give me such a hard time.

“If I were you, I’d want Colton to come with me. A meeting like that is exciting, but will probably be out of your comfort zone.”

Before I can politely tell her to fuck off, she spins on her heel and marches off, ass swaying in a gray miniskirt that’s entirely too tight for her ass and much too short for the office.

I hope it rips when she bends down to refill the printer with paper.

My laptop pings, and an email drops down from Will.

From: Will Jones

To: Drew Callaghan

Subject: Re: Repeet invite (Stop being so formal, Baby.)

Drew,

Does this mean we get to have our first vacation together? I’ll book the hotel suite and restaurant. How about Japanese? There’s this fucking awesome sushi restaurant in Williamsburg.

Will x

Are you kidding me right now?

From: Drew Callaghan

To: Will Jones

Subject: Re: Repeet invite (Stop being so fucking unprofessional.)

William,

For the benefit of company records and anyone monitoring this email string, I would like to confirm that my client is, in fact, messing around and we are not, in fact, sharing a hotel suite.

Drew

Switching from email to text, I pick up my cell and begin typing the response I really wanted to send.

ME

Could you be any more reckless? My boss sporadically checks my inbox!

WILL

Wait. People check your email?

ME

Yes! A little like how you go through medical examinations and tests for doping, my electronic footprint can be monitored at any point.

WILL

Shit. Sorry. Maybe delete those messages then. But also ... electronic footprint. You are so formal sometimes. It's hot in a geeky way.

ME

You think I'm geeky?

WILL

Nope. I know you're geeky.

ME

Says the boy who aced his bachelor's in math.

WILL

I got my brains from my mama.

ME

Is there anything you can't do?

WILL

Yeah, actually. I'm struggling to get you in my bed. Can you help a guy out?

Holy hell.

ME

I already told you that it can never happen.

WILL

But do you want it to?

ME

Will.

WILL

Drew.

ME

Stop fucking with me.

WILL

I miss you.

ME

I don't know what to say anymore.

WILL

Do you want something to happen between us?

After I set my phone down on the desk, my eyes rove around the office. Everyone—including Lydia—is busy, either on calls or in other conversations.

I slowly pick my phone back up and reopen the message thread with Will.

ME

I've thought about it. But that doesn't change our reality.

WILL

And this is why rules are so fucking stupid. It's better to take what you want because we only live once.

ME

One night to scratch an itch isn't worth a lifetime of hassle.

WILL

Who said anything about only one night?

Holy fucking hell.

WILL

Just say that we can talk while we're in New York.

Over Japanese food.

ME

Again, I refer you to rule number two.

WILL

Technically, this wouldn't be a work-based meeting. So, rule two doesn't apply.

ME

You're incorrigible.

WILL

Just say yes and stop denying yourself what you want.

I promise to keep it professional.

Unless you tell me not to ...

ME

BTW, you didn't just get your brains from your mother. You got your stubbornness also.

WILL

And you got your mom and dad's resilience. Damn, woman.

I giggle because he's absolutely correct.

ME

Okay.

WILL

To Japanese food, the hotel suite, or both?

This time, I snort loudly at his latest message.

ME

To a meal and talking. I'll book my own accommodations.

WILL

Where are you staying?

ME

With your parents.

WILL

Banging while my parents sleep next door. I like your style. Bad girl.

ME

I'm not staying with your parents. Stupidly, I thought that would be a line even you wouldn't cross. Actually speechless right now.

WILL

Baby, the aim is to make you speechless. But I haven't even laid a finger on you yet. Let's take things nice and steady to begin with, yeah?

ME

Will you ever stop?

WILL

There are only two circumstances where I'd back off.

ME

Let's hear them.

When a voice note lands next, I bend down and scrabble through my bag for my AirPods so I can listen in private.

Popping the case, I slide them into my ears and hit Play.

"If you're listening to this on loudspeaker, I'd advise that you don't."

A few seconds later, Will begins speaking again. I haven't heard his deep voice in over a week, and it surprises me how much I've missed it.

"Anyway," he continues, "you asked me under what circumstances I'd back off from you. Number one: if you asked me to. As irresistible as I am, I'm not into forcing anyone to want me." He breathes out a long exhale. "And second ..." He pauses, and, shit, what the hell is he going to say next? "Second ... I'd back off if you ordered me cheesecake without my prior consent again."

I'm out of my chair and heading for the restrooms in record time, hitting the Record button as soon as the door closes behind me.

"I think I might actually hate you." Standing in front of one of the mirrors, I place a hand in the center of my chest and feel the fast thump of my heart. "I genuinely wondered what you were going to say next. I think it's best if I lead all conversations when we meet with Repeat."

It's all of ten seconds after I sent the voice note that a kissing-face emoji and a slice of cake—which I assume is supposed to be cheesecake—pops up, followed by a final message from the boy who drives me mad every hour, yet I'm still left wondering when I'll next hear from him.

WILL

You can talk all you want in that meeting, so long as I get you all to myself afterward.

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Will

MASON

Win or lose, when we play in Brooklyn, I need to go out and drink afterward.

SILAS

Mid-season? How do you plan on getting that one past Coach?

MASON

By not telling him.

SILAS

You'll reek of alcohol the next day, and he'll pick up on it.

MASON

My marriage is over for good. Whatever Coach thinks about me right now is the least of my worries.

SILAS

Fuck. Seriously?

TRISTAN

Where is Eloise now?

MASON

Seriously. She isn't coming back from France, and she wants a clean break.

ME

Fuck it. I'm in, buddy.

TRISTAN

One pint of beer, and you'll be comatose.

ME

What can I say? I'm a cheap date.

TRISTAN

It's almost worth me buying you a drink just so you'll be quiet for the whole night.

ME

Oh, wait, if Tristan's there, then I'm out. I have a reputation to uphold.

TRISTAN

And what a reputation it is. How many women did you bang in Pittsburg? Three, four?

ME

None. And this is about Mason. Stop being a dick.

MASON

No, by all means, you two carry on. Watching you two go at it is like a spectator sport, and it's keeping my mind off whose bed my wife is currently warming.

SILAS

You don't think she'd move on to someone else that fast, do you?

MASON

We're technically separated, and I know there's at least one dude who will jump at the first chance he gets.

ME

Who are we beating up?

MASON

I appreciate the sentiment and you having my back and all, but unless you plan on boarding a plane to northern France and seeking out her childhood sweetheart, named Gabriel, then you might struggle.

Closing out the group text chat, I slide my cell into my pocket and pause outside Drew's door. Showing up here unannounced is in direct breach of rule three on her ridiculous list, but an hour of sitting on the other side of a table in a boring boardroom isn't going to be enough for me. All she did yesterday in our catch-up meeting was talk about Repeet and potential opportunities with other brands.

I need more.

Knocking a couple of times, I wait for a response, but get nothing.

It's past seven p.m., so I know she's finished in the office.

Maybe she's at the gym?

Or at her parents'?

Or ... fuck ... maybe she's out on a date and plans to do the same as Eloise.

I knock louder, fully convinced that she's beneath another dude when her door finally swings inward and I'm met with a warm smile, which morphs into a scowl.

Her big eyes land on the bouquet of freesias in my hand, and a hint of warmth returns to her expression.

"Will, um ..." Covered by nothing but tiny pink sleep shorts and a white tank top that cuts low at the front, Drew immediately pulls her lilac robe across her body and secures it with the tie. "Did I miss a meeting or something?" Her voice is as panicked as her face.

Fuck, why did I not consider that she could be semi-naked and—I peer over her shoulder into the living space and see a tub of ice cream sitting on the coffee table—eating all the sugar she could lay her hands on?

"You look cute as hell. And like you would ever miss a meeting," I tell her, holding out the bouquet for her to take.

It took me ages to pick out what I thought she'd like best. In the end, I went with a pretty flower that packed an incredible scent. Everything about a freesia reminds me of Drew.

When she takes the flowers and smells them, her eyelids flutter closed. "So, why are you here?" Her eyes snap open, and I see an emotion in them that wasn't there before. "And how did you know freesias were my favorite flower?"

I step closer to Drew, and the smell of the flowers has nothing on the strawberry sweetness emanating from her tonight. I'd love to bottle that shit and spray it on my pillows. Better yet, have the real thing lying next to me all night.

"This is where I could take all the credit and claim that I always knew they were your favorite flower. But that would be a lie, and I don't bullshit."

Still standing in the doorway, she brings the white and purple petals to her nose and inhales deeply. "They are my mom's favorite, and I like that

you picked them by chance, even if I'm not sure why I have them in the first place."

Wincing, I grip the back of my neck. "They're an apology and a just because."

Drew steps to the side so I can enter and closes the door behind me.

"You know, you don't need to apologize for having fun on an away series. So long as you aren't breaking rule seven and arranging hookups via private messages that can be screenshot, then you're free to do what you want."

I don't bother to turn around and face her, opting to take in the cozy setup she has in her living room. A duvet is slung over the deep blue couch that faces a widescreen TV, which is paused on an episode of *The Last Kingdom*. A spoon sits in a half-finished tub of chocolate brownie ice cream, and I'm pretty sure the empty mug beside it was once a hot chocolate, based on the smeared evidence around the rim, along with the pink lip stain.

And now I'm jealous of a fucking mug.

Kicking off my Repeat sneakers—which I only wore over here because I knew Drew would notice them—I take a seat in the center of the couch and tap the empty space to my left.

"Come sit."

Drew frowns at me. "Last I checked, I was a human being and not a dog. You can't order me to sit when it pleases you."

Without a word, I rise from the couch and walk over to her, taking the flowers in one hand and interlacing our fingers with the other. She doesn't fight me on it, and for once, I love how compliant she's being.

"Baby, if I had my way, I'd be commanding you to do a lot more than just sit. Unless ..." I trail off, and a filthy smirk traces my lips. "Unless you were sitting on my—"

"Stop!" Drew interjects. Deep pink, the same color as her sleep shorts, creeps down her neck. "I know what you were insinuating."

Still smirking, I lead her over to the couch, and she takes a seat next to me.

I reach behind us and pull her light-blue duvet across our laps.

"Will ... what the fuck are you doing?" Drew's protest is weak, and she knows it.

Throwing her a big, cheesy grin, I set the flowers down next to me and grab the TV remote from the armrest, hitting Play.

She sighs heavily.

“I didn’t know you liked to watch violence,” I say.

Drew reaches across us both and pauses the program again.

I point toward the TV. “I was watching that.”

Grabbing the duvet, she yanks it away from me. “You shouldn’t be here. Watching TV and pretending like there’s nothing strange about a client and his publicist cuddling on a couch.”

I quirk an inquisitive brow. “Cuddling? Were you expecting me to put my arms around you?”

She scoffs, and I chuckle. “I honestly don’t know what to expect from you anymore. Other than your complete and total disregard for the rules I set for good reason.”

Drew’s right. I keep overstepping, and I shouldn’t have shown up here tonight.

Rising to my feet, I shove my hands into my pockets and drop my shoulders. “For what it’s worth, nothing happened with the women I was pictured with in Pittsburg. The flowers were an apology for all the times I’d acted like a dick. I could’ve had them delivered to your door, but that would have meant passing on an opportunity to see you outside of boring business meetings.”

Through thick, dark lashes, Drew peers up at me from the couch.

“You aren’t a dick, Will. I just ...” Her fingers tangle together in her lap—a sure sign that she’s stressed or maybe more confused. “I don’t know how to act around you anymore. For years, I’ve seen you as the family friend I could banter with at Christmas parties.” Her eyes drop to the floor. “And now it feels like everything has shifted because we’ve spent alone time together.”

I hate how uncomfortable she looks.

Crouching down in front of her, I thread my fingers through her right hand. “If you want me to leave, then I’ll go. I came here tonight because I missed you and I felt like you’d been avoiding me. But, Drew ... I never want to put you in a position where you feel pressured.”

When I release her hand and turn to head for the front door, she stands and cups my elbow in her palm.

I'm not testing Drew, and I hope she knows that. If she hadn't stopped me from leaving, then I genuinely would've walked out the door. I can feel every ounce of the sexual charge between us, but I need this girl to show me that she can sense it, too, for me to take things any further.

"I want you to stay a while longer. I think we need to talk."

My hands are on her hips in seconds, and I swear to God, I feel the delicious shudder as it racks through her small frame.

"Talk about what?" I ask, dropping my forehead against hers. "Because if it's about schedules or social media content, then I'm not sticking around."

She shakes her head. "You didn't come here to talk work, and I think this thing between us isn't going to go away with time and distance. Is it?" Drew says the final two words like she's seeking reassurance from me.

I'm happy to validate her thoughts.

"No, Baby, it won't. Because I'm not going anywhere," I whisper softly, tucking a stray piece of hair behind her ear. The rest is piled on top of her head in a way that only adds to her sexual appeal.

Fuck me, I want her so freaking badly.

"Let me kiss you," I softly plead. "Just once, and I promise with no tongue."

She shakes her head again. "I can't let you do that."

"Why not?"

She swallows thickly. "Because I don't trust myself around you."

"Then I'll leave, and we'll go back to the way things were before September."

After a beat, she sets a hand on my right cheek, and, wow, the feel of her warm palm has my knees ready to give out.

Keep it together, Will.

"I've been sitting here all night, thinking about New York and what happens after the Japanese restaurant."

My cheeks ache from the grin I'm unable to suppress. "You've been thinking about me?"

She's all innocence, and all I want to do is wrap her legs around my waist and corrupt every part of her.

"You test me in ways I've never been tested before, Drew. I've never chased a girl because I've never been interested in pursuing someone." I

bite down on my lip. “The way I would move fucking mountains to spend a night with you.”

She rises on her tiptoes, our lips a hairbreadth apart when she whispers, “Would it be like how you are with all the other girls? One night, and you’re done with me?”

My forehead is back against hers. “It’s funny you should ask that.”

Drew pulls back to look at me properly. “Why?”

I bring her body into mine, hands slowly moving from her hips to the tie holding her robe together. When I slowly start to unravel the knot and she doesn’t stop me or take her eyes away from mine, I’m certain she’s comfortable with me seeing her.

When her robe is hanging open, my gaze slowly descends her body, hands back on her hips.

This time—and without a robe in the way—I feel the heat from her skin radiating into my palms. I can make out the faint outline of perfect pink nipples through her white tank top, and when they harden beneath my gaze, I yank my black T-shirt overhead and toss it on the floor behind us.

See me, Drew.

Her jaw pops open as she takes in my upper body. I’m acutely aware that I haven’t answered her last question, but words aren’t what’s needed in this moment.

I suck a sharp breath through my teeth when she sets a hand in the center of my chest. It must be at least thirty seconds before she finally asks me, “Why?” again.

I’m in deep. Way out of my comfort zone but powerless to hold back in my pursuit of Drew Callaghan.

“Because I’ve been wondering the same thing about you—if I take you to bed and risk feeling things I’ve never felt with anyone else, will I wake up in the morning to find your side cold and empty with an email in my inbox, telling me that we can’t work together anymore?”

Pulling one hand from her hip, I tip Drew’s chin up to look at me. My lips are right there, hovering over a kiss that will plunge me straight into an ocean of darkness. An unknown I’m so desperate and fearful to explore.

Would she yank herself away and scream at me to leave if I went ahead and took what I wanted, or would it be the biggest payoff of my life? By nature, I’m a huge risk-taker, but this is fucking risky, even by my own standards.

“Let me kiss you. Just once.” I don’t even try to disguise the plea in my tone as I repeat what I said earlier. “If you feel nothing, then we can put this behind us.”

“And if I feel everything?” she asks in a small voice. “What then?”

I nod in the direction of her hallway, which I know leads to the bedrooms. “Then I’ll peel those illegal shorts from your stunning body and show you just how reckless I can be.”

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Drew

Will still has his left hand under my chin, demanding all of my attention.

I've never wanted a man's mouth to cover mine more than I do right now.

I'm scared, excited, nervous, and hopeful. Of course I'm going to feel his kiss all the way to the tips of my toes, and when I do, he'll haul me into his bare, chiseled chest and peel my soaked sleep shorts down my legs, just as he promised he would.

I want this. I know it deep in the pit of my gut, and even though agreeing to a kiss is the worst idea for us both, it's surely futile to ignore its inevitability.

He looms like a Viking, waiting on me to finally give in and let him command the next however many hours between us. But regardless of my need, I'm still hesitant to throw caution to the wind and tell him yes.

Will's lips inch closer to mine, and our breaths mingle.

It's been so long since I last kissed a guy, and nerves flutter around my body like I'm a preteen at the school dance, desperate for her date to make the first move.

Fortunately for me, Will is the kind of guy who needs no encouragement, a confident grin overtaking his expression while he pins me in place with his gaze.

"How long do you plan on leaving me hanging here? I'm asking for a friend."

His hand slides from beneath my chin to the nape of my neck, and I imagine this is his favorite way to kiss a girl. His large palm feels dominant,

and because all willpower has left the building, I wet my lips on reflex.

“Do you have somewhere you need to be?” I counter.

“No,” he whispers into the shell of my ear. “I have all night and all morning, too, if necessary.”

I tingle all over, sparks firing into every nerve ending.

Women don’t stand a chance when it comes to the charm this boy can unleash whenever he sets his sights on what he wants.

“I ...” I break off and force another breath into my lungs. “I want to kiss you, but I’m scared, knowing everything will change when we do.”

Will’s eyes drop to my mouth. “True. I’ll be insatiable, needing to taste you each chance I get.”

“And what about our careers?” I ask, excitement giving way to fear. “Nothing will be the same once we cross that line.”

His fingers toy with the loose hair at the back of my neck. “Or maybe nothing has to change at all.”

I balk. “Oh, come on. We both know I’d have to quit as your publicist, and then questions would be asked about why we could no longer work together, and then—”

And then he’s kissing me, and every single spiraling thought—positive or catastrophic—exits my brain as it fights to keep my body upright while processing how this could possibly be the first time we’ve done this.

It feels natural and spectacular at the same time. I feel like, despite knowing I’m not a virgin, this is the only time a man has put his hands on my body and truly made it count.

He promised just one kiss, although he never specified how long it would last. I hope it never ends.

“God, Jesus,” he mumbles against my lips.

“Don’t stop,” I quietly beg, and now he’s smiling against them too.

Will runs his hot, wet tongue across my bottom lip. “Do you want more of me, Drew?”

Since words have failed me, I nod and whimper, opening my mouth in response to his question.

He takes what he wants and palms the back of my head, driving the kiss deeper, until the lines of professionalism aren’t all that’s blurred. He’s consuming me, until I’m not sure where our bodies begin and end, and with every stroke of his tongue, I’m happy to be the victim in the game of cat

and mouse we've been playing since the day he helped me with my grocery bags.

It wasn't supposed to be like this. When Colton assigned Will as my client, I anticipated the unexpected, but I always felt like I knew the man standing in front of me, who's now pulling another strangled whimper from my throat.

In reality, I'm not sure I know Will Jones that well at all. At least not this part of him—the side that is soft and gentle.

Floating his fingertips across the waistband of my sleep shorts, he blends dominance with the right amount of respect, and when his hand dips an inch below my shorts and pauses, my voice is raspy when I say, "I thought you didn't seek permission, but rather forgiveness."

Will groans into the side of my neck, and when he pulls me into his body again, I feel how hard he is. It's unmistakable.

I freak out, lurching back to put distance between us. "I—I can't," I force out, missing his hands all over me.

I'm cold without his touch and frustrated at myself for craving it at the same time. It's like he can read my thoughts when he closes the gap I just created, although he doesn't place his hands back on my body.

"I need you to be specific, Drew. Are you saying you can't do this with me or that you don't want to?"

And that's the million-dollar question. The one that will keep me awake tonight in bed because I have to climb in there alone.

"I don't want to do this." The lie falls from my tongue far easier than I thought it would.

Will studies me for a beat, those dark brown eyes figuring me out like a mathematical equation. Maybe that's all I am—a challenge to keep him occupied this season because he sure as shit has the Rogues fans eating out of his palm. Right now, he can do no wrong in the public eye, and suddenly, I'm hit with another pang of fear.

If any of this between us got out, then it would be my career on the line and not his. I'd be branded the unprofessional publicist who took advantage of her position and bagged the hottest rookie. No one would see—or want to understand—that we both played a part. Ultimately, it would be me who paid the price, throwing away everything I'd worked for.

All because I had fallen into the same trap that had caught so many women before me.

The red flags are all here, waving around in the high breeze that usually precedes a full-blown storm.

I'd be a fool to ignore their warning.

I'm nothing but a conquest and another notch on Will's bedpost—and likely one he'd go on to regret when everything went up in smoke.

"You're a bad liar." Will cocks his head to one side, waiting for me to confirm the truth in his statement.

He needs to leave, but I won't be the one to ask him. Resisting a night together is hard enough.

When I don't speak, he takes my hand back in his and walks me the few steps to the couch. I take a seat and stare up at him as he sets the duvet over my lap and picks up his shirt, pulling it back over his head.

"Where are you going?"

Will scrubs a hand over his mouth, and I know it's to disguise his smugness. I sound about as needy as I feel right now.

"I'm not going anywhere." He tips his head at my kitchen area. "Are you hungry?"

Starving. But I just took a six-foot-four hockey player off the menu, so my options are limited to the pink toy sitting in my nightstand. The same one I used last night while thinking about him.

I shake my head. "No, thank you."

Still standing, Will leans over my body, his hands braced on either side of my head. Sexy confidence oozes from him. The gold pendant he's wearing dangles from his neck, and on closer inspection, I see it's a compass.

"How about a hot chocolate loaded with everything?"

"No," I reply, wondering how I could justify our mouths accidentally finding each other again. "I already had one tonight, and I've been comfort eating all day. If I keep going, then I won't get in the suit I picked out for New York."

Will's eyes lower down my body, bottom lip disappearing between his teeth. "Your body will always be perfect, and it's not how you'll fit in your suit that concerns me ..."

"More how you will remove it later?" I finish for him.

He doesn't say anything more, simply holding me captive in his gaze before he finally releases me, picks up the bouquet of freesias, and makes his way into the kitchen.

Will fills the sink with water and drops the flowers in. Next, he opens the refrigerator door and inspects its contents. I wince at what he must be thinking. Other than half a bell pepper and a couple of bottles of water, it's full of everything he loathes.

"You don't need to say anything, by the way. I can hear your thoughts well enough from over here, and I know they're in breach of rule number four."

Heavy footsteps fall behind me, and then I'm over his shoulder. He cracks his palm down on my left ass cheek, and I squeal in shock and delight, giggling as he maneuvers me until I'm exactly how he wants—legs wrapped around his waist and arms looped around his neck, like a koala.

With one strong arm beneath my ass to hold me in place, Will moves about the kitchen, making me the hot chocolate I didn't ask for, but really wanted. To him, I must weigh nothing.

"Why are you comfort eating, Drew?" Will asks, shaking a can of whipped cream.

I watch as he squirts a generous amount on top of my drink and then moves to the exact cupboard where I keep the sprinkles.

Does he remember where I store them from the one time he helped put my shopping away?

My face burns when he finishes adding sprinkles and wraps a second hand under my ass.

"You should know that I would never ever tell anyone about us or what we do. It's our business, and you're safe with me."

Us?

I reach up and absent-mindedly play with his chain; the compass looks like it was stamped into an old coin, which is weathered and worn.

"Is this meaningful?" I ask, attempting to deflect the conversation.

Will's hand wraps around the one I have on the pendant. "I'm not answering that question yet, and anyway, you still haven't answered mine. Why are you comfort eating?"

He sets me on one of the stools at the island and slides the hot chocolate between my hands. This is another element of Will Jones I never knew existed—patience and a deep intrigue in others.

Swiping a finger through the cream, I bring it to my lips, and Will watches me the whole time.

Inappropriate satisfaction curls inside me as I become aware that I wield a level of power over him I never thought I had. He absolutely wants this finger between his lips.

“I have my reasons”—the cream slides down my throat—“none of which I’m able to share as your publicist.”

I’m back in his arms in seconds, and he marches us toward the couch, sitting down with me straddling him. We’re face-to-face, nose-to-nose, and I know if I placed a palm over his heart, I would feel it beating at a rapid pace to match mine.

“Tell me, Drew.” His voice sounds pained, desperate. “You can’t play with me and claim that you don’t want something to happen between us and then suck on this finger”—he lifts it to his lips and kisses the tip—“like you’re imagining it’s my dick.”

Heat pools in my center. If I sit in his lap much longer, I’ll no doubt leave a mark on his sweatpants.

“I need to climb off.”

Will shakes his head and sinks his fingers into my hips. “You belong right here.”

More heat between my thighs.

“If I don’t, then I’ll need to throw your pants in the washing machine before you leave.”

The satisfaction I was feeling earlier is nothing compared to the way he looks at me.

“Do I turn you on, Baby?”

“No comment.”

He doubles down, grip tightening. It feels like he’s squeezing all the air from my lungs.

“What happens between us stays between us, Drew.” Will repeats his earlier sentiment.

“I don’t doubt that it would,” I reply, and he nods. “But that doesn’t mean I’m safe. All it would take is for one person to see us and start spreading rumors, and my career would be toast.”

“I wouldn’t let that happen,” he reassures me in a stern voice. “So, why don’t you go ahead and give me your next objection? And then I’ll tell you why that’s a nonissue too.”

I chuckle. “There are too many obstacles to list them all, and you won’t change my mind on this. I like you a lot, but the risks for me are too steep.”

Will pushes his head back into the couch and opens his thighs a little wider. I sink further into him—physically and emotionally. “Then I guess I have to be patient a while longer.”

He lifts me from his lap and tucks me under the duvet before moving across the room to retrieve my hot chocolate.

“Where are you going?” I ask when he hands me the drink and heads for the front door.

From over his shoulder, he just grins. “Heading back home so you can comfort eat a bit more and think about everything you’re missing with me.”

He winks, and I melt like the cream running down the sides of my mug.

“Have a good night, Drew. I guess I’ll catch you on the flight to Brooklyn.”

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Drew

“**I** kissed him,” I announce, dumping myself down on a barstool in front of Vesper.

Her jaw hangs open, and she lifts a finger at me before handing change to a customer and locking in on our conversation.

As always, she looks incredible. Tonight, she’s wearing a dark blue bodycon dress and high-top white Converse. Teamed with her trademark red lipstick and nails, she looks like the American dream.

“You tell me this like it should land as a surprise.”

“Wait, what?” I panic. “Someone already told you about the kiss?”

She chuckles and leans on the bar. “No, silly. I’m saying that it was obvious you liked him just from our previous conversation. It was only a matter of time before something physical happened. What was he like?”

I roll my lips together, certain I can still taste him nearly a week after the kiss. “Incredible.”

When Vesper winks, I pick up the cocktail menu, and she takes it from my hands.

“Manhattan?” she asks, already adding whiskey to a shaker.

“Sounds perfect,” I croon, grateful to have shared my secret with someone.

I’ve always enjoyed watching bartenders mix cocktails, and Vesper is particularly skilled, throwing the shaker behind her back. It somersaults over her head, and she catches it in front of her.

“Did you just stop by tonight to update me on your sordid love affair or snag another free drink?”

I twist my lips to the side, and she pours the cocktail into a glass before sliding it into my hand.

“Both, but also neither,” I reply, taking my first sip and letting the whiskey warm me from the inside. Seattle in November is freezing, and I stupidly wore a skirt and no tights to work today. “I actually could use some advice if you have the time?”

Vesper’s gaze roves the relatively empty bar area. “As you can see, I’m slammed. But shoot, and I’ll try and help you.” She points at the cocktail and then me. “In return, I’ll need you to stick around for a second drink to help alleviate the boredom of tonight’s shift. Thursdays are always slow-going.”

I lift my glass and nod. “Girl, you just got yourself a deal, although I’m limiting myself to two because I have an early flight in the morning.”

Intrigue overtakes her face. “Don’t tell me he’s taking you on a mini vacation somewhere already.”

I snort a laugh and briefly consider what it would be like to go away somewhere with Will. Like me, I know he enjoys traveling to Europe, although he’d probably make me go on hikes or adrenaline-fueled adventures involving quad bikes and bungee jumping.

I, on the other hand, would happily settle for a good book and a lounge chair.

“No, we aren’t going on a vacation. In fact, it’s a business trip to Brooklyn. I’m accompanying Will on an away series. He has a big sponsorship meeting while he’s in town.”

Vesper looks impressed. “Nice. So, you won’t be sharing a hotel room then?”

I squeeze my thighs together. “Absolutely not. Will is staying in the team’s hotel and rooming with Silas.”

At the mention of his name, she looks away, a flash of discomfort in her eyes.

I take another sip of cocktail, the alcohol already loosening my tongue. “Can I ask you something?”

I’m met with a side-eye. “If it’s about the Rogues captain, then no. Nothing good can come of me talking about him.”

If her aim was to suppress my curiosity, then she’s only succeeded in piquing it.

“Is there ... history between you and Silas?”

Vesper bursts out laughing. “What?! As in a romantic history? Hell no! Like I told you before, I’m dating his brother—have been for a while. Silas is a unique character, and he and my boyfriend don’t always see eye to eye.”

I’d buy her story if it wasn’t accompanied with a crimson flush across her cheeks. That said, Vesper doesn’t strike me as the type of girl who would get involved with another guy while still seeing someone else, and especially not his brother.

She’s too straightforward for that shit.

“You know I’m here if you ever want to talk about things, right?” I lift my eyes from the cocktail glass to the gorgeous girl standing in front of me.

I hope she can read between the lines and decipher that I’m not only referring to Silas, but also the boyfriend who doesn’t give me great vibes. I’ve never met him, but from my brief interactions with Silas, I feel like he is a good judge of character—case in point: he doesn’t like Lydia.

“I know, and I appreciate that.”

Another Manhattan slides alongside my half-full glass when I feel a vibration in my shoulder bag.

Reaching inside, I pull out my cell and pause when I see Kate’s name on the screen.

What does she want?

KATE

Hey, girl. So, a little birdie told me you’re heading to Brooklyn tomorrow night with the team. What are your plans after the meeting with Repeat? It feels only right that we invite you and your dad to a night hosted by the Jones family. Sometimes, a good charcuterie board is the only appropriate remedy for working with my son. He can be a handful, I know.

On Saturday night, we’re going to have dinner at the Japanese restaurant Will hasn’t stopped talking about. That said, how am I supposed to tell her that without it sounding like a date? Or maybe I’m reading way too much into this. We could be going out for a business meal to decompress after the meeting.

Hitting Reply, I begin typing out a response and then delete it. I begin typing again when another message lands from Kate.

KATE

And if you're wondering about the Japanese meal Will booked for you both, he said he'll just treat you when you get back to Seattle. My advice would be to take him for all he's worth. He's got more money than sense, that boy.

I chuckle and breathe a sigh of relief that she already knows about the meal.

ME

I assume he told you about his latest car.

KATE

The Ferrari? Yes. That money was supposed to be invested and not wasted on a supercar he absolutely does not need, but there's no telling Will sometimes.

Like mother, like son.

ME

Did you say my dad was invited too?

KATE

Yep, he just replied actually. He can stop by for an hour, but then has to work. Can you make it? I'd love to see you, and I know June misses you. Oh, and I have your belated twenty-first birthday gift here, so I can give you that too. I was nervous to mail it.

ME

OMG, you didn't have to buy me a gift! But thank you. Sure, I can make it.

KATE

Drew, you're like family to me and Jensen. There's no way we're not marking the biggest birthday with something nice—and sparkly.

I stare down at Kate's last message.

Family.

She sees me as family because that's what I've always been to them. Meanwhile, each night, I'm running the batteries down on the pink wand hiding in my dresser drawer because I can't stop thinking about her son.

I almost throw my phone across the bar when a message drops down from Will.

WILL

Miss me?

ME

I was just texting with your mom.

WILL

I know. I was texting her at the same time. Given she's hosting one of her special dinner parties, I think it would be best if we stayed in the same hotel. For ease.

ME

What does a dinner party at your parents' house have to do with where I sleep that night?

WILL

It will likely go on until late, and if we both stay at the same place, then there's no messing around with multiple stops.

ME

I'm not staying in the same hotel as you.

WILL

Why?

ME

You know why. It's too risky.

WILL

What if I promise to be a good boy and walk you to your room at the end of the night?

ME

I expected that as the bare minimum. My dad—aka your coach—will be staying there too.

WILL

Your dad is my coach? You should've said.

ME

Don't get smart with me, William.

WILL

So, that's a yes to staying in the same hotel? I'll call the reservations line now and book you a suite.

ME

First Line handles all the bookings.

WILL

And you don't think it'll look a bit weird to them when you switch hotels?

Shit. True.

ME

Okay. But ONLY because it's more convenient. And I don't need a suite; a double will do just fine.

WILL

Too late. I just booked the honeymoon suite.

ME

TELL ME YOU DIDN'T.

WILL.

WILLIAM JONES. RESPOND IMMEDIATELY.

WILL

This is me, asking for your forgiveness.

ME

Rule eleven: Moving forward, the client is prohibited from booking accommodations on the publicist's behalf because he clearly cannot be trusted.

WILL

Duly noted.

P.S. There will be a fruit basket and Dom Pérignon waiting for you on arrival. See you bright and early at the airport.

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Will

Other than the Scorpions, the New York Blades have dominated the NHL for well over a decade, the Cup often passing from one team to the other, one season to the next.

Toronto aside, I was destined to be drafted to the Blades and play for the team my dad helps coach. Tonight's game has only solidified those feelings.

It would've been less painful to lie down on the ice and let the Zamboni flatten me because I've barely seen the puck for the first two periods, and as I switch out on a line change and make eye contact with Tristan, I know my teammate has zero intention of playing as an actual team.

Fucking fine. I'll score my own goddamn goals.

The Blades are on a power play, thanks to a stupid and out-of-character challenge from Silas, but as the puck spills free from the boards and Mason picks it up, I find myself in more space than usual. Perhaps the four-to-zero lead the Blades have has gone to their heads, and they've neglected to remember that I'm on the roster.

Mason wastes no time shooting a pass to me, which is perfectly placed to take in my stride. A bit like our team, the Blades' weakest link is their goalie since they never replaced the talent and consistency of Archer Moore, who retired from pro hockey when I was in my sophomore year in college. I know Dad will be watching my every move, but like a true professional, he'll want his goalie to come out on top.

Too fucking bad. He commits before I do, diving to his right and presenting me with the easiest finish I'll likely have all season. I let the puck slide over the line while I skate across to the Rogues' fans who traveled to watch tonight's shit show.

At least I've given them something to cheer about.

It's four to one with only two minutes left on the timer. We've lost, but I celebrate with the crowd like we just made it to the playoffs.

"You're a freaking phenomenon, man." Mason wraps his arm around my shoulders, and we bump helmets. "A future Hall of Famer, for sure."

Within a couple of seconds, most of the team is circled around me. I should really be celebrating with them and not breaking away to head for the VIP area, which is conveniently located at ice level.

I can feel every pair of eyes on me—at least twenty thousand—as I pull off my left glove and glide my hand along the plexiglass, throwing up ice when I pull up in front of where she's sitting.

It's fucking idiotic and totally on brand for me when I make direct eye contact with Drew.

Goddamn, she looks beautiful today. Dressed in a light-blue suit, she's styled her hair in loose waves that fall down her back.

"Come here." I beckon with my fingers.

She scowls at me, but I see the faintest smile that tries to break free.

Drew shakes her head at me and mouths, *No*, which only spurs me on.

Arms folded over her chest, she finally yields and stands, approaching the plexiglass with a stern look.

Because I promised Mason I'd join him for drinks tonight, this will probably be the only time I get to see her. She'll likely be working all night to prepare for tomorrow's meeting with Repeat.

The crowd is loud, and I know I'm around ten seconds from picking up a minor penalty for delaying the game.

Whatever. We've lost anyway.

"What the fuck are you doing?"

I can't hear her, but after years of playing and watching hockey in deafening arenas, I'm good at reading lips.

"That goal was for you," I yell back.

The pink staining her cheeks tells me that she understood, but then she claps and motions toward a small group of Rogues' fans.

"It's for them," she volleys back.

Pushing off the boards, I glide backward toward center ice, shaking my head and chewing on the corner of my mouth guard.

She can deny and deflect all she wants. But that goal, right there, was for my girl.



“YOU REALIZE THAT THE BLADES REGULARLY HIT UP THIS BAR AFTER games,” I tell Mason when he sets another pint of IPA in front of me.

Apparently, now that I play for the Rogues, I’m more careful with my public image and less cautious about my liver.

Taking a seat next to me in the booth, he knocks his glass against mine. “I do. And you realize that you slurred at least three words in your last sentence.”

From opposite us, Tristan snorts a laugh, and I glare at him.

“I’m not *waishted*.”

“Ha!” Silas blurts out, and Mason slumps back in the booth, grinning at me.

At least he’s smiling tonight, even if it is at my expense.

The pint I’m holding is my third of the night. I’m definitely going to pay for it in the morning if I finish this drink.

“I feel honored that you’re making a rare exception and drinking beer with me.” Mason chuckles while Tristan watches me from over the rim of his glass.

“You act like he’s the league’s golden boy.” Tristan nods his head at Mason.

The defenseman picks up his beer, taking a big pull and setting the glass back down on the table. None of us should be drinking tonight, and we all know it.

“I mean, is he not? Our boy here is the second-highest goalscorer in the league this season despite us losing more games than we’ve won.”

Tristan’s face contorts, and I celebrate by taking a mouthful of beer.

“It’s only November. Let’s see how his goal record stacks up in April.”

Silas clears his throat and looks between me and my asshole teammate. “Did you two break each other’s heart in another life or something? Because I’m getting tired of the petty gibes. They’re getting old real fast.”

“You know who else looks tired of your antics, Will?” Tristan smirks at me, and I know exactly what’s coming. “Your publicist.” He scratches at his temple, confused. “What the fuck was that celly all about?”

Mason shifts an inch in his seat. He’s the only one sitting at this table who knows about the crush I have on Drew, and to his credit, he hasn’t breathed a word about it to anyone.

“And here I was”—I grin back at Tristan—“thinking you’d be more concerned over me pulling away from you in the goal rankings.” I take another sip of beer. “Does it bother you when I interact with my publicist?”

Tristan scoffs and sits back in the booth, arms folded across his chest in a defensive stance. “I’m just pointing out that you guys seem to be pretty close for only having a working relationship.”

“Will and Drew have been friends for years.” Mason immediately comes to my rescue, resting his tatted forearms on the table.

“You guys play for the Rogues, right?” A blonde girl wearing a short black dress and sky-high heels approaches our table, closely followed by her brunette friend. She’s wearing a similar type of dress but in light blue.

Normally, based on the way the brunette is looking at me, I’d be sure that the night is ending with her riding my dick. But today, that same thought couldn’t feel further from the truth.

I’m going home alone tonight.

“We do,” Mason confirms with a flirtatious edge to his tone.

I guess now that he’s separated, he’s free to do whatever he wants, but, wow, hooking up tonight would be fast.

“Can we join you?” The blonde’s eyes drop to the space beside Mason and Silas.

My captain clears his throat and pushes his beer away. “No offense, girls, but I was actually planning to call it a night.” He tips his chin toward me, Mason, and Tristan. There’s a warning in his gaze not to let tonight get too late or wild. “So, I’ll leave you in the safe hands of my boys here.”

I know for a fact that Tristan is single, so when he says, “And I don’t want to be presumptuous, but my new girlfriend probably wouldn’t appreciate me hanging out with two beautiful women. However, this guy?” He points at me. “Well, we know he loves all the female attention.”

I want to annihilate him.

The brunette’s eyes light up, and—

Fuck, get out of this one, Will.

Five minutes later, I’ve got Ashley—the brunette who won’t stop talking about how her ex-boyfriend cheated on her last summer—sitting in my lap and a smug Tristan opposite me with his phone out in front of him.

I swear to God, if he’s taking pictures, I’ll crush him against the boards next practice.

To my left, Mason has his hands all over the blonde while he talks directly into her ear.

I nudge him in the side. "Should I make myself scarce from our hotel room tonight?"

The blonde pulls out her phone and snaps a picture of her kissing his jaw, immediately posting it to her socials.

My roommate is hammered, although I see the look of uncertainty in his eyes. He knows he's effectively putting the final nail in the coffin with Eloise.

"Where will you two go?" His eyes flick to Ashley as she talks with her friend about the story she just uploaded to Instagram.

All I want to do is slide this girl off my lap and make a beeline for Drew's hotel room. I don't care if we drink hot chocolate and watch Viking programs all night, so long as I'm near her and she knows that the girl in front of me never made it to my bed.

"I'm not taking her home."

"Wait, what?!" Ashley's head snaps to me, brows pulled together in confusion. "I thought we were going to hook up tonight."

I don't need to see him to know the dark laugh echoing behind Ashley belongs to Tristan.

I shake my head and slide out from beneath her. "I don't know where you got that idea from, but it isn't happening."

She points to my lap. "Um ... I guess I kind of got that impression when you let me sit on you."

Ashley has a point, and if my fucking teammate laughs one more time, then I'm going to throat-punch him.

"I'm kind of seeing someone."

Fuck. I said it.

Mason's attention snaps to me. "You are?"

"I'm sure she'll be really chill over you getting into it with me tonight," Ashley snaps at me. "Once a playboy, always a playboy."

The beer sitting in my gut rolls around, and I pull my phone from my pocket, opening my latest messages to Drew. They were all sent after the game, and she still hasn't replied to any of them.

ME

You looked stunning, and I couldn't help the celebration.

You're mad at me, aren't you?

If I come to your room tonight, will you answer?

Don't ignore me. I bought you a fruit basket and champagne.

Here's a picture of me. Dressed to head out for a night with my teammates when all I can think about is spending it with you.

I should take her silence as a hint and let her cool off ahead of tomorrow's meeting.

That's definitely what I should do.

ME

I don't know if you're asleep, but in around twenty minutes, there will be four knocks on your suite door, and they will all belong to me.

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Drew

I should text Will back and tell him not to show up at my door.
Dressed in a black version of the same nightwear I wore the last time he saw me in pajamas; I begin typing out a message to that effect.

ME

You can't come to my suite. What if someone sees?

My thumbs hover over the keyboard.
Just hit Send and be done with this whole game, Drew.
But ending whatever this is between you two isn't what you want.
You want him in your room.
Your bed.
The whole damn night.

Four sharp knocks cause me to leap off the bed, throwing my phone behind me on the duvet. I march toward the white double doors of this ridiculously large—and no doubt overpriced—suite and yank on one of the handles.

“You’re awake.” Will knows precisely what he’s doing each time he throws me his trademark smirk.

Grabbing hold of his gray sweatshirt, I pull him into my suite and slam the door behind us.

“Did anyone see you?” I rush out, squinting through the peephole set in the center of the door.

No one is lingering out in the hallway.

“Drew.”

Two hands land on my hips, and slowly, they swivel me around until my back is flat against the door, and I've nowhere to go except into the large arms of a looming hockey player.

His sweatshirt is open at the collar with the zipper pulled down to reveal a small amount of dark chest hair I was so tempted to run my fingers through the last time we were this close.

Black dress pants sit just above his ankles with tan loafers I'm sure cost two months of my salary alone.

And then it hits me—the woodsy cologne I smell each time I rest my head on the pillow and think about what it would be like to go to bed with this guy.

“What, Will?” I gaze up at him and sigh. At this point, I'm more exhausted than anything else. And that's all down to me and my determination to resist what I desperately want.

Him.

Like the uber-confident guy he is, Will doesn't take my exasperated tone personally. If anything, there's only understanding and patience in his expression when he leans down and whispers in my ear, “I want to sleep with you, and I don't think I have it in me to walk away without showing you how fucking amazing my hands can make you feel.”

I rest a palm in the center of his chest. As I suspected, his heart is beating at a wild pace. “And when tomorrow rolls around?”

He wraps his fingers around my hand and brings it to his mouth, kissing the end of my fingertips in turn. The move is romantic and not what I expected from him.

“Why don't we just enjoy tonight and let tomorrow look after itself?”

“Is that what you tell all of them?” I mumble beneath my breath. It's probably a little unfair, but if I'm going to be another one of his conquests, then I might as well be clear on where I stand.

Will's lips find the shell of my left ear, and goose bumps break out all over my body. “Perhaps you should ask the girl who was sitting across my lap a half hour ago when I peeled her from my body and made a beeline for your hotel suite.”

I pull back as far as the door will let me. “What did you say to her?”

His eyes move atop my head before he pulls the black tie from my hair, letting it cascade around my shoulders. “I told her that I was seeing someone.”

A delicious shiver licks down my spine. It's exciting and the kind of feeling every girl fantasizes about.

"Seeing someone?" I shake my head. "Will, what happens if she goes and tells the press or posts about it on social media? What then?"

He pushes a hand through my hair, and my eyelids flutter closed.

"Then I'll confirm that I'm no longer single. That way, I can wait in peace for my girl to decide if she wants more than just one night with me."

My eyes snap open.

Deep brown eyes stare back at me like two shots of espresso on a bright morning.

"I've moved from one woman to the next my whole life, and I've had a lot of fun in the process. But no girl—whether it was a one-night stand or a couple of hookups and a date—ever made me want to stick around long enough to see how beautiful she'd look beneath me in the morning. Not until you had me running around and finding excuses to grab five minutes in your company, just so you could give me more shit and add to your infuriating list of rules."

One palm lands flat beside my head, and his lips find mine.

At first, I think it's me who whimpers, and then I realize that the soft moan belongs to Will.

"Take this off," I plead into his mouth, hands finding the hem of his sweatshirt.

Our lips only part for a split second so he can remove his top, and instantly, my fingers are dancing in his chest hair, toying with the pendant I want so badly to know more about.

I know there's a story behind it, and mysterious Will both intrigues and turns me on in equal measure.

"How do you want me?" I ask, voice a little breathy.

"Fuuuck," Will responds, ripping my top straight down the center.

I've always seen myself as average-looking, but Will drinks me in like I appreciate a Manhattan made by Vesper.

"Don't you dare tear my sleep shorts," I warn, which causes him to snicker into my neck, thick fingers dipping below the waistband.

Like the needy bitch I am, I part my thighs so he can find my center. Sure enough, it's embarrassingly wet when he dances two fingertips over my clit.

My moan is loud and screams of a woman who hasn't been touched in a long time.

"This is where I'm supposed to say that I'll make love to you in any way you want. The cold facts are, I'm too fucking hard, and you've made me wait far too fucking long to even pretend like I'm capable of being a gentleman with you tonight." Will sucks a sharp breath through his teeth, and one long finger plunges inside me.

"Oh Jesus," I gasp, digging my fingernails into his shoulders. I'm definitely going to leave marks, but fuck it, I'm taking what I want tonight.

"Then fuck me," I command.

This time, his whimper is more of a maniacal groan. "Dangerous words to use with me, Drew. I'll leave your skin sore from my mouth and your pussy aching from my cock." A deep rumble fills the space around us. "And your voice? It'll be nonexistent for tomorrow's meeting."

"Number one on my revised set of rules," I say, gripping his hard dick through his pants. He's even bigger than I imagined, but I refuse to let any intimidation show in my voice. With the weapon he's packing, I won't be able to sit down for days. "Whenever we're alone, it's mandatory to make your publicist scream."

Will

I want to fuck her right here against this door. Partly because I don't have the patience left to wait any longer, but mainly because anyone who hears her cries will know that Drew Callaghan is mine.

But just being here with her is a privilege I won't take for granted. I know she's anxious about us sleeping together, even if we both acknowledge that it's going to happen anyway.

Pulling my finger from her pussy, I bring it to my mouth and let her watch how good she tastes.

Like I did that day in her apartment, I curl my hands under her ass, and she wraps her legs around my waist, tits bouncing against my bare chest as I carry her toward the bedroom.

"You'll be pleased to know that I regret renting such a large suite. More steps are needed to get you right where I want you."

She snorts a laugh, soft hands interlinked at the nape of my neck.

When we reach the four-poster bed, set in the center of a modern bedroom, I let Drew fall to the mattress.

Silky, dark hair fans out against crisp white bedding, and—*Lord have mercy*—I feel like it's my first time having sex again.

Jon Morgan, debut season: forty-nine goals, one hundred forty-three assists.

Because I'm right on the edge of blowing and my dick needs a second to gather itself, I pin my eyes on Drew and slowly unloop my belt in front of her.

She rises up on her elbows, top teeth biting down on a plump lip I want around my cock so fucking badly.

"Do you know how hot that is for a woman?" Her eyes fall to my belt as I pull it from my pants, dropping it to the floor.

I wink at her. "Really? I had no clue."

She rolls her eyes, and I pop the button on my pants. I swear to God, I can smell her sweetness from here. Or maybe it's the lingering taste of her perfect pussy that's driving me wild.

Wearing only black boxer briefs that hide nothing, I stand over Drew and lift my chin at her sleep shorts. "Take them off and spread yourself. Show me what I'm fucking tonight."

Her mouth falls open, and I wonder if it's shock, disgust, or excitement. I hope it's the latter.

"Dirty boy," she scolds, thumbs hooking under her waistband. "I thought your mama brought you up better than that."

I grip my dick. "Nah. And there will be nothing classy about the way I'm going to fuck you." I push my boxers to the floor and let my dick spring free.

This time, I know it's excitement in her eyes as she takes me in.

"Will ..." Drew's voice is hesitant but needy as she points to my cock. "That is not normal. It's more of a weapon than a dick. Do they make condoms big enough to fit that thing?"

Fuck. I've never forgotten about contraception before, but this girl makes my brain useless.

"I have one in my wallet. If you want me to wear one, then I can."

When Drew doesn't automatically say yes, I struggle holding it together, or, more specifically, not fucking blowing my load right here and now.

Holy shit. She wants to go bare with me.

“I’m on birth control, I haven’t been with anyone since I last got tested, and I know you guys are always peeing in cups.”

I feel my chest tighten. After all the girls I’ve slept with, I didn’t think that I could have a first with someone again.

“It’s your call,” I say with an easy smile designed to hide my nerves.

“I think”—she shimmies a little on the bed, taunting me—“that you want to feel every part of me.”

Tossing my head toward the ceiling, I moan out a confirmation. “I fucking hate condoms, and I’ve never been with someone and not worn one.” I fix my attention back on Drew, eyes burning into her. “Going without for the first time with you sounds like a dream.”

I stroke myself once at the thought of her warm pussy without any barriers. Any more, and I’ll come right in front of her.

“I need to see you. How much longer are you going to make me wait?”

She lifts one challenging brow and finally does what I originally asked.

Like a good fucking girl.

Legs still closed, she tosses her sleep shorts at me. I catch them against my chest, bringing them to my nose and inhaling.

Fuck. I’m going to eat well tonight.

“Spread them, Baby,” I demand once again.

Just like I anticipated, Drew takes her time. This girl is her own woman. The way she twists me up, making me wait on her every move, is precisely why I’m obsessed with her.

“You rock my fucking world,” I breathe out slowly, heartbeat thumping in my ears.

“I know.”

Raising her knees, she drags her feet apart to reveal a beautiful pink pussy, glistening in the soft lighting in the room. She keeps herself totally bare, and I love that.

“Did you wax especially for me?” I ask, scrubbing a hand over my jaw.

She shakes her head.

Of course she didn’t.

Moving toward her, I kneel on the bed between her thighs, bracing my palms on either side of her elbows. My chain dangles down between us, and I’m tempted to reveal the meaning behind it, but all in good time. Vulnerable Will isn’t what she needs tonight.

“What are you waiting for?” she whispers.

I grip my shaft and edge toward her entrance, chest tightening, cortisol spiked at an all-time high. I pause for the briefest second.

She looks up at me, and then I see it—the flash of uncertainty.

Taking my body weight on one hand, I use the other to tip her chin up.

“For the record, I’m not hesitating because I’m having second thoughts with you, Drew. But because we’ll never be here again—about to have sex for the first time. I want to savor this moment with you.”

She takes her own weight on one arm and wraps her hand around my cock.

One languid pump from her surges my hips forward until I’m pushing inside her, and Drew falls back onto both elbows.

“Fuck, Will, fuck!”

Moans of my name, tiny gasps from her lips—they all leave me biting on the inside of my cheek while I work myself inside her.

Her head falls back, and I take full advantage, sucking hard at the base of her neck.

“You’re going to mark me up.”

“Mine.” A single word leaves me, but she doesn’t flinch at the possession in it or when I mark her again and smooth my tongue to ease the sting.

When I’m all the way inside, I sit back on my haunches and wrap my hands under her thighs until she’s straddling me and our chests are pressed together.

I love her like this, towering over me like some kind of goddess.

She moves her hips and moans into the bedroom. If this place wasn’t so big, then we’d definitely be heard.

Drew’s body trembles in my hands, and I reach behind my back, wrapping her legs around me. I want to be as deep inside her as possible. To worship every inch of her body before I ruin it for any other man.

“Kiss me,” I plead, pulling her mouth down to mine. “You’re mine, Drew. Mine.”

While our tongues tangle, Drew rocks over me again. Each time she moves, my cock buries itself deeper.

She breaks the kiss. “I won’t last long like this,” she gasps into the crook of my neck.

Wrapping my fist in her hair, I pull her head back so I can mark her again.

“It’ll be the first of many, so go ahead and come all over my dick.”

I snap my hips into her, and she screams my name in a way that I’ll forever repeat in my brain.

So, I do it again, only harder this time.

“Will,” Drew warns, “if you keep doing that, I’m going to ruin these bedsheets.”

Oh, hell yes.

Over and over, I piston into her. Thrusts lacking mercy, yet perfectly placed to steal my first orgasm from her pussy.

“The best sex ever.”

I grin up at her. “Just getting started.”

She deadpans, and that’s it—her bratty attitude sends me right to the edge of losing it altogether.

“On your motherfucking knees,” I grit out, moving her into position. “It’s a shame I can’t manipulate this body and stay inside it, but”—I crack a palm against her right ass cheek and maneuver myself behind her—“I want you from behind, and compromises need to be made.”

My cock’s dripping, and she’s panting exactly the way I want, fisting the bedsheets while she waits for me to fuck her.

“Stay strong for me, Baby. Don’t collapse on me,” I say when I thrust back inside and her legs begin to shake.

She tips her head over one shoulder, ocean-colored eyes more of a midnight blue as she parts her ass cheeks for me.

I think I just fell in love.

“You know, that’s not very fucking professional,” I goad, looping one arm around her waist so I can pound into her like we both want.

“Screw professionalism.” She half laughs, half cries.

“Or how about I just screw you, yeah?”

“Yeah.” Her voice turns devilish. “Fuck me until I’m sore, Will.”

I pull out and jackhammer back into her. “Call me William.”

Big eyes narrow at me. “I only call you that when I’m mad at you. That or Hotshot.”

She spreads her knees wider and leaks all over my dick.

“I fucking love it when you’re mean to me. Call me William.”

“Will-i-am,” Drew pushes out between desperate pants.

“Atta-fucking-girl.”

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Drew

The first thing I feel is a vibration between my legs.

The second sensation is a tongue swiping straight through me, followed by a low, appreciative moan.

“I think I’m addicted to you, Drew,” Will whispers against my pussy.

Before I fell asleep last night, he asked if it would be okay to wake me up like this.

Did I think he was being serious? Nope.

Did I hope that he was? Hell yes.

Last night was ... wow.

Will showed me exactly what it was like to be with a guy who cared for a woman’s needs—or at least made her feel like she was special to him.

I can see precisely why he broke Tristan’s sister’s heart. One night, and I’m already thinking about when we’ll next get to share a bed or, at the very least, when my nerve endings will feel this alive again.

This morning, he’s going down on me with languid strokes of his tongue. I haven’t looked in the mirror yet, but I know my body is covered in hickeys. Every inch of my skin stings in a delicious way I didn’t think was possible until the star Rogues forward carried me to bed and had his way with me.

Sucking my clit into his mouth, he releases it with a pop and crawls up my body, a huge grin on his face when he appears from under the duvet.

“Morning, Baby.”

His lips find mine, and I taste myself. It’s not as bad as I imagined it would be, or maybe it’s just because I love the way he kisses me.

His tongue massages against mine while his left knee nudges my thighs further apart.

“I have to fuck you again. Is that okay?”

My pussy aches with need at the thought of him back inside me.

“What time is it?” I sleepily ask. It could be daybreak or past ten in the morning for all I know.

“Who cares about the time?” He pushes inside me, and the sensation as I take all of him is incredible. “Let’s not go anywhere today. Shall we just stay here in this bed?”

Oh, the temptation to answer with a yes and let him have his way with me for hours ... it almost has me abandoning all of our plans.

“Did you forget about the small matter of a meeting with Repeet?”

Will’s fingers work my clit while he strokes in and out of me in the missionary position. This boy is insatiable and every woman’s undoing.

“What if I fly your boss—Colton, is it? —to New York? He can handle the sponsorship deal, and we can do fun things together.”

I chuckle and then moan when he pulls out and replaces his dick with two fingers, curling them toward my front wall. My mouth hangs open, and he mimics my expression, totally delighted with himself.

“Is that good, Drew? Do you want to come all over my hand?”

Nodding because words fail me, I get a dark laugh and another finger added inside me.

“I’m curious,” he mumbles around my left nipple. “What’s the record for the number of orgasms a guy’s given you in a single twelve-hour period?”

“Why?” I grin up at him. His hair looks even better like this—all messy and the product of my fingers running through it. “Are you looking to set the record?”

His grin tells me yes.

Cupping his cheek in my palm, I’m not ashamed to admit what leaves my mouth next, even if I do feel inexperienced compared to him. “Well, you’ll be pleased to learn that you already set the record when you made me come for a second time.”

Will stops moving inside me, a look of horror strewn across his face. “*The fuck?*”

I shrug like it’s no big deal because it honestly isn’t. Every girl I’ve spoken to about sex has reported the same thing. Coming once is the

standard with a lot of guys, and I remember at least two occasions where Paul didn't get me off at all.

"It's just the way it is," I tell Will.

We're out of the bed in a flash, my legs wrapped around his waist while he marches us into the bathroom and cranks the shower.

"What are you doing now?" I say, gazing down between us.

He's still hard and inside me, making me question if he's human or a machine.

"Fucking you in the shower"—he nods his head at the white tiles, and steam begins filling the room—"while you're suspended against that wall."

For the next ten minutes, Will makes good on his promise, coaxing another orgasm from my body.

I fall into his chest as the water cascades over us, crashing against his broad shoulders.

"Why are you accepting less than what you deserve, Drew?" Will kisses me in earnest, water droplets falling from the ends of his thick lashes. "That really bothers me—to think of you being wasted on guys who didn't appreciate what I have in my hands."

I roll my lips together and stare up at him. "I guess I could ask you the same question."

His brows pull together in confusion.

"Why are you moving from one woman to the next when you clearly have the heart to make someone really happy?" I release one hand from around Will's neck and stroke my thumb across his prominent cheekbone. "You're a little bit romantic when you want to be."

Silence falls between us, the crashing of water all we can hear.

"I mean it," I whisper, a rush of emotion overtaking my voice. "I don't think I've ever felt as special as I did last night and then again this morning."

He presses our foreheads together, and water runs down the bridge of his nose and over mine. "I already told you that there has never been another girl who has made me want her so badly. I've never chased anyone in my life the way I've gone after you."

My heart skips—I'm sure it does.

"Will ..."

He closes his eyes. "Don't say it, Drew. Don't spoil the moment and point out the obvious."

I fall quiet for a few seconds and then reach across and turn off the shower.

“We could never date—you know that, don’t you?”

He looks almost annoyed with me, and it’s then I realize that was what he didn’t want me to verbalize.

My heart skips again.

“I’m not asking you to date me ...” He clears his throat, which sounds thick. “But I don’t want this to be our last time together, not by a long shot.”

“I already figured that out,” I softly reply.

With no warm water, my slick skin should be turning cold. Will’s body keeps me warm though, and just like he said, I don’t want this embrace to be our last.

“How about this?” Will says after maybe a minute of nothing but our joint breathing. “We make a deal to hook up when we can—because we both clearly want each other. We can work things out from there.”

I push my head back into the wall so he can see my eyes when I say this. “I’m not into messing around with someone if they’re sleeping with other people at the same time. It’s not really something I like.”

Will throws his head back and laughs toward the ceiling, and I feel my cheeks heat from embarrassment.

“Baby ... you really do talk some shit at times.”

I try to wiggle out of his grasp, but he holds me there.

“Don’t mock me, Will. I—”

Full, damp lips crash down onto mine, cutting off my angry ramble.

“I can’t physically be with anyone else, Drew,” Will whispers into my mouth. “It’s like my body and brain reject any thought of me touching another girl who isn’t you.” He drives the kisses deeper, panting heavily when we break apart. “And that scares the shit out of me because I’m convinced that guys like Tristan would take you to bed in a heartbeat.”

“I don’t like Tristan though,” I volley back.

“Is it because he’s an asshole?” Will asks, and damn my brain for finding him funny.

“He isn’t an asshole,” I scold him between kisses. “He’s a good person and a scorned brother because you broke his sister’s heart.”

“I would never break yours.”

“Huh?” I reply, sure I didn’t hear that correctly.

He shakes his head into the side of my neck and works on leaving another hickey, which I'll need to cover with concealer.

"Nothing. It doesn't matter."

Against my better judgment, I decide not to press him for clarity. A few dates is one thing, but there's no way Will Jones would ever consider having a girlfriend. Anyway, it's not like I'm at a point in my life where I'd get serious with anyone.

Would I?

"If you want to hook up more, then we can try and make it work," I say quietly, like someone could be eavesdropping.

He pulls me away from the wall and turns us around, yanking a white towel from the rail and wrapping it around my shoulders. How he does it all with one arm is impressive, but not entirely surprising, given his strength and build.

"When?" he questions, walking us back through to the bedroom.

"When what?" I ask when he stands me next to the bed.

"When can we hook up again?" he asks, dropping to his knees and setting a kiss just above my navel.

The heat of his breath makes my core ache, and I guide his mouth toward my apex.

"How about right now?" I joke while being deadly serious at the same time.

Will swipes his tongue through me and holds my ass in his palms, squeezing my cheeks together in a way that shouldn't be so freaking sexy. It's this guy's dominance and the possessive way he treats my body that I love.

"What about later tonight?"

My eyes bug out. "After we've had dinner at your mom and dad's?!"

He just shrugs. "Why not? I promise to be on my best behavior while we're there."

I roll my eyes at him and only because I know my disdain feeds his desire for me.

"I'll think about it, Hotshot. But ..." I lift a finger and cut him off before he goes down on me again. "We need to go over the notes for today's meeting while you're here."

Like a petulant child, he drops his shoulders. "Boring."

"Necessary," I counter.

I nearly fall backward when he lifts my right leg and rests it on his shoulder. I grip his wet hair to steady myself, and he groans with pleasure.

“All right, Baby. You run me through today’s agenda, and I’ll work this pretty clit until you’re screaming it. Categorize your orgasms under *Other Business*.”

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Will

Mom's been talking for the past few minutes, and I haven't heard a word that she's said.

All I can think about is last night and this morning.

Drew's beautiful, naked body laid out beneath me, her soft moans, parted lips. The way she gazed up at me in the shower when I reminded her that she was the only woman I'd ever chased. I wasn't sure she believed me. This morning, I knew the truth finally resonated with her.

There is no doubt in my mind that while we might be opposites in many ways, we fit together—in and out of the bedroom—so fucking perfectly.

Unlike Drew, I'm not scared of getting caught hooking up, although I totally get why she's hesitant to risk us being found out. I'm not idiotic enough to not know that, in the eyes of the public, her career is more dispensable than my own, but what Drew hasn't quite grasped is that I will literally do anything to protect her and everything she has worked for.

She deserves to be the highest flyer in her field, and I know she will be one day.

When I turned pro, I felt bitter toward the team I'd been drafted to, but mainly, I felt lost because the Rogues wasn't where I'd always imagined I'd end up. If I'm ever going to lift the Cup, it will be a long-ass time before this team is ready to do it. My teammates are good players, but much is missing from our setup.

Coach Callaghan is likely thinking the same thing as he sits next to Drew and spoons shrimp risotto into his mouth.

There's a chance he's also wondering why I can't stop staring at his daughter like she just hung the goddamn moon.

If only he knew that she had rocked my whole world last night and I plan to do the same to her when I get her back to the hotel. As soon as fucking possible.

I've thought about how he would react if he found out about me and Drew, and honestly, I don't really give a fuck. What Drew's dad thinks about me doesn't enter my mind each time I crash my lips against hers.

Bench me.

Trade me.

He won't do either because he needs me on the team.

Hell, tell me I'm not good enough for his princess. Even if I am.

I guess if you use my reputation as the barometer, then he'd probably be right—just ask Hallie and all the other women who wanted more and I ended up breaking their hearts.

But with Drew ... I'm the one tagging along like a lovesick puppy, waiting on the next flash of her eyes and curve of her lips. The girl I stroke my dick to whenever she isn't around.

So, no, I'm not worried about Coach finding out or how our families will react. Because for the first time since I was drafted to the NHL, I know exactly what I want.

To make Drew Callaghan happy. I'm a Jones, and when we set our minds on something, we don't stop until we have it—or them—in our grasp.

“Will?”

Mom's frustrated tone snaps me back into the room, and I blink a couple of times.

“Yeah?”

She drops her shoulders before repeating what I missed, thankfully.

“I was asking how often you will be expected to wear Repeet merchandise as part of the potential deal.”

Drew adjusts the collar on her green turtleneck sweater, one I know she wore to hide the legacy of my lips. Pretty blue eyes settle on me as she says, “We still need to work out a few details in the contract. Potential collaborations are stacking up in my inbox, and the last thing Will's agent and I want is to overcommit to one brand at the expense of something more lucrative in the future.”

Help me, for I am hard and sitting at my parents' dinner table.

Taking a chance that I find Drew and not Coach, I rub my sole over the top of her foot.

Drew doesn't flinch, but does roll her lips together when we make contact.

Bingo.

She fights back a chuckle when I move my foot again.

Perhaps she's ticklish?

Noted for later.

"If you ask me, Drew has achieved the impossible—turning my brother into a desirable person."

"Oh, I'm desirable all right," I say, leaning back in my chair so I can see June sitting at the end of the table. "Drew just had to peel back the layers and discover the real me."

I can't help it; I throw Drew a quick wink, and she scowls at me like I stole the food from her plate. Could this be our first lovers' tiff?

I hope so. Bossy Drew is my favorite; angry Drew could surely make me come in my pants.

"You're so gross," June scoffs and pushes her bowl away. "I don't know how you put up with him, Drew. You deserve a gold medal."

From beside me, Dad points at my sister's food. "If you aren't going to finish that, then let me have it. Your mom worked really hard, reducing that stock into the best risotto I've ever tasted."

Coach gives Mom a thumbs-up. "I second Jensen. The food is delicious, Kate."

Mom shimmies her shoulders and refills June's wineglass. "Thank you, Jessie. I'm only sad that Mia and Marley couldn't make it to Brooklyn this time."

When she stands and makes her way over to Drew with the wine bottle, my girl shakes her head. "No more wine for me, thank you. I have an early flight in the morning."

Wait. I thought she was flying back on the team plane in the evening.

"You aren't flying home with us?" I ask, garnering a raised brow from Coach.

I guess it is weird that I would be bothered which plane his daughter takes back to Seattle.

Drew doesn't give me eye contact, replying, "I'm actually not heading back home, but catching a flight to Vancouver. Marley has managed to get a

few days off, and I arranged a week of working remotely so I can spend some time with her.”

“Oh, that’s really great. Send her my love, will you?” Mom immediately responds when all I can do is stare at the girl who still won’t look at me.

The next few minutes pass by in a blur, June, Dad, Mom, and Coach all talking back and forth about work and plans to meet up this Christmas.

“I’m going to use the bathroom,” Drew says, setting her napkin on the table.

Mom points toward the hallway. “If you use the downstairs bathroom, then you can sample the latest Jo Malone soap I was telling you about earlier.”

Mind still spinning out over Drew’s surprise visit to Vancouver, I push my seat back and begin collecting plates.

“Stay seated, Mom. I got this,” I instruct, earning an appreciative grin from her and suspicious eyes from Dad.

Arms loaded with dishes, I stalk into the kitchen and set them down by the sink, waiting for the toilet to flush in the downstairs bathroom.

It feels like forever before Drew finishes up, and I’m propped against the opposite wall in the hallway, waiting for her to step out of the bathroom.

When she pulls the door open, I push off the wall and pull her back into the room, locking the door behind us.

“Will, what are you doing?” she whisper-hisses at me, eyes diverting to the door. “They’re all sitting only a few feet away, likely wondering where the both of us have gone!”

I wave a hand at her. “Have you heard my mom and sister talk? They can go at it for hours without coming up for air.”

Despite the annoyance written across Drew’s face, she snorts a soft laugh.

I pull down the neck on her sweater, lips grazing along the marks I left only hours ago.

What I wouldn’t give to leave some more.

“Are you running away from me, Baby?”

We both know I’m referring to her impromptu trip to Vancouver.

“No,” she breathes out softly. “But I do need some time to think everything over.”

She looks so freaking beautiful tonight in dark blue jeans that hug her shapely legs and a green sweater that contrasts perfectly with her bright

blue eyes. Her hair is down but styled straight this time. I love the way it frames her heart-shaped face.

"I don't understand," I stutter out, heart rate spiking at the thought of her backtracking on what we agreed on in the shower. "Are you talking about us?"

After a beat, Drew nods her head and drops her eyes.

No fucking way. I need her to look at me when she tells me she can't do this.

I tip her chin up with one finger. All I want to do is cover her mouth with mine and prevent the bullshit she's about to spew.

"Firstly, there isn't an *us*, Will. There never can be." She points in the rough direction of where our families are currently sitting. "Secondly, speaking with your parents and June tonight has brought home how reckless we're both behaving. Can you imagine how wild things would be if this ever leaked to the press? Our dads are two of the biggest names in hockey." She shakes her head and swipes my hand away. "We'd be making a mockery out of their careers, as well as our own."

For the first time since this whole thing started between us, I don't have an immediate solution to Drew's doubts. I guess I never thought about it from Dad's or Coach's point of view.

"You're so fucking smart, Drew. So fucking kind too."

She cocks her head to one side. "I don't follow."

Setting my hands on her hips, I pull our bodies closer together.

"You're right when you say that it would be a big deal to both of our families, although I think you forgot one thing in all of this."

She waits for me to speak.

"My dad was never accepted by my mom's asshole parents, and he told them to go fuck themselves anyway." I drop my forehead against hers. "And if I remember correctly, your dad waited years for Mia's dad to finally admit that they were meant to be together."

Drew's breath hitches, and I seal my mouth over hers until she breaks from me a few seconds later, chest rising and falling at an erratic rate.

"But we aren't falling for each other like Kate and Jensen or my mom and dad were."

Speak for yourself.

"I refuse to let what we have go. I can't let you go, Drew."

She presses a palm into the center of my chest and steps toward the bathroom door. “In the end, I’m not sure we’ll have any choice, Will.” Her eyes look regretful when she rests a hand on the door handle and tips her head over one shoulder to look at me. “Like I said, I need some time to think everything through. I’ll see you in a few days, yeah?”

“Yeah,” I say, shoving my hands into my pockets.

I’m fucking gutted right now, but she clearly needs space, and I have to grant her that. Pushing harder will only serve to force a girl like Drew away.

With a half smile, she steps out of the bathroom, and I wait a couple of minutes before I pull the door open and step out into the hallway, drowning in my own thoughts.

“You’re playing with fire.”

I spin around to find Dad standing at the far end of the hallway. Dressed in all black, he looks ominous as the soft lighting accentuates his salt and pepper hair.

Fuck.

“How long have you been there?” I ask.

He shrugs and moves toward me, an unreadable expression across his face. “Long enough to work out that you two were in that bathroom together. But don’t worry; Drew has no idea that I saw her leave.”

I rest my back against the wall and drop my head forward.

“What’s going on, Will?” he asks quietly.

I lift a shoulder and laugh without humor. “Do I really need to spell it out for you?”

“Are you sleeping together?”

I nod once. “Only since last night and then again this morning.”

Dad drops his head. “Jesus, son. Jessie is going to lose it if he finds out that you’re screwing around with his daughter. I’m on the edge of losing it, to be honest.”

My head snaps to him, hot rage rising up my throat. “I’m not *screwing around* with Drew. I—”

“You what?” Dad challenges me, taking another step in my direction. “You what, Will?”

I push my head back against the wall and stare up at the white ceiling.

“I’m falling for her, and I don’t think the feeling’s mutual. We’ve been working together a lot and—”

“Your feelings *are* reciprocated,” Dad cuts me off again. “The difference is, Drew is scared, and you’re already a household name in hockey.”

I let all the tension leave my body in one long exhale. It feels good to finally admit my feelings out loud and for the recipient to be someone I’ve trusted and looked up to my whole life.

“What do I do?” I ask, eyes tracking to Dad as he comes to stand in front of me, one hand resting on my right shoulder.

He cocks his head down the hallway, where Drew disappeared a few minutes earlier. “How did you guys leave it in the bathroom? Because Drew looked pretty upset when she walked out.”

The need to march into the dining room, take my girl by the hand, and tell her that I got her, no matter what happens, burns through me like wildfire.

I draw a deep breath into my lungs, knowing that would be the worst idea right now. “She told me she needs space.”

Dad nods, like that doesn’t come as a surprise. “Then that’s what you have to give her.”

“I know it is,” I respond. Irritable. “Easier said than done when I’m fucking obsessed with a girl for the first time in my life and there’s nothing I can do about it.”

He just smiles like he knows the score all too well.

“I never said there’s nothing you can do about it.” He smirks at me, creases forming around his sparkling dark eyes. “I’m just saying that you have to pick your moment and make the right move.”

I drop my shoulders. “And how will I work that one out?”

He keeps grinning. “Trust me, Will, when the time is right, you’ll make her yours. If that’s what you both really want.”

I let his words sink in for a second. “Are you going to tell Mom about this?”

Dad looks more unsure than he did before. I can tell he’s thinking about this one carefully.

“Your mother is your biggest cheerleader and will likely ream me out for keeping secrets from her.” He pulls at the back of his neck. “But I think this particular scenario should stay between us for the time being. She’s got a lot going on at work, and she’s already stressing out over some of the shit you’ve pulled online recently.”

I throw him an apologetic glance. “I’ve got this under control.”

He flicks his eyes at me. “I hope so. You know where I am if you need me. Just make sure you keep your feelings close to the vest this time and not out in the open for every man and his dog to comment on. You’re a Jones, Will, and I expect you to carry the name with integrity.”

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Drew

The comfort of my sister's arms is exactly what I need when she pulls me into an embrace in the Vancouver Airport.

"I never want to go that long without seeing each other again," I whisper into her blonde hair, which smells of peaches and caramel.

She takes my carry-on bag, which is all I brought with me since I had anticipated a few days in Brooklyn and not another week away from home.

"Drew, we only had to wait another six weeks, and you could've spent Christmas here. You didn't have to rearrange your entire work schedule."

We begin walking toward the exit, where the pickup line is situated.

"Did you drive here, or are we getting a taxi back to your place?"

She rolls her eyes, and we step out into the frigid November air; it's even colder in Vancouver than it was in Brooklyn, and I instantly regret not packing my winter parka.

"I borrowed Greg's car. Taxi prices are ridiculous around here."

"You really should think about getting your own car," I reply as she lifts my bag into the trunk.

She slams it shut, and I make my way to the passenger side, pulling open the door and climbing into Greg's black SUV.

Marley slides into the driver's side and cranks the engine, immediately pulling onto the road. From memory, the journey from the airport to her house is at least a half hour, giving me plenty of time to unload on the one person I can talk to freely about everything that's happened.

Ordinarily, I would talk to Mom as well. But given the circumstances, it feels unfair to expect her to keep such a huge secret from Dad.

“With Greg working from home, we only really need one car, and auto insurance is so damn expensive!”

I look at her with wide eyes. “You know that our parents are millionaires, right? I’m sure if you asked them, they would get you a car.”

Marley shakes her head and joins the freeway. I’ve always considered myself humble, but my sister takes it to another level. Her stubbornness also reminds me a lot of Will, and suddenly, I’m thinking about our last interaction in the hotel lobby.

I really wanted to invite him to my room so we could reenact everything we’d shared the night and morning before, but falling into bed together wasn’t going to help clear my head.

It was supposed to be just sex—a hookup between two people who couldn’t resist the urge for each other any longer. That wasn’t what transpired though. The way he looked at me, the emotion that coursed through my body when he pushed inside me for the first, second, and third time—they weren’t typical of a one-night thing or the way I imagined it would be if I ever slept with Will.

I am scared of being discovered and the consequences that will follow. But I’m also scared because I don’t want to be another Hallie, falling victim to Will’s charm, only to be left brokenhearted when he’s done with me.

So, why did he look at me like I was holding his heart in my hands?

And why did his eyes linger on mine until the very final second when the elevator doors closed in the lobby?

“I’m going to go out on a limb here and say that wanting to see me isn’t the only reason why you booked a last-minute flight to Vancouver.”

I gaze over at my sister, her silhouette growing blurrier by the second.

This is why I needed to come to Vancouver.

“I think I’m in way over my head, Marl.”

We leave the freeway, and she pulls up at a stoplight.

Marley takes my hand in hers, resting them both on the center section. “Is it to do with a guy?”

I blow out a long breath, and we start moving again. “How did you guess?”

She squeezes my hand. “Because I know my sister and because you have that look in your eyes—one that screams that you’re in love.”

My laughter rings around the car. “In love?! What drugs are you taking this week?”

Marley doesn't laugh along with me though, releasing my hand so she can take a right and merge onto another freeway.

"What's his name?"

I stare out of the passenger window. Even though she's my sister, I'm struggling to make eye contact, for fear of how she'll react.

"Drew?" she presses me for an answer.

"I need you to promise that you won't freak out when I tell you this."

"And you know whenever someone begins a line with those words, that's exactly what the other person does."

"It's Will." I say the words quickly, like I'm ripping a Band-Aid off.

One hand on the steering wheel, she holds up the other. "Wait, what?! As in Will Jones?! William freaking *Jones*?! The family friend you're supposed to be representing and ... oh my God ..." She draws in a sharp breath, horror in her voice. "You're in love with him?!"

"I'm not in love with him!" I shriek. "But ... yeah, I'm talking about Will Jones."

"Holy freaking Lord."

"Not helping," I sing at her. "I was hoping for more of a calm response to this news. You know, the kind where you tell me that I'm not a freaking idiot for sleeping with him."

"You're sleeping with him?!" Marley practically pulls off the road. She grips the steering wheel tighter, drawing deep breaths into her lungs.

I don't say anything for a few beats, giving her time to calm down.

"Drew ... I ... I don't know what to say." She quickly looks at me and then back at the road. "I guess all I can think to ask is, what's he like in bed?"

We both start laughing because of all the questions my sister could have asked, of course she had to go ahead and pick the most inappropriate one.

"Listen ..." She holds up another hand, still laughing as she says, "You can't blame a girl for going there. The boy has a reputation for being amazing in bed. You only have to run a quick search of him on social media to figure that one out." She winces at her own words. "Sorry, that's not what you wanted to hear."

I shrug and gaze out of the window. Vancouver truly is a beautiful city. "I'm well aware of his reputation, but that's the thing ..." I turn to look at her. "I think he might really like me."

Marley side-eyes me, but doesn't say anything else.

“And I think I might really like him too.”



MARLEY TAKES A SEAT AT THE KITCHEN TABLE AND SLIDES A PLATE OF spaghetti Bolognese my way. It looks incredible, but my appetite has deserted me in favor of my stressing over the boy with a smile that makes me giddy. He will have landed back in Seattle by now, and I haven't heard a thing since last night.

I stare down at my phone.

“Were you hoping that by running off to Vancouver, he might follow you here?”

Marley's question hits me right in the gut. I don't want to admit the truth in it or the fact that I'm missing him and allowing my mind to spiral.

What if he's hooking up with someone else right now?

“I came here to see you,” I tell her. “But, yeah, I'm thinking about him, and I can't deny that.”

I twirl some spaghetti around my fork, but it clatters to the plate when my phone buzzes on the table, and I immediately grab it.

WILL

In case you were wondering, I miss you. And, yeah, I've already googled flights from Seattle to Vancouver. Twice.

Okay, maybe three times. But who's counting?

“Oh, girl, you are definitely into him.”

I could try all night but still struggle to hide the smile as it pulls at my lips.

Taking a big bite of food, I close my eyes and swallow. “You're still a great cook, Marl.”

“Don't deflect, Drew. I want to know what Will said.”

“How do you know it was him who messaged me?”

She narrows her eyes. “And don't play dumb with me either.”

Now hungrier than ever, I pick up my cell and unlock it, bringing up the text thread with Will and handing her the phone.

For several minutes, she studies our interactions as I continue to eat. Every now and then, she gasps or raises an eyebrow, and I giggle,

wondering which bratty comment from Will has my sister all twisted up. Probably all of them.

Rather than me verbally fill her in on every detail, it feels easier to let her read through everything that's been said.

When she's finished, Marley locks my phone and slides it toward me.

I take a last mouthful of pasta and wait for a verdict.

"What do you think?" I eventually ask, too anxious to let the silence last any longer.

Blue eyes, a shade darker than mine, gaze back at me. "I think we need to go out and have a drink. Because that boy"—she points to my cell—"isn't going to stop until he has my sister right where he wants her."

I open my mouth to reply, but she shushes me, turning all gooey-eyed.

"And I, for one, am really freaking jealous. Any girl who claims that she doesn't want a hot hockey player obsessed with her is nothing more than an accomplished liar."

“All cell phones must be switched to Airplane mode now, sir.”
I nod once and ignore the attendant. We both know I have at least five more minutes before I need to use the plane’s Wi-Fi.

ME

I have 36 hours before the next practice, and even then, I could spin Coach a story about having the flu.

MASON

Are you seriously on a flight to Vancouver?

ME

Yes. Quicker than the ferry because the weather is shit.

MASON

Damn. Maybe this is where I went wrong with Eloise for all those years. I should’ve been chasing her across countries rather than simply picking up the phone and calling her like a normal person would.

ME

Ha-fucking-ha. You know Drew has gone dark, and therefore, calling is no longer an option.

MASON

Did you ever stop and think that maybe she actually needs the space she told you about when you stalked her into your parents’ bathroom?

ME

I wish I hadn’t told you about that part.

MASON

Was she still peeing when you barged in and declared your love for her?

ME

Fuck off.

MASON

I think if I were a chick and you were obsessed with me, then I'd flee to Vancouver too. At least then, I could take a leak in peace.

ME

Fuck off.

MASON

But seriously, what are you going to do when you arrive in Vancouver? Do you even have her sister's address?

ME

Yeah. Her sister texted it to me before I booked the flight.

MASON

I have no words other than wow. You even have Drew's family wrapped around your finger. Well, other than Coach, who will bury you under the rink when he finds out that you're boning his eldest daughter.

ME

We've slept together once—if you count multiple times that night and then again in the morning as one session—and I'm not chasing her for sex.

Okay, maybe I'm hoping for a little bit of sex while I'm there, but not just for that.

MASON

Thanks for the breakdown of your first sexual encounter with Drew. I really appreciated that. What else do you have planned besides rolling around in bed with your publicist?

ME

Fuck me, man. I'm really fucking glad these messages are encrypted.

MASON

Same.

ME

What's the latest with Eloise?

MASON

She isn't answering my calls, and I can't say that I blame her. Would you pick up after seeing those images with the blonde girl in Brooklyn?

ME

Probably not. Sounds like you should book a flight to France.

MASON

I would if she was actually in France and I thought that our marriage wasn't totally fucked. Last I heard, she was in Seattle, and when I got home from Brooklyn, I noticed a few more things were missing from the house.

ME

She returned to Seattle while you were gone, but didn't tell you?

MASON

Yeah. I guess that says it all—if she truly wanted to work things out, then she would've stuck around and waited so we could speak face-to-face.

ME

I need to ask, what went wrong between you?

MASON

How long until your flight?

ME

We're literally taxiing to the runway now, and I need to switch to Airplane mode.

MASON

Okay, well, when we're next sharing a hotel room on an away series, I'll tell you everything.

ME

Fuck. How much detail is there to go through?

MASON

Buddy, we were together for a decade and married for over half of that time. A lot has gone down between us, and I'm not proud of some of my actions.

Mason begins typing again, and I pause on replying to see what he'll say next.

MASON

I know I've joked around about you flying to Vancouver between practice sessions. But really, I'm sitting here, taking notes and wishing that I'd been that smart with Eloise. She deserved more than I gave her, and now another guy will get his chance with the only woman I've ever loved.



WELL, THIS IS FUCKING AWKWARD, I SAY TO MYSELF AS I SIT ON THE COUCH, opposite Marley's boyfriend, Greg, and drink a beer with him that I was too polite to decline.

I've never met the guy before, although he continues talking like we're long-lost friends. All I want to know is where his girlfriend and sister are tonight and if their whereabouts is why Drew isn't replying to my texts.

"I still can't believe I've got *the* Will Jones in my living room." He shakes his head and downs the rest of his beer, motioning toward the full bottle between my palms, which I've been nursing for the past half hour. "Can I get you another?"

"Nah, I'm good, thanks," I reply.

He stands from the bright purple couch I know Marley picked out based on her sunshiny personality alone. He shakes out his long red hair and checks his watch. The pause in him talking presents me with the ideal opportunity to ask him again where Drew and Marley went tonight.

Seriously, if this guy was any more relaxed, he'd be horizontal.

"Did the girls tell you where they were headed?"

Greg makes his way into the kitchen, yelling, "I can't remember the name of the place, but I think it was some new club that just opened a few blocks from here. Marley has been desperate to check it out, but I'm getting too old for that shit."

He reappears in the living room with a fresh bottle of Bud.

A club? *Fuck.*

Sliding my cell from my jeans pocket, I check the time. It's past eleven p.m.

“Did they say when they’d be back or if they needed a ride home?”

Greg looks at me with disbelief. “A ride home? They’re only a few blocks away, and they can grab a taxi if they need it.”

When I first showed up here, I kind of liked Greg. Now that I’m getting to know him better, I’m tempted to ask if he’s related to Tristan.

“Do you not give your girlfriend a ride home when she needs it? It’s not like you’re busy tonight.” I cock my head at the bay window overlooking downtown Vancouver, rain thumping down on the sidewalks. “Did they take an umbrella out with them?”

He scoffs at me and sits back on the couch, picking up the TV remote and switching to a random channel playing music videos. “Dude, I can’t even remember what my girl was wearing when she left. Whether she was carrying an umbrella sort of passed me by.”

Out of respect to Marley and Drew, I smile at Greg and refrain from saying what I really think. *This guy is a dick.*

Marley can do so much better—even I can work that one out in the short time I’ve known him. Being honest, it surprises me that Coach and Mia haven’t told Marley to dump this loser, but then again, they aren’t the type of people who would try and control who their daughters do and don’t date.

I hope that autonomy extends to me when they eventually find out about the feelings I harbor for Drew.

“Oh my God!” Marley’s joyful—and really loud—voice echoes down the hallway before the apartment door slams shut, and then I hear Drew whisper something I wish that I could make out.

Setting the bottle of beer on the coffee table in front of me, I sit forward and rest my elbows on my knees, trying to get ahold of myself.

Why am I nervous to see her?

“They’re definitely his sneakers, Marley!” This time, I hear Drew clearly, and my heart leaps into my throat.

Is she excited to see me too?

“You gave him your address?! You didn’t tell me that!” Drew attempts to whisper, but fails miserably.

“You realize that we can hear every single word you’re saying, right?”

Both Marley and Drew fall silent as soon as Greg points out the obvious, and Marley is the first sister to appear in the living room doorway.

Seriously, how her outfit isn't imprinted in Greg's brain is beyond me. She looks freaking stunning in a red dress that hits mid-thigh with a sweetheart neckline.

"Hey." She waves a tentative hand at me, and that's when I set eyes on the girl I chased across North America.

Holy fuck.

Gold has never looked so breathtaking as it does on my girl, who walks into the living room, wearing a matching two-piece miniskirt and cami. I feel sure the outfit is one of Marley's, and, goddamn, I bite down on my knuckles—the only way I can keep from verbalizing thoughts that are only meant for Drew.

Looking a little awkward, she stands in front of me, and all I want to do is plant my hands on her hips and pull her between my parted thighs like I know she'd love.

Marley grabs Greg's hand, peeling him off the couch and marching them toward the doorway. "I think we should leave Will and Drew to talk."

She points down the hallway. "Will, Drew has been using the inflatable bed, but if you want to crash on the couch, then there are some extra pillows and blankets in the closet on the right."

Drew burns red, and I want to burst out laughing at how freaking awkward this whole situation is.

My girl tries to act cool with a casual smile. "Yep, Marl, thanks for that, but I think we can take the sleeping arrangements from here."

With one last wave, Marley and Greg exit the living room and close the door behind them, their voices growing fainter until I hear another door close. All that remains is the noise from the streets outside and the thump of my pulse as it pounds in my ears.

"Hi," I say, rising from the couch and standing in front of Drew.

Her hair is pulled into a braid tonight, which rests over one shoulder. She's wearing more makeup than usual, and it's applied similarly to Marley's.

"You covered my marks on your neck," I point out, desperate to make more.

She gazes up at me through long lashes.

So fucking beautiful.

"You came."

I run my pointer finger across the back of her right hand, and I see the way her breathing picks up at the smallest touch.

"I already told you, you're the only girl I've ever chased."

She rolls her lips together, and I'm sure it's to suppress a satisfied smile.

"Me coming to Vancouver wasn't a test, if that's what you think."

I shrug and lace our fingers together. "Test or not, it makes no difference to me. Did I pass?"

She snorts a soft laugh, and her eyes, winged with black liner, fall to my lips.

Go on, Baby. Kiss me.

"Shouldn't you be practicing in Seattle?"

Moving myself backward, I take a seat on the couch and part my thighs so she can step between them.

"I have twenty-four hours before I need to be back on the ice."

She looks at me, aghast. "Will, you are wild. Do you know that?"

"Yeah, I know," I say on an exhale, releasing her hand so I can palm her hip. I edge her cami up with my thumb, as if her soft skin were begging for my tongue.

Goose bumps break out across her stomach.

"You look insane in this outfit." I bite on my bottom lip and stare up at her. "How many guys asked to dance with you? Or should I ask, how many of them do I need to beat up?"

A bratty expression overtakes her. "Oh, you know, just a few ... dozen."

I'm jealous, and it's all over my face. "And how many of those invites did you accept?"

If I wasn't hard before, I'm like stone when she hitches up her skirt and straddles my thighs in a cowgirl position, running one hand through my hair.

"Correct me if I'm wrong, but is William Jensen Jones actually jealous?"

I could play it cool and deny it, but that would also mean lying.

"Yeah, Drew," I say, playing with her braid between my fingers, "I am. Do you have an issue with that?"

She looks off to the side and inhales a deep breath. On the face of it, we might be messing around, although we both know that behind my words lies a more serious message.

One that screams of possession and exclusivity beyond a hookup arrangement.

“Back in New York, you told me you didn’t want me hooking up with other women if we were actively sleeping together,” I whisper before sucking on her neck. “The thing is, Drew, I can’t deal with thoughts of another man’s hands on you.”

I run my fingers from her knees all the way to the hem of her skirt—needy heat radiating hotter, the higher I travel. “Your body molds to me perfectly when I hold it like this.”

I suck again, and she melts into me.

“And I can tell you right now that there is no one else in this world who can make you feel as special as I do. June will confirm that I’ve never been good at sharing, and I’m not feeling generous when it comes to you.”

When Drew tugs at my white shirt, I raise my arms overhead so she can remove it.

Tossing my top to one side, she spends a couple of minutes studying my chest. I’m not sure if it’s the years of work I’ve put in at the gym that she’s appreciating or the way I shudder as her fingernails trace lines across my pecs and then down to my abs.

Her eyes pause on my gold compass, and in the warm lighting of the room, her lips shimmer when she swipes a quick tongue across her bottom lip.

“Have you ever thought about getting a tattoo?” Drew’s question comes straight out of left field, especially after what I just said.

Knowing this girl, I’m sure she’s digesting my words and thinking everything over.

“No.”

She cocks her head to one side, curious. “Why not? Most hockey players have at least one, don’t they?”

I pause for a moment before answering, “I guess I’ve never really felt strongly enough to get one done. I thought about inking my sister’s handprint at one point. After we were born, Mom and Dad had our handprints taken, and that felt like a cool idea, but ...”

“But what?”

I lean back a little so I can take Drew in more carefully. “But I’ve always felt like a tattoo should be something we can’t ordinarily see with our eyes. It should represent a feeling, memory, or someone special. That

one person or moment we could never let go of.” I quirk a brow at her. “Why don’t you have any tattoos? Most publicists have them, right?”

She chuckles softly and takes my compass between her fingers. “I think this might be the one time where we’re similar. I’ve always wanted a tattoo, but I could never think of what to get.”

“How about a picture of my face on your left ass cheek?”

She swats me in the chest, and I catch her hand in mine, sucking her middle finger into my mouth.

As we maintain eye contact, her jaw pops open, and it’s one of the hottest moments of my life. Deeply intimate yet so freaking simple.

So much of me wants to peel her out of these clothes and take her on the couch right now. I fucking love sex, and sleeping with Drew is like nothing else.

But moving to the next base would also mean breaking the spell that’s keeping our attention locked on each other, and if I could exist like this forever, then I would.

I’ve never been in love with a girl before, not even close. I’m falling for the beauty perched in my lap though. I know it.

“I guess we should get some sleep.” Drew breaks the silence too soon for my liking.

“Do your thing, Baby,” I instruct, hauling her into my arms and standing.

She wraps her legs around my waist, and I walk us toward the closet Marley pointed out earlier.

As I hold her steady, Drew pulls out what we need, and we return to the living room before I set her back down on the couch and cover her with a blanket.

“Cuddle with me tonight?” I ask her like a fucking teenager.

She shuffles back as I join her on the couch and slide a couple of pillows beneath our heads.

“Are you scared of the dark, Will?” she mocks in a small voice.

I roll on top of her and bracket her in with my forearms. “If I said yes, would you cuddle me all night? I promise to be a gentleman. Unlike the last time.”

Drew’s lips twist in thought, but all I can sense is her happiness, and that does things to me. Good things.

“I could probably tolerate cuddling you for one night.”

I drop my lips and kiss the end of her nose, letting her scent pull me deeper. “Let’s get some rest. I have *big* plans for us tomorrow.”

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Drew

“Should I die, I’ll come back and haunt you,” I hiss at Will.
 And if he doesn’t take the shaky hand I’m offering, then I’ll never cross the threshold into the gondola.

He snorts a laugh as he pulls me into the cabin, wrapping me in a bear hug when the doors close, and we continue moving around the station. In around thirty seconds, there will be nothing between us and a nine-hundred-meter drop.

“What if the wire fails?” I bury my face in Will’s black hoodie.

He looks so hot in a backward baseball cap, although it won’t be enough to save him if anything goes wrong. I’ll puke in it and set it back on his head.

For saying we slept on the couch, I can’t remember the last time I drifted to sleep so easily. This morning, Will made Marley and me black coffee and blueberry pancakes. Greg was already at work, and from the moment Will broke the news of where we were going today, I’ve been wishing I were back in the office and listening to Lydia’s annoying voice.

The whole drive here in a fancy rental car, Will reassured me that it was “healthy to do something that scares you each day.”

All right, William, tell that to my stomach.

“Then I’ll make sure I hit the ground first and give you a soft landing,” Will croons, smoothing his hand down my hair.

I swallow hard, and he kisses me with smiling lips.

“Nothing bad is going to happen, Drew. Promise.”

“Are you sure no one will see us?” I gaze around the empty attraction.
 “This place is very ... public.”

Will shakes his head. "I already told you, I hired the gondolas for an hour, so no one will know we're here beyond the staff."

"And when we get to the top?" I ask.

He shakes his head again, hugging me tighter. "Nothing to worry about either. You'll see how private it is."

"I actually might hate you for putting me through this, even if you hired the whole place out like a swoony book boyfriend," I playfully scold him, feeling my stomach drop again.

Will keeps his arms around me as we glide off the platform and suspend midair.

"Total transparency," he whispers and sets a chaste kiss into my hair. "I had no idea that your fear of heights was this bad. I'm already thinking of more days out like this, just so I have an excuse to wrap you in my arms."

Last night, I wanted to sleep with him again, but I appreciated the way Will took his time, kissing and hugging me until I fell asleep on his chest. Today, I crave the safety of his touch even more.

Will is every bit the man I thought he was when we started working together, yet nothing like him at all. I love that he keeps me guessing, and I think I might be one of the lucky few people to see the real him.

"Do you think they have security cameras in these things?"

Will gazes around the cabin and shakes his head. "I thought they might, but I can't see anything."

Still looking up at him, I drop to my knees, fingers finding his belt buckle.

He covers my hands with his. It isn't enough to stop me from unlooping his belt and unzipping his pants.

"What are you doing, Drew?" he asks in an unsteady voice.

I smirk up at him and dip my hand into his boxer briefs. He's already hard, and when I wrap my fist around his shaft, he drops to the wooden bench behind him.

"We're all alone, and I have at least fifteen minutes of hell to endure." I lift a shoulder and pull his dick free, teasing the tip with my tongue. "I figured your cock could double as a handy distraction."

Will fists my hair, eyes darkened with feral lust. "Are you going to use me, Baby?"

I bite down on my bottom lip and take him into my mouth. Not too far to begin with, but enough to have him shuddering.

It's not lost on me that Will has had more blow jobs than I've had hot dinners, although I'm determined to make this one the best.

"All good boys deserve to be treated once in a while, don't you think?"

Words fail him, and confidence inflates my chest.

When I press him deeper down my throat, he pushes his head back into the glass wall, eyes squeezed shut.

"Drew ... Drew ... Drew ..." Will repeats my name on a whisper, fingers tangling in my hair the whole time. "Christ. Where did you learn to do this so well?"

I circle my tongue around the shaft and grin. "Do you really want me to answer that question?"

Will nods his head and then immediately shakes it, swallowing hard. "Yes—no—fuck. No, I don't want to think about my girl with anyone else. *You're mine.*"

I continue sucking him, brain short-circuiting at the possessive way he speaks about us.

Would I mind being Will Jones's girl?

Never going to happen.

When he hardens in my mouth, I cup his balls in my palm and mumble, "Come for me," around his dick.

"Drew, wait," he says between gasps, tugging my hair so I'll look up at him.

When I release his dick, it bobs between us.

"I'm going to shoot in your dirty fucking mouth."

I beam up at him, reveling in his pleasure. "That's what I want you to do."

Will takes my chin between his thumb and forefinger. "You want me to blow between these pretty lips?" He runs his thumb along my bottom lip.

"Did you assume that I was too much of a good girl to be dirty once in a while?"

Will looks off to the side and immediately back at me. His eyes are now black, pupils blown wide.

"Take my cock to the back of your throat and hold it there."

I click my tongue at him. "You want me to deep-throat you?"

He nods and inches his boxers down a little more. "Yeah, Drew, I want you to suck my dick like the demon you are." His hand is back in my hair,

tugging deliciously at the roots as I hover my lips over the tip. “You’re no good girl. Just a nasty slut, addicted to my cum.”

I take him deep and fast, bringing him closer to the edge each time I swallow him.

“*Fuuuck!*”

Will explodes, and I give him my eyes. I’ve never let a guy come in my mouth before today, but I’m already thinking of the next opportunity I’ll get to do this again with him.

When Will’s given me all he has, I release his dick, and he tucks himself away, maneuvering me to sit across his lap.

“Say something.” I giggle nervously after a minute of silence.

His fingertips dig into my jean-covered thighs. I think I might have rendered him speechless.

“I can’t,” he whispers after a few more seconds, staring directly ahead rather than at me.

“Why not?” I question, craning my neck to capture his attention.

It doesn’t work, and he swivels his cap around, pulling the bill over his eyes.

“Was it ... bad?” I ask hesitantly, almost sure he enjoyed it.

“No,” he says with earnest. “I just can’t say anything right now, Drew.”

I decide not to push him. Mind spinning out over what went wrong in the last two minutes.

“It’s best if I keep my thoughts internal right now,” Will adds, moving his arms so they loop around my waist. “But that ...” He finally looks at me with so much emotion. “You. Everything about you. Just ... wow.”

Ten minutes later, I’m pleased to confirm that we’re both still alive, having reached the summit, and Will is back to his usual cocky self.

“Follow me.” Will guides me by the hand through a quiet woodland area until we find a small café nestled between pine trees.

“I didn’t even know this was here,” I say. “It wasn’t on their website.”

Will turns to look at me, upper lip raised in the corner. “Of course you’re one of those people who researches a place before she visits.”

I throw him a dubious glance. A forty-minute car ride is more than enough time to scan the visitor information for the basics. “I don’t trust people who go on day trips without making plans. How do you know where the nearest bathrooms will be? Or whether you’ll need to bring your own lunch?”

Still holding my hand, Will starts walking backward, voice laced with humor. “Are you serious? As in, like, a brown bag with an apple, sandwich, and a bottle of water?”

I feel my cheeks flush hot. “I mean, maybe? No one wants to be caught short, needing to pee or eat.”

My back is flat against a tree in a millisecond, Will’s tall figure looming over me.

He swivels his cap backward and drops his face into my neck. “Can I tell you a secret?”

“Of course,” I breathe out into the woodland, the smell of pine mixing perfectly with his familiar woody cologne.

He sets a kiss against my collarbone and pulls the collar on my blue parka back in place. “You know I’m part Canadian, right?”

I deadpan, “No, William. I wasn’t aware of your Canadian roots. Your dad only mentions it every Christmas.”

Will doesn’t argue because he knows I’m right. “On summer break, Mom and Dad used to stop here on our drive to Whistler. Hardly anyone, other than the locals, knows about this place.” Will pushes some hair out of my face.

He looks so freaking handsome every day, but today, I can honestly say that he’s spectacular. The sun outlines his broad frame and shoulders in a golden glow that looks almost mystical.

He gazes over his shoulder toward the café set behind us. “Secluded Sips does the best hot chocolate around. Every kind of flavor you can imagine, they have it. All the sprinkles plus Cadbury Flake, which is my personal favorite.”

I hesitate for a beat. “Wait a second. Are you trying to tell me that you, William ‘My Body Is a Temple’ Jones,” I mock, “actually like something that isn’t organic and not sourced from the purest virgin rivers known to mankind?”

His fingers find my ribs, and I burst out laughing, begging him to stop.

“Oh, I see how it is.” Will peppers kisses along my jawline. “I offer to buy you hot chocolate, and you proceed to berate me for looking after my body.”

He tickles me again, and now I’m crying out for him to relent.

“I thought you were ticklish that night we had dinner at my parents’ house. And now I know for sure.” His fingers slow to a torturous pace. “I

plan to exploit your weakness every chance I get. If you play hard to get with me in the future, I'll just use these"—he wiggles his fingers again, and I squirm—"until I break down all your willpower to resist me."

Another few seconds, and he lets me catch my breath before I test to see if he's ticklish. I'm left disappointed when he stands stock-still.

Will sets a palm against the tree above my head, and we make out for what feels like forever.

Today has been amazing, and I haven't even sampled the best hot chocolate around.

"So, what happens once we get back to Seattle, Drew?" Will breathes against my damp lips. "Do I get to kiss you there too?"

When I boarded the flight to Vancouver, I felt sure that space was what I needed. As I stand against this tree, caged in Will's arms, I know distance wasn't what I was searching for.

"I want to carry on hooking up with you," I confirm. "We're having too much fun to stop now."

Will's hand slides down the trunk and cups my left cheek. The warmth of his big palm comforts me, just like his embrace did on the gondola.

"Good decision, Baby," he croons. "I won't let anything bad happen to you or your career. I'll tear social media apart before anyone gets a chance to post one bad thing about the woman I can't get enough of."

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Drew

It's been a week since I got back from Vancouver and even longer since I last saw Will. As we approach the holidays, the regular hockey season always intensifies, and the Rogues have been on the road more than at home.

I guess I should be grateful for Will's absence because for the first time in my life, I've fallen behind on work. This morning, a follow-up email from one of my other clients landed in my inbox.

My reply was an apology, explaining that I'd been out of town for work. I hate lying to anyone, let alone the people who literally pay my salary, but what was I supposed to say?

My apologies, Malcolm, but now that I'm taking a short break from screwing the star Rogues forward, I'll be able to actually do my fucking job.

Once I've stopped daydreaming about that kiss against the tree or the way he sucked on my neck while we spooned all night on my sister's couch, I tune back in to reality and Colton's voice. The monthly staff meeting is mid-flow, and I pray that my boss isn't expecting me to engage in the conversation.

The boardroom is packed with my colleagues, all of whom I'm convinced can read my mind. Or maybe it's just the guilt telling me that they can.

Lydia sits opposite me, smiling away at Colton as she updates him on the portfolio of clients I know she hasn't expanded upon in months. Perhaps if she took more interest in her own work rather than mine, she might have something exciting to report in these meetings.

“And how about other collaborations, Drew? I know you’ve been working on multiple, so do we have any offers?”

I shift in my chair, trying to recall the exact details of a recent deal a large watch brand put forward. I know it was decent, but the day they emailed, I was giving Will a blow job in a gondola, and that’s all I can think about right now.

“We received an offer, yes. Will has various opportunities on the table, either at offer stage or still in negotiation. I have presented all of the details to Will and his agent, and they are currently thinking them over.”

From across the room, I ignore Lydia’s narrowed eyes and focus on Colton.

He scratches at the back of his neck. “Correct me if I’m wrong here, Drew, but I’m struggling to see what needs to be considered. Is Will inundated with collaborations at this time? Because that would be news to me.”

I feel my cheeks flush hot, and I unbutton my jacket, desperate to get comfortable when I can feel at least twenty pairs of eyes boring into me.

“Um ...” I clear my throat, voice overcome with nervous energy. “I’m not saying that he won’t take the deal, but my client is being cautious to select the right collaborations and not overstretch himself.” I pause and grin at Colton. “He’s reluctant to become a walking billboard.” For the first time since I walked into this stuffy boardroom, I feel like I’m talking sense. “Will’s main objective is to build his performances on the ice and not get waylaid with photo shoots and other non-hockey-related obligations. So, while I think he will take many of the opportunities that come his way, I—”

“Is that not literally the definition of your job—to secure as many collaborations for your client as possible? Or am I out of touch with the industry?”

Offering Lydia a sweet smile instead of a scowl, I tip my head to one side. “What good is a client if they’re too exhausted to properly fulfill their contracts? My job is to raise Will’s profile while protecting his well-being at the same time. Blindly pursuing deals for the sake of it is counterintuitive and an outdated approach I’m not accustomed to.”

If looks could kill, I’d be lying in a pool of my own blood right now while Lydia hovers over my body with a knife.

“I think finding a middle ground is the ideal scenario,” Colton speaks up.

“Or maybe trying to steal clients and pretending like nothing happened is on trend these days?” Lydia’s cynical tone cuts through the room, leaving nothing but silence in her wake.

Colton rears back, and my eyes rove around the space.

Who is she referring to?

“Oh, come on, Drew. I’m growing tired of this innocent act you carry when everyone is watching.” Lydia’s voice grows louder before she points her finger at me. “When were you going to tell me about Silas Stanton requesting a switch to your management, or were you hoping to keep it quiet?”

“Right!” Colton claps his hands together. “I think that’s a wrap for today’s meeting.”

Apart from me, my boss, and Lydia, everyone begins filing out of the room. Low-grade murmurs pass between the last people to leave before they close the boardroom door behind them.

I stare at my empty laptop screen, a mixture of rage and confusion coating my insides.

“I haven’t stolen any of your clients, Lydia,” I quietly reply as Colton takes a seat, but she remains standing.

Clutching her notepad and pen, my colleague’s hands vibrate with anger.

“Then why didn’t you inform me about the email he sent you weeks ago? I need to know if my clients are unhappy.”

Colton’s head swivels to me, his attention moving back and forth, like he’s spectating a tennis match. If it were a real game, I’d be love-forty down because Lydia is correct. I should’ve at least notified my boss about Silas’s approach, and I probably would’ve done that if I had been locked into my job and following standard practices instead of breaking them every chance I got with Will.

“Why didn’t you say something, Drew? Mr. Stanton is the last client First Line wants to lose.”

All senses sting as emotions build behind them, and I force myself to swallow hard, determined not to reveal how disappointed I am in myself.

This isn’t who you are.

I don’t operate like this at work. I’m the first one in the office each morning and the last one to leave at night. Drew Callaghan is a walking, talking rulebook with a full schedule and a spreadsheet for everything.

“I guess ...” I close my laptop and twist my hands around on the lid. “I guess I didn’t want to upset you, Lydia. To be honest, I’ve always felt like you’ve had this issue with me, and I can’t work out why. Coming to you with the email from Silas felt awkward and like it would only make the animosity between us worse.”

When my eyes meet hers, I hope that I’ll see a shred of understanding in them. All I get is more anger and a frown between her brows.

“I want to make a formal complaint, Colton.”

It feels like my stomach hits the floor.

“A complaint?” I whisper. “Lydia, we can work this out without—”

“Can you please ask Drew to leave the room so we can have some privacy?” Lydia talks over me, attention centered solely on our boss.

Colton’s eyes flash briefly to me and then back to Lydia. We’ve definitely reached the equivalent of a break point.

He and I both know if I don’t get up and go, this could blow up into an HR nightmare. My kind boss doesn’t deserve that.

Pushing back my chair, I gather my belongings and immediately head for the door, stepping out into the main office area, where at least a dozen heads turn my way.

I need to get out of here, stat.

I’m halfway to the staircase when a call starts vibrating in my hand, and I hit Accept on my cell without checking the contact.

“Hello?” I croak out, diving into an empty break room.

What I wouldn’t give to hear Will’s voice right now even though I know he’s the last person I should be speaking to.

“Drew? It’s Vesper. Are you okay and free to talk?”

By the sound of her broken-up voice, I should be asking her the same thing.

“Sure,” I push out quickly, trying to hide the day I’m having.

“I guess my call is out of the blue, given we haven’t really spoken since we exchanged numbers that day in the bar, but ...” She goes quiet and then sobs.

Vesper isn’t the type of girl to cry. Whatever day she’s having must be worse than mine.

“No, no, you’re fine, babe,” I say, setting my laptop down on a table and taking a seat. The view over Seattle from this room is one of my favorites. I love watching the world go by beneath me. “What’s going on?”

I hear a door close before she sighs heavily.

“I didn’t know who to call, but then I remembered you said I could always talk to you. I figured I could trust you not to say anything ...” She trails off, and I know she’s seeking reassurance.

I place a palm over my heart, remembering something Marley and I used to swear when we were younger. “Girl secrets are always safe with me.”

Although I can’t see her, I’m sure Vesper is smiling when she says, “Thank you, Drew. I just needed an ear to listen.”

“Is everything okay?” I ask after a beat.

Another sigh. “Not really—well, at least not at the moment anyway. I broke up with Kane and—”

“Who’s Kane?”

“Oh.” Vesper chuckles softly. “I didn’t realize I never gave you his name. Kane is—was—my boyfriend.”

“Silas’s brother?” I inquire, knowing that he must be.

A short stretch of silence falls between us before she replies, “Yeah, Silas only has one sibling.”

My heart aches at the sadness in her tone. “I’m really sorry you guys didn’t work out. Who ended it?”

“Me.” Vesper’s reply is clear and concise. “Trouble is,” she adds, “now I’m temporarily living in a hotel, and I have an ex-boyfriend blowing up my phone, wanting to patch things up. I really don’t want to go back there with him. He’s texted me twice while I’ve been on the phone with you.”

“Oh jeez ...” I wince, wondering how to word my next sentence. “Babe, can I ask you something?”

“Sure.”

I gaze out of the window and see a helicopter flying past in the distance. “Is Kane an asshole? I get a hunch that you might be better off without him.”

She blows out a humorless breath. “How did you guess?”

I shrug a shoulder. “Like I said, just a hunch.”

More silence falls on the conversation, and I swivel in my seat to check the clock on the wall behind me. I really need to get back to my own shitty day. Equally, I don’t want to leave Vesper when she needs someone.

“When is your next night off?” I ask her.

She chuckles. "I have a habit of working seven days a week since I need the money, but I actually took tomorrow off so I can try and sort my life out."

Relatable.

"How about we meet for dinner, my treat? There's a cute Italian restaurant just down from my place, and we can talk more there."

"Drew, I can't let you pay for me," she protests.

"Tough," I bluntly retort, which pulls another chuckle from her and a surprising smile onto my face. "Tomorrow at seven p.m."

"Hmm ..."

"Vesper," I warn, "I won't accept no for an answer."

"You know, I didn't have you down as a bossy one, but now I can see how you keep those hot-blooded pro athletes in check." She pauses for a moment. "Speaking of, how are things going with a certain hockey player?"

Butterflies swarm my stomach whenever I think of him.

"I'll fill you in tomorrow night. I'm in the office, and it's hard to speak freely."

"Ooh," Vesper sings down the line. "Now I have to show up tomorrow. I need some tea to go with the free meal you're offering."

I burst out laughing right as the break room door swings inward, and Colton appears in the doorway.

Great freaking timing. My colleague just made a formal complaint about me, and how do I react from his perspective? Laugh.

"I need to go," I tell Vesper. "I'll text you the restaurant's address and make a reservation."

She takes the hint from the urgent tone in my voice and ends the call.

"Drew, do you have a minute?" Colton thumbs behind him.

I pick up my laptop and stand. He doesn't look mad, but then again, I don't think I've ever seen Colton lose his cool.

"Sure," I say. "Do I need to make any notes or just bring myself?"

He smiles warmly and holds the door open for me. "Just you will be fine."

Radio silence from Drew isn't unusual, but today, it has me worried. Something doesn't feel right, and I don't have the patience to wait for a reply to my last text that may arrive in the next five minutes, hours, or if I know my girl, possibly even days.

I know she's busy working on a deal with a luxury watch brand for me, but I expected at least one formal email, reaffirming the terms my agent accepted an hour ago.

"You know, I don't especially like being partnered with you either. But your face looks like we just lost the Cup in the final period."

I side-eye Tristan and get back to spotting him. It's like Coach is finding any excuse these days to pair us up in the hope that we'll become friends.

Never going to happen.

"I've got a lot on my mind, is all," I grumble under my breath, taking the weight from my teammate when he raises the bar above his head to complete his final rep.

Keeping his back to me, he sits up and straddles the bench, flexing the muscles in his back.

"If I had landed the kind of deals you are in my rookie year, I'd have at least been grateful for the opportunities instead of standing there"—he swivels to face me and picks up his water bottle from the floor—"acting like an entitled, spoiled brat who thinks he should have everything handed to him just because his last name is Jones."

I lower the bar back onto the rack, briefly contemplating how many games I'd be benched for if it accidentally crushed his neck the next time I spotted him.

“You really believe you’ve got me all figured out, don’t you?” I ask in a callous voice, not caring if Coach, Silas, or any of the other guys in the gym overhear our exchange. I’m not the one behaving like an asshole right now.

For once.

Tristan just smirks at me, one that reaches his ears. “I don’t like you, and I never will. The fans might see you as this golden boy who can do no wrong, but I know who you are beneath that bullshit smile of yours.”

I lean against the weight rack, crossing my ankles casually. “If you hate me so much, then why not put in for a trade? There’s still time before March. You could be across the country in a matter of months.”

Swinging one leg over the bench, Tristan stands in front of me.

I edge closer and look down at him, just so he’s reminded of our height difference.

“Talking of moving on, did you hear the latest news about Candice?”

I don’t let him see the panic as it rises inside me.

“No. What about her?”

He takes another sip of his drink, holding his smirk before he turns and walks off.

“What about her?” I repeat.

Tristan pauses, lifting a shoulder, like he’s loving the upper hand. “I heard that she’s handed in her resignation. Something about history with a player making her feel uncomfortable.”

I don’t need a gym mirror to know that all the blood has drained from my face.

“The player Candice is referring to couldn’t be you, could it?”

I narrow my eyes at Tristan. This isn’t the first time he’s accused me of messing around with Candice. “Your jealousy is really starting to show. I guess I’d be envious, too, if a rookie rolled into town and started collecting points like candy. Being shown up as an average player has *really* got to sting.”

Tristan takes a step toward me and then stops, attention focused over my left shoulder.

“Will, I need to talk with you in my office.”

Coach’s blue eyes impale me as I turn on my heel to find him standing directly behind the weight rack.

How long has he been there, and what the fuck has he heard?

“Sure,” I quickly respond, voice light, like I have nothing to hide.

I don't like the way he's looking at me right now, and I suspect it has everything to do with what Tristan just said.

"Good. See you in five minutes."



A NEW FAMILY PORTRAIT SITS ON THE CORNER OF COACH'S DESK WHEN I slide into a seat opposite him and dump my training bag down on the floor.

"I need to say something." I decide to break the ice quickly.

He shakes his head, refusing to even look at me.

"I can explain what happened with her and set the record straight," I continue.

Coach holds up a hand. "At this point, Will, out of respect to you and your family, I think it's best if you stop talking."

I furrow my brow at him. Why would what happened with Candice implicate our personal history?

"I don't understand," I reply.

Coach throws me a look similar to the ones I've received from his daughter. "Don't play dumb with me, Will. You know exactly what you're doing."

I fall silent, genuinely disturbed by where this conversation is headed. I sure as shit don't think it has to do with Candice anymore.

Coach clicks his tongue and sits back in his chair, pushing away his keyboard and paperwork on the desk in front of him. "For the purpose of the next few minutes, I want to be really clear—whatever is said between us stays between us. And that includes me keeping this from my wife because"—he blows a breath into his cheeks—"she'll lose her mind if I tell her what I've witnessed. You got that?"

His intense gaze holds me in place before I nod once.

"Are you into my daughter?"

I knew it was coming, but Coach's question still hits me square in the chest.

Into her? No.

Falling for her? Yep.

I clear my throat to rid the tension building in it. "Why would you ask me that?"

He looks frustrated at my question, but I need him to answer it and clear up where his suspicions originated.

Did Drew say something, and that's why she's been quiet? Did Coach hear about my hookup with Candice, and now he's convinced I'm moving on to the next workplace fling?

He lifts a brow. "I'm not an idiot, Will, so don't treat me like one." He leans forward on the desk. "At the gala, I managed to convince myself that you were staring at Drew because she was dancing with Tristan and you wanted to make sure that she was okay." His jaw tenses, eyes turning a darker shade of blue. "But then I had a front-row seat at Jensen and Kate's place. And let's not even go there with that shit you pulled against the Blades. Did you think that celebration was clever, or do you just like playing games with the press?"

A thousand possible responses race through my mind. If left up to me, I'd own my feelings and confirm them to Coach right here and now. The only thing holding me back is Drew and what she wants her parents to know. After all, she didn't tell Coach about us. He worked out my attraction to her for himself.

"*Completely fucking see-through.*" Mason wasn't wrong when he said I was transparent at the gala.

"What do you want me to say, Jessie?" I reply, sitting back in my chair and crossing my arms.

He doesn't react to my use of his first name. In fact, he doesn't say anything at all.

I study him closely for a few seconds, trying to work out what's going through his mind.

In the end, I do what I've always done best and just say it because I wasn't scared a few weeks back and I'm still not scared to admit it today. "I'm attracted to Drew."

Pushing his chair back, he stands suddenly, hands planted on the desk between us. "I fucking *knew* it, Will!"

I gaze up at him, tongue swiping across my bottom lip. He's mad, and I don't blame him. From his perspective, all I want from his daughter is a fun night between the sheets.

I want everything with her.

"Back off, right now," he bites at me.

"Why?" I counter. "Tell me why."

He scoffs like it's obvious. "Because you'll fuck up her career, is why!" He starts pacing the room, sliding a hand down the side of his face. "She deserves ..." He trails off and stops pacing, head falling between his shoulders, just like my dad.

"She deserves better than me?" I quietly finish for him.

He doesn't move his head when his eyes find mine. "You know I love you, Will. From the day you were born to the moment you walked through this door, I've cared for you and your career."

"But I'm still not good enough for your daughter?" I press. "Someone like me, with a reputation for fucking women around, I could never be good enough for an amazing woman like Drew."

He looks regretful. "My daughter has the right to date who she wants, as do you. Look at everything Mia and I fought through to be together." His hands slide into his pockets as he exhales. "But pursuing Drew when you know that it could fuck up her career is where I struggle to support whatever it is you both have going on. It's where the respect I have for you is tested to its limits."

Attention everywhere but on my face, he retakes his seat in front of me.

"Has ... anything happened between you both?" He's almost wincing as he asks the question, and now I'm truly torn on how to respond.

"Maybe that's something you should be asking your daughter."

"Jesus fucking Christ!" he blows out, inner wrist banging against his temple. "How could you both be so goddamn stupid?!"

"I never said that—"

"You don't need to say any more, Will!" he lashes out, panic laced through his voice. "Does anyone else know?"

I shake my head because I'm not about to pull Mason into this. "No."

Coach blows out a relieved exhale. "Well, that's something at least."

"I know you probably don't want to hear this right now, but—"

"I don't want to hear another word leave your lips for the foreseeable future," he snaps at me again.

"Fucking tough," I bite back, pushing back my own chair and standing this time.

When his jaw pops open, I know I finally have his full attention. At least for a few minutes.

"I'm not who you think I am, Jessie," I say, my tone and body language much calmer now. "And I'm not going to stop seeing your daughter."

He sneers at me, “Your dad would be really fucking disappointed in your lack of professionalism.”

I crack my neck to one side, thinking over Dad’s advice. “I’m not sure I agree with you.”

He snorts a sarcastic laugh. “If this getting out wouldn’t leave Drew jobless, then I’d bench you right now.”

I nod once, voice still even. “If that’s what you need to do, then go ahead and do it.”

He throws a hand up, voice rising higher. “Are you not listening to a word I’m saying, Will?! Or are you too fucking cocky to recognize how your actions are going to fuck up Drew’s life?”

“Maybe I’m just too fucking gone for her,” I reply.

Coach’s brows shoot to his hairline. “What did you just say?”

All I do is fucking smile. I smile at the way she wraps her legs around my waist and clings to me as I walk us around the room. I smile at the way her breath hitches right before I kiss her. The night we spent cuddling on the couch and the dirty things she did to me on the gondola. I smile because I know I’m in love with Drew Callaghan, and nothing can beat or change this feeling.

“Are you two dating?”

I swallow thickly, desperate to say yes, yet equally determined not to lie.

“I *want* to date her, but your daughter is smart and putting me through my paces.”

A proud smile traces his lips. If I’m ever lucky enough to become a father, Jessie Callaghan would make the ideal blueprint, alongside my own dad.

“She’s scared that the whole thing will blow up in her face. We’re both aware of the risks.”

Coach interlaces his fingers, deep in thought. “If you plan to carry this on, then you need to do the right thing and end your professional affiliation. Now.”

“I’m leaving that decision to Drew.” I roll my lips together. “And I’ll support her regardless. I won’t let her career be affected in any way.”

Coach looks doubtful. “You really don’t get it, do you, Will? The media will come for my daughter and First Line. She’ll never be taken seriously in her field again.”

“I’ll keep her safe, I promise,” I reiterate.

Bending down, I loop my bag over one shoulder, ready to leave.

“Will”—Coach stands as I reach the door—“does Drew know the depths of your feelings for her?”

I scrub a single hand across my jaw, feeling the weight of my emotions as they pool behind my eyes. “No. Partly because I don’t want to freak her out and make things more complicated and partly ...” I pull oxygen into my lungs. “Partly because I’m falling that damn fast. Each time I open my mouth to admit how I feel, the words won’t fucking come. It’s like my brain is incapable of doing my heart justice and ...”

I swipe quickly at my cheek, and Coach’s eyes soften.

“Your daughter is really fucking special to me, and I’ll do—be—anything she wants. I don’t recognize the person I was before I spent all this time with her, and I already like the man I am way more than the boy who first pulled on a Rogues jersey nearly three months ago.”

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. . .

Will

Sometimes, in life, everything goes right for you.

Like those car journeys where each stoplight goes green just before you pass through or when every touch I have in a game turns golden.

Thank Christ that tonight is one of those nights. The chances of gaining access to Drew's office building were slim, and I knew that, driving over here.

But when a guy who works in the same building buzzed me through reception and then a woman held the security door open for me before it slammed shut, I knew luck was on my side.

And it needs to be because Drew still isn't answering her phone, and following the conversation I just had with her dad, I need to talk to her more than ever.

Other than a few meeting rooms, the First Line offices are open plan and generally stark and bright. Not tonight. A single desk lamp in the far-right corner of the room is all that illuminates Drew's face as she types away on her laptop, bottom lip pinned between her teeth in thought.

Like I anticipated, she's the last one standing in the office, and I wonder how many nights she's stayed late and put in extra hours she wasn't paid for.

There's something so beautiful about my girl when she's like this—locked in and focused on her job. While I could lurk out of sight and watch her forever, a painful truth weighs heavy in my mind—this career means the world to her. If she didn't have me as her client, I have zero doubt that she'd be scoring big deals and have an inbox bursting with new inquiries.

Quietly, I move toward her, the sound of her typing growing clearer with each step. She still hasn't noticed me, and I can't help but grin at her inevitable reaction when she finally clicks that I'm here.

Another couple of steps, and I'm less than twenty feet away when the floor creaks beneath my left foot, and her head whips up, eyes wide.

"Hey," I quietly greet her, voice a little hoarse.

It's a couple of seconds before Drew's face breaks into a smile, and I stalk toward her, fingers itching to touch my girl.

She goes to stand from her chair, but I get there first, wrapping my palms under her ass so she can loop her legs around my waist.

Drew's breath wafts over me in sweet waves, and it's then I notice the empty mug of hot chocolate sitting by her laptop. She has an email from a huge French fashion brand pulled up on her screen, and a sense of privilege rolls through me. I get to hold this smart woman in my arms on the daily while she kicks ass on my behalf.

"Busy taking over the world?" I ask, nuzzling my face into her neck.

Her pulse point thrums against my lips when I set a chaste kiss there.

She just sighs, although it's more despondent than happy.

I sit her down on the desk, crouching between her parted thighs so we're eye level.

Today, she's wearing the light-blue suit she wore to the Repeat meeting in New York. Drew in a skirt is hot as fuck, but there's something about fitted pants and heels that just ... yeah.

Gliding my hands up and down her thighs, I softly exhale into the room. "Shall I interpret your sigh as the reason why you haven't been replying to my messages?"

Drew doesn't need to answer for me to guess that it is, and my heart sinks an inch in my chest. Did she hear about Candice leaving the team, or has Coach already convinced her to pull away from me to save her career?

"I haven't felt much like talking all day, if I'm being honest."

My thumbs rub anxious circles over her pants. "Why?"

Drew's eyes drop from my face to the floor, like she's ashamed of something. "You're looking at a First Line employee on her first official warning."

Fuck.

I tip her chin up to look at me. "Did Colton find out about us?"

Drew shakes her head slowly, and my heart kicks back into life.

“I think if that was discovered, I wouldn’t be employed at all, don’t you?”

Coach’s warning to protect Drew’s career bounces around in my brain.

“Then what happened?”

Drew’s shoulders slump. “Lydia fucking West is what happened. She made an official complaint about me not reporting Silas’s request to transfer to my management.” Turning animated, Drew randomly points ahead like she’s reliving the moment when it all went down. “In front of all my colleagues, she accused me of stealing her clients and then lodged a formal grievance. Obviously, Colton had to take it seriously because it is a breach of code of practice, but ...” Her eyes are narrowed in anger as she looks at me again. “As if I was *ever* going to go behind her back. I already told Silas that working together wasn’t a possibility. Lydia is out to get me, and this was an excuse to exercise the vendetta she’s had since I started working here.”

As the first tear runs a track down her cheek, my already-troubled heart cracks clean down the center.

How the hell am I supposed to tell Drew about her dad now? Or his comments about us stepping away from each other either personally or professionally? I know nothing about PR, but even I can see that the seismic deal she’s working on is enough to catapult her career once again. And that’s precisely why she’s still in the office at past eight in the evening.

We’re a team in every sense of the word, and I can’t—no, I won’t—be the one to shatter my girl’s dreams all because some fucking clause in our contracts says I can’t hold her like this or lie down next to her in my bed tonight.

“Baby, look at me,” I whisper, pointing at my eyes.

Drew’s glassy gaze reluctantly finds me.

“Hurt people hurt other people because it makes their shitty lives feel less painful for a few minutes.”

Drew sniffs and shakes her head. “But why me? Sure, it was a mistake not to report Silas’s inquiry, but I’ve only ever tried to be honest. When I joined First Line, I actually referred a client inquiry to Lydia because I thought she would be a better fit for them than me.”

A proud smile breaks out across my face. “Of course you did—because you’re beautiful inside and out, and that’s why I’m falling so fucking hard for you.”

Mouth agape, Drew stares at me for the longest moment before I nod once and kiss away all of the stress from today.

“Will ...” she purrs against my mouth. “Rule two in my revised list: The client cannot catch feelings for his publicist, no matter how amazing she might be.”

“Tough,” I argue, moving my lips over hers. Goddamn, she feels so fucking good. “I’m falling fast, and no one can stop me. I don’t want to be stopped until I’m on my knees, begging you to be my girlfriend.”

A delighted giggle rises up her throat, and I swallow it down like the simp that I’ve become.

“Y-you want to date me?”

I cup the back of her head in my palm and deepen the kiss, showing her how serious I am about us with my tongue. “Close your laptop and take my hand. Come back to my place and sleep with me. I don’t want your answer until the delicious ache between your thighs renders you powerless to resist me anymore. You belong with me, Drew.”

Her hands fall to my black training top, and I could scream at myself for halting her before she removes it.

“You don’t want the second time we fuck to be here. You’re too professional for that, and there’s no way I can take my time with you either.”

Her lack of protest confirms I’m right as she dips her fingers beneath my collar and finds the gold compass.

“I think it’s high time you told me when and why you got this. You weren’t wearing it last Christmas, and I refuse to go home with you until you tell me more.”

I drop my chin to look at the pendant as Drew twists it around in her fingers.

“Do you believe in fate?”

Inquisitive blue eyes continue studying the compass. “I guess. I’ve never really had an experience that’s caused me to feel strongly either way, but the older I get, the more I agree that everything happens for a reason.”

Reaching behind my neck, I unclasp the chain for the first time since I saw it in a jeweler’s window the day before my twenty-second birthday.

I hand it to Drew. She might as well keep it since it’s always belonged to her.

It wasn't expensive, and I wasn't out shopping, but I was instantly drawn to the store window. The second I saw it, I wasn't leaving without it.

"You have to promise me you won't laugh when I tell you this," I say.

Drew tips her head from side to side. "I'll try my best."

"Brat," I softly scold, going in for another kiss. "Back in February, I saw a tarot reader."

Drew's shocked face almost makes me laugh. "Seriously? Of all the things I expected you to say, that was not it."

I kiss her again. "I love it when I keep your smart-ass guessing."

She frowns and plays with my compass again. "Did the reader give you this?"

"No," I reply, taking the chain from her hand and securing it around my girl's neck.

"What are you doing, Will?"

I take a step back to appreciate how fucking beautiful it looks on her. "Gifting it to you because it's only ever been yours." Pulling my phone from my pocket, I open the camera and take a photo of her wearing it, determined that, in the future, the image will feature as my screen saver.

I set my phone down on the desk, and Drew shakes her head, voice a little wobbly as she says, "I don't understand. What has the tarot reader got to do with your chain, and why does it belong to me?"

I just smile, knowing that I'll likely tell her the whole story one day. "Patience, Baby. When the time is right, I'll explain everything. Tonight isn't that night."

She opens her mouth, but I silence her with my tongue, whimpering when I lace my fingers through hers.

"If you don't walk this cute butt out of here in the next thirty seconds, I'm going to throw you over my shoulder and carry you to my car. Your choice."

Drew melts into the kiss, throwing her arms around my neck. "Make me, Hotshot."

I growl because this woman makes me all kinds of crazy. "Fine. Have it your way."

Throwing her over my shoulder, I slap her ass and make her squeal as a preview of later tonight.

"Now hold still," I command, stalking toward the elevator. "The time to writhe around is when you're beneath me and I'm fucking you senseless for

being a disobedient rulebreaker.”

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Drew

The sound of my phone pinging on the nightstand causes me to roll over in Will's bed.

Eyes still closed—because I'm not a morning enthusiast after I was kept awake all night—I stretch my fingers across the mattress and find nothing but bedsheets.

Feeling lonely, I reluctantly crack an eyelid. Sure enough, the only part of Will left in the bedroom is his woodsy cologne on the pillows.

"Will?" I pathetically call out. "I need coffee to function."

At first, I'm met with nothing but silence until the faintest sound of music filters from beneath the closed bedroom door.

"Will?" I try again, voice still just as pathetic as before.

With no answer, I roll the other way in bed and grab my cell from the charging pad, smiling when I read Mom's sarcastic message.

MOM

So, apparently, I have this 21-year-old beautiful daughter named Drew. Have you seen her anywhere?

She's right. We've barely seen each other in weeks, and that isn't like me. I'm the biggest homebody in Seattle.

ME

She's still here, just insanely busy with work and life. I'm sorry.

MOM

All will be forgiven with a meal at our favorite Mexican place tonight. Shall I book a table?

I wince, knowing I can't make it and how disappointed she'll be.

ME

I'm actually meeting a friend for dinner tonight. She needs some girl advice, and I can't let her down.

MOM

When can you fit me into your busy schedule? I feel like since you've been working with Will, we've hardly seen each other. Remember to take a break, Drew. You can't pour from an empty cup.

If only she knew how busy Will has been keeping me. At some point, I know I need to tell her everything. Today isn't that day.

In truth, I need to talk to a lot of people about what's going on since the hookup arrangement is now so much more.

Last night, he asked me to be his girlfriend—or at least, he made his feelings really freaking clear.

Colton deserves my full disclosure, and if that means stepping back from being Will's publicist, then I need to bite the bullet and come clean.

Dread swirls inside me at the prospect of how my boss will react. There's a chance he'll fire me on the spot, but at least I'll have done the right thing.

No more secrets. No more sneaking around. No more worrying about the damage we could do to our families. I could step away from First Line and look for another job in PR without the whole world finding out.

But after Colton, the next person I should open up to is my mom. The woman whose arms have always been my safe space without fear of judgment.

With a lump in my throat, I type out another response to her.

ME

How about this Saturday night? I can book the Mexican place.

MOM

Just you and me?

ME

Yes.

MOM

Sounds perfect. I miss you so much. Don't forget to come home once in a while. Otherwise, I'll be showing up at your place, unannounced, just so I can get a glimpse of my baby girl. It's hard enough already with Marley over in Vancouver.

"Morning, sleepyhead." Will's smiling face peers around the bedroom door before his whole—and totally naked—body comes into view.

My mouth waters as I take in the finest male physique I've ever seen.

He slides into bed next to me, cupping my head in his huge palm.

Like always, I melt into his kiss, phone slipping from my hand onto the floor when every muscle relaxes beneath his touch.

I can't walk away from this. From him. I'm convinced there is no one out there who can make me feel the way Will does. No job could ever come close to this happiness whenever I'm around him or the fizz of the electric current each time we touch.

"About last night ..." I purr into his mouth.

The second he carried me into his apartment, he was inside me. Aside from my gasps and his name falling from me on repeat, we've barely spoken a word to each other in favor of letting our bodies do the talking.

This morning, I have plenty to say.

"You want to be my girlfriend?" Will chuckles against my lips, like he's manifesting the words he's desperate to hear from me.

I don't respond, and after a beat, he pulls back to look at me.

His full lips are swollen and red, and I reach up, running the pad of my thumb across the bottom one, loving the way his breath hitches in response.

"Don't play with me, Drew. I know we mess around a lot, but my heart can't deal with you—"

I cut him off with a kiss of my own, just like he's done so many times before with me.

"I'm not playing with you, Hotshot. If dating me is still what you want, then I'm all in."

All I get is wide brown eyes and silence.

"Say something," I plead, heart thumping at an erratic pace.

After what feels like forever, swollen lips curve into a familiar cocky grin. "Call me your boyfriend."

I blow out a laugh. "You're the wildest person I know, without a doubt."

Will moves on top of me, nudging my legs apart with his knee. I'm also naked and now incredibly turned on, thinking over what he might do with me next.

One hand dips beneath the bedsheets, and two fingers push into my pussy.

My jaw hangs open at the first stroke against my front wall. If I wasn't already falling for him, then I'd be stupid to walk away from his ability to please my body.

"Am I your boyfriend, Baby?"

My eyelids flutter closed.

So many emotions.

"Yes," I whimper out, now even more pathetic than earlier.

"Say that this pussy is mine," he croons, adding another finger to fill me.

"This pussy ..." I open my eyes and see nothing but pure adoration staring back at me. "It's yours."

Will pumps his fingers in and out of me, and I spread my legs like the needy girl I really am.

"I want to have sex with you. I need you inside me," I beg, knowing that I'm entirely responsible for the egotistical look on his face.

The bastard pulls out his fingers and licks them clean in front of me.

"That's just girlfriend cruelty," I complain.

"Girlfriend," Will whispers into my neck. "I love the way that sounds, coming from you, although I have bad fucking news."

I set a hand in the middle of his chest and push him upward. "Don't scare me with those kinds of statements. Did something get out about us?"

Will strokes a thumb across my cheek. "No, nothing like that. I think I left my phone in the locker room yesterday. I've been searching everywhere for it, and I can't remember where I last had it."

His eyes settle on the gold chain around my neck. The one he gave me last night.

"Wait. I took a photo of you wearing this before we left your office." He drops his head against my chest and sighs a relieved breath between my tits, causing me to giggle from the sensation.

He snaps his head up, delighted at how ticklish I am.

"I can grab it for you when I head into the office."

He shifts his hips forward, the head of his dick sliding just inside my entrance.

“And now I have the perfect excuse to spend tonight with my girl.”

I lift a suspicious brow. “William, did you plan this whole thing so I would be forced to return your phone?”

He rears back in mock hurt. “No. I genuinely forgot it. You have this effect on me, where I lose my goddamn mind around you.” Thick fingers tease my ribs as he fills my pussy.

I don’t know whether to laugh or moan.

In the end, I do both.

Ten minutes and another orgasm later, I’m sitting at Will’s kitchen island with a steaming mug of coffee, watching him make blueberry pancakes.

I’m dressed in one of his old college training tops while he is only allowed to wear a pair of black boxer briefs. These days, I prefer my breakfast with a beautiful view.

“I can bring your phone over after work, but I can’t stay overnight.”

Will rounds the island, muscles flexing as he spins my stool to face him. “You work way too late every night. You need to take it easy.”

I smile up at him, remembering the text conversation I had with Mom.

“I’m meeting a friend tonight for a meal. I can swing by with your cell on my way home to get changed after work.”

He pushes some messy hair behind my ear and whispers into it, “I’m going to pretend like I’m not jealous of this mysterious friend.”

I roll my lips together in amusement. “I’d be jealous if I were you.”

“Brat,” he softly scolds, playfully biting down on my earlobe. “Is this friend a guy I need to lay some ground rules with?”

I shudder and clench my thighs together at the sensation of his mouth. “I’m actually heading out with Vesper, the head bartender at Riley’s. We’ve gotten friendly, and she needs some advice after breaking up with her boyfriend.”

Will’s eyes scan my face. “What if I swung by your office with a change of clothes for you? I can grab my phone at the same time and head to the gym.”

I shake my head. “You don’t need to do that.”

“I want to.” His eyes fall down my body. “Shit. What are you going to wear to work today?” He grins, delighted with himself. “When I carried you

out of the office and ruined your panties last night, I wasn't thinking about this morning."

I pat his cheek mockingly. "A little like how I research a place before visiting, I'm always prepared with spare panties in my bag and a clean blouse in the bottom drawer of my desk."

"You're too good for me." Will kisses my jaw. "Let me swing by your place and bring you some clothes for tonight."

"You don't have a key to my apartment," I counter.

He shrugs. "Leave one with me and a description of the outfit you want to wear tonight."

I study him for a beat. "Are acts of service your love language, Mr. Jones?"

He kisses me gently. "When it comes to you? Acts of fucking everything. There isn't anything I wouldn't do for you. I do need you to do one thing for me if you could?"

"Of course."

He slides his tongue along my bottom lip. "I was scheduled to collaborate on the sponsorship announcement with Repeet this morning, and I'm leaving them hanging. In the absence of my phone, could you do the honors?"

Reaching across to the stool next to me, I pull my door key from my bag and hand it to him. Next, I pick up my phone from the kitchen island and open Will's Instagram.

He stands, hovering over me, swallowing hard when I'm met with the login screen.

"Did you sign out?" I ask him.

Intense dark eyes gaze back at me. "I updated my password and forgot to tell you."

"Was someone trying to hack you?"

He shakes his head and comes to stand behind my stool, arms wrapping around me as he rests his hands over mine so we're both holding the phone.

"Will, what are you doing?" I chuckle.

"Typing in the password," he whispers.

His thumb clicks the little eye icon in the password box, and when I see the first few letters, I hold my breath, then watch him type out the rest.

Iloveyoudrew!sayyoulovemetoo

"Oh my God."

It feels like I'm having an out-of-body experience when he hits the login button, and the post from Repeet pops into the feed, Will having already accepted the collaboration.

"You love me?"

My stool spins to face him and strong hands wrap under my ass as he lifts me into his body, and I assume the regular position around him.

"I love you, Drew," he reaffirms. "So fucking much. Maybe it's too soon for you to say it back, but when I jumped on my laptop this morning and accepted the post from Repeet, I figured it was time for me to tell you exactly what I'd been feeling for so damn long."

With our foreheads pressed together and my food likely ruined, I couldn't be happier.

"When I get into work, I'm going to tell Colton about us."

Will's face is full of shock. "Are you sure?"

I nod. "I've never been so certain of anything in my life. It's time we came out and stopped dicking around."

His lips are back on mine, and, God, I could do this every day for the rest of my life.

"Your dad knows how I feel about you."

I balk at him. Strangely, the only emotions I feel are relief and hope. Relief that Will is still alive despite my dad finding out. Hope that maybe we'll be accepted by our families or at least taken seriously as a couple.

"When?"

Guilt flashes in his eyes. "Only since yesterday. Initially, he went crazy at me, but then I told him to go ahead and bench me because I wasn't going to stop seeing you."

It feels like he's looking into my soul when he speaks again. "I also told your dad that I wouldn't let anything bad happen to you or your career. If you want me to be there when you speak to Colton today, then just say the word. I'll stand up in that stark-as-fuck boardroom and tell him that you're my girl and the best damn publicist in the world. I'll tell him that, one day, you will be wearing my ring."

Speechless. I'm utterly speechless.

"You are so your dad's son," I tease.

"I'm all Jones, Baby, and it's only a matter of time before you are too." Will starts walking us back to his bedroom, kicking the door shut behind him and tossing me onto the mattress.

I squeal and catch his face in my hands when he flops down on top of me.

“Fuck breakfast.” Our lips crash together. “I need to consummate you being officially mine.”

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Drew

I thought my appetite was impressive.
It has nothing on Vesper's.

As I sit opposite her in an Italian restaurant, she nails another slice of garlic bread and washes it down with a gulp of red wine.

"What?" she asks, eyes dropping to my full plate of food. "I thought you liked it here. The cannelloni is excellent."

She goes in for a green olive next. "And if you haven't already worked it out, I eat when I'm stressed, and I'm really stressed out right now."

We've been eating and talking about general shit for at least a half hour. I didn't want to press Vesper about Kane before this moment, but it feels like she's cracked the door for me to ask more.

Picking up my soda, I think through the best way to approach the subject of her ex. Mom and Dad have always encouraged Marley and me to trust our gut when it comes to people. If we get even the slightest hint that someone might be in danger, we cannot ignore it.

"I need to ask if you feel unsafe around Kane or intimidated in any way at all." I think back to his repeated calls during our short phone conversation yesterday. "Calling you multiple times in the space of a few minutes isn't normal. It's neurotic."

Vesper stops chewing and swallows her mouthful, sitting back in her seat as she observes me. Aside from a couple of other tables, it's quiet in the small restaurant tonight, and I wonder if she's going to give me a tiny glance into her past.

My friend looks off to the side before setting her palms on the green tablecloth. She looks classically Vesper tonight in a maroon sweater dress

and knee-high black leather boots. Her hair is styled in a similar way to mine—straight and sleek.

“Kane struggles to respect my boundaries. Things between us have been difficult for a while and he showed no signs of changing in the relationship, so I decided to end it.”

I pop a piece of mushroom ravioli into my mouth, chewing and nodding at the same time. “It’s easy to fall into a cycle because we think it’s the safest route for us at the time when, actually, the relationship was over way before.”

Vesper mirrors my nod. “I considered moving back to Cincinnati to be with my sister, but I love my job at Riley’s, and I don’t want to give it up. The money is ... okay, although it’s the customers I enjoy interacting with. Being the manager, I have the flexibility to create new cocktails whenever I want.”

I cock my head to one side. “Then don’t. Stay in Seattle.”

She blows out a cynical breath. “Yeah, sure. Do you have an extra two thousand dollars a month hiding somewhere that I can use for a basic one-bedroom place?” She pauses and picks up another piece of garlic bread. “Wait, no. Actually, of course you do. Your dad is a multimillionaire, and I’m not at all jealous.”

I snort a laugh and consider asking about her parents. She’s already spoken about her sister. Before I get a chance, Vesper carries on talking.

“Seriously, babe, I barely made rent while sharing the load with Kane, and I spent all day today searching for affordable accommodations.” She shakes her head, gazing out of the large window set behind me, like the darkened street holds the answers to her financial predicament. “The only long-term option for me is to move in with roommates, and we all know how that type of arrangement ends.”

“How?”

She quirks a brow at me. “Well, the last time, the guy I lived with tried to bone me. I’m down for saving money on rent, but not if it means sleeping with the landlord.”

A couple of seconds pass before we both fall over laughing, and instantly, the mood shifts to something lighter.

For the next twenty or so minutes, we finish up eating and order dessert. Vesper goes with a crème brûlée, and I opt for cheesecake.

Obviously.

My fork hovers over the cheesecake when the words, “Why don’t you move into my place?” leave my lips.

She looks horrified. “Don’t say crazy shit like that. You barely know me.”

I shrug and dig into the strawberry cheesecake, warmth flooding me when I recall the way I ordered dessert for Will that time. I only saw him a couple of hours ago when he stopped by the office with some clothes and picked up his phone. I already miss him.

“You know me better than a stranger who may or may not try to hump you. I promise not to put the moves on you in the middle of the night.”

Vesper smirks and leans forward, pointing her spoon at me. “Only because you’re too busy rolling around in bed with the hot Rogues rookie.”

I flush like a schoolgirl. “I can neither confirm nor deny.”

She sits up straight and eyes me. “What’s the latest in your love life?”

Just like that night in Riley’s, when I blurted details about Will failing to show for our meeting, I feel a similar sense of ease in front of Vesper.

Which is why I offered her my spare room a minute ago.

“We’re ... dating.”

Slapping a palm across her mouth, Vesper gasps behind it. “Seriously?”

I nod and take the biggest bite of cheesecake, anxiety rolling through me. I still haven’t told Colton about Will. At lunch, I was primed to enter his office and lay it all out when a serious PR issue broke for one of his best clients.

“Seriously,” I confirm. “This morning, he told me he loved me.”

She drops her palm, and it slaps against the table, making one of the servers jump. “Holy shit! Girl, why aren’t *you* moving in with *him*?!”

Try as I might to fight back the smile as it spreads across my face, I fail miserably. “Because it’s really early in our relationship, and as it stands, I’m his publicist, and I definitely shouldn’t be sleeping with him, let alone shacking up with him in his penthouse.”

A mischievous grin overtakes her expression. “Secret relationships are the best. I love reading about them in romance novels.”

The fact that I didn’t have Vesper down as a romance reader will have to take a back seat in this conversation because all I can think about is Silas Stanton and her obvious intrigue in him.

“Is that why you blush every time I mention the Rogues captain?”

Guess what. Vesper’s cheeks turn a rosy shade of pink.

“Anyway”—she clears her throat—“about you offering to—”

“Oh, no!” I declare. “No chance are you getting away that lightly. I want to know when I can expect a six-foot-five, blue-eyed hockey player knocking down my apartment door for sexy fun time with my new roommate.”

Vesper’s own blue eyes grow wide as she glares at me in disbelief.

“Excuse me.” A petite woman with ash-blond hair approaches our table, bottom lip pinned nervously between her teeth.

We both pause our conversation and smile at her. She’s pretty, with green eyes that turn different shades the longer I look at her.

“This is really embarrassing actually,” she says, thumbing behind her toward the restrooms. “But my friend already left, and the tampon machine in this place has run out, and I didn’t anticipate ...” She pauses, and her cheeks turn pinker than Vesper’s. “Well, I didn’t anticipate starting my period. My cycles are all over the place at the moment, and I wondered if ...”

I swear I can hear a French accent when she speaks. Maybe she’s visiting on vacation, and she didn’t pack any supplies. Either way, we can all relate to that moment when you head for a pee and get a whole lot more than you bargained for.

Vesper immediately holds up a hand, the other reaching down to pick up her purse. “Girl, I got you. CVS was having a sale on tampons, and I stocked up. Do you need mid-flow or something not to be messed with?”

The girl smooths a hand down her long hair, eyes flicking between us. I get why she’s shy. I would be if I approached two random people and asked them for a tampon.

Vesper’s eyes soften as the blond girl’s fill with unshed tears.

“Hey,” I say, reaching out and running a hand down her forearm. “Honestly, it’s okay.”

Vesper takes out her phone and wallet and hands over her purse to the girl. “Use what you need and bring it back to me when you’re done. Truly, it isn’t a problem.”

She tentatively takes the bag. “Thank you so much. Without giving you my whole life story, I’ve had my head up my ass these past few weeks, and I should actually be back in northern France right now, but I’ve been staying with a friend, trying to work out what to do about my failing

marriage.” A tear tumbles down her left cheek. “Kindness like this sets me off all over again. I think I’m just hormonal.”

So, she is French, even if she speaks perfect American English.

Vesper studies the girl for a moment. “You look familiar. Have you ever been to Riley’s Bar?”

The girl’s eyes light up. “Oh my God! You’re their new bartender, aren’t you?”

Vesper nods and gives me a quick glance, like this impromptu exchange is precisely why she loves her job so much.

“I am.”

Vesper continues talking with her, and I zone out when my cell buzzes next to me on the table, lighting up with a message from Will. He knows I’m out tonight, and we agreed to talk in the morning.

A wave of dread washes through me as I open it up and read while Vesper continues rambling about cocktails.

WILL

Hey, Baby. Can you call me ASAP? There’s something really urgent I need to speak with you about.

ME

I’m still in the restaurant. Can it wait?

His reply takes less than five seconds to land.

WILL

Really, no. But I need to explain to you on the phone first.

Whenever I speak to my boyfriend, every nerve feels like it’s alive with excitement. This time, it feels like they’re on fire with worry.

I turn back to a delighted Vesper as the blonde girl heads to the restroom.

“Well, how about that?” she muses. “Her name is Eloise, and I served her the best Manhattan she’s ever tasted.”

I know she wants me to smile, but I can’t.

Her eyes drop to the phone still in my hand. Will’s message is open, so she can read it.

“Oh shit, what’s going on?” she asks, waving to attract a server’s attention. “Could we get the check, please?”

“If Will is flipping out over something, it has to be bad,” I whisper in such a small voice that I’m not even sure she heard me.

Vesper begins frantically typing something on her phone.

“What are you doing?” I question.

“Calling a cab.”

“I can give you a ride home,” I tell her.

She laughs darkly, and instantly, whatever Will has to say doesn’t seem as drastic compared to the bullshit this girl is going through.

“That would be great, babe, if I actually had a home.”

“No,” I insist. “You can come back to my place.”

Vesper silently protests, but I set a hand over her phone screen, blocking her from calling a cab. “Take the offer to live with me for however long you need or at least until you can find a place of your own.”

When she pulls a deep breath into her lungs, I know accepting help isn’t easy for this girl, even if she knows it’s the sensible thing to do. Realistically, it’s her only decent option.

“Are you sure? I don’t want to intrude on your personal space.”

I nod just as Eloise reemerges from the restroom. “I’m sure. Also, I own a Boston shaker, so you can whip me up one of your special cocktails to numb the impact of whatever shit is about to be laid on me in the next few minutes.”

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Will

I'm around a hundred yards from the restaurant Drew told me she was meeting Vesper at when her call finally vibrates in my pocket.

"Baby ... I'm at the Italian place. Are you still there?" I gasp down the phone and not because I basically ran from where I'd parked my car, but because I can't fucking breathe regardless. Each time I inhale, it feels like razor blades are caught in my lungs, throat constricting with every swallow.

I don't know how to tell her.

Because I sure as shit can't show her the screenshots, which are now circulating all over the internet.

I'm about to ask again if she's still at the restaurant when I grind to a halt in front of its huge glass window and find my girl standing, staring at me with watery eyes so big that they could be entire oceans.

With the phone to her ear, she looks straight through me, mouth open, but no words materializing.

Face-to-face, we stand on either side of the glass. Vesper is sitting at the table behind Drew and looking deeply worried for her friend.

"H-how did our private text messages get leaked onto the internet, Will?"

Her voice is broken, a little like how the glass separating us will be if I don't get my arms around my girlfriend in the next second.

Truthfully, I'm not certain how messages got leaked, although I have a pretty fucking good idea who is responsible for throwing us under the bus.

"We need to get every post taken down. Every screenshot." A tear escapes Drew's lashes, trickling down her cheek. "Every reshare."

I shake my head, hating myself for saying this. I promised to keep my girl safe, and I'm failing, like a fucking loser. "I just spoke with Colton and my agent. They said it's now impossible to contain."

Drew's head lolls forward, and Vesper shoots off her chair, pulling Drew into her chest.

Hitting End on the call, I push through the restaurant entrance and make a beeline straight for her.

She pulls back from Vesper and flops into me. "Get me out of here—right now," Drew pleads between sobs.

Heartbreak isn't something I've ever experienced. Until this moment.

With one arm still looped around Drew, I reach into my back pocket for my wallet.

"Sir, there's no need to settle the bill. This one is on the house. Miss Callaghan is an excellent customer of ours, and we are all huge fans of yours."

I nod my appreciation at a dark-haired guy, who I assume is the manager, and lace my fingers through Drew's.

Stepping out into the cool night air, we keep walking. Vesper tails us a few paces behind. She's carrying Drew's jacket and purse and trying to give us some privacy, which I appreciate on a day when it feels like the whole world is judging us from their misplaced moral high ground.

When we round a corner onto a calmer street, Drew stops walking and looks up at me from beneath my arm. Eyes now red, they contrast with pale skin. "I think I'm going to puke."

She takes a step back from me before she heaves once, twice, and empties her stomach all over the sidewalk.

I try hauling Drew into my arms so I can carry her the rest of the way home when she steps back again, one hand out in front of her.

"Wait. The messages must've come from your phone. I have multiple secure passcodes set on mine, and our text chat is locked down. I never leave my phone unattended and ..." Her rambling fades to nothing but silence, face paling further. "Last night. Your phone."

I shake my head. "No. I don't think that's when it was hacked. And I should've been more careful with security and listened to you when you warned me about easy-to-guess passwords."

Trying to swallow past the lump in my throat, I attempt to gather Drew in my arms when she looks at me in horror.

“Will, please tell me you changed your password from those goddamn jersey numbers.”

Guilt charges through me like a freight train leaving the tracks. Deep down, I know the leak couldn't have come from Drew's cell because she's too careful and I'm too fucking laid-back to listen to her advice when she warned that I was being lax with online security.

“*Tell* me you aren't that fucking stupid, William,” she bites into the freezing fall night, big puffs of air filling the space between us.

“Drew ...” Vesper approaches her from behind, hanging my girlfriend's jacket over her shoulders. Vesper's eyes find mine before they rest on the back of Drew's head. “We need to get you home so we can talk through the best way forward.”

“Let me take you—”

“No!” Drew bites out at me, eyes ablaze with rage. “I'd say you've done enough with being a careless asshole, wouldn't you?”

It feels like my molars might snap when I clench them together.

She's right; I fucked up. And there's nothing I can say or do right now to make her feel any better.

“Fuck!” I yell toward the sky, white-hot rage tearing through me.

“If you don't think your phone was hacked last night, then when do you think it was?” Drew whispers, now shivering beneath her jacket.

She's in shock, and it's all because of me.

“The only time I leave my phone is in the locker room.”

Drew presses her lips together. “Are you suggesting that Tristan is behind this?” She shakes her head. “You guys might not get along, but he wouldn't—”

“He could, and he would,” I cut her off and immediately regret it, desperate to set a palm on her hip.

I reach out, and Drew steps back again.

“My career is over,” she declares in a broken voice. “And I let it happen, knowing that sooner or later, this whole thing was going to blow up in my face.”

“Our faces,” I correct, wanting her to know we're in this together and she isn't alone.

“No, Will.”

Drew wraps her arms around her waist, and that's when I see it—the disappointment in her eyes. An emotion I never wanted her to feel toward

herself or us when it came to the circumstances surrounding our relationship.

“We’re meant to be together, Baby. Nothing and no one can change that.”

When Drew doesn’t argue, the tiniest seed of hope blooms in the pit of my gut.

“Maybe we are ...” Her gaze drops to the ground before she looks at me again. “But that doesn’t mean I was right to risk everything I’d worked for just so we could mess around and have fun together.”

I open my mouth to speak as a car passes by, its headlights bouncing off the gold chain I only gave her twenty-four hours ago.

“I put everything on the line for us, Will.” Drew’s shoulders slump, hands hanging down by her sides. “And you couldn’t even update the goddamn passcode on your phone.” She blows out a disbelieving breath. “The irony is, I was supposed to fix your online presence and persona, and in the end, all it’s done is destroy everything I’ve worked for because you were—no, you *are*—incapable of following the rules.”

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Drew

DevastatedDino: *When you're that bad at your job that you have to bang your client to stay employed.*

DevastatedDino: *Golden boy of the NHL? Wake up, Rogues fans! The only passion Will Jones has is for his coach's daughter.*

DevastatedDino: *I'd sure hate to be Jensen Jones or Jessie Callaghan right now. THE HUMILIATION. I guess that's what happens when you spoil your kids enough that they walk all over your legacy.*

DevastatedDino: *First Line PR should distance themselves from this scandal, their disgusting employee, and their client. And by "distance themselves," I mean fire Drew Callaghan and Will Jones.*

DevastatedDino: *Didn't Drew graduate from college early? Not so smart after all. #justanothernotchonwillsbedpost*

There's no end to the posts from an anonymous account that was set up last night on every social media platform available. In the space of less than a day, they've accumulated over a hundred thousand Instagram followers and a similar number on TikTok.

The moment Will asked me to call him, I knew it had all gone very wrong. I knew I was finished, and I couldn't resist as I pulled up socials and was instantly hit with thousands of notifications and tags, all calling for me to address the rumors and confirm their validity.

DevastatedDino is the original poster and likely the hacker who managed to guess Will's pathetic excuse for a passcode. And judging by the way they're taking the time to respond to every single comment on each post they've shared, they aren't at all sorry about it.

"Drew ..." Vesper's soft voice is followed by a gentle hand over mine. She comes to sit next to me on the couch, attempting to curb my doomscrolling. "Girl, you need to stop looking at that shit, or you'll make yourself sick again."

"They shared every single message. The only one they left out is a naked picture Will sent to me and only because it would be pulled down as a community guideline violation. They have no shame. No fucking shame!" My voice doesn't feel like mine.

I know I'm in shock and that Vesper is right. Still, since we got back to my place ten minutes ago, all I've done is torture myself with the internet.

Instagram disappears, and Will's contact lights up the screen again.

I reject the call and push out a frustrated breath. I'm so fucking mad at him, but mainly at myself for being so damn stupid.

"Did I break up with Will back there?" Through sore eyes, I turn to look at Vesper. "I can't remember how we left it before we made for my car."

Locking my phone, Vesper takes it and rests it in her lap.

"Not officially, no. But you made it pretty clear that you're pissed."

She casts her eyes around my apartment, and all I want is for Will to show up here, unannounced, like he's done so many times before. Equally, I don't have anything good to say to him other than how fucking angry I am that, once again, he refused to follow my advice.

"It's your dad." Vesper interrupts my thoughts, offering the phone for me to take before she rises from the couch and makes herself scarce.

I stare down at the call, bile rising up my throat as I hit Accept and wait for him to say something.

"Drew, sweetheart, are you okay?"

The sound of Dad's voice rips an uncontrollable sob from my chest, and I lose it, a deep wail tearing from my throat. It feels like I've lost everything, including the man I risked it all for.

"Drew, it's your mom. We're both here, and we've both seen everything online. Where are you right now?"

"Are you at his place?" Dad asks, tone much harsher than when I first answered the call.

I shake my head even though it's pointless. "No. I'm at home with a friend."

I pull a huge breath into my lungs, and it feels like I might pass out.

"I want you to know we aren't mad at you, but we are very concerned. We want you to call a taxi and come home for a few nights," Mom pleads.

"No," I protest. "I'm not a teenager anymore, and I'm not going to run to my parents at the first sign of trouble."

Dad chuckles, but it sounds more dark than humored. "How did the messages get leaked, Drew?"

Vesper reappears, holding a glass of water out for me.

I offer her a tight smile and take a small sip.

"Drew?" Dad presses, and all I want to do is end the call.

"What's going to happen with Will?" I question, knowing Dad will understand exactly what I'm referring to—his future on the team.

"That's not your concern," he simply replies, sounding increasingly frustrated.

"He's my boyfriend."

"Oh, honey." Mom's soft reply makes me crave the safety of her arms.

"I'll deal with my player when I know my daughter is safe and okay," Dad grumbles. He doesn't mean for his voice to sound harsh, but it does. Whenever he's really worried about me or Marley, he comes off as mad.

I close my eyes, hating having to say this, but all too aware that my parents deserve full disclosure. Dad's reputation is also getting a hammering right now for his allegedly failing to control his players.

"We're pretty sure the leak came from Will's phone, and Will thinks the person responsible is Tristan Vaughn."

A sharp scoff rings down the line. Genuinely, this couldn't be worse news for Dad. One player and his daughter caught up in the scandal is bad enough. Two players, and he'll be lucky to hold on to his job.

"I'm really sorry, Dad."

"Hey, hey!" He immediately shuts down my apology. "I don't want to hear a single sorry from you, sweetheart. Yes, it's a mess, but I'd be a hypocrite to criticize you for making mistakes when I've made more than I can count in my life."

The migraine forming makes me want to puke again, and I take another sip of water before setting the glass down on the coffee table.

"Will isn't a mistake."

When Dad doesn't respond, I look across at Vesper. She's chewing anxiously on her perfectly manicured thumb.

"I'm not saying he is, Drew." Dad releases a forlorn sigh. "But that won't prevent the PR shitstorm from raining down on us all."

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Will

When Tristan picks up the puck for a breakaway, I almost feel bad for wishing he'd trip over his own skates and face-plant on the ice.

Couldn't happen to a nicer guy.

As it transpires, he tucks it in the top-right shelf and sends us up by a goal in the third period against the Scorpions.

From my position on the bench—where I've been the past two games and again tonight—I lock eyes with Dad, who's sitting ice level in the VIP area.

He's pissed with Coach for benching me, although he knows, deep down, that if he were in his best friend's shoes, he'd probably do the same thing.

Tristan skates by the bench, bumping fists with the coaching staff and the rest of the team. I swear he slows down as he approaches me at the end of the line, just so he can rub it in my face a second longer. With tonight's goal, he's only three points behind me for the season, and given Coach hasn't indicated when I'll next play, Tristan could be sailing past my points tally before Thanksgiving.

"I'd say my winger is the least of your worries," Silas says from beside me on the bench. His ice time has been reduced tonight due to a wrist injury he picked up at the end of the first period. He's been sitting next to me ever since, both of us barely uttering a word. "You look pissed that we just went ahead in the game, and that won't do anything for your public image."

Both hands braced on the stick I haven't used in fucking ages, I drop my head between my shoulders and bite down on the corner of my mouth guard. "I'm mad at everything right now."

The Scorpions win the face-off, and Silas keeps his eyes on the ice when he next speaks. "I like you a lot, Will. But seriously, what did you expect to happen? You were secretly dating Coach's daughter, who is *also* your publicist."

"I *am* dating," I correct my captain, lifting my head to look at him. "We haven't broken up."

Silas side-eyes me. "Have you guys spoken since it all blew up online?"

Anxious, I rip off my helmet and shove a hand through my hair, catching Dad's line of sight before focusing back on the game. It's been the hardest four days since I last saw Drew. "She keeps asking for space to think everything through, plus she's suspended from work, pending a full investigation. Fucking Lydia West is temporarily covering in Drew's absence, and I hate it. All I get from her is one-worded emails, like she's judging me too."

He nods his understanding. "And I assume you're giving Drew space?"

"Pretty much, yeah."

He twists his head to look at me, one brow raised beneath his helmet. "Pretty much?"

"Losing my girl isn't an option. If she wants a few days, weeks, or months, then fine. But I refuse to live without her."

Silas clicks his tongue.

"What?"

Elbows planted on his knees, he looks like he wants to say something, but then doesn't.

"Say it," I press.

He shakes his head, and I knock my knee against his.

"Say it."

"You know, just because you want something badly enough, it doesn't necessarily guarantee success. Sometimes, it's wise to walk away before serious collateral damage is done."

"You sound like you speak from experience," I reply, not entirely surprised if he is.

"There's ..." He pauses and adjusts the strap on his wrist. "There's this one girl who ... well, let's just say, she is my Drew Callaghan." He smirks at me. "But unlike my teammate, I know where the line is."

I smirk back at him. "Or you're too chickenshit to just go for it. She's probably sitting at home right now, wishing you'd make a move."

Silas scrubs a hand over his mouth. “You have no idea what you’re talking about. Just take it from me when I say, I know when it’s appropriate to go after what I want. I’ve made too many mistakes in life to keep making bad decisions.”

Mason slams the Scorpions center into the boards as Tristan switches out for a line change. He takes a seat at the end of the bench and bumps fists with Coach. I’m literally the only guy who can see straight through my teammate’s bullshit. Even Coach doesn’t want to hear my theory on how Tristan accessed my phone and humiliated his daughter, just so he could get at me.

Tristan peers down the line, and I sneer at him.

It’s only a matter of time before I find out the truth.

“Let it go, Will,” Silas casually warns me, eyes fixed firmly on the game. “The last thing you need is to get into it with your teammate and find yourself on the trade list.”

I tear my eyes from Tristan, hating that I’m the first to look away. “He was the one who posted our messages on social media.”

Silas shakes his head. The night Drew left me standing in the street, it wasn’t long before my captain was on the phone, asking what the fuck was happening. He’s now heard the theory about Tristan swiping my phone in the locker room at least a half dozen times, yet he still isn’t buying it.

“Believe it or not, Tristan values his career and place on the team way more than he does bringing you and your girlfriend down for having a secret relationship.”

I scoff. “He basically accused me of being the reason why Candice quit her job. I haven’t spoken to or even seen her in weeks.”

Silas’s head darts to me. “Quit? I just got a message from her last night. She said nothing about quitting. In fact, she just accepted a promotion to senior therapist.”

If I wasn’t sitting in a packed arena, I would take Tristan out right now.

“He told me that she’d left the PT team and claimed it was my fault.”

My captain clears his throat. “And why would he do that? Do you and Candice have a history?”

I close my eyes, thinking back to the disappointed look in Drew’s eyes that day she showed up at my apartment and discovered me hooking up with Candice instead of meeting her at Riley’s Bar.

Such a fucking jackass.

“You know what?” Silas continues. “I actually don’t want to know if you’ve played around with my PT. It’s none of my business.”

I bite down on the inside of my cheek. “My history is irrelevant anyway.”

“Why?”

Like a slideshow seeking to torment me for all the times I’ve let Drew down, my girl’s face flashes before me.

“Because this time next year, I’ll be a married man.”



ME

Hey, Baby, I don't know if you're at home right now, but if you are, can you head downstairs? There's a delivery waiting for you.

Only five minutes pass before Drew responds, although it feels like about five hours.

DREW

WILL. What am I supposed to do with all of this???

She attaches a picture of two large crates of chocolate brownie ice cream, and I can just imagine her face when she saw it—a combination of delight and pure disdain for my impractical gift.

DREW

My freezer isn't big enough.

ME

You could ... always store the rest in my freezer?

DREW

Is this your way of getting me to come over?

ME

No, that would be too manipulative for my style. I prefer the direct approach.

Stay in my bed tonight, Drew. It's been days, and I actually think I might be dying from withdrawals.

DREW

Withdrawals from what?

ME

You know they say death from a broken heart is actually a thing, right?

DREW

I can't come over. Besides, I have to be in the office first thing tomorrow morning.

ME

Colton's letting you come back to work?!

DREW

No, the opposite. I think I'm getting fired, which I absolutely deserve. He wants me to bring my office keys and laptop with me.

Sitting in Riley's Bar, Silas and Mason raise a beer to celebrate our first win against the Scorpions. Meanwhile, my heart sinks to the bottom of the soda I haven't touched.

ME

If Colton lets you go, he's making the biggest mistake.

DREW

I breached my contract, Will, and the internet is calling for me to do the professional thing and quit. One way or another, I'll be officially jobless tomorrow.

If it wasn't for Vesper moving in with me and paying half the rent, I'd probably go back home. Marley offered for me to move to Vancouver and start over.

ME

What are you going to tell her?

DREW

I don't know. The whole city seems to hate me right now, especially the Rogues fans. Lydia has inherited all my clients who haven't already pulled away from First Line. Colton doesn't deserve for his company to be dragged anymore. And I don't feel welcome in my hometown.

“Come on now, guys. I know my goal was wild, but let’s not make it the only topic for tonight’s conversation.” Tristan slides into the booth next to Mason, who rolls his eyes at his teammate.

Phone out in front of me, I start typing a reply to Drew.

“Careful what you say, rook.” Tristan’s annoying voice floats across the table. “These hackers could be anywhere, waiting for your next PR scandal.”

I drop my phone to the table with a thud, and from beside me, Silas rests a firm hand on my shoulder.

“Drop it, Tris,” Mason pleads in a maniacal voice.

Tristan just shrugs. “I’m wondering how many more lives Will Jones is going to get before the hockey world wakes up and realizes that he doesn’t have the same talent as his dad.” He leans toward me, and I can feel my lips as they tremble with rage. “Or how many off-limits women he’s going to screw over before the entire female population catches on to his fuckery.”

I’m instantly on my feet and standing in front of Tristan. He gazes up at me, cocky smirk reveling in my misfortune. More importantly, in my girl’s.

“Fucking around with my career is one thing. Messing with Drew’s reputation is a one-way ticket to hell.”

He blows out a laugh, and I lose it, grabbing his gray sweater by the neck and hauling him to his feet.

“Go ahead and laugh a little harder—I dare you,” I growl. “See what happens when you push me to show you a side of my personality you definitely won’t like.”

Mason’s out of the booth in seconds, hands planted on my and Tristan’s chests as we square up.

“Go on, admit it,” I spit. “You swiped my phone, guessed the passcode, and stole private messages between me and Drew.”

“That true?” Mason looks at Tristan. “Because, damn, man, if you did, then that’s really fucked up.”

“He spread bullshit about Candice leaving. Why not go the whole way and try to destroy people’s lives online?” I add.

“Christ, Tristan. Did you hack Will’s phone or not?” Mason tries to placate the rising tension with a genuine appeal for the truth.

I hold my breath, fists forming by my sides. If Tristan says yes, I’m definitely breaking his nose.

His cocky smirk stands strong as he eventually replies, “No,” in a steady, self-assured voice. “I’m many things, Will, but I’m not loser enough to care that much about your private life. Messing with you is satisfaction enough for me. You think I have the time to create a fake account, post, and reply to every comment?” He runs his tongue along his bottom lip. “I much prefer stalking your sister’s latest business venture. Do you think she’d want to interview me about my amazing performance tonight?”

I lurch forward, and Silas steps fully between us, facing me.

“If you hit him, Will, you’ll be warming the bench on the farm team.”

Fingers flexing by my sides, I seriously consider how good it would feel to teach this asshole a lesson he’d never forget.

My eyes lock on Tristan’s.

Mason looks between us both. “So, if Tris didn’t share the messages, who did?”

“I don’t know,” I confirm on a long exhale, brain spinning out over ways I can fix this for Drew. She’s all that matters to me. Without her, I’m nothing, and I know it. “But I have an idea to make all of this right.”

I take one step back, and Mason grabs my forearm, eyes wide with concern.

“Where are you going, and what the hell are you going to do?”

Shrugging off his grip, I snag my jacket. “Home, and it’s best if I don’t tell you. Trust me when I say, you don’t want to get pulled into this.” I grab my phone from the table and check for messages. Nothing. “I’ll see you at morning skate.”

Drew

The reception lights almost blind me as I step into First Line's offices early the following morning.

Just like the last day I was here, there's no one around, except our normally friendly receptionist, Dawn, who doesn't appear all that welcoming today.

Offering me a tight smile, she holds up a hand when I go to buzz in, using my fob.

"Sorry, Drew. Your fob won't work this morning. The system was manually updated the other day, and yours"—she looks more than awkward—"wasn't included in that update."

It's not Dawn's fault that I've been locked out of the building before being formally fired, but she sure looks at me like it is.

"It's fine," I say brightly, trying my best to alleviate some of the tension.

She buzzes me through the barrier, and before I've taken a single step toward the staircase, she winces.

"Actually, Colton has asked if you could remain down here. I'll let him know you've arrived, but he didn't want to make things uncomfortable for other staff members."

I smile again, although this one is less convincing. "Sure."

Nothing but five long minutes of total silence later, Colton's unmistakable footsteps sound down the staircase before he stands at the top of the last flight and ... grins at me warmly?

I must be hallucinating. I fully expected to be shown a brown box full of my things and then the door.

“Drew, it’s good to see you.” He takes the final few steps and comes to stand in front of me, both hands tucked into gray dress pants. “How are you doing?”

I gaze down at the black suit dress I’m wearing, feeling like an idiot for not going with the jeans and sweater I initially picked out this morning. Still, if I’m going to fall from grace, I might as well do it in style.

“I’ve been better,” I reply honestly. “The past few days haven’t been my favorite.”

He turns on his heel and leads me up the staircase of doom—which it shall now be known as—before using his working fob to enter the open plan office.

The familiar smell of paperwork was once a comfort to me. I loved being here, no matter how stressful the day turned out to be. Now, the scent rolls my stomach as I refuse to make eye contact with any colleagues who have already arrived. I don’t even glance at my desk since I don’t want to see all my things packed away and waiting for me.

Colton pushes the boardroom door open and holds it for me to enter. When I finally look ahead and see the projector set up and switched on, Will’s Instagram profile page lights up the darkened room.

Fuck. What’s happened now?

“Take a seat, Drew.” Colton’s voice remains warm, and now I’m really confused.

Downstairs, I suspected he was putting on a show for Dawn’s benefit, and now I’m wondering if he’s one of those people who acts friendly right before they totally lose their shit.

I take a spot in my usual seat and set my bag down on the floor next to me. He takes the one opposite, folding his hands together on a deep sigh.

I glance again at Will’s profile, noticing that his picture has changed from an action shot I selected when I first took over his socials. The new picture is one from when he was younger. He must be only sixteen in this photo, and I’m pretty sure it was taken by me one year at a Christmas party.

Blinking a couple of times, I push back the tears threatening to form.

“I’ve run through numerous ways I could conduct today’s meeting,” Colton begins talking. “How I could remind you of the fraternization clause in your contract, which clearly states romantic relationships with clients is strictly prohibited.”

I swallow hard, but don’t say anything.

Colton's professional expression softens a fraction, and my shoulders lower an inch.

"In reality, Drew, I know you don't need to be reminded of the rules. Since the day you walked through these doors as an intern, you've set an example for your colleagues, even to some of the more experienced members on the team."

I know Colton means every word, and I truly appreciate his kindness. That doesn't stop the next words from leaving me. If anything, his benevolence compels me further.

"It's okay, Colton. I value everything you said, but I want you to know it's fine, and I expect you to let me go. My actions were unacceptable, and I was already on a warning. You have to do what's best to protect your business and its reputation."

Colton looks at me, pensive eyes examining my face before he pulls his open laptop toward him and clicks the Message button on Will's profile.

I hold my breath when I see Will's face in his private messages.

"Last night, before I went to bed, I decided to torture myself once more and check social media." He hovers the cursor over the Play button set in the center of the video from Will. "Of all the messages I anticipated receiving, this wasn't one of them. Around twenty minutes ago, Will set this video live on all of his social media platforms."

Colton lowers the volume and hits Play, resting back in his chair as I sit forward in mine.

My palms sweat when the video begins with Will adjusting the camera in his living room and then taking a seat on his couch. He looks so handsome in black jeans and a white button-down shirt, open at the collar, but he's missing the gold chain I'm wearing right now.

I smooth my fingers over the compass around my neck, and Will opens his mouth. He isn't smiling, and his eyes are bloodshot and puffy.

"Hey, guys," he begins in a small voice, which breaks my heart. "Will Jones here, your favorite—or maybe not-so-favorite—hockey player."

I try to swallow, but it feels impossible; my mouth is so dry.

"I, err ..." He slides a hand through his tousled hair, appearing stressed. "I didn't plan on making this video, so I haven't made notes or rehearsed anything I'm about to say."

"Oh fuck," I voice my inner dread, and Colton softly chuckles.

“I guess, by now, a lot of you are already aware of and have likely formed an opinion on the events of the past few days.” Will braces his elbows on his knees, shirtsleeves rolled halfway up his arms. “I think it’s only human nature to be presented with a set of circumstances or a narrative and to believe only what we’re being told. A lot of the time, it feels safe to follow the crowd and tell ourselves that we could never make a mistake like that or be mortal enough to fall in love with the one person you shouldn’t.”

“Will ...” I breathe his name so quietly that I barely hear myself.

“But despite all of that and every single judgment being passed—even as I record this video—I am in love with Drew Callaghan. My publicist, my coach’s daughter, and my long-term family friend, who oftentimes thinks I’m a nightmare.” He chuckles to himself, and the first tear hits my cheek. “Being honest, she’ll probably ream my ass out for this video when she eventually sees it.”

Clasping his hands together in a praying motion, he rests his chin on his fingertips and gazes into the camera. I know thousands—possibly even millions—of people will watch this, but it feels like I’m sitting next to him on the couch. The lights are dimmed, and there’s no one else around while he speaks directly to me.

“To the Rogues fans, it’s time I leveled with you. When I was drafted to the team, I was bitter, maybe even pissed that I wasn’t destined to play for a prestigious team. I felt like I’d been screwed over, and that resentment spilled into my college years.” He pulls in a deep breath, and I do the same. “Looking back now, I’m not proud of the way I behaved online or the needless arguments I had with random people on the internet. But when I arrived in Seattle, I was still the twisted-up college kid who felt like the world owed him something.”

Colton turns the volume up on his laptop, attention shooting to me for the briefest second.

“A lot of you have spent the last few days pointing fingers at my publicist for fucking up the rest of our season because I’d no doubt end up benched—or worse, traded.” He leans toward the camera like he’s making an appeal. “I’m having the season of my life *because* I’m dating the girl of my dreams. Back in September, expectations weighed heavily on my shoulders. Every day, I was in the gym, analyzing my diet, performance, training schedule and growing increasingly neurotic over getting it right.

Drew changed everything for me.” His voice cracks a little as he finishes his sentence, and I swipe at my cheeks.

Reaching into his pocket, Will pulls out a scrap of paper, and I know what it is without seeing what’s written on it.

Our original list of rules.

“When Drew was assigned as my publicist, we were friends who had known each other for years, each of us trying to accomplish the crazy dreams we’d set for ourselves. The only difference? I was going about it in an unprofessional way, acting like I was some kind of *hotshot* ...” He smiles at the camera, and I know that reference is for me. “Drew went about her work in a methodical manner, writing a list of rules one night to focus my attention and to get me to quit the fuckery I was always caught up in. She secured a collaboration I’d thought was unsalvageable and curated a public image I honestly wasn’t deserving of. She was—and still is—responsible for so much of my success this season. For the goals you, as the fans, have celebrated in packed arenas. In Brooklyn, I dedicated a goal to her because *she is* the reason why I’d scored it.”

He swallows hard, and I release a sob for the both of us, head falling into my hands.

“Drew, if you’re watching this, Baby, I want you to know it’s all going to be okay. When I asked you to kiss me for the first time, I promised you that I wouldn’t let anything bad happen. This is me making good on those words. This is me, on my knees, saying I’m so fucking sorry for being careless with my phone. If you lose your career, then so will I—I’ll quit hockey, and we’ll run off into the goddamn sunset together. It’s pointless, tying my skates, if I don’t get to see you take over the world and make other athletes’ dreams come true with your unrelenting talent and work ethic. You are a *true* professional and someone who will always seek permission first. I’m proud of you, and I stand with you, with us. I stand by the love I feel for you, deep in my bones.”

He points to his chest and taps it a couple of times.

“That compass? You always wanted to know why I bought it. My dad once told my mom that she was his north. No matter which way she twists, turns, and tries to evade their truth, he’s pointing straight at her. They were meant to be together, Drew, and you are going to be my wife one day. That’s why I gave you the compass, and that’s why it’s always belonged to you.”

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. . .

Will

MASON

What a motherfucking speech!!!

SILAS

I'm on my third watch. For me, it's the part when he taps his chest and talks about the compass he gave Drew. I actually cried a little.

MASON

Are you serious?

SILAS

Yes. I mean ... tears may have appeared.

ME

Fuck off, both of you.

MASON

Hey, I was being genuine.

SILAS

Me too.

TRISTAN

Well, I think it was the biggest pile of horse crap I've ever witnessed. I'm going to bill you for the five minutes of my life I'll never get back.

ME

Only because you wish you were as romantic as me.

MASON

Do we think Drew's seen the video?

ME

I don't know. I posted it an hour ago, and I haven't heard anything as of yet. My best guess is, she's still in the meeting with Colton. I sent him the video last night, hoping he would see it before making any rash decisions about her job.

SILAS

And has he seen it?

ME

Yeah, but he didn't reply to me.

MASON

I'm so anxious that I'm sweating.

TRISTAN

Moving on to more important topics. Which shampoo should I use tonight? Bourbon or fresh pine?

ME

So, that's the overpowering smell I get whenever you're around. My two cents: use whichever fragrance will best mask your jealousy, just go easy on the quantity for the sake of my nostril hair.

SILAS

Moving on again ... let us know how everything plays out, Will.

MASON

And preferably today. Christ, I haven't been this stressed out since Ross mixed up Emily's name on Friends and accidentally called her Rachel.

MASON

My single is showing, isn't it?

SILAS

Nothing wrong with Friends or being single. But for fuck's sake, get yourself together, Mas.

TRISTAN

I don't need an update since I don't actually give a fuck.

Setting my phone down on the counter rather than biting back at Tristan like he wants me to, I head for the fridge but stop in my tracks and skid on the kitchen tiles when my cell starts vibrating.

I scramble to answer it.

“Drew?!” I exclaim, not knowing if it’s her, but praying anyway.

“No, it’s the other woman in your life.”

I slide onto one of the stools at my island and get comfortable.

We could be here a while.

“Did you see the video?” I ask.

Mom snuffles down the phone, voice barely above a whisper. “I did, and, oh my goodness, William, it was absolutely beautiful.”

“Tell him it was so cute that I puked a little in my mouth.” My sister’s sarcastic voice filters down the phone.

“June, don’t be so gross!” Mom scolds. “Don’t you have videos to edit for YouTube?”

June grumbles something I can’t make out before a door closes, and Mom continues speaking.

“First, you and your father kept the whole secret-dating thing from me, and now I wake up to find my son pouring his heart out to the whole world!”

I’m pretty sure if I were in the same room as her right now, she’d have her arms around me. I’m also pretty sure I have the best mom on the planet—and definitely the scariest.

“Shouldn’t you be at work?” I ask her, trying to sound like my whole fucking world isn’t falling apart.

She doesn’t need to witness her only son’s breakdown if I don’t hear from my girlfriend.

Mom puffs out a breath. “I don’t have any client meetings scheduled, and I’m trying to introduce one day a week for admin, I need to start taking it easy now I’m getting older and retirement looms. I’d actually get something done if your *sister* didn’t make so much goddamn noise.”

I attempt a pathetic laugh and check my phone when it vibrates.

Just a random email.

“Have you heard from her yet?” Mom softly questions.

I shake my head, knowing that Drew will be done with her meeting by now. “Nothing.”

“Will ...” Mom’s shaky voice trails off. “Did you ... did you really mean it when you said that you’d quit hockey if Drew’s career didn’t recover?”

I close my eyes, praying it will never come to that for us both, but mainly for Drew.

“Yes.”

I fully expect her to tell me I’m an idiot for making such a bold claim, so when she says, “I get it,” I open my eyes and stare straight ahead. “And I want you to know I have never been prouder of you than I was in that moment.”

Teeth dig into my lips as I press them together. I bite down harder, anything to prevent me from losing it on the phone.

That comes after Mom concludes that I’m okay.

“I anticipated this call to play out differently.” I chuckle without humor. “Like you telling me to issue an immediate statement, retracting my intention to quit if everything goes south for Drew.”

“Will, honey ...” Mom releases a forlorn sigh. “Did you forget what your grandparents were like?”

I just growl at the memory of Mom’s evil parents, Violet and Henry.

“All I have ever wanted is for my children to be happy, to love and be loved in return. Nothing—not a career, money, or social status—should ever come before integrity and what’s morally right. And from a woman’s point of view ...”

She sucks in a sharp breath, and I push back my stool, now pacing the living room with blurry eyes.

“Your statement was the perfect way to align your life with the woman who I just know you will marry one day. You showed that you two are a team and demonstrated her value in the most powerful way possible—you put your own heart and career on the line, just as she did for you. Your dad and I are so damn proud, and I know Jessie and Mia will be too. Even if he’s benched you, it’s because he has no choice but to follow team protocol.”

“And you’re slightly less intolerable in my eyes too!” June announces, obviously having reentered the room to berate me in a way that tells me she cares.

We don’t need lengthy conversations about how each of us is feeling. We instinctively know what the other needs.

Twin love at its finest.

“Fuck off, JJ.” I half laugh, half sniff down the phone.

Walking over to the large window overlooking Seattle on a bright morning, I think about where my girl is right now, praying she’ll stay here and not force me to chase her to Vancouver again. Marley and dickface Greg probably don’t have room for my ass on a permanent basis.

“I love hockey, and I will always love it. But watching my girl’s dreams end while I continue with mine? Yeah, no, that’s never going to happen. Every time I stepped onto the ice, I’d be thinking about the long nights Drew had worked herself into the ground. How she commanded a conversation with a brand and the caring way she looked after her clients’ needs. She’s incredible, Mom.”

“You actually are your father.”

Despite the sick feeling of dread I can’t rid from my gut, I burst out laughing right as there’s a knock at my front door.

“Why do you say that?” I ask.

Mom just blows down the phone. “You’re a boy obsessed with a Rottweiler attitude and a powerful woman has you on your knees for her. Just make sure you don’t go and get her unexpectedly pregnant—your father has a habit of doing that too.”

Drew

There’s this moment in between Will opening the door and us locking eyes for the first time in several days that melts away all the tension pulling at every muscle in my body.

“Hey,” I say quietly. “I was hoping you’d be home.”

He doesn’t hesitate, stepping forward and dragging me by the hips until I’m pressed against him, only my black suit dress separating our skin since my jacket is unzipped. He’s bare-chested and wearing dark green athletic shorts with the number twenty-five stamped across his right thigh, and I watch as the lines creased into Will’s forehead disappear.

“You once asked me if there was anything I couldn’t do.” He loops his hands under my ass and lifts me until we’re nose-to-nose. “Turns out, I’m fucking terrible at waiting for you, Drew.” He spins us around and kicks his front door shut, walking us over to the kitchen counter, where he sets me

down and cups my face in his hands. “Do you know how difficult it’s been to keep away? I’m not built to give you space. I’m built to serenade the shit out of you.”

I throw my head back and giggle. “You’re being very presumptive, William.”

A rogue grin spreads across his face. “In what way?”

I drop my eyes to his tented shorts, thick biceps twitching when I run my palms along them. “Pulling me into your body and standing between my thighs in such a provocative way. I could be here to break up with you for being a careless douche and putting us both through hell.”

His top lip quirks, perfectly aware that I’m messing with him. “Then tell me to stop touching you.”

I say nothing, and he moves his lips closer to mine.

“Tell me not to kiss you.”

I inch my mouth forward.

“Say you aren’t mine, and I’ll step away and let you leave.”

My breath hitches, and he notices.

“No, you won’t. I don’t think you’ll ever be able to let us die.”

Somehow, his lips move even closer to mine.

“Is that what you truly believe? That I could never let you go?”

My body hums right before I whisper, “Yes.”

“Such a clever fucking girl.”

Will’s lips caress mine, languid movements of his tongue unraveling any last knots of anxiety. I came here to talk when, really, all I want to do is kiss him. I needed to be back in his arms after the worst few days of my life.

“I need to know,” Will whimpers against my lips. “Now that I don’t need to pull on my sneakers and chase you, I need to know what Colton said.”

I rest my forehead against his and smile because I can’t help it. It’s impossible to not feel happy whenever I’m around this boy.

“I’m still on a warning, although I remain employed. He asked for my laptop and fob so he could run security updates on them. He also changed up the passcodes to enter the office building because he’s smart, unlike someone I know.”

He pulls back, actual stars dancing in his eyes. “For real?”

I nod once and drop my head into Will's chest, inhaling my favorite woody cologne that transports me back to Secluded Sips and endless hours of talking about nothing.

"I was convinced Colton would hand me a box of my things and show me the door. He didn't." Chin resting on Will's sternum, I gaze up at him. "He said the video you'd posted didn't change his decision to fire me because that was never his intention. What it did was make it a whole lot easier to justify keeping me to the world. Instead of hate and shitty messages and comments on First Line's social media, people are reaching out with compassion and understanding. They want to know when I'll show up to a game, wearing your jersey."

I set a kiss against his chest. "What you did for me was incredible."

Will cups the back of my head in his hand. "No, it wasn't, Drew. It was me doing what needed to be done. What was right and what you were entitled to. I might be a famous athlete, but I am *nothing* without you. You and me"—he motions between us—"we are the strongest team I've ever been a part of, and if I'm not next to you on the roster, then I don't want to be on anyone else's. And now that everyone knows how I feel about you"—he gives me a panty-melting wink—"you're fair game for me to love indefinitely."

Taking the chain he gifted me between his fingers, I drop my chin down and admire the compass. "Colton told me that when he first became a publicist, he had a secret relationship with his colleague. When it all came out, he discovered that she was only using him for referrals and so she could steal his ideas. His boss never fired him for misconduct. They gave him a second chance, and now he's a successful CEO. He also told me that you were a keeper, and he hopes you'll stick around as a First Line client."

"So long as I don't have to work with Lydia."

I sneer at the mere mention of her name, feeling sure that she's loving every minute of my anguish.

"Colton also spoke about taking you as his own client with me helping him behind the scenes. Your video sparked an influx of collaboration inquiries." I set a hand on his shoulder. "At the risk of your head growing even bigger, I think you might be more popular now than before people found out that we were dating."

Will brushes his lips gently over mine. "Do you know what else is growing even bigger?"

“You’re actually insufferable at times—you know that?”

He takes my bottom lip between his teeth, slowly pulling my jacket down my back.

“I know, Baby. But do you think you could suffer my dick for a while? It’s gagging for you.”

When he nips at my pulse point, I know there’s only one bed I’m sleeping in tonight.

“I could probably stand it for a short time, I suppose.”

His hands glide up my thighs, dipping beneath my dress before they halt abruptly when he finds me bare.

“Drew.”

“William.”

“Did you wear panties to the meeting?”

I nod once, a mischievous expression overtaking my face. “Of course. I’m not totally inappropriate. I removed them while riding the elevator to your floor.”

He practically chokes on his own breath when I pull a black thong from my jacket pocket and hand them to him.

“I think you’ve turned me into a bad girl, Hotshot.”

Will brings my panties to his nose and inhales, eyelids fluttering closed.

“Show me.”

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Will

With one firm palm on my chest, Drew pushes me back, and I collapse onto the mattress.

Fingers interlaced behind my head, I hold my breath as she glides the side zipper down on that hot-as-fuck black suit dress.

“Are you wearing a bra?” I ask, rising onto my elbows for a better view of the greatest fucking show.

Her mouth doesn’t answer my question as she lets the dress pool around her ankles.

Soft, bare skin begs for my tongue.

Climbing onto the bed, she straddles my thighs, pink manicured fingernails teasing the waistband of my shorts.

“Want to know a secret?” I tease.

When I lift my ass, she slides my shorts down a couple of inches, tongue swiping along her bottom lip when the glistening head of my cock appears. I’m so hard that it actually hurts.

“You skipped underwear too?” she muses.

I let her carry on undressing me, abs contracting with need as I anticipate over what she’ll find next.

“Will ...” Drew’s hands pause, and her attention is fixed on my left thigh. “What’s this?”

Because she’s frozen in place, I help her remove my shorts and toss them across the room.

Back to straddling me, she traces her fingertips over the ink I got the day after everything went so fucking wrong.

In place of the *N* on the compass I had tattooed to my body, I asked the artist to write my girl's name.

"I don't even know what to say," she croons, reaching behind her neck to unclasp the chain.

She places the pendant next to the tattoo; it's an exact replica other than the one change I requested. The weathered elements and indentations were executed perfectly.

"I can't believe you have my name on your body."

Her eyes track to mine, and I pick up the chain, setting it on the nightstand beside us.

"Giving you my last name feels way more permanent than any ink ever could be."

I interlace our fingers before wrapping her arms around the back of my neck. "Fuck me however you want, Drew. Fast, slow, for hours without stopping. I want you to control what we do."

The devilish smile on her lips tells me that she loves the idea.

Rising up, she sinks down on my cock, taking the whole length without pausing to adjust herself.

I gaze down in awe while I disappear inside her. "Like a goddamn glove, Baby."

The first rock of her hips forces me to bite hard on the inside of my cheek, pressure shooting to the base of my spine.

Jon Morgan, final pro season: seventy-one goals, one hundred thirty assists.

Strands of Drew's dark hair tickle my thighs as she leans back and plants her hands just above my knees.

"Are you enjoying the ride?"

She whimpers, and, fuck me, her tightening walls strangle the base of my cock as she rolls into me again—a smooth motion that drags my shaft along her front wall.

Beads of sweat shine on her forehead, and her parted lips, forming the perfect *O*, remind me of the way she can suck my dick like no other woman ever can or will. I'm a reformed man with an addiction to one pussy.

"Will ..." Drew's head falls forward, trembles racking through her body.

She snaps her hips, and my balls tighten, desperate to fire into her pretty cunt.

Braced on one elbow, I replace the chain I gave her with my hand and guide her face toward mine. “Apparently, I’m not allowed to get you pregnant anytime soon.”

Deep blue eyes spread wide, although it’s not panic I see in them. They’re too dark with lust for that.

“To be honest ...” My attention descends her stunning body as it continues to ride me into submission. “I wasn’t even thinking about it, but now I can’t stop fantasizing over how good you’d look, carrying my child.”

Drew comes hard and fast, crimson invading every inch of her skin.

“How would you feel about that, huh? Me painting your insides until your stomach grows for us both?”

“Holy shit!” she wails into my bedroom, fingernails now clawing at me with need.

Drew rides me hard, determination stamped across her face, as I fall back to the bed, and she pins my wrists above my head, hips thrusting, body searching for her next high.

“That’s right, Drew. Fuck this cock like you mean it,” I grit out.

Another thirty seconds like this, and she’s coming again before I roll us over and drive into her from above, one leg hanging over my shoulder while I mark her calf with my mouth.

“Harder. Fuck me harder,” she demands, and, Jesus, does she get her own way as I plow into her on repeat.

Each time I sleep with this girl, I’m left stunned over the length of time I last, given the instant I slide inside her, my balls are ready to blow.

“I love you.”

Three words still my hips, chest heaving, because I must be hallucinating. I couldn’t have heard her right.

“Say that again for me,” I request, kissing the inside of her foot.

She tries to pull it from my shoulder, but I grip her ankle so she can’t move, dragging my tongue along her instep.

“Say that again, or I’ll torture this pretty foot until you scream it.”

After a beat of silence, I pull my dick from her pussy, and she moans out a protest I can’t quite decipher.

“Did you say that you love me, Miss Callaghan?” I inquire, one hand still clamped around her ankle, the other now dragging up and down my shaft.

I toss my head back, Drew's arousal making it easy to jerk myself in smooth strokes of rippling pleasure.

She pins her bottom lip between her teeth as her eyes become hooded at the sight of me using her release to jack off.

"Come all over my pussy, and I'll consider repeating what I just said." Drew quirks a serious brow. "I'll even put it in writing if you need."

My tongue slithers down her instep again, and she squirms with delight.

"Fuuuck ... I love it when professional Drew comes out to play."

She reaches between her thighs and fingers herself in front of me, pulling them out to offer me a taste. "Am I as sweet as you remember?"

All I can do is groan and pump my cock at a faster pace. I'm such a fucking simp for my woman, happy to let her call the shots over me on the regular.

"You taste like a four-carat diamond ring I just slid onto your left hand."

She just grins up at me with a bratty expression. "Come for me, Will."

My orgasm slams into me, hot jets hitting her pussy one after the next as I grit my teeth and try to stay upright. Open-mouthed, Drew gazes down at the ropes of cum covering her lower half.

I've never shot my load for this long or anywhere near as hard. I guess I should've expected sex with someone you love to be like this, but the dizzying high rocks my body like a drug I'll crave again within the hour.

"I said that I love you." Drew peers up at me through her lashes, black mascara smudged around one eye.

Totally satiated, I release her leg and fall over her body, one elbow holding me up by the side of her head.

"Say it again," I whisper, already smiling like I just won the lotto.

She rolls her eyes, and I push a finger inside her pussy.

"I love you, Will."

Retracting my finger, I swipe it through my cum and reenter her slowly, adding a second for good measure.

"Spread your legs for me."

She does as I asked, and I continue to fuck her with my hand, licking into her mouth when it falls open.

"I want it all with you," I say, not needing a response, but her cries of pleasure as she comes apart for me once more.

Briefly pulling out, I take some more of my cum and push it deep inside my girl, praying that we'll be lucky enough to start a family one day.

“Every goal I score, it’s for you. Every deal I sign, it’s because you showed me the way I want to live my life. The man I want to be from now on. Your man.”

I drop my head into the crook of Drew’s neck, breathing in her scent while she imprints on my heart. “You know they say it’s wise to give the people what they want. How do you think your dad would take it if you showed up to a game, wearing my name?”

She kisses the tip of my nose. “As long as it’s a Rogues jersey, I’m fairly certain he’ll be okay with it.”

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Drew

“**D**id you get the jersey okay?” Will asks as I race down the hallway toward my apartment, phone tucked under my chin while I rummage around in my bag for house keys.

Work has been kicking my ass on repeat lately, but only in the good way. Colton is inundated with inquiries for Will, and I’m growing my client portfolio way faster than any of my colleagues. Especially the lovely Lydia, who has complained to Colton—yet again—requesting that I’m removed from the business due to inappropriate behavior.

With the way she carries on, anyone would think that she owns First Line PR.

“I got the jersey from Dawn on my way out of the office.” I slide the key into my door and wince. “But I’m going to be late to the game. I’m sorry.”

“Is everything okay?”

In the background, I hear a car door slam. Will must’ve just arrived at the rink.

“Everything is fine, I just got held up, working on a speech for Silas. Why is that guy such a freaking mystery? I’m still trying to work on getting his voice right.”

Will huffs out a breath and says hello to someone. “I’d ask him right now if he hadn’t canceled on a ride to the rink at the last minute. He’s been acting strange since the Scorpions game. At first, I thought it was the wrist injury he picked up, but that’s almost fully recovered, so I’ve no clue what’s going on with him.”

Pushing into my apartment, I kick off my heels and smile at how clean and lovely it smells. Vesper is, hands down, the best roommate. All I need is for her to start loving ice cream, and I'm golden.

"Maybe the best thing to do is ask him outright if he needs to talk or if you can help in any way," I suggest, dropping my laptop bag down on a stool and pulling the refrigerator open. "Sometimes, I think guys should take a leaf out of our book and—"

I pause when I see the contents.

"Let me guess ..." The grin on Will's face is unmistakable from his voice. "You just opened your refrigerator."

"How did you know?" I whisper, checking out one of the glass jars labeled *Butterscotch, Baby*. There must be at least a dozen jars in here, each containing whipped cream in different colors and flavors, labeled individually in Will's handwriting.

I pick up one jar, and my mouth waters when I see fresh raspberry pieces stirred into the cream.

"I notice everything, Drew. When you get home on a weekday, you kick off your heels by the door, leave your bag on a stool, and make a beeline for sweet treats. On the weekends, you wake up, grab a coffee from the machine, spend around twenty minutes on your skin routine—which is way too much since you're already flawless—and then decide on which sugar kick you're going for this time."

I have no words.

But I am thanking past Drew right now for never taking my apartment key back from Will.

"They're for hot chocolate," Will clarifies as I stare into my refrigerator, mesmerized and flummoxed over how much time he must have spent thinking up flavors. "I get there might be some that don't usually go with milk chocolate, so I restocked your cupboards with white and dark chocolate drinks too. Oh, and I organized your sprinkles because, damn, Baby, you have a collection going on."

"I love you," I declare, opening the jar labeled *Strawberry Fucking Cheesecake* and chuckle. Ugh, it smells insanely good.

"I know you do. I think I'd love me too, to be honest."

I deadpan even though he can't see me. "Annnd then your uncontrollable ego has to go and ruin it."

Will starts talking about the game and how excited he is to see June tonight, and I close the refrigerator, turning on my heel for the fastest outfit change in history when I slam into a muscular wall, heading in the opposite direction down my hallway.

“Shit, Drew.” A deep voice I recognize from our multiple work phone calls cuts through my daze.

“Silas?”

Dressed in black pants and a light-gray jacket and shirt, he runs a hand through his light-brown hair.

Interesting ...

I’m about to pose the obvious question—asking what he’s doing here, especially with a game in less than two hours—when Vesper appears in her doorway, looking ... kind of flustered and annoyed, if I’m honest.

“I was just stopping by with a gift for Vesper,” Silas quietly explains.

Vesper’s eyes dart to the awkward hunk still blocking my path to the bedrooms.

“Gift?”

“For my birthday,” my friend answers at the same time Silas says, “Early Christmas present.”

I quirk a brow at them both, and Silas takes the opportunity to slip past me and out of the front door with a rushed goodbye.

At this point, both my new roommate and I are now really late to the game.

“So, shall we have this conversation now or later, when we get home from the arena?” I tease, casually leaning against the wall.

Whenever I allude to Silas, Vesper always shifts on her feet or tries to change the subject, but today, she brushes my words off like they didn’t even happen.

“You know Silas and I go back a long way, and he was literally just leaving when you got here.”

I press my lips together, trying desperately not to smirk. My friend is giving *leave it* vibes right now, and I’m too curious to drop the subject.

“Is it normal practice for him to deliver said gift directly to your bedroom orrrr ...”

Her eyes drop to the phone in my hand and—

Fuck, Will!

“Hello?” Will’s now yelling through the speaker when I put it to my ear, and sure enough, Vesper seizes the opportunity to disappear out of sight.

“Shit, sorry,” I whisper back, stepping inside my bedroom and closing the door behind me.

“I thought you’d entered into a sugar coma or something,” he jokes.

For the briefest moment, I consider telling Will what—or who—really stole my attention.

In the end, I decide against saying anything at all. Vesper’s holding back, and judging by the final look she gave Silas before he left, I’m fairly certain it isn’t about her undying love for the Rogues captain.



“HOCKEY PLAYERS ARE HOT.”

“Blake!” Billie Richards, wife of Emmett Richards and mom to one of the most iconic teenagers I’ve ever met, swats her daughter in the arm. “We’re here to support your dad’s team, not ogle them.”

Seated next to me in the family box, Blake rests her chin in one palm, elbow braced on the armrest. “Don’t take this the wrong way, Drew.” She inconspicuously flicks her eyes to me. “But all the girls in school have serious crushes on your boyfriend.” She sighs heavily. “He’s really freaking dreamy.”

“He’s really freaking something, is what he is,” June pipes up from the other side of Vesper. Who, incidentally, has said very little since we left our apartment and drove in near silence to the arena.

“Yeah, well, you would think that, June.” Blake sits back in her chair. “If someone thought my brother was hot, I’d definitely react in the same way.”

“I’m merely concerned about the size of his ego,” June counters. “Any bigger, and his helmet won’t fit.”

She smiles warmly at me, and for the first time, I consider what it would be like to have her as a sister-in-law. Much like her brother, June and I have always been opposites—and not just because she’s amazing at hockey, unlike me, who can barely hold a stick the right way up. In all likelihood, June probably knows more about the game than Will.

“Which player are you interviewing this time?” I ask, trying to keep a track on her sports journalism business, which has been going viral the past couple of months.

She rolls her eyes and pulls out her cell, clicking the screen a few times before showing me. “Tristan Vaughn. Will’s favorite person in the entire world,” she sarcastically adds.

I cringe a little. “Does Will know yet?”

Shaking her head, she locks her phone and repockets it. “Christ, no! It’s going to be a surprise drop on my socials next week, and Tristan’s rep has offered to collaborate on it, too, which should generate a few more followers.”

“Silas might be interested in an interview.” The second I say his name, Vesper locks in on the conversation right as Will nets another goal, sending the Rogues one ahead against the Philly Flames.

June cocks her head to one side, now addressing both me and Vesper. “I’ve heard he’s grumpy these days. Don’t get me wrong; I’m more than capable of dealing with a moody man, but I’m not wasting my time if all I get is three words and a couple of grunts. I’m keeping this interview on the down-low in case I decide to abandon it altogether.”

Vesper bursts out laughing and points at June. “You so remind me of your mom. Kate stopped by the apartment the other day and floored me when she explained how she’d been deliberately drying Jensen’s ‘ugly’ shirts on a high temperature just so she didn’t have to look at them any longer.”

“Queen behavior,” Blake chimes in. “You should definitely start doing that with my brother’s crappy Colorado merchandise, Mom.”

While the girls bounce back and forth between each other about gross clothing, grumpy men, and hot hockey players, I center my attention on the only man I’ll ever see again. The guy whose name I currently have stamped across my back.

Picking up the puck just beyond center ice, he takes on one Philly defenseman, dekes the next, and with a wrist shot I don’t see coming, propels the puck straight between the goalie’s legs.

I’m aware of the arena noise when I stand from my seat and make my way to the balcony, resting my arms on the railing next to Jensen as he watches his son bump fists with my dad and the rest of the team. It’s clear

he lives and breathes every second whenever Will takes to the ice or his daughter posts her latest interview.

“It’s a good thing you were a goalie and not a forward when you played,” I muse, eyes diverting to the jumbotron, the camera zooming in on Will and his teammates.

He puffs out a laugh and nods. “Even better that I didn’t have to face him. I thought your dad was good, but, goddamn, Will might just be better.”

I nod once, knowing none of what Jensen said is rooted in bias. Will really is that spectacular.

For the first time since the game started, Jensen tears his eyes away from the ice and focuses on me.

“The way he feels about you is exactly how I felt—and still feel—about Kate.” He tips his chin at the jumbotron, and like he can sense us talking about him, Will stares straight at me.

“I won’t break his heart if that’s what you’re worried about,” I reply, mine skipping a beat when Will tucks his stick under one shoulder and holds up three fingers on one hand and four on the other—his way of showing that goal number thirty-four for the season is also dedicated to me.

My heart jerks again, struggling to establish a steady rhythm.

Jensen just smiles like that was never his concern. “He asked me to pass on a message, and now that I have you alone, I might as well do that.”

He pulls a set of car keys from the inside of his jacket pocket and hands them to me.

The same set of Ferrari keys from that night at the gala.

I look down at them and then back up at Jensen, who checks his watch.

“Will asked if you could meet him in the players’ parking lot right after the game.” Jensen shakes his head and chuckles to himself. “He also said that you might as well take the keys now because you’ll be driving.”

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Will

The headlights on my Ferrari are lit, the engine idling as I push through the door leading out to the players' private parking lot and make my way toward Drew.

With no press responsibilities tonight and my excuses made to Coach and the guys about needing some personal time to rest after a grueling game, I'm eager to spend a night of fun with the girl who plays on my mind, even when I'm on the ice.

It's been too many months of sneaking around, pretending like all we are to each other is business partners and friends. In reality, I've been in love with Drew Callaghan since way before the conscious side of my brain caught up.

Right from the moment I hauled her into my arms and carried her around the kitchen, making hot chocolate, I've agonized over how good it would be for us to wake up together every morning and go to sleep at night, reflecting on the day.

"Nice game tonight," Drew greets me as I slide into the passenger seat in my Ferrari and feel my pulse race at the sight of her wearing my jersey.

"I'm going to need you to drive," I say, closing my eyes slowly.

Drew just giggles, knowing precisely what the effect of her wearing my name while sitting behind the wheel of a supercar does to me.

"Where did you have in mind?" she questions, shifting into gear and revving the engine.

I lean across the center section and pull her earlobe between my teeth. It's almost like she wanted to make her neck available to me tonight, with her hair piled on top of her head in a messy bun.

“Just drive. I’ll give you instructions as we go.”

She gasps, and I start scrolling through one of my playlists on the entertainment system selecting “At Last” by Etta James.

Drew’s eyes flare when I start singing the opening lyrics.

“I didn’t know you were into older music. O-or that you could sing.”

“Just full of surprises, eh?” I say as she pulls out of the parking lot and picks up speed.

I try to control the hard-on forming in my pants when she depresses the clutch, driving with two feet like a fucking pro.

“Let me guess.” She holds the steering wheel with one hand and taps her lips with the other. “Your parents secretly put you through drama school or something equally as flashy.”

I shake my head, and the music switches to John Legend’s “All of Me.”

“Nah, I think it’s the Welsh Canadian blood in me. Dad can sing, and so can June. Mom sounds like a wailing banshee every time she tries to form a note.”

Drew pushes her head back into the seat and laughs, and, fuck me, I’m so in love with this girl.

“So, where do you want to go?” she asks again when we approach a set of stoplights.

I point at the sign for I-90. “Take the ramp and keep driving.”

“For how long?”

Should I spill the secret now? Nah.

“For as long as it takes. Patience, Baby,” I reply sweetly, reaching out and smoothing a finger down her right arm. It’s covered with my jersey, although by the way she shivers at the contact, I’m confident her skin pebbles beneath it.

“All the way to the bridge across Lake Washington?”

I hesitate for a second before confirming, “Yes. All the way over the bridge until I tell you to stop.”



“PULL IN HERE,” I INSTRUCT, POINTING TO A LIT GRAVEL TRACK, SET BEHIND black iron gates.

Drew slows to a full stop and shifts into neutral, brows pulled together in deep thought. “Um, Will, where the hell are we?”

Butterflies swirl in my stomach. I’m never nervous, except when it comes to putting my heart in Drew’s hands and trusting her not to crush it.

Peering through the windshield, I wave at the security camera fixed to a pole beside the left gate. Gradually, the gates begin to open.

“Will ...” Drew warns, eyes fixed on the opening gates.

Taking her chin between my thumb and forefinger, I turn her head to look at me. “On a scale of one to ten, how much do you love me?”

She rolls her eyes, and I kiss her.

“That all depends on whatever is hiding behind those gates.”

Brushing my mouth across hers, I revel in the way she whimpers at the slightest touch. “What if I told you that a few hundred yards down that gravel track is a house I just closed on for us?”

She pulls back, jaw popped open, eyes bursting from their sockets. “You’re kidding me!”

Since the car is keyless, I pick up the key chain and dangle the keys in front of her. “Did you not notice something different when my dad handed you these earlier?”

Drew studies them for a beat, and then it clicks. “Wait, what are those two black keys?” She takes them between her fingers. “Are these what I think they are?”

“Why don’t we find out?”

A few minutes later, we pull up outside a white double-fronted lake house set on at least two acres of land. I won’t lie; this place cost me a fucking fortune, but when I drove past it on a random drive one day in October, I knew it was made for us. It’s amazing how fast you can buy a place for the right price and a stack of cash waiting to go.

“I actually have goose bumps.” Drew’s voice is awestruck. Head shaking, she gazes out of the driver’s window.

I hop out of the car and round the hood, opening her door and holding out a hand.

She unclips her belt and kills the engine, stepping out of the car like she’s never seen a big house before. She absolutely has, but is too humble to act nonchalant.

“William, you are so freaking extra.”

I take her by the hips and pull her into my body. “Look at me.”

Blue eyes I'm obsessed with make my pulse race as I cup the nape of her neck with my hand.

"I bought this place because the second I saw it, I couldn't stop thinking about boat rides across the lake or the tree swing set in the huge backyard. I could see you in the garden room on your laptop, slowly taking over the world while I brought you an endless supply of processed sugar."

She snorts, and I press my forehead onto hers.

"If you don't like the house, then I'll sell it and buy something you do like. I just want—no, I need—to wake up with you every morning in a place we can call our own. Somewhere hidden away, like the café in the forest. Everyone knows that you're my girl, but that doesn't give them the right to witness every part of our relationship."

Excitement flashes in Drew's eyes, although I detect a hint of uncertainty, and I pray that she isn't having second thoughts about us.

"I want more than anything to live with you." Drew interlaces her fingers through my spare hand. "But I just offered Vesper a place to live, and now I'd be moving out."

Relief washes through me like a cool shower on a hot summer's day. "Keep your place as an investment property. I'm sure Silas will do a good job entertaining your former roommate. He has her address after all."

She balks at my knowing grin. "Wait. How did you know about that?"

I wink and bring my mouth to her ear. "I heard everything on the phone earlier today. One thing about me, Baby: I don't miss a beat when it involves you."

"Do you think they're sleeping together? Vesper comes off like she kind of hates him, to be honest."

I scrunch up my nose, doubtful. "Probably not."

"I don't know ..." Drew sings as I guide her up the pathway leading to the large white porch, set in the center of an Edwardian-style frontage. "Hate sex is a thing, and they looked pretty flustered in my hallway."

"Trust me," I say as we reach the top step, and I guide her face back to mine before she gets a chance to peek through the glass front door.

I want to give her the guided tour and then take her on every surface we own.

"The way my captain looked when he burst into the locker room did not scream of a guy who had just shared a great time with a girl. More like one he wants to forget."

Still holding her by the hand, I slowly turn her around so I can see my name where it belongs.

Where it was always supposed to be before either of us even knew it.

“How about I show you around your new palace? I need you to see the walk-in pantry. I reckon it has enough storage for a lifetime’s supply of sprinkles.”

She throws her arms around my neck, and like we’ve done a hundred times before, I loop my hands under her jean-covered ass, and she crosses her ankles at my lower back.

“You’re too good to me, Hotshot. Way too fucking good.”

We make out beneath the soft glow of the porch lighting, a couple of boats out on the lake and stars in a clear night sky above our heads.

“No, Drew,” I breathe into her mouth, heart thundering at a ridiculous pace. “This is just the way I’ll worship you each and every day. And for as long as you’ll have me, I promise to give you nothing less than the love you absolutely deserve.”

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epilogue

. . .

Drew

August—Eight Months Later

“Do you think if we all climbed into a boat and sailed across the lake, they’d notice that we left?”

One brow arched and a glass in hand, Kate throws me an understanding glance. “I think we could sail once around the world, and those boys would still be debating the superior way to grill a chicken wing.” She takes a sip of champagne and observes Will and Jensen as they continue arguing whose barbeque food is better. “It’s actually pretty nauseating, watching their egos at work,” she adds.

“Truly.” June sidles up next to her mom, sunglasses resting partway down her nose so she can fully appreciate my boyfriend’s breakdown to Jensen about why Monterey Jack cheese is the best choice for today’s garden party. “And when did my brother start eating normal food again?”

“After he realized eating only seeds and the occasional organic lettuce leaf actually had nothing to do with him making lead goalscorer for the Rogues in his first season,” I comment, taking a sip of my own drink.

The early August heat beats down on the backyard, and Lake Washington glimmers beneath the sunlight. Will and I have been living in the lake house for just over six months, and honestly, it’s been the best half year of my life.

Last month, I was promoted to senior publicist after I landed a huge sponsorship deal for Silas, and despite the shit show that rained down on us late last year, First Line PR’s success continues to grow.

“Yeah, well, lead goalscorer or not, if I don’t get my hands on some chicken soon, I’m going to ram that—”

“Yes, JJ, I think we get the point.” Kate cuts her daughter short, holding a pleading hand up for her to stop.

“I’ll fetch the salad,” I confirm, turning on my heel and heading for the kitchen, which backs directly onto the garden. “Perhaps if they see us setting up the table to eat, they might actually start plating food before Christmas.”

Crossing the wooden bridge Will built over the koi pond in the spring, I take the stepping stones one at a time. My knee-length summer dress blows in the breeze as I step into the kitchen and find Vesper chopping tomatoes.

“I say this with kindness ... but why are you annoyingly motivated when it comes to household tasks? You were constantly cleaning when we lived together, and the laundry basket was always empty. And now I find you prepping food I should’ve done, like, a half hour ago,” I tease, throwing my arms around her neck as she scoops a handful of sliced tomatoes and cucumber and tosses them into a salad bowl.

She just shrugs and starts on the celery. “I’m not really. I just hate the hot weather, and your AC is way more effective than the apartment’s.” Vesper winks at me when I unloop my arms and add dressing to the salad. “I’m only using you to keep cool.”

I screw my face up at her, but my friend’s attempt to be playful falls flat. I drum my fingers against the countertop, knowing I can’t avoid the subject for much longer.

“So, I’d be wrong to assume that you’re hiding in the kitchen, away from the one who shall remain nameless.”

She blows out a breath and adds the celery to the bowl. “If you’re referring to Silas, then, no, I’m not avoiding him. We just don’t have a lot to say to each other.”

I flick a tomato seed from her strapless black top. “What happened that day when I caught him sneaking out of your bedroom?”

She rolls her eyes like this is the hundredth time I’ve asked her that question. In fact, we’ve hardly spoken about what happened prior to the first—and last—time she attended a Rogues game with me. While Will and I had some renovations done to this house, I opted to stay in the apartment with Vesper before moving out a couple of months later. Even while we

were still living together, she never wanted to talk about Silas, and he never showed up at the apartment again.

That I'm aware of.

"It really doesn't matter because that's all in the past."

I turn to face her as she starts work on a fruit salad.

"You've never wanted to talk about it. I—"

"Silas wanted me to take out a restraining order against Kane. His brother wouldn't stop calling me, and I wouldn't respond to Silas's messages, checking if I was okay. He stopped by the apartment that day and stuck his nose in where it wasn't needed."

My jaw almost hits the floor. "Vesper, why didn't you say something sooner to me?"

She makes a frustrated noise. "Silas didn't need to get involved. I had it handled and eventually blocked Kane's number."

"And did that stop him from trying to contact you?"

When she hesitates, I know it didn't work.

"Babe"—I reach out and smooth a palm down her arm—"maybe Silas has a point."

Bright blue eyes stare back at me. I can see the anguish in them, and it breaks my heart to think of her struggling day after day, night after night, with that fucker calling her on repeat.

"What he's doing is abusive and controlling, and Silas is right to be concerned. *I'm concerned.*"

My friend shakes her head and peels a banana. At this point, I'm not sure how much she enjoys domestic chores and cooking and how much of it serves as a distraction from things—or people—she doesn't want to think about.

"Silas needs to stay out of my business." Finishing up on the fruit salad, she covers it with plastic wrap and clutches it to her chest. "I don't want to talk about him, or Kane, anymore." Sadness flashes through her eyes. "My life is complicated and I don't have the words, or the energy, to keep thinking about it. I just want to spend a nice day in the sunshine with my friends."

Blowing out a long breath, I watch Vesper step out into the garden. My mind is racing over the best way to support her when a strong arm wraps around my waist, spinning me to face a grinning Will with sun-kissed cheeks.

Ugh, he looks too good today in a short-sleeved black shirt with a couple of buttons open at the collar and a pair of gray shorts and tan loafers.

"Where did you disappear to?" he croons at me.

Chewing on my bottom lip, I want to talk to him about Vesper, but then notice my phone in his hand, the screen lit with Colton's name.

Will passes me the phone, and I swallow thickly, wondering the reason why he's calling on my day off.

"Is everything okay?" I forgo an official greeting in lieu of swirling anxiety.

"Hey, Drew. Sorry to pull you away from your family and friends, but have you got a second to talk?"

He doesn't sound like the world is ending, so that's something, I guess.

"Sure, no worries," I reply, pulling myself up onto the counter.

Will steps between my legs, fingers creeping beneath the hem of my dress. I bat his hand away, and he chuckles silently, palms smoothing up and down my thighs.

"Is Will still with you?"

"I am," my boyfriend confirms.

"Okay, cool. Can you put me on loudspeaker because this involves you both?"

A wave of panic shoots through me before Will's calm voice tempers it.

"What's the problem, Colton?"

My boss falls quiet for a moment, clearing his throat before he simply says, "Lydia."

"W-what about her?" I ask.

Colton's heavy sigh echoes down the line. "I know what happened last year is very much old news. However, I couldn't risk you guys finding out from social media or anyone other than me. Lydia is DevastatedDino and the person who stole your private messages and posted them online."

In hindsight, perhaps Lydia was the obvious choice for who tried to ruin my career and humiliate Will and our families. But each time my brain speculated over the perpetrator being my asshole colleague, I pushed it to the back of my mind. After all, I had no proof, and I had a second chance with First Line. I wanted to move on with my life positively, not dig up the painful past.

"Are you sure?" I ask in a small voice, struggling to believe she would be so stupid to risk her own career.

All she cares about is getting to the top as quickly as possible.

Will, on the other hand, doesn't look at all surprised.

"I'm sure," Colton responds in a steady voice.

"How did you discover her?" Will asks, pulling me into his body like he knows it's exactly what I need.

While we've come so far in the past nine months, the impact from such an invasion of privacy will live with me for a long time to come. I think that's why I love this house so much—it's hidden away from the world. Will was right when he said it was made for us.

Taking the phone from my hand, Will sets it beside us on the white countertop.

"By chance," Colton clarifies. "Earlier today, she left her company cell face up on the desk and went to the bathroom. I needed to grab one of Will's files since she was working on it as part of the turnover to me, and that's when an Instagram notification popped up. It was a direct message from an anonymous user, asking if DevastatedDino had *no shame* in what they'd done."

"Oh my God." I bring a shaky palm to my mouth and feel the vibrations of a growl emanating from Will's chest.

"When I confronted her about it, she burst into tears, explaining that she bitterly regretted what she'd done and then begged for her job. Lydia claimed that she'd acted out of spite, driven by jealousy. She couldn't see that your achievements, Drew, were because of your talent and hard work rather than preferential treatment from me." Colton's voice sounds disappointed. "I treat all of my staff based on merit, and her actions almost cost me my business and caused a lot of unnecessary distress. If one of my employees has concerns over a colleague, then I expect them to come to me directly. Not put them on blast to the world."

"What did you do?" I ask Colton.

"I fired her, effective immediately, and escorted her off the premises. I'm currently trawling through her laptop, praying I don't find any more misconduct while simultaneously berating myself for not keeping a closer eye on her activity using First Line devices."

My heart plummets for Colton.

"Total transparency." Will soothes me, running a hand down my back, and I look up into his eyes as he starts speaking. "I've had my suspicions about Lydia for a long time, and that's why I insisted you take over

representing me after I was temporarily assigned to her. If I didn't have the respect I do for you, Colton, I'd have explored my options with a private investigator in an attempt to flush her out. My first priority is protecting my girl, and with that in mind, I'm relieved to hear that Lydia is no longer with the company. One more false move from that woman, and her jealousy toward Drew will be the least of her concerns. I'll become her number one problem."

Will drops his lips to mine, setting a soft kiss against them. One hand creeps beneath my dress again.

I don't stop him this time.

"I appreciate the respect you have shown my business, Will. Both of you have acted with nothing but integrity from the moment the news broke, and ... Christ, this might sound a bit condescending, but I'm proud of you."

Will kisses me again, and I part my thighs wider.

"Such a fucking professional, you dirty girl," Will purrs into my mouth, voice barely a whisper.

"Colton," Will says just as his fingertips trace over my damp thong, "I'm going to take your best employee back to the garden party now if we're finished up here?"

"Yes. Absolutely!" Colton announces down the phone. "I'll see you in the morning, Drew."

The call disconnects, but neither of us says a word, the faint noise of laughter drifting through the patio doors.

"Do you think they can see us from down there?" I question, tipping my head toward the lake.

Will drops his mouth to the crook of my neck, sucking until it stings. I clamp my legs around his ass and pull him closer.

"Do you care anymore, Drew? Because I fucking love showing you off to the world."

He slips one finger into my panties and glides it through my slickness.

I hold my breath, tipping my head back when he pushes inside me and strokes my pussy exactly where I love it.

Pulling his finger out, he plunges two back in, and my legs shake with rolling pleasure, body desperate to find its high, yet my brain is needy for him to draw this moment out forever.

Will retracts his hand and sucks on his fingers, lips twisting to the side as he considers something.

“Jesus!”

At the sound of my dad’s voice, I snap my head around and find him standing in the doorway leading to the hallway.

He throws a hand over his eyes, and I scramble to cover myself. Will does the same as he grabs a hand towel and holds it over his tented pants.

“Jensen asked me for the chipotle marinade, and now I’m thinking I’ll just burn my eyes with it instead.”

“Oh, don’t be so fucking dramatic,” Will mocks, pulling open the refrigerator and handing him the marinade.

Dad’s still covering his eyes but manages to wrap his hand around the bottle on the third attempt of grabbing at it.

He goes to leave, and Will steps back between my thighs when Dad pauses.

“Do you think I’ll ever get used to this?” With the hand holding the sauce, he haphazardly motions between us. “You two dating.”

Will tips my chin up, ensuring my eyes are fixed on his and nowhere else.

“I sure hope so, Coach, because you interrupted me just when I was about to ask your daughter to be my wife.”

Holy hell.

THE END



Silas’s story is up next. Read on for the first chapter in his book, [*Code Violation*](#), now!

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CODE VIOLATION

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prologue

Silas

Mid-December

“Should I take a seat or remain standing?”

Rocking back on my heels, I hold my breath and wait for Vesper to kick me out of her bedroom.

I shouldn't be here, but that's nothing I haven't told myself repeatedly from the moment I climbed into my truck and drove the ten-minute journey from my place to her apartment.

The only reason why I'm standing in her bedroom and not still at the front door comes down to her fear of us being seen together and not just my inability to stay away.

She's my half-brother, Kane's, ex-girl, and I'm fucking obsessed with her.

Sitting on the bed, Vesper pulls her knees toward her chest and rests her head against the plush green headboard. She releases a long-drawn-out breath, and I brace for rejection. Or maybe *ejection* would be more apt.

“If any of the next few words to leave your mouth involve Kane, then you know where the door is.”

And there it is.

The invite I should definitely take to stop talking and leave.

Taking a seat on a chair in the corner of her room, I lean forward with my elbows braced on my knees as I study the frowning woman before me and then her surroundings.

The apartment she shares with my rookie forward's girlfriend, Drew, is really nice and a far cry from the hole Vesper was living in when she was

dating the brother I hate being associated with.

At least she's safe here with security downstairs and a code required to ride the elevator to her floor.

Which begs the question, why did she let me up here in the first place? I'd like to think that it's because she likes me as a person and wants my help to make a clean break from Kane, although I'm ninety percent sure that I'm incorrect on both counts.

"When was the last time Kane called you?"

Her eyes roll to the back of her head as another sigh passes through her full, red-stained lips.

With Vesper, it would be easy to interpret her stoic demeanor and put-together appearance as signs that she's happy and loved.

But after years of knowing her, no amount of makeup can fool me.

Lifting a red manicured finger, Vesper points at her closed bedroom door. "Go. You knew the rules when I opened the front door."

I hang my head, index fingers massaging my temples in rhythmic circles.

"Ves ..." My voice is soft and coaxing as I speak toward the cream carpet beneath my feet.

"Leave, Silas."

I lift my head up, hating the way she bites out my name. Only when Vesper's stressed does she call me Silas. Whenever we're messing around or texting back and forth, I'm always Si.

"I'll leave when you tell me the last time he called you."

An ambulance tearing through the Seattle streets below the apartment sounds like it's passing through Vesper's bedroom, the atmosphere between us so eerily quiet.

"This morning."

My head snaps up, and my molars crunch together.

"The *fuck*? You told me he'd stopped."

Somehow, Vesper's knees draw closer to her chest. This woman isn't just the most beautiful creature I've ever laid eyes on, but incredibly petite too. To my knowledge, Kane has never laid a finger on her, which is the exact reason why he's still somewhere in this city, breathing air into his lungs.

Vesper rolls her eyes again, and I want to stop her brush-off with my lips.

We've never kissed, not even come close. That hasn't stopped me from thinking about how fucking good it would be. How fucking amazing my mouth would make her feel.

I'm not here for that though. I'm here because I care and I always have, ever since the day Kane showed up with her to a Thanksgiving meal at my place just over two years ago and introduced Vesper as his girlfriend.

The fact that I've fallen in love with her during that time is inconsequential at this point, especially because she has no idea how I feel.

To Vesper, I'm the meddling older brother of her ex-boyfriend and the captain for the Seattle Rogues hockey team. I should be more interested in hooking up with pretty girls than sitting in awkward silence while she periodically tells me to leave.

Vesper blows a breath into her cheeks, not at all shocked at my visceral reaction. "I blocked his number, so he won't be able to contact me."

"Until the next time you unblock him." I sound incredulous and every bit the pain in the ass she views me as. Trouble is, I'm in too deep to temper my words. Too deep in her life, this situation. In her in general.

She frowns at me, slender legs now crossed beneath her as she sits forward.

"Ever heard of boundaries, Silas? Because you're well over each one right now."

I push out a sarcastic laugh, and Vesper's face contorts.

"You realize how ridiculous that sounds? You have a guy who won't take a hint, calling you around the clock when you've already made it clear that there's no going back between you two."

Vesper drops her eyes to the white bedding, and suddenly, I'm not so sure of my last statement or that she was being truthful with me a few seconds ago.

"You blocked his number, right?"

Nothing. Not even a frown this time.

I'm on my feet, pacing her sizable bedroom so I don't lose my cool completely. Large blue eyes track me the whole time, until I eventually stop in the center of the room.

"Why, Ves? Are you still in love with him?"

She rolls her lips together, and I push a stressed hand through my light-brown hair.

“Why do you care so much?” Vesper asks a genuine question, although the exasperation in her tone is unmistakable.

I slap a palm against my thigh, acutely aware that the truth will do nothing to set me free in this scenario.

The last thing she needs is to hear how I feel, even if the words *pick me* dance on the edge of my tongue, like the devil taunting me to crash and burn.

When I move toward her, Vesper doesn’t recoil, like I’ve seen her do so many times with Kane. Watching her shrink back into the corner of the couch whenever he sat next to her made my heart hurt in ways it didn’t have any right to.

For me, women have come and gone my whole life. But at thirty-one, I’ve never had one leave a lasting mark like Vesper.

When our mom passed away less than eighteen months ago, she made me promise to look after Kane. He’s always been a fucking loser, destined to wind up unemployed—or worse, behind bars. Keeping to my word was hard, but no way was I going to betray her. Kane has taken full advantage of my loyalty, spending “loans” I lent him on booze, drugs, and probably prostitutes.

I’m no fucking angel, but there isn’t a single cell in Kane’s body deserving of an ounce of Vesper’s attention. And deep down, she knows that. Trouble is, when people are treated badly enough for long enough, they oftentimes start to believe that assholes like my brother are the norm and that they are the problem.

I can’t stand by and watch Vesper go back to this guy. Not anymore.

Tentatively, I lower myself on the edge of her bed. We’re only a few feet away, and I can smell her perfume.

“You know why I care.”

“Yeah, well, you shouldn’t. I can look after myself.”

When I twist my neck, we make the kind of eye contact that would floor me if I didn’t have a king-size bed frame beneath my ass.

“Tell me that you aren’t considering going back to him.”

When Vesper breaks eye contact with me, I have the answer I was dreading.

“He won’t treat you any better this time around. It’s all just bullshit to get you where he wants you. Give it a couple of weeks, and he’ll be back to

his former ways—expecting you to clean up after him around the house and snapping at you every chance he gets.”

“I’m not going back to him.”

I pin her with a look, determined to see through the lies.

She shakes her head, throwing up her arms. Today, she’s wearing a pair of casual blue sweatpants and a long-sleeved white top. Hair pulled into a high-top ponytail, pieces falling around her delicate features.

Christ, he really doesn’t deserve her.

“You can do so much better, Ves.”

I’ve overstepped another boundary, except I can’t find it in me to care as I keep my eyes trained on hers.

Vesper opens her mouth and then closes it, finally deciding on a response as she declares once more, “I’m not going back to him.”

There isn’t much more to say, and I don’t have any words to give her other than, *I can show you what a real man looks like.*

Rising from the bed, I walk toward her bedroom door.

I don’t want to leave and definitely not like this. I showed up here tonight, hoping to find Vesper done with Kane and busy living her best life, not with the sadness I see in her eyes right now.

“Si.”

With my hand on the door handle, I slowly turn to face her. She climbed off the bed and is now standing a few feet away from me. A pair of sneakers I bought her when she first started her job at Riley’s sit beside her bed, and I remember how fucking happy she was at the surprise gift. Vesper has never had a lot in life, but she never complained either, just soldiered on in a way that makes my heart hurt—and relate—equally. There’s so much strength in this woman, even if she doesn’t believe it herself.

I tower over her, wishing that it were appropriate for me to wrap her in my arms. This woman is the strongest person I’ve ever known, with a feisty attitude to match. Does she know the impact that she has on me every time we’re in the same room?

My heart thumps in my chest like it can hear my racing thoughts.

“Yeah, Ves?” I ask, voice noticeably flat.

Vesper starts chewing on the corner of her thumb, and I reach up and pull her hand away before she does some serious damage to those pretty nails.

“Why do you care?” she asks again, only softer this time. “You are literally a famous hockey player with a huge following of fans. I’m nobody to you.”

I close the space between us, opening my mouth to tell her exactly why I give a damn. I’ve spent too long holding in my feelings. There’s only so many times I can swallow them down.

“Wait.” Vesper’s attention darts to her bedroom door. “That’s Drew.” She snatches her cell from the nightstand, panic rising in her eyes. “Shit! Have you seen the time?”

I pull my own phone from my bag. “Fuck! I was supposed to be at the rink ten minutes ago.”

“And I was supposed to be ready to leave with Drew. Now she’s going to catch you leaving my bedroom and draw all kinds of conclusions.”

Vesper grabs her bag from the floor next to her sneakers, and I wrap my hand around her upper arm, asking her to slow down.

“When can I see you again? We need to talk.”

I watch the way Vesper closes herself off, like a curtain coming down at the end of a show.

“There isn’t anything more to say, Silas. I’ve asked you to stay out of my business, and you still showed up here, wanting to get involved in a life and relationship that isn’t yours.”

Vesper’s eyes flick to her bedroom door when Drew’s voice grows louder. She’s probably on the phone with her boyfriend and my teammate, Will Jones. He’s likely wondering where I am after I bailed on a lift to the arena.

I’m here, trying not to spill my guts on how fucking gone I am for Vesper Stone.

“I don’t want to lose you from my life.”

Vesper peers up at me, a myriad of emotions flowing through her. “Then turn around and go and leave this conversation exactly where it belongs—in the past.”

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acknowledgments

The irony about writing acknowledgments is I rarely manage to find the right words to adequately explain how grateful I am to so many people who support me, not just through the writing process, but in my daily life in general.

Whenever I sit down to write a new story, I would be lying if I said that I wasn't nearly always overcome with anxiety and excitement. Will it be what my readers want? Will the characters find love in the way that I hope? That is never truer than when I embark on writing a new series, especially when kicking it off with a second-gen book involving the son and daughter from two sets of beloved characters.

But here's the thing: I'm one of the luckiest authors on the planet because I have the most incredible people around me, and while some of you may be friends or work colleagues, I view every single one of you as my family. Because without you by my side, these stories wouldn't exist.

So, to my mum and dad, thank you for always being on the other end of the phone. For the late-night chats and the early morning wake-up calls, checking to make sure that I'm not too far into writing and that I remember to eat!

To my husband—Thank you for being the one to feed me! For delivering endless cups of tea and snacks and for also making sure that I'm taking the breaks I need. Writing Will and Drew's story was one of the best times of my life, but I'm acutely aware of how I love to hyperfixate and forget not only the time, but how long I've been sitting at my desk!

To my little boy—Thank you for being the reason behind my smile. For the long walks when the sun is shining and the cuddles on the sofa when there's rain. Thank you for being the inspiration behind so much of what I do. You have made me a better person.

To Naomi and Jenny, aka my alpha readers—You know I'm going to skip straight to the long voice notes and say thank you for putting up with my long ramblings while I basically converse and argue with myself until I

finally land upon the answer. No, but seriously, you guys truly help me to pick through all the noise, and I would be lost without your guidance, opinions, and reassurance. I attribute so much of my progress as a writer to you both, and I am so incredibly fortunate to have you in my circle.

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To my wonderful readers—I really mean it when I say that I truly have the best readership out there. The way you tear through a new release and love on my backlist day after day. You have changed my life and given me purpose, and I will never ever forget that. Will and Drew are, without a doubt, one of my favorite couples ever, and I am so excited to share them with you. I hope you love them just as much as I do.

All my love, always,
Ruth xx

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about the author

Ruth Stilling is an avid romance reader turned writer. Having spent many years reading about and dreaming of her ideal book boyfriend, she finally decided to create her own and to share them with the rest of the world.

Living in a small town in Derbyshire, England, Ruth is an introvert by nature and spends much of her time talking with her equally book-crazy friends from across the globe.

When she isn't writing your next book boyfriend, Ruth enjoys watching all kinds of sports and is an Aston Villa and Derby County fan. The outdoors is a real favorite, and if the British weather were kinder, she would spend all her time writing outside.

Ruth is a wife to her best friend and number one cheerleader, whom she married in 2015, and a mom to her beautiful son, who has shown her a new perspective on life—enjoy and celebrate who you are as a person and cherish those who are there for you through rain and shine.

Ruth is incredibly excited to share *Fair Game*, the first book in her new hockey romance series *The Rules of the Rink*!

You can follow Ruth and keep up to date with what's coming next via Instagram and TikTok by searching @authorruthstilling



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